

Spanish, Step by Step, Root by Root

An etymology-driven curriculum, built one commute at a time

Adhithya Rajasekaran

This edition compiled incrementally — new chapters added as they
are written.

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Preface

This book teaches Spanish one word at a time — and it teaches each word by taking it apart. A huge fraction of Spanish vocabulary is not arbitrary: it is Latin, lightly worn by a thousand years of use, and English borrowed from the same Latin so often that the two languages are full of hidden cousins. So no word here is a fresh thing to memorize. *gracias* arrives next to *grace*, *gratitude*, *gratuity*, *ingrate*, and *congratulate* — a family you have owned your whole life. The bet is simple and, as far as we can tell, how the brain actually works: you learn the new by welding it to the known.

Three things follow from that, and shape every lesson:

- **One word per lesson, gone deep.** Not “the ten greetings” — *hola* is a lesson, *buenos días* is a lesson. A few minutes each, the size of a single errand or commute.
- **The widest honest web of cousins.** Every word reaches for all the English relatives it can *truthfully* claim — because the more live connections a word has, the more places it sticks. False cousins are flagged, not smuggled in.
- **The reason, not the rule.** Why is it *buenos días*, plural? Because it is the fossil of a blessing, “*may God give you good days.*” We learn the culture and the idiom hiding inside the grammar — the things Spanish 101 skips.

How to use this book

Every numbered section is one word, or one small phrase, and takes a few minutes — the length of a queue, an errand, or the walk to the bus. Read them in order the first time through: each section stands on the ones before it, and nothing is used before it has been taught. After that the book becomes reference, and you can open it anywhere.

Say the Spanish out loud wherever you can. The prompts under *Your turn* are written to be spoken, and saying a word is most of what makes it stay. The questions under *Before you move on* carry their own answers in brackets: cover them, answer from memory, then look.

Nothing here is gated behind pronunciation. Each lesson names the one or two sounds its own word needs, exactly where they are needed. The whole system is gathered in a reference at the back of the book — somewhere to look things up when you are curious, never a chapter to sit through first.

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Chapter 1

Hola and Buenos Días

Modes: 🎧 voice (7) 📞 Hands-free start: all 7 lessons.

***By the end of this chapter:** I can greet someone in Spanish, say how I am, and wish them a good day.*

*A short doorway greeting: **hola**, an answer to how you are, and **buenos días** on the way in.*

1.1 hola — hello

The very first word, and the easiest to say — but there’s already one trap hiding in it, and one small mystery.

Sounds you’ll need

- **silent-h** — the **h** is **silent**. *hola* is said *OH-la*, never *HOH-la*. The letter is written but makes no sound at all. This is true of every Spanish *h* you’ll ever meet. → pronunciation reference
- **vowel-o**, **vowel-a** — two pure vowels: *OH*, *AH*. No glide, no drift.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

hola — hello / hi.

This one is a genuine mystery, and honesty matters more than a tidy story: *hola*’s origin is **not settled**. It’s an old interjection — a hailing call — and that’s about as far as the evidence firmly goes. You’ll see it confidently linked to English *hello*, or to Arabic *wallāh* (“by God”), or

to a nautical shout. Treat all of those as **folk etymology**: plausible-sounding, not established.

In particular, the resemblance to English *hello* is a **false friend**. English *hello* comes from a Germanic hailing root (*hail*, *holler*, *hollo*) — a completely different family from anything Spanish. The two words sound alike by pure coincidence, not shared ancestry.

Why flag this so hard? Because the whole method of this book is building on real family resemblances between Spanish and English. A *fake* one is worse than none — it teaches a connection your brain then has to unlearn. So: enjoy *hola*, but don't file it next to *hello* in your head. They're strangers who happen to look alike.

Why it's said this way

hola is **informal**. It's the “hi” you'd say to a friend, a kid, a shopkeeper you know. It carries no time of day and no deference — which is exactly why, in more formal or first-meeting situations, Spanish speakers reach past it for *buenos días* and its siblings (the next lessons). Knowing *when not* to use *hola* is as much the lesson as the word itself.

Note the written form: an exclamation gets an **upside-down mark** at the front — *¡hola!* — so you know the tone before you start reading it aloud.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “hola” — *OH-la*, silent h
- “¡hola!” to an imagined friend — light, informal

Before you move on

Two things to lock in: what sound does the *h* make? (None.) And is *hola* actually related to English *hello*? (No — a coincidence, a false friend.)

1.2 bien — “well,” a whole answer in one word

You have *hola*. Now the word that carries half of everyday small talk: *bien*. It answers “how are you,” it agrees to a plan, it stands completely on its own — and it opens a family of English words you already use.

What to know first

- *hola* — your first word; *bien* is what you say back when someone asks how you are.

Sounds you’ll need

- diphthong-**ie** — **ie** is a quick *YEH*: *bien* is said *byen*, one syllable. → reference
- **v-b** — the **b** is soft, halfway to a *v*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

bien — “well.” Root: Latin **bene** (“well”). That *bene* is the piece hiding in a shelf of English words, every one about something being *good* or *well*:

- **benefit** — literally “to do **well**” (*bene* + *facere*).
- **benevolent** — “wishing **well**” (*bene* + *volens*).
- **benediction** — “speaking **well**,” a blessing (*bene* + *dicere*).
- **benefactor**, **beneficial**, **benign**.

So *bien* is the Spanish member of the *bene*- family you’ve owned in English your whole life.

Using it on its own. This is the useful part: *bien* is a complete answer.

- “¿Cómo estás?” (how are you?) → “**Bien.**” — “Well.” / “I’m good.” Done.
- As agreement, when someone suggests something → “**Bien.**” — “Okay / fine.”

The adjective sibling: *bueno* / *buena*

bien is an **adverb** — it describes *how* something is done (“you speak *well*”). When you want the **adjective** — to describe a *thing* as “good” — Spanish uses **bueno** (for a masculine word) or **buena** (for a feminine word). These come from Latin **bonus** (“good”), *bene*’s sibling: Latin split the idea of “good” into an adverb (*bene*) and an adjective (*bonus*), and Spanish kept both. The Latin-descended English cousins of *bueno* are *bonus*, *bonanza*, and *bounty*.

English does the exact same split: *well* (adverb) vs. *good* (adjective) — “you did *well*” but “a *good* job.” English’s pair happens to be Germanic, not Latin, so *well/good* aren’t blood cousins of *bien/bueno* — but the *structure* is identical, and that parallel is your handle: **bien = well**, **bueno/buena = good**.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “bien” as the answer to “how are you”
- “bueno” then “buena” — the adjective, masculine then feminine

Before you move on

Which is the adverb (“well”) and which is the adjective (“good”)? (*bien* / *bueno–buena*.) And name an English *bene-* cousin of *bien*. (benefit, benevolent, benediction...)

1.3 *el* and *la* — “the,” and the gender it carries

Before your first noun, meet two of the smallest, most frequent words in Spanish: *el* and *la*. Both mean “the.” Your job here is simply to recognize the pair and connect each form to its label.

What to know first

- *bien* / *bueno* — you saw *bueno* change to *buena*; this lesson explains the gender that made it happen.

Sounds you'll need

- vowel-e, vowel-a — two clean vowels: *el* (*ehl*), *la* (*lah*). → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el — “the” (masculine). **la** — “the” (feminine). English has one word, “the”; Spanish makes this two-way distinction.

Where they come from. Both are worn-down Latin **demonstratives** — words that meant “**that one (over there)**”:

- **el** ← Latin **ille** (“that one,” masculine).
- **la** ← Latin **illa** (“that one,” feminine).

Over centuries the pointing force faded and the initial *i*- dropped: *ille* → *el*, *illa* → *la*. What began as “that one” softened into a plain “the.” The same *ille/illa* spread across the whole family — French *le/la*, Italian *il/la* — every Romance “the” is eroded Latin “that.”

The twin thread. Those *same* Latin words, *ille/illa*, also became Spanish **él** (“he”) and **ella** (“she”). So the article *el* (“the”) and the pronoun *él* (“he”) are twins from one Latin parent — told apart only by the accent. (English “the,” by contrast, is Germanic and *unrelated* — a shared job, not a shared root.)

What you've built

el and *la* are **articles**: little words that mark “the.” Keep them apart from their accented relatives *él* and *ella*, the pronouns “he” and “she.” The next micro-lesson explains why Spanish needs two article forms.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “el” then “la” — the two “the”s
- which article goes with a masculine noun? with a feminine one?

Before you move on

Which form is labelled masculine? (*el*.) Which is labelled feminine? (*la*.) Both come from Latin words meaning what? (“That one” — *ille* / *illa*.)

1.4 Grammatical gender — the two noun classes behind *el* and *la*

You know that *el* and *la* both mean “the.” Now give their two labels: *el* is masculine; *la* is feminine.

What to know first

- *el* / *la* — the two definite articles.

Grammar Lens: grammatical gender

Every Spanish noun belongs to one of two **grammatical classes**, traditionally called masculine and feminine. This is not a claim about biological sex. It is a matching system: a masculine noun uses *el*; a feminine noun uses *la*.

Latin had masculine, feminine, and neuter classes. Spanish reduced that three-way system to two, with most old neuter nouns joining the masculine class. The word *gender* itself comes through Latin *genus*, “kind” or “class.”

You cannot always predict a noun’s class from its ending. Learn each new noun with its article, as one small unit: *el* + *noun* or *la* + *noun*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the article for a noun labelled masculine
- the article for a noun labelled feminine
- what grammatical gender classifies — nouns, not people

Before you move on

How many noun classes did Latin have? (Three.) How many does Spanish keep? (Two.) What should travel with every new noun you learn? (Its article, *el* or *la*.)

1.5 día — your first noun

You just learned how Spanish tags gender with *el* / *la*. Now put it to work on your very first noun — *día*, “day.”

What to know first

- *el* / *la* — grammatical gender and the two “the”s; *día* is where you apply them.

Sounds you’ll need

- **accent-i** — the accent sits on the **í**: *día* is *DEE-a*, two beats. → reference
- **d-soft** — the **d** between vowels is soft, toward the *th* in *this*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el día — “the day.” Root: Latin **dies** (“day”). The family fans across English, mostly through French:

- **diary**, **diurnal** (“of the day”).
- **journal**, **journey** — French *jour*, “a day” (a *journey* was once “a day’s travel”).
- **quodidian** (“every-day”), **meridian** (“mid-day”), and *dismal* (*dies mali*, “evil days”).

Its two tags: gender and number

You already know gender from the last lesson; here’s how *día* wears it. **Gender.** *día* is **masculine** — *el día* — which is a small surprise, because it ends in *-a*, the ending that usually signals feminine. Why the exception? Because Latin *dies* was masculine, and *día* inherited that

gender whole, spelling be damned. (This is exactly why gender must be learned *with* the word, not guessed from the ending — and it’s the first of several “-a-but-masculine” nouns you’ll meet.)

Number. One rule for now: a noun ending in a vowel adds **-s**. *día* → *días* (“days”). (Consonant endings take *-es* — later.)

Grammar Lens: why the gender matters next

Gender isn’t a passive label — it *forces* the words around the noun to match. The very next lesson, *buenos días*, turns *bueno* (“good”) into *buenos* precisely because *día* is masculine and plural. So the gender you just attached to *día* is about to earn its keep.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “el día” — with its masculine “the”
- “días” — plural, vowel + *-s*
- is *día* masculine or feminine, and why? (masculine — from Latin *dies*, despite the *-a*)

Before you move on

Which “the” goes with *día*, and why? (*el* — masculine, inherited from Latin *dies*, despite the *-a* ending.) How do you make it plural? (*días* — vowel + *-s*.)

1.6 buenos días — the greeting you say before noon

You can already greet someone at any hour with *hola*. Now the one you use in the morning — the greeting everyone knows.

What to know first

- *día* — the word *day*, which you have already met.

Sounds you'll need

- **diphthong-ue** — **ue** is a quick *WEH*: *bueno* is *BWEH-no*.
- **accent-i** — *días* keeps its stress on the *í*: *DEE-as*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

buenos días is, word for word, “**good days**” — plural, and nobody knows quite why the plural stuck. Spanish says it in the plural and always has.

Take it whole. It is one thing you say, not two things you assemble: *buenos días*, said as a single run, the way English says *good morning* without stopping to think about *good* or *morning*.

The shape of it — why *buenos* and not *bueno* — is a real rule, and a useful one. It is also not the rule you need in order to say hello before lunch. It comes later, once you have enough words for it to be worth explaining.

Why it's said this way

So why “good **days**,” plural at all? Because *buenos días* is a **fossil** — the worn-down stub of a blessing: “**Buenos días os dé Dios,**” “*may God give you good days.*” You weren’t wishing one good morning; you were asking heaven for many good days ahead. The plural is the last bone of that prayer — and it’s why *buenos días* feels warm and a little formal, where *hola* is casual. It is, almost literally, a small *benediction* (the *bien* lesson’s word). (*A widely-accepted account; exact history debated.*)

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- build it slowly — “bueno” ... “días” ... “buenos días”
- “hola, buenos días” — casual + warm, stacked
- why is it *buenos*, not *bueno*? (out loud, in your own words)

Before you move on

Two things: why is it *buenos* and not *bueno*? (Agreement — *días* is masculine plural.) And what blessing was *buenos días* shortened from? (“May God give you good days.”)

1.7 Practice — hola and buenos días

End of the chapter. No new words — just the four you have, turned over until they’re automatic.

What you’ve built

In four short lessons you went from nothing to two full greetings and the first two rules of Spanish grammar:

- **hola** — the casual “hi.”
- **bien** — “well/good,” a complete answer on its own; and its adjective sibling **bueno** / **buena**.
- **día** → **días** — a noun, and the plural rule (vowel + *-s*).
- **buenos días** — assembled from *bueno* + *días*, with **agreement** turning *bueno* into *buenos* to match.

Your turn

Say each out loud; don’t just read.

Say these aloud:

- greet a friend casually — *hola*
- greet someone warmly in the morning — *buenos días*
- stack them — *hola, buenos días*
- answer “how are you” with one word — *bien*
- the four shapes of “good” — *bueno, buena, buenos, buenas* — and for each, is it masculine/feminine, singular/plural?

Twice through: Build *buenos días* from scratch, out loud: *bueno* → agree with masculine-plural *días* → *buenos días*. Do it until the “why” feels obvious, not memorized.

Before you move on

You can now greet two ways and give a one-word positive answer. The very next question is the one that opens a real conversation: when *someone else* says *buenos días* to you — **what do you say back?** That’s the whole next chapter, and it’s where these words start turning into an exchange.

Chapter 2

The Rest of the Greetings

Modes: 🗣️ voice (6) 🖱️ Hands-free start: all 6 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can greet someone correctly at any hour — morning, afternoon or night — and say why the greeting changes shape.

The same greeting exchange run three times across the day, choosing the right form for each hour.

2.1 tarde — “afternoon,” and the “late” hiding inside it

You built *buenos días*. The afternoon greeting is coming, but first its key word on its own — *tarde* — and it’s secretly a word you already know from English.

What to know first

- buenos días — you’ll pair *tarde* with *buena* the same way you paired *días* with *bueno*.

Sounds you’ll need

- Regular stress: *TAR-de* — ends in a vowel, so the stress falls on the second-to-last syllable. → reference

la tarde (feminine) — “afternoon.” Root: Latin **tardus** — which did *not* mean afternoon. It meant “**slow, late.**” And *that* is the meaning English kept:

- **tardy** — late.
- **retard** — to slow down (literally “to make late”).
- **tardigrade** — “slow-stepper,” the real name of the little water-bear that plods under a microscope.

How did “late” become “afternoon”? Naturally — the afternoon *is* the late part of the day, the day growing old. Spanish took the Latin word for “late” and let it drift to name the lateness itself. Say *tarde* and you’re calling it “the late hours.”

Its gender: *tarde* is **feminine** — *la tarde*, not *el tarde*. (Contrast *el día* from the last lesson: your first masculine and feminine nouns, side by side.) Learn each noun *with* its *el/la*, because gender isn’t reliably guessable — and it will decide the shape of every word that describes the noun, starting next lesson.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “tarde” — *TAR-de*
- “tarde” then English “tardy” — hear the shared root
- “tardes” — plural, add *-s* (vowel ending), just like *día* → *días*

Before you move on

What did Latin *tardus* originally mean, before “afternoon”? (Slow, late — as in *tardy*, *retard*.) And how do you make *tarde* plural? (*tardes* — vowel + *-s*.)

2.2 buenas tardes — assembled, and now the *feminine* side of agreement

Same move as *buenos días*: take “good” and “afternoon” and snap them together. But watch the ending — this time it comes out *buenas*, and that difference teaches you the other half of the agreement rule.

What to know first

- bien / bueno — the adjective *bueno* and its four shapes.
- tarde — the noun *tarde*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

buenas tardes = **buena** (“good”) + **tardes** (“afternoons”) = literally “good afternoons.”

Why it’s said this way

Buenos días in the morning; **buenas tardes** in the afternoon. The ending changes, and there is a reason for it — the same reason that comes later, with the rest of the pattern. For now: two greetings, two shapes, both said whole.

Why it’s said this way

Same fossil blessing as the morning greeting: *buenas tardes* is short for “*Buenas tardes os dé Dios.*” One cultural note on timing — *tardes* runs from after the midday meal until it’s genuinely dark, which in much of the Spanish-speaking world is late. Spanish follows the daylight, not the clock; there’s no fixed “12:00 = afternoon” line.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “buenas tardes” — *BWEH-nas TAR-des*
- “buenos días” then “buenas tardes” — hear the *o* flip to *a*
- why *buenas* and not *buenos*? (out loud, your own words)

Before you move on

Why is it *buenas tardes* but *buenos días*? (*tarde* is feminine, *día* is masculine — the adjective agrees with each.)

2.3 noche — “night,” and a Latin sound-change you can now spot

The last time-of-day word before the evening greeting. *noche* — “night” — and it shows off a spelling pattern that will help you decode dozens of Spanish words later.

What to know first

- *tarde* — same build ahead: word first, then *buenas* + it.

Sounds you’ll need

- **soft-c** — the **ch** in *noche* is the *ch* of English *church*: *NO-cheh*. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la noche (feminine) — “night / evening.” Root: Latin **nox**, stem **noct-** — which was itself *feminine* in Latin, and *la noche* inherited that gender straight down (just as *el día* inherited its masculine from Latin). That *noct-* runs all through English:

- **nocturnal** — active at night.
- **nocturne** — a piece of night-music.
- **equinox** — *equi* (“equal”) + *nox*, the day when night and day are equal length.

A pattern worth banking: Latin *noctem* → Spanish *noche*. The Latin **-ct-** softened into Spanish **-ch-**. This happened again and again: *factum* → *hecho* (“done”), *lactem* → *leche* (“milk”), *octo* → *ocho* (“eight”). Once you know *-ct-* → *-ch-*, you can often guess the Latin root (and its English cousins) behind a Spanish *-ch-* word on sight.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “noche” — *NO-cheh*
- “noche” then “nocturnal” then “equinox”

- “noches” — plural, vowel + -s

Before you move on

What English word is *equi-* + *noche*’s root? (*Equinox*, “equal night.”)
And what Latin sound did the *-ch-* in *noche* come from? (*-ct-*, as in *noctem* → *noche*.)

2.4 buenas noches — good evening *and* good night

The fourth greeting, assembled the way you now expect — and it has one quirk the others don’t: it works both coming and going.

What to know first

- buenas tardes — feminine agreement (*buenas*); *noche* is feminine too, so the same shape applies.
- noche — the noun *noches*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

buenas noches = **buena** (“good”) + **noches** (“nights”). *noche* is **feminine** (*la noche*), plural here, so — exactly like *tardes* — the adjective is **buenas**. No new rule; you’re now just *fluent* in the agreement you learned two lessons ago: masculine *días* → *buenos*, feminine *tardes/noches* → *buenas*.

Why it’s said this way

The same amputated blessing (“*Buenas noches os dé Dios*”) — but with a twist. *buenas noches* is both a **greeting** and a **farewell**:

- Arriving at a dinner at 9pm → *buenas noches* (“good evening”).
- Leaving that same dinner at midnight → *buenas noches* (“goodnight”).

English splits these into two phrases; Spanish uses one and lets context tell you the direction. The blessing doesn’t care which way you’re going — you’re wishing good hours either way.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “buenas noches” arriving somewhere
- “buenas noches” leaving somewhere
- all four times of day — “buenos días, buenas tardes, buenas noches” — and notice which take *buenos* vs *buenas* and why

Before you move on

What’s unusual about when you can use *buenas noches*? (Both hello and goodbye.) And why *buenas*, not *buenos*? (*noche* is feminine.)

2.5 buenos or buenas — the rule you have been using all along

Say all three greetings, in order through the day: *buenos días*, *buenas tardes*, *buenas noches*.

You have been saying them for two chapters without being told why the first one differs. Now it is worth knowing.

What to know first

Two things you already have:

- Every Spanish noun is **masculine or feminine**. *Día* is masculine; *tarde* and *noche* are feminine.
- Adding **-s** makes a noun plural: *días*, *tardes*, *noches*.

Grammar Lens: the describing word copies the noun

In Spanish a describing word **copies** the noun it sits next to — it matches both the masculine-or-feminine and the one-or-many. *Bueno* is the describing word in all three greetings. It copies:

- *días* is masculine and plural, so *bueno* becomes **buenos**.
- *tardes* is feminine and plural, so *bueno* becomes **buenas**.

- *noches* is feminine and plural, so again **buenas**.

That is the whole rule. One word changing its last letter to agree with the word beside it.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

The **-o** and the **-a** are old. Latin marked masculine with *-us* and feminine with *-a*: *bonus* and *bona*, “good.” Spanish wore *bonus* down to *bueno* and kept *bona* as *buenas*, and the two endings have been doing this same job for two thousand years.

English lost this entirely. *Good* is *good*, whatever it sits beside.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “buenos días” — and say why it is *buenos*: *días* is masculine.
- “buenas tardes” — and why *buenas*: *tardes* is feminine.
- all three in order, morning to night.

Before you move on

Why *buenos días* but *buenas tardes*? (*Día* is masculine, *tarde* is feminine, and the describing word copies the noun.) Which Latin endings are hiding in *-o* and *-a*? (*-us* and *-a*.) Does English do this? (No — *good* never changes.)

2.6 Practice — the four greetings

You can now greet at any hour of the day. Let’s make the choice — and the grammar behind it — automatic.

What you’ve built

- **hola** — any time, casual.
- **buenos días** — morning (*días* masculine → *buenos*).
- **buenas tardes** — afternoon (*tarde* feminine → *buenas*).

- **buenas noches** — evening *and* goodnight (*noche* feminine → *buenas*).

The one grammar thread running through all of them: **agreement**. The “good” word copies the gender of the time-of-day word. That’s why it’s *buenos* días but *buenas* tardes and *buenas* noches.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- greet for the actual current time of day, correctly
- all three “buenos/buenas” greetings in a row; for each, say whether the noun is masculine or feminine and why the ending fits
- “hola, buenas tardes” — casual + timed, stacked

Twice through: Run morning → afternoon → night, out loud, without hesitating on *buenos* vs *buenas*.

Before you move on

Quick: is it *buenos* or *buenas* noches, and why? (*buenas* — *noche* is feminine.) Next chapter, someone finally greets *you* back — and you learn to say your name and ask for theirs.

Chapter 3

Un and Una — the Other Article

Modes: 🗣️ voice (3) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 3 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can say a day, an afternoon and a night, choosing the article by the noun’s gender.

un is the number one, and English a is the same word worn down.

3.1 un — “a,” and the number hiding in it

How do you say “the day”? (*El día*.) Which word is doing the work of *the*? (*El*.)

Grammar Lens: the other article

El día is **the** day — a particular one, the one we both know about. For **a** day, any day, not one we have settled on, Spanish swaps the article:

un día — *a day*.

That is the second article, and Spanish has only these two kinds. *El* points at something known; **un** does not.

Like *el*, it carries the noun’s gender — so *un* is the masculine one, and its partner is coming in the next lesson.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Here is the part worth keeping.

Un is the number one. Latin *ūnus*, “one”, and Spanish never really

separated the two — *un día* is *a day* and *one day* at once, and context decides which you meant.

English did exactly the same thing and hid it better. Our *a* and *an* are the word **one**, worn down over centuries of being unstressed. That is why *an hour* and *one hour* start with the same sound, and why *a* feels like almost nothing when you say it: it has been eroded from a whole number down to a single vowel.

So the two languages made the same move. Spanish just left the seam visible.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “el día” then “un día” — the known one, then any one
- “un día”, and hear the number *one* still sitting in it

Before you move on

How do you say “a day”? (**Un día.**) What is the difference between *el* and *un*? (*El* points at something known; *un* does not.) And what number is *un*? (**One** — and English *a* is the same word.) Next: the feminine partner.

3.2 una — the feminine one

Say “a day.” (*Un día.*) And what is the word for “the afternoon”? (*La tarde.*)

Grammar Lens: the partner

Tarde and *noche* are feminine, so they take the feminine article:

una tarde — *an afternoon.* **una noche** — *a night.*

You now have both, and they behave exactly as *el* and *la* do — the article takes the gender of the noun standing next to it. Nothing new is being asked of you; the rule you learned for *el* and *la* simply applies again.

	masculine	feminine
the	<i>el</i> día	<i>la</i> tarde
a	un día	una tarde

This table is allowed here because every box in it is something you can already say.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

One detail, because it runs against what you might expect.

Una is not *un* with something added. It is the other way round: Latin had *ūnus* and *ūna*, and **una kept the whole word while un lost a syllable.**

That is the ordinary direction of travel. The forms said most often wear down fastest, and *un* — standing in front of masculine nouns, which are the default for anything unspecified — got said more.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “un día, una tarde, una noche”
- each noun twice — once with *the*, once with *a*

Before you move on

Say “a night.” (**Una** noche.) Which article goes with *día*, and why? (**Un** — *día* is masculine.) And which of the pair is the worn-down one? (**Un** — *una* kept the whole Latin word.)

3.3 Review — the four little words

Nothing new here. Say “the day,” then “a day.”

What you’ve built

Four words, and they cover every noun you will ever meet in this book:

- **el** · **la** — *the*, pointing at something we both know.
- **un** · **una** — *a*, pointing at no one in particular.

Two jobs, two genders, and the gender is never the article's own — it is borrowed from the noun beside it, exactly as *bueno* borrowed it from *día*.

That is one rule doing all four jobs, and you have now seen it three times: on the greeting, on the definite article, and here.

Your turn

- *Say it:* “el día, un día” · “la tarde, una tarde” · “la noche, una noche”

Twice through: Until the article arrives with the noun rather than after it.

Before you move on

Name all four articles. (*El, la, un, una.*) Which two point at something known? (*El* and *la.*) And where does an article's gender come from? (**The noun beside it** — never from itself.)

Chapter 4

Saying Your Name

Modes: 🗣️ voice (4) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 4 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can say my own name in Spanish.

Saying Your Name — the chapter run end to end.

4.1 me — your first pronoun, and a *real* English twin

A tiny word doing big work. *me* is your first **pronoun** — and unlike *hola*, its English look-alike is the real thing: a true cousin, not a coincidence.

Sounds you'll need

- vowel-e — one clean syllable, *meh* (the *e* of *bed*).

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

me — “me / myself.” Root: Latin **me** (the object form of *ego*, “I”). Here’s the satisfying part: English **me** is a **genuine cousin**, not a false friend. Spanish *me* comes from Latin *me*; English *me* comes from Proto-Germanic — but both trace back to the *same* ancient ancestor (the Proto-Indo-European root *me-*, “me”). So do English **my** and **mine**. This is the opposite of the *hola/hello* trap you saw earlier: here the resemblance is real, and you can lean on it hard. Spanish *me* = English *me*, all the way down.

Grammar Lens: what a pronoun is

A **pronoun** is a stand-in word that points to a person or thing without naming them — *I, you, he, me, it*. *me* specifically is an **object** pronoun: it marks the person the action lands on (“call *me*”, “give *me*”). In Spanish it usually sits **right before the verb** — you’ll see it next lesson in *me llamo*, literally “myself I-call.” For now, just hold *me* = “me / myself.”

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “me” — *meh*
- “me” then English “me”, “my”, “mine” — all one family

Before you move on

Is Spanish *me* a true cousin of English *me*, or a coincidence like *hola/hello*? (A true cousin — both from the same ancient root.) What part of speech is it? (A pronoun.)

4.2 llamo — “I call,” from a root that shouts

The verb inside “my name is.” On its own it means “to call” — and its Latin root literally means *to shout*, which is why it echoes through a whole family of English words.

What to know first

- me — you’ll bolt *me* onto *llamo* next lesson.

Sounds you’ll need

- ll-y — ll sounds like English y: *llamo* is *YA-mo*, not *LA-mo*. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

llamo — “I call.” The dictionary form (the infinitive) is **llamar**, “to call.” Root: Latin **clamare**, “to cry out, to shout.” That *clam-* shouts all through English:

- **exclaim**, **exclamation** — *ex-* (“out”) + *clamare*: to shout **out**.
- **proclaim**, **proclamation** — *pro-* (“forth”): to call **forth**.
- **acclaim** — *ad-* (“toward”): to shout praise toward.
- **claim**, **reclaim**, **disclaim**; and **clamor**, borrowed whole.

A sound-pattern to bank: Latin *cl-* became Spanish *ll-*. *clamare* → *llamar*. It happened repeatedly: *clavem* → *llave* (“key”), *flamma* → *llama* (“flame”), *plovere* → *llover* (“to rain”). A Spanish word starting *ll-* is very often a Latin *cl-/fl-/pl-* word in disguise — and its English cousin usually kept the original cluster (*clamor*, *flame*, *pluvial*).

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “llamo” — *YA-mo*
- “llamo” then “exclaim”, “proclaim”, “clamor” — the shouting root
- “llamar” (to call), “llave” (key) — both from Latin *cl-*

Before you move on

What does the root *clamare* mean? (To shout / cry out.) Latin *cl-* becomes which two letters in Spanish? (*ll-* — *clamare* → *llamar*.)

4.3 me llamo — “I call myself”

Snap the last two lessons together — *me* + *llamo* — and you can introduce yourself. But notice Spanish doesn’t say “my name is” at all.

What to know first

- me · llamo

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

me llamo = **me** (“myself”) + **llamo** (“I call”) = literally “**I call myself.**” Then the name: *Me llamo Susana* — “I call myself Susan.”

Grammar Lens: reflexive verbs

When the action loops back onto the person doing it — you call *yourself* — the verb is **reflexive**, and Spanish marks it with that little pronoun in front: *me* (“myself”). *llamo* alone is “I call [someone else]”; *me llamo* is “I call **myself.**” English can do this (“I call myself Sam”) but usually doesn’t bother, flattening it to “my name is.” Spanish keeps the reflexive loop visible.

This matters because the pronoun **changes with the person**: *me llamo* (I call myself) → *te llamas* (you-informal call yourself) → *se llama* (he/she/you-formal calls himself). You’ll meet *te* and *se* in a few lessons; for now, lock in *me llamo* for yourself.

Why it’s said this way

Spanish presents your name not as a thing you *have* (“my name is”) but as what you *do* — what you call yourself. It’s subtly more active, and it’s the completely standard, neutral way to introduce yourself.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “me llamo” + your own name
- “hola, me llamo ____” — greeting + introduction
- what does *me llamo* literally mean, word for word?

Before you move on

Literally, what is *me llamo*? (“I call myself.”) What makes it reflexive? (The *me* — the action loops back on you.)

4.4 Saying your name — putting it together

Three lessons became one sentence. Say it to a stranger. Nothing new in this lesson — only what you already have.

The exchange

— Hola. **Me llamo** Susana. — Me llamo David.

What you've built

You can now put your own name into Spanish, which is the first thing anyone will ask you for.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the whole exchange, both parts, without stopping
- it again, faster, and let it sound like speech rather than recital

Twice through:

Before you move on

Run it once more from memory. If a word does not come, go back one lesson rather than pushing on — this chapter is short on purpose.

Chapter 5

The Three Words for You

Modes: 🎧 voice (5) 🖱️ Hands-free start: all 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can choose between tú and usted, and recognise vos.

The Three Words for You — the chapter run end to end.

5.1 tú and usted — two of the three words Spanish says to one person

English has one word for “you.” Spanish has three for speaking to one person, and today you get two of them — the two you will use yourself. What the choice *means* socially, and the odd grammar *usted* drags along with it, comes next. The third word comes shortly after, and you will only ever need to recognise it.

The two words

tú — “you,” **informal**. For friends, family, children, peers, anyone you are on easy terms with.

Root: Latin **tū**. This is a **true cousin** of English **thou** — the word English used to have for exactly this job, the intimate “you” (*thou/thee/thy*), before it faded out around 400 years ago. Both *tú* and *thou* come straight from the same ancient root (*tu-*). So Spanish still uses, every day, the pronoun English quietly retired.

usted — “you,” **formal**. For strangers, elders, officials, customers, anyone you are showing respect or keeping distance with.

Both are the “doer” word — the one that says who is acting, like *yo* (“I”). Say them enough times that they come out without hunting: *tú*, one syllable with the accent; *usted*, stress on the second, with a very soft final *d*.

Not the whole story, and you should know that now.

Across Argentina, Uruguay, Paraguay, most of Central America and parts of Colombia, the everyday informal “you” is a *third* word — not *tú* at all. That is well over a hundred million people. You are learning *tú* because it is understood everywhere, and you will meet the third word shortly, only to recognise.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “*tú*” — for a close friend
- “*usted*” — for someone you’d address respectfully
- “*tú*” then English “*thou*” — the retired twin

Before you move on

Which is formal, *tú* or *usted*? (*Usted*.) What English pronoun is the lost twin of *tú*, and what happened to it? (*Thou* — it faded out of English around 400 years ago.) How many words does Spanish have for “you,” and how many will you say yourself? (*Three, for one person; two*.) Next: what picking one of them tells your listener.

5.2 *tú or usted* — a choice you have to make every time

You have both words. Now the hard part: Spanish makes you **choose** one every time you speak to someone, and the choice is never neutral.

What to know first

- *tú* / *usted* — the two words themselves.

Why it's said this way

Tú and *usted* do not differ in **meaning** — both are “you,” singular, one person. They differ in **register**: the social distance you are claiming.

you say	you are signalling
tú	closeness, equality, ease
usted	respect, deference, distance

English used to carry this too, with *thou* against *you* — and when *thou* died, English lost the ability to say it at all. One-size-fits-all “you” means an English speaker never has to decide. A Spanish speaker decides every single time, and getting it wrong is not a grammar mistake but a **social** one: *tú* to a stranger can read as presumptuous, *usted* to a friend as cold.

The safe default when you cannot tell: **usted**. Over-formal is recoverable; over-familiar is awkward.

Grammar Lens: *usted* takes he/she forms

One structural surprise, because it shapes every lesson after this: ***usted* takes the *he/she* verb forms, not the informal “you” forms.**

That is why “what’s your name?” formally is *¿cómo se llama usted?* — using the *se llama* you would otherwise use for “he calls himself” — and not *te llamas*. Grammatically, *usted* behaves as though you were talking **about** the person rather than **to** them. That is a fossil of where the word came from, and the next lesson digs it up.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “*tú*” and name someone you would use it with
- “*usted*” and name someone you would use it with
- which verb pattern *usted* takes — the he/she one

Before you move on

Do *tú* and *usted* differ in meaning or in register? (**Register** — both mean “you”; they signal closeness versus respect.) Which do you pick when unsure? (**Usted**.) Which verb forms does *usted* take? (The

same forms used with **he** or **she**.)

5.3 vos — the third “you,” and you only have to recognise it

Two words so far. Which one do you use with a friend? (*Tú*.)
Which one keeps a respectful distance? (*Usted*.)

What to know first

vos — “you,” informal. It does the same job as *tú*.

Where it lives, in part: Argentina, Uruguay and Paraguay, and most of Central America. It is also alive in Chile, and in parts of Colombia and Bolivia — this list is not the whole map. Counting only the places named, that is **well over a hundred million people** for whom *vos*, not *tú*, is the ordinary word to a friend.

You are learning *tú* because it is understood everywhere, those places included. But a course that never mentioned *vos* would be teaching you a Spanish nobody speaks in Buenos Aires.

What you owe this word. Recognition, nothing more. Hear **vos**, think *tú*. Its endings differ a little, and you will meet that where you meet the endings themselves — not before.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Vos is Latin **vōs** — and Latin **vōs** was the **plural** “you.” The word Romans used for a group.

How does a plural become the word for one friend? By politeness. Addressing someone as though they were several made them bigger. The courtesy wore off, and across much of the Americas the word slid into *tú*’s place.

English began the same way and ended in the opposite place.

You met *thou* earlier in this chapter. What retired it was **you** — a *plural*, used to one person out of politeness, exactly as Spanish used *vos*. But English’s polite plural won and spread until it was the only word left; standard English now has no separate singular at all. Spanish’s *vos* went the other way — it *lost* the polite job and dropped into the intimate one.

Same start, opposite ends. And what took the polite job away from *vos* is the very next lesson.

Your turn

Recognition only — nothing to produce here.

- [YOU HEAR: “vos”] → think: *tú*. A friend, an equal, someone at ease with you.
- [YOU HEAR: “usted”] → think: distance, or respect.
- [YOU SAY: “tú”] — still your word, everywhere you go.

Before you move on

How many words does Spanish have for “you” when speaking to **one** person? (*Three.*) Which do you say? (*Tú* — and *usted* for distance.) Name a country where *vos* is the everyday word. (*Argentina, Uruguay, Nicaragua...*) What was Latin *vōs* originally? (*The plural “you.”*)

5.4 *vuestra merced* → *usted* — respect compressed into one word

You use *usted* for respectful “you,” and it takes the same verb form as “he” or “she.” That surprising grammar preserves the word’s history.

What to know first

- *tú* / *usted* — the informal and formal choices.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

usted wore down from **vuestra merced**, “your grace” or “your mercy.” *Vuestra* comes from Latin *vestra*, “your.” *Merced* comes from Latin *merces*, *mercedem*, “wages, reward, favor.” The *merc-* root links **mercy**, **mercenary**, **commerce**, **merchant**, and **merchandise**. A respectful title was repeated so often that two words

compressed into one pronoun. Its older abbreviation **Vd.** still preserves the *v* of *vuestra*.

Why it's said this way

A title like “your grace” refers to a respected person in the third person. That is why modern *usted* still takes the he/she verb form even while it means “you.” The social history remains visible in the grammar.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the two-word title that became *usted*
- “usted” followed by “mercy” and “merchant” — the *merc-* family
- which verb pattern *usted* takes

Before you move on

What did *vuestra merced* mean? (“Your grace” or “your mercy.”) Why does *usted* take the he/she verb form? (It began as a third-person title.) And the third “you” you met last lesson — which is it, and do you say it or just know it? (*Vos*; you recognise it, and keep saying *tú*.)

5.5 Choosing your “you” — putting it together

Three words, one choice, and it is social rather than grammatical. Nothing new in this lesson — only what you already have.

The exchange

To a friend: **tú**. To a stranger, an elder, an official: **usted**. Heard across the Southern Cone and Central America: **vos** — understand it, keep saying *tú*.

What you've built

You know which word to reach for, and why *usted* takes the shape it does.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the whole exchange, both parts, without stopping
- it again, faster, and let it sound like speech rather than recital

Twice through:

Before you move on

Run it once more from memory. If a word does not come, go back one lesson rather than pushing on — this chapter is short on purpose.

Chapter 6

Asking Someone's Name

Modes: 🗣️ voice (6) 👁️ eyes (1) ✍️ pen (1) 🗣️ Hands-free start: first 1 of 8 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can ask someone's name in either register and say it was a pleasure.

Asking Someone's Name — the chapter run end to end.

6.1 cómo — “how,” your first question word

To ask someone's name or how they are, you need this word first.

Cómo — “how” — and hiding inside it is a little Latin word for “manner” that you already own a dozen English versions of.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

cómo — “how.” Root: Latin **quo modo** — not a word but a **two-word phrase**, “in what **manner**.”

The two halves, and their English cousins:

- *modo* (“manner, measure”) → English **mode**, **modal**, **model**, **moderate**, **modify**, commodity.
- *quo* (“in what”) is the Latin question-stem **qu-**, the seed of nearly every Spanish question word.

How the phrase became one word — the wearing-down. Spanish did not borrow *cómo* ready-made; it **eroded** out of *quo modo* over

centuries of everyday speech. The final *-do* fell off and the middle collapsed:

quomodo → *quomo* → **como**

The *qu-* (a *kw* sound) flattened to a plain *k*, written *c* before *o*. What is left is a whole Latin phrase worn smooth — the way a pebble loses its edges in a river. The same erosion gave Italian *come*, Portuguese *como*, French *comme*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “cómo” — *CÓ-mo*, stress on the first syllable
- “cómo” then English “mode”, “model” — the *modo* root
- the erosion — “quo modo, quomo, como”

Before you move on

What does *cómo* mean? (“How.”) Walk the erosion: *quo modo* → ? → *cómo*. (*Quomo* → *como*.) What did the two Latin halves mean? (*Quo*, “in what”; *modo*, “manner” — the root of English *mode* and *model*.) Next: the two marks Spanish puts on a question.

6.2 ¿cómo? — the two marks that say “this is a question”

You have the word *cómo*. Written down, it wears **two** marks that English has no equivalent for — and neither of them is decoration. Both do a job English leaves to word order and guesswork.

What to know first

- *cómo* — the word itself, and where it came from.

Script — the upside-down opener

Spanish questions open with an upside-down ¿ and close with a normal ?:
¿cómo?

Why? Spanish word order often does not change in a question — *cómo estás* looks the same whether you are asking or reporting. A reader coming to a long sentence would not know to raise their pitch until they hit the mark at the very end, by which time it is too late. The ¿ is a piece of engineering: it tells your voice, in advance, what shape the sentence has. Only the **question part** gets bracketed, not necessarily the whole line.

Grammar Lens: the accent that marks a question

Now watch the accent mark do real work:

written	means
cómo	“how?” — the question word
como	“like / as” — or “I eat”

Same letters, same sound. The written accent is the **only** thing marking the difference:

- ¿*Cómo* estás? — “**How** are you?”
- *Como* tú. — “Like you.” / *Yo como*. — “I eat.”

Every question word you will meet — *qué, dónde, cuándo, quién* — carries this accent for exactly this reason. It is not about stress (the stress is the same either way); it is a flag that says “**asking.**”

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “¿cómo?” — with question intonation, opening high
- the pair — “cómo” (how?) then “como” (like / I eat)

Before you move on

Why does Spanish open a question with ¿? (Word order often does not change, so the reader needs the warning **before** the sentence, not after.) What changes when the accent disappears from *cómo*? (It stops being the question word — *como* means “like / as,” or “I eat.”)

6.3 The *qu-* question family — one ancient pattern, many clues

You traced *cómo* back to Latin *quomodo*. Focus now on its first piece, *qu-*, without trying to use a whole set of new question words yet.

What to know first

- *cómo* — “how,” from Latin *quomodo*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Latin used a recurring *qu-* stem in questions. Spanish preserves that family, although centuries of sound change gave the modern forms different shapes:

Spanish clue	← Latin	future meaning
<i>qué</i>	<i>quid</i>	what
<i>quién</i>	<i>quem</i>	who
<i>cuál</i>	<i>qualis</i>	which
<i>cuándo</i>	<i>quando</i>	when
<i>cuánto</i>	<i>quantus</i>	how much
<i>cómo</i>	<i>quomodo</i>	how

These are previews, not vocabulary to produce today. For now, use the family only as an etymological clue: a question form beginning *qu-* or *cu-* may continue the same Latin pattern. *Dónde*, “where,” is an exception from Latin *de unde*, “from where.”

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the Latin source of *cómo*
- the recurring Latin question stem
- whether the table is today’s production list or a preview

Before you move on

Which old stem connects *qué*, *quién*, *cuándo*, and *cómo*? (*qu-*)
Which word in the preview is the exception? (*Dónde*.)

6.4 se llama — the reflexive that fits *usted*

You can say *me llamo* (“I call myself”). To ask someone *else* their name — especially formally, with *usted* — you need the version that loops back on *them*: *se llama*.

What to know first

- *me llamo* — the reflexive “I call myself.”
- *tú* / *usted* — and the key fact that *usted* takes *he/she* verb forms.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

se llama = **se** (“himself / herself / yourself-formal”) + **llama** (“calls”). So *se llama* = “he/she calls himself,” or — because *usted* uses third-person forms — “**you** (formal) call yourself.”

se — the reflexive pronoun for the third person (and for *usted*). Root: Latin **sē** (“himself, herself, itself”). That same *se-* — carrying the sense of “self / apart / aside” — is bolted onto a shelf of English words:

- **secede** — *se* + *cedere* (“go apart”).
- **seclude**, **segregate** (“apart from the flock”), **separate**.
- **seduce** — *se* + *ducere* (“lead aside”).
- **secure** — *se* + *cura* (“free from care”), **secret** (“set apart”).

Every one is something turned in on itself or set apart — the same idea as a reflexive looping the action back on the doer.

Grammar Lens: the reflexive pronoun changes with the person

The verb *llamar* stays, but the little reflexive word in front shifts to match *who* is doing the calling:

- **me** llamo — *I* call myself
- **te** llamas — *you (informal, tú)* call yourself
- **se** llama — *he / she / you (formal, usted)* calls himself/yourself

Three persons, three pronouns: *me / te / se*. That *se* is exactly why the formal “what’s your name?” is *¿cómo se llama usted?* — *usted*, born from “your grace,” politely takes the *he/she* shape.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “se llama” — *seh YA-ma*
- the set — “me llamo, te llamas, se llama”
- “se” then “secede”, “seclude”, “separate” — the set-apart root

Before you move on

Which reflexive goes with *usted* — *te* or *se*? (*se* — because *usted* takes third-person forms.) What’s the “self/apart” root inside *secede* and *separate*? (Latin *se-*.)

6.5 ¿cómo se llama usted? — assembling the question, and answering it

Everything you built this chapter clicks into one sentence: how to ask a stranger their name, and how to answer back. This is your first real two-way exchange.

What to know first

- cómo · se llama · usted

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

¿Cómo se llama usted? = *cómo* (“how”) + *se llama* (“do you-formal call yourself”) + *usted* (“you,” formal).

Literally: “**How do you call yourself?**” Spanish asks *how*, not *what*, for a name — you’re asking by what name a person goes, the manner they’re called.

The informal version, for a friend, swaps the reflexive and drops the formal pronoun: **¿Cómo te llamas?** (*te llamas*, from *tú*). Same question, two registers — exactly the *tú/usted* choice from earlier, now live in a real sentence:

- To a stranger, an elder, a customer → *¿Cómo se llama usted?*
- To a friend, a child, a peer → *¿Cómo te llamas?*

How to answer

You already have the answer from the *me llamo* lesson: **Me llamo** ____.

— *¿Cómo se llama usted?* — **Me llamo David.**

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- ask a stranger their name — *¿cómo se llama usted?*
- ask a friend the same — *¿cómo te llamas?*
- the whole mini-exchange — ask, then answer with *me llamo* ____

Before you move on

Formal vs. informal “what’s your name”? (*¿Cómo se llama usted?* / *¿Cómo te llamas?*) Does Spanish literally ask “what” or “how” is your name? (“How” — *cómo*.)

6.6 mucho — “much,” and a sound-change you’ve already seen

One more word before “pleased to meet you.” *mucho* — “much, a lot” — and it hides the same Latin-to-Spanish sound trick you spotted in *noche*.

Sounds you'll need

- **soft-c** — the **ch** is the *ch* of *church*: *MOO-cho*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

mucho — “much, a lot.” Root: Latin **multus** (“much, many”). The English cousins keep the original *-lt-*:

- **multiple**, **multitude**, **multiply**, **multi-purpose**, **multimedia**.

The sound-change, again: Latin *multum* → Spanish *mucho*. The Latin **-lt-** softened into Spanish **-ch-** — the very same move as *noctem* → *noche* (*-ct-* → *-ch-*, as in the *noche* lesson). Spanish has a habit of melting these consonant clusters into *ch*. So a Spanish *-ch-* word very often points back to a Latin *-ct-* or *-lt-* root — and the English cousin usually preserves it (*nocturnal*, *multiple*).

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “mucho” — *MOO-cho*
- “mucho” then “multiple”, “multitude” — the *mult-* family
- “noche” and “mucho” — two words, same *-ch-* from a melted Latin cluster

Before you move on

mucho comes from Latin *multus* — what English words keep the *-lt-*? (multiple, multitude, multiply.) What Latin cluster melted into the *-ch-*? (*-lt-*, like *-ct-* did in *noche*.)

6.7 gusto → mucho gusto — “much pleasure”

The line you say when you shake someone’s hand. First the noun *gusto*, then snap *mucho* onto it, and you’ve got it.

What to know first

- mucho — “much,” about to modify *gusto*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el gusto (masculine) — “taste; pleasure, liking.” Root: Latin **gustus** (“a tasting, a taste”). The English cousins:

- **gustatory** — to do with the sense of taste.
- **disgust** — *dis-* (“not, opposite”) + *gust*: literally “**distaste**.”
- **gusto** — borrowed whole into English, meaning zest, relish, enjoyment.

False friend to flag: a *gust* of wind is **not** related — that one’s from Old Norse *gustr*. Same spelling, different root. Resemblance isn’t proof.

mucho gusto = *mucho* (“much”) + *gusto* (“pleasure”) = literally “**much pleasure**” — short for “it’s a great pleasure [to meet you].” *gusto* is masculine (*el gusto*), and *mucho* is in its plain masculine form to match it: another quiet piece of the agreement you’ve been building.

Why it’s said this way

Spanish greets a new acquaintance by naming the *pleasure* of it — “much pleasure” — where English names the *person* (“pleased to meet **you**”). The phrase works by itself, so this first exchange needs no extra reply formula.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “gusto” then “gusto” (English), “disgust”, “gustatory”
- “mucho gusto” — on meeting someone

Before you move on

What does *mucho gusto* literally mean? (“Much pleasure.”) Is *el gusto* masculine or feminine? (Masculine.) And the English cousin of *gusto* built from *dis-*? (*Disgust* — “distaste.”)

6.8 Practice — introducing yourself

Ten lessons of atoms now assemble into a real conversation. No new words — just the exchange, run both formally and informally until the *tú* / *usted* choice is automatic.

The exchange

Formal (a stranger, an elder, a customer):

— Buenos días. Me llamo Susana. **¿Cómo se llama usted?**
 — Me llamo David. **Mucho gusto.**

Informal (a friend, a peer): only two words change, and they’re the ones that carry the whole social difference:

— ¡Hola! Me llamo Susana. **¿Cómo te llamas?** — Me llamo David. Mucho gusto.

What you’ve built

- **me llamo** — introduce yourself (“I call myself”).
- **tú** / **usted** — the informal vs. formal “you,” and *why* (the retired *thou*; *usted* from “your grace”).
- **¿cómo te llamas?** / **¿cómo se llama usted?** — ask a name, in either register, the pronoun (*te* / *se*) tracking the choice.
- **mucho gusto** — “much pleasure,” pleased to meet you.

And one from two chapters back, because it is worth keeping warm: *buenos días* but *buenas tardes* — the describing word copies its noun.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the full *formal* exchange, both parts
- the same exchange *informally* — catch yourself on *se llama* → *te llamas*
- for a police officer, then your best friend — which “you” for each, and why?

Twice through: Run the formal version start to finish without stopping.

Before you move on

Which two words change between the formal and informal introduction? (*se llama usted* → *te llamas*.) Next chapter, you will learn how to ask how someone is doing.

Chapter 7

Thank You, Yes, and No

Modes: 🗣️ voice (5) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can thank someone, answer when I am thanked, and say yes or no.

Thanks, the answer to thanks, and the two words that let you accept or decline.

7.1 sí — yes

The smallest useful word — and the accent on it is doing real work.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

sí = **yes**. One syllable, said *see*.

The written accent is not decoration — it is the **whole difference** between two words:

- **sí** (with the accent) = **yes**
- **si** (no accent) = **if**

They sound almost identical, so Spanish uses the mark to tell them apart on the page: *Sí, si quieres* = “Yes, if you want.” Miss the accent and you’ve written “if” where you meant “yes.”

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

sí is Latin **sīc**, “thus, so” — answering a question with “just so,” exactly the move Latin also made with **ita** (“thus” = yes, from the Latin yes/no lesson). Its Romance cousins kept the same root:

Latin <i>sīc</i>	→
Spanish	sí
Italian	sì
Portuguese	sim

French is the odd one out — it went a completely different way for “yes” (*oui*), which its own lesson tells. But say *sí*, *sì*, *sim* in a row and you hear one Latin word answering across three countries.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “sí” — *see*, and picture the accent
- the pair — “sí” (yes) vs “sì” (if)
- the cousins — “sí, sì, sim” — all from Latin *sīc*

Before you move on

How do you say yes in Spanish? (**sí**.) What is the *only* difference between **sí** “yes” and **si** “if”? (The **written accent**.) What Latin word is *sí* from, and what did it mean? (**sīc** — “thus, so”.)

7.2 no — no / not

The easiest word yet — and it quietly does two jobs Spanish never splits apart.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

no = **no**. Said *noh*, a clean single vowel.

It is Latin **nōn** with almost nothing worn off — just the final consonant gone. Compare the family, all from the same *nōn*:

Latin <i>nōn</i>	→
Spanish	no
Italian	no
French	non

Why it's said this way

Here's the thing English splits and Spanish doesn't. English has “**no**” (the answer) and “**not**” (inside a sentence) — two different words. Spanish uses **no** for **both**:

- as the **answer**. Someone asks you something — anything at all — and this one syllable declines it. You do not need to understand the question to answer it, which is exactly why this word comes early.
- and later, as the word that turns a sentence around — but that needs a sentence first, so it waits until you have one. For now: **no** is how you decline, refuse, and disagree, which is most of what a beginner needs it for.

<!-- the negator sense is taught in ES-C06-hablo-espanol, the first lesson where the learner has a verb to put it in front of. Named by lesson id, never by chapter number: an earlier version of this comment gave a number, went stale across three rennumbers, was “fixed” with a fresh number, and went stale again two PRs later. Chapter numbers move; lesson ids do not. -->

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “no” — *noh*
- “No.” — flat, once, the way you would decline a second coffee
- “Sí.” then “No.” — the two shortest complete answers in Spanish

Before you move on

How do you say no in Spanish? (**no**.) What Latin word is it from? (**nōn**.) Spanish *no* does the work of which **two** English words? (“**no**” the answer, and later the word for “not.”) Where does *no* go to negate a sentence? (**Right before the verb.**)

7.3 gracias — “thank you,” and a whole family of English words

You can now introduce yourself. The next exchange is *how are you?* — but every answer ends the same polite way, so we learn the courtesy word first: **gracias**.

Sounds you’ll need

- **vowel-a** — the clean *ah* of *father*, twice.
- **r-tap** — a single flicked *r* (not the English one, and not yet the rolled *rr*): the tongue taps once, like the middle of American *butter*.
- **ci-th-s** — the *ci* is a soft *s* in Latin America (**GRAH-syahs**) and a soft *th* in most of Spain (**GRAH-thyahs**). Either is correct — pick one.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

gracias is the plural of **gracia** (“grace, favour”), from Latin **grātia** — *favour freely given*. Saying *gracias* literally offers someone “graces,” i.e. good will in return for theirs.

That one Latin root **grātia** fans out across English — once you see it, you get a fistful of words for free:

- **grace, gracious, graceful** — the direct borrowings.
- **grateful, gratitude** — being *full of* grātia.
- **gratis, gratuity** — something given as a *favour* (for free, or a tip).
- **congratulate** — literally “to wish grace *together with* someone.”

- Italian **grazie**, French *grâces*, Portuguese *graças* — the whole Romance family kept *grātia*, even where everyday thanks went elsewhere (French says *merci*, Portuguese *obrigado*).

So *gracias* is not a word to memorize cold: it is **grace**, made plural and handed to another person.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “gracias” — *GRAH-syahs*, one soft tap on the *r*
- “gracias” then English “grace, grateful, gratitude” — one family

Before you move on

What everyday English word is *gracias* the plural of, at the root? (*Grace*.) So when you thank someone in Spanish, you are literally handing them — what? (Graces / favours.) Next: the little reply that closes the exchange, **de nada**.

7.4 de nada — “you’re welcome,” or “it was nothing”

Someone says **gracias**. You need the reply that closes the loop: **de nada** — literally “*of nothing*.” You’re waving the favour off as no trouble at all — the same move English makes with “*it’s nothing*” / “*no problem*.”

Sounds you’ll need

- **d-soft** — the *d* in *nada* is soft, almost the *th* of *this* (**NAH-thah**), not a hard English *d*. Spanish *d* between vowels always softens.
- **vowel-a** — three clean *ah* sounds: *deh NAH-thah*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

- **de** = “of / from” (Latin **dē**) — the same *de* hiding in English depart, deduct, descend.
- **nada** = “nothing.” And this is the beautiful part.

nada comes from Latin (**rēs**) **nāta** — “(a thing) *born*.” From *nāscī*, “to be born,” the same root as English **native**, **nature**, **natal**, **re-nais-sance** (re-birth). Latin speakers said *nōn est rēs nāta*, “there is not a born thing” — *not a single thing that ever came into being* — and over centuries the emphatic *nāta* (“born thing”) wore down until **the word for ‘born thing’ became the word for ‘nothing’ itself**.

So the reply *de nada* literally says “**of [a] born-thing**” → “of nothing at all.” French did the identical trick with **rien** (“nothing”) — which is Latin **rem**, “a thing.” Two languages, same move: the word for *thing* collapses into the word for *nothing*.

Grammar Lens: the courtesy pair

gracias → *de nada* is a fixed **adjacency pair**: one turn expects the other. Learn them as a unit, the way English glues *thank you* → *you’re welcome*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “gracias” ... “de nada” — the full exchange, both voices
- “de nada” then English “native, nature, natal” — nada’s true family

Before you move on

nada (“nothing”) started life as the Latin word for a *born* — what? (A *thing* — *rēs nāta*, a born thing.) What English words share that “born” root? (Native, nature, natal, renaissance.) Next: the verb the whole “how are you?” question turns on — **estar**.

7.5 Thank you, yes, and no — putting it together

Two words that travel everywhere together. Nothing new in this lesson — only what you already have.

The exchange

— **Gracias.** — **De nada.**

And the two words that let you answer anything at all:

— ¿...? — **Sí.** / — **No.**

What you've built

You can thank someone, answer when you are thanked, and — for the first time — accept or decline. Until you have *sí* and *no*, every question anyone asks you is unanswerable.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the whole exchange, both parts, without stopping
- it again, faster, and let it sound like speech rather than recital

Twice through:

Before you move on

Run it once more from memory. If a word does not come, go back one lesson rather than pushing on — this chapter is short on purpose.

Chapter 8

How Are You

Modes: 🗣️ voice (4) 🖱️ Hands-free start: all 4 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can ask a stranger how they are.
Greeting plus the question that opens almost every conversation.

8.1 *estar* — “to be,” the *standing* kind

To ask *how are you?* Spanish needs a verb for **being**. Today just the verb itself and where it came from; how to use it, and its two forms, come next.

Sounds you’ll need

- **st-no-e** — Spanish never starts a word with a bare *st-*; it props it up with an *e*: *es-TAR*. (That reflex is why Spanish speakers say *e-Spain*, *e-student* — the same *e* that Latin *stāre* grew to become *estar*.)
- **r-tap** — the final *r* is one soft tap: *es-TAR*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

estar comes straight from Latin **stāre**, “*to stand*.” Hold onto that picture: it is the whole reason this verb behaves the way it does. How you are **standing** at this moment — well, tired, here, there — is a snapshot, not a permanent fact.

That root **stā-/sta-** is one of the most productive in English. *Estar*

hands you a large family for free:

- **stay, stand, stance, station, stable, stationary** — to stand or stay put.
- **state, status, statue, estate** — a way of *standing* (your state is how you stand).
- **constant, circumstance, substance** — “standing with / around / under.”

So *¿cómo estás?* is, at the root, “**how are you standing?**”

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “estar” — *es-TAR*, with the little propping *e*
- “estar” then English “stay, state, status, stable” — all *standing*

Before you move on

Which Latin verb is *estar* — “to be” or “to stand”? (To **stand** — *stāre*.) Why does Spanish put an *e* on the front? (It never begins a word with bare *st*.) Name two English cousins. (*Stay, state, status, stable, estate*...) Next: the two forms you will actually ask with.

8.2 estás / está — the two forms, and what they are for

Estar is “to stand.” Now put it to work. Two forms, one job: saying how somebody is **right now**.

What to know first

- *estar* — the verb and its Latin “to stand” root.
- *tú* or *usted* — why *usted* takes he/she forms.

Grammar Lens: state and location use *estar*

Use **estar** for a **current state** or a **location** — the two things that can change without changing what something *is*:

- a state: *estoy bien* — “I’m well” (today; maybe not tomorrow).
- a location: *está aquí* — “it’s here” (for now).

“How are you?” asks about a current state, so it takes *estar*. Spanish has a second be-verb for identity, and it arrives in its own later lesson; keeping it out of today’s drill lets one contrast settle at a time.

Grammar Lens: the two forms you need

you’re addressing	form	reads as
tú (informal)	estás	“you are”
usted (formal)	está	“you are”

Notice that **está** is also “he is / she is.” That is not a coincidence and not something extra to learn — it is the *usted*-takes-he/she-forms rule you already met, showing up for the first time in a real verb.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “estás” ... “está” — the two forms you’ll ask with
- which one goes with *tú*, which with *usted*
- a state, then a location — “estás bien”, “está aquí”

Before you move on

What two kinds of thing does *estar* cover? (**Current state** and **location**.) Which form goes with *tú*, and which with *usted*? (*Estás*; *está*.) Why is *está* also “he/she is”? (Because *usted* takes the **he/she** verb forms.) Next lesson, you finally ask it: **¿cómo está usted?**

8.3 ¿cómo está usted? — “how are you?”

Everything you’ve built this chapter now snaps together into one question. You already met **cómo** (“how”) and the **tú / usted** choice back in when you first met them; you just learned **estar**. Assemble them.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

¿Cómo está usted? = “How are you?” (formal) literally:
“In what manner are you standing?”

- **cómo** = “how / in what manner”
- **está** = “you are” (the *usted*/he-she form of **estar** — state, not identity)
- **usted** = the formal “you”

Note the **¿** — Spanish opens a question with an upside-down mark so you know the melody is coming before you start reading aloud. (We take that mark apart in a dedicated writing lesson.)

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “¿Cómo está usted?” — formal, for a stranger
- the pieces — “cómo + está + usted”

Before you move on

Which be-verb does “how are you?” use — *ser* or *estar*, and why? (*estar* — it’s about your current state.) What changes between formal and informal? (**The next step changes the ending and pronoun.**) Next: choosing the register.

8.4 How are you — putting the question together

You have a second “to be” and the question it carries. Nothing new here — only what you already have.

The exchange

— Buenos días. **¿Cómo está usted?**

The answer is the next chapter. Asking is this one.

What you've built

You can ask a stranger how they are, which is the question that opens almost every conversation you will ever have in Spanish.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “¿Cómo está usted?” — to someone you have just met
- the greeting and the question together, as one breath

Twice through:

Before you move on

Which “to be” carries how someone is, and why? (*Estar* — a state, not an identity.) Ask the question once more from memory.

Chapter 9

Answering, and Handing It Back

Modes: 🗣️ voice (4) 🖱️ Hands-free start: all 4 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can answer how I am, choose my register, and return the question.

The answer, the register choice inside it, and handing the question back.

9.1 ¿cómo está usted? / ¿cómo estás? — choose the register

You can already ask a stranger **¿Cómo está usted?** Now change only the relationship: ask the same question of a friend.

Grammar Lens: one question, two relationships

register	question
formal (stranger, elder, customer)	¿Cómo está usted?
informal (friend, peer, child)	¿Cómo estás?

The formal version uses the third-person ending **está** plus **usted**. The informal version uses second-person **estás** and normally omits **tú**. This is the same relationship contrast you drilled with **se llama** / **te llamas**.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- to a doctor you just met — “¿Cómo está usted?”
- to your cousin — “¿Cómo estás?”
- swap back and forth — “está usted / estás”

Twice through: Ask both versions until the ending swap is automatic.

Before you move on

Which version fits a stranger? (¿Cómo **está** usted?) Which fits a friend? (¿Cómo **estás**?) What two things change? (The **verb ending** and the **pronoun**.)

9.2 regular / más o menos — the honest “so-so”

You asked *¿cómo estás?* Now you can answer three ways: great, middling, or a wave of the hand. You already have **bien** (“well”). Today, the *middling* answers — because nobody is *bien* every day.

What to know first

Recall **bien** — “well.” Root? (Latin *bene*, “well” — same as *benefit*, *benevolent*.) So *estoy bien* = “I’m well.” Now the answer for when you’re *not* quite bien.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

regular — as an answer to “how are you?”, it means “so-so, average, not great.” (A famous false-friend trap: it does **not** mean English “regular / normal / usual” here.) From Latin **rēgula**, a *straight rod* a builder used to check a line — the **ruler**. So *regular* is “on the rule, on the average line” → middling.

That *rēgula* rod is everywhere in English: **rule**, **ruler**, **regulate**, **regular**, **regiment**, and even **rail** (a straight rod). All the same straight stick.

más o menos — “more or less,” the shrug-answer:

- **más** = “more,” from Latin **magis** (“more”) — cousin of *major*, *master*, *maximum*.

- **menos** = “less,” from Latin **minus** — the very word English borrowed for *minus*, *minor*, *minimum*, *minuscule*.

So *más o menos* is literally “**more or less**” — the exact phrase, root for root, that English uses for the same shrug.

Grammar Lens: a small answer set

You now have a scale to answer *¿cómo estás?*:

answer	sense
(muy) bien	(very) well
regular	so-so
más o menos	more or less / meh

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “regular” — *reh-goo-LAR*, soft tap on both *r*’s
- “más o menos” — a little shrug in the voice
- answer “¿cómo estás?” three ways — bien / regular / más o menos

Before you move on

As an answer, does *regular* mean “normal” or “so-so”? (So-so — the false-friend trap.) What straight-rod Latin word is it from, and what English “rod” words share it? (*rēgula* → rule, ruler, regulate, rail.) Next: put the whole exchange together.

9.3 y / ¿y tú? — pass the question back

You can ask how someone is and answer. One tiny connector turns that exchange around so the other person gets a turn too.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Y means **and** and sounds like Spanish **i**: *ee*. It continues Latin **et**, also “and.” English borrowed that Latin word intact inside **et cetera**,

literally “and the rest.”

Grammar Lens: the shortest return question

Put **y** before a person you already know:

- **¿Y tú?** — And you? (*informal*)
- **¿Y usted?** — And you? (*formal*)

Nothing else needs repeating. The little question hands the previous topic back to the other person.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “Bien. ¿Y tú?” to a friend
- “Regular. ¿Y usted?” to a stranger
- “y” — one clear *ee* sound

Before you move on

What does **y** mean? (**And.**) How do you hand a question back to a friend? (**¿Y tú?**) To a stranger? (**¿Y usted?**) Which Latin word survives inside English **et cetera**? (**Et**, “and.”)

9.4 Asking how someone is — putting it together

Now the question, its answer, and the register choice inside it.
Nothing new in this lesson — only what you already have.

The exchange

— **¿Cómo está usted?** — **Bien**, gracias. **¿Y usted?** — **Regular**.

What you've built

You can ask how someone is, formally or not, answer honestly, and hand the question back.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the whole exchange, both parts, without stopping
- it again, faster, and let it sound like speech rather than recital

Twice through:

Before you move on

Run it once more from memory. If a word does not come, go back one lesson rather than pushing on — this chapter is short on purpose.

Chapter 10

The Written Accent

Modes:  voice (1)  pen (2)  Hands-free start: none of the 3 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can hear where a Spanish word is stressed and see why the accent is written.

The Written Accent — the chapter run end to end.

10.1 á é í ó ú — the acute accent, and the two jobs it does

You’ve been reading accented words since your very first noun — **dí**a, **có**mo, **está**, **má**s. Time to make that little stroke make sense. Spanish uses one mark to write exceptional stress — the *acute* accent, ´, leaning right — and it does two jobs in the words you know. Learn the stress job now; the next lesson adds its grammar-label job.

Script — shape and stroke

A short stroke rising **left-to-right**, sitting on top of a vowel: **á é í ó ú**. (On the *í*, it replaces the dot.) One clean up-stroke — the opposite lean from the French *grave* accent â. Spanish never uses grave or circumflex; if it leans the wrong way, it isn’t Spanish.

Grammar Lens: the mark records exceptional stress

Spanish stress is regular, so most words need **no** mark. The default:

- word ends in a **vowel, -n, or -s** → stress the **second-to-last** syllable (*ho-la*, *lla-mo*, *gus-to*).
- word ends in **any other consonant** → stress the **last** syllable (*us-**ted***, *re-gu-**lar***, *es-**tar***).

The accent appears **only when a word breaks that rule** — it marks the exception. *está* ends in a vowel, so the rule wants *ES-ta*; the accent overrides it to *es-**TÁ***. *cómo* ends in a vowel (rule wants *co-**MO***) but is stressed *CÓ-mo*, so it gets the mark. The accent is a **spoken stress you can see** — it never changes the vowel’s sound, only which syllable you hit.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “hola, llamo, gusto” — second-to-last stress
- “usted, regular, estar” — final stress
- “está, cómo” — the accent overrides the default

Before you move on

How many accent marks does Spanish have, and which way does it lean? (One — the acute, ´, rising left-to-right.) Its two jobs? (Mark irregular stress; the next step covers its look-alike job.) When does a word ending in a vowel, **-n**, or **-s** need an accent? (**When its stress breaks the second-to-last default.**)

10.2 el or él? — the accent as a meaning label

You know **el** as the article “the.” Add one acute accent and the same two letters do a different job.

Grammar Lens: one mark, two grammatical jobs

The **tilde diacrítica** separates words that otherwise look alike:

no accent	with accent
el = the	él = he
The two words are pronounced alike. Here the accent does not move stress; it labels meaning and grammar. Other pairs will arrive only when you know both words, so this lesson asks you to hold one contrast, not memorize a list.	

Your turn

- *Say it:* “el” — the
- *Say it:* “él” — he
- *Write it:* **el** / **él**, adding the meaning-label accent only to the pronoun

Before you move on

What is the accent’s second job? (**Separate look-alike words.**) Which means “the”? (**El**, no accent.) Which means “he”? (**Él**, with the accent.) Does this mark change their stress? (**No — it labels the job.**)

10.3 The written accent — putting it together

Two lessons on one small mark that changes both sound and meaning. Nothing new in this lesson — only what you already have.

The exchange

está is not *esta*. *él* is not *el*.

What you’ve built

You can hear where the stress falls and see why the mark is there.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the whole exchange, both parts, without stopping
- it again, faster, and let it sound like speech rather than recital

Twice through:

Before you move on

Run it once more from memory. If a word does not come, go back one lesson rather than pushing on — this chapter is short on purpose.

Chapter 11

Enye and the Upside-Down Marks

Modes: ⇄ voice (1) ✍ pen (4) ⇄ Hands-free start: none of the 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can read and write ñ and the upside-down question and exclamation marks.

Enye and the Upside-Down Marks — the chapter run end to end.

11.1 ñ — the letter that remembers a doubled n

ñ is the one letter English does not have — and it has the best origin story in the alphabet. That wavy hat (~, a *tilde*) is not decoration. It is **a tiny second n, written on top to save space**. Once you know that, you know both how to write it *and* why it sounds as it does.

Sounds you'll need

ñ = the *ny* in “canyon” or “onion” — one squished sound, tongue flat against the roof of the mouth. English *canyon* is, in fact, Spanish **cañón** with the ñ spelled out as *ny*. Say “onion,” freeze on the middle: that is ñ.

Script — how to write it

Write a normal **n**, then a small wavy ~ floating above it. Two strokes, one letter.

Careful: ñ is its own letter, not “n with an accent.” *año* (“year”) and *ano* (a rather different word) are completely different words — the tilde is not an optional flourish, it is a distinct letter of the alphabet, with its own slot in the dictionary.

Why it’s said this way

That wave is a **medieval shorthand**. Scribes copying Latin were forever writing double letters, so they saved a stroke: write the letter **once**, and put a little mark above meaning “...and one more of these.” A bar over a vowel meant a dropped *n* or *m* (Latin *tantum* → *tātum*); a wave over an *n* meant **nn**.

Spanish is full of words where a Latin **-nn-** did exactly this:

- Latin **annus** (“year”) → *anno* → **año**. (That same *annus* gives English **annual**, **anniversary**, bi-**ennial**.)
- Latin **canna** (“reed”) → **caña**; Latin *domina* → *donna* → **doña**.

So the tilde on ñ is a **frozen abbreviation** — a thousand-year-old note saying “there used to be two *n*’s here.” You are writing a scribe’s shortcut.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “año” — *AH-nyo*, one squished *ny*; then English “annual”
- the doubled-n words — “año, caña, doña”

Before you move on

What is the tilde on ñ, really? (A tiny second *n* — a scribe’s shorthand for a doubled *nn*.) What Latin word gives *año*, and what English words share it? (*Annus* → annual, anniversary.) Is ñ a separate letter or an accented *n*? (A **separate letter**.) Next: the two everyday words you will be writing it in.

11.2 mañana, español — the ñ in the words you are about to need

You can write **ñ** and you can say it. Two of the next words in this book carry it, and both are worth a minute on their own — because neither of them got its *ñ* from a doubled *n*.

What to know first

- **ñ** — the letter, the sound, and the scribe’s shorthand.

Script — the two forms

- **mañana** — “tomorrow,” and also “morning.” *ma-NYA-na*: the *ñ* is in the **middle**, and it is the stressed syllable.
- **español** — “Spanish.” *es-pa-NYOL*: the *ñ* is at the **end**, right before the *-ol*.

Now the honest footnote. The scribe’s doubled *nn* is **one** road to *ñ*, the one you met with *año*. These two words took a **different** road: Latin’s **-ni-** before a vowel. *Mañana* traces back through *maneana* to **māne** (“morning” — the root of English **matinée**); *español* comes from **Hispaniolus**, built on **Hispania**. In both, a *ni* sequence squeezed together into the same single palatal sound.

So *ñ* is where **two** separate Latin sequences ended up — *-nn-* and *-ni-*. One letter, one sound, two histories.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “año, mañana, español” — the *ñ* in three positions
- the two roads — “año, from *-nn-*” then “mañana, from *-ni-*”

Before you move on

Where does the *ñ* sit in *mañana*, and where in *español*? (Middle; end.) Did those two get their *ñ* from a doubled *n*? (**No** — from Latin **-ni-** before a vowel, a second road to the same letter.) What was the first road? (**-nn-**, the scribe’s shorthand, as in *año*.)

11.3 ¿ ¡ — the marks that open a question

You’ve been writing them since *¿cómo está usted?* Spanish is the one major language that puts an **upside-down** question or exclamation mark at the **start** of the sentence, as well as the normal one at the end. It looks exotic; the reason is purely practical.

Script — the two opening marks

- ¿ ... ? wraps a question: *¿Cómo estás?*
- ¡ ... ! wraps an exclamation: *¡Hola! ¡Gracias!*

The opening mark is just the closing mark **flipped 180°** — turned upside down *and* left-right. To write ¿, draw a normal ? and rotate it half a turn: the hook ends up at the bottom, the dot on top.

Why it’s said this way

English lets you read most of a sentence before the final ? reveals it was a question — fine, because English usually flags a question early with word order (“Are you...”, “Do you...”). Spanish often **doesn’t reorder words**: *Tienes hambre*. (“You’re hungry.”) and *¿Tienes hambre?* (“Are you hungry?”) are the **same words** — only punctuation and the spoken rising tone tell them apart.

So the Spanish Royal Academy, in **1754**, made the opening ¿ official: it warns the reader “*a question is starting — read this with rising intonation from the very first word.*” It’s a **melody cue placed before the melody**, the exact same instinct as the written accent marking stress you can’t otherwise see. For a language read aloud, it’s genuinely useful.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- read “¿Cómo estás?” — start the rising *question* melody from the very first word, the way the ¿ tells you to
- “¡Hola!” — the ¡ warns you to begin with exclamation energy

Before you move on

Why does Spanish open a question with ¿? (Because word order often doesn't change, so the reader needs an early warning to use question intonation.) How do you write it? (A normal ? rotated 180°.) Does it always sit at the sentence's start? (**The next step places it around a question inside a larger sentence.**)

11.4 Where does ¿ begin? — bracket the spoken span

You can open a whole question with ¿. Now place that mark inside a larger sentence, exactly where the questioning voice begins.

Script — bracket the spoken span

The opening mark goes where the **question** begins, even if the sentence started earlier:

Roberto, ¿cómo estás?

The name **Roberto** is outside the question. The marks bracket the words that need question intonation. The same principle works for an exclamation:

Roberto, ¡buenos días!

This is why the opening mark is more than decoration. It tells the reader exactly where to begin and end a change in spoken melody.

Your turn

- *Write it:* “María, ¿cómo estás?”
- *Write it:* “María, ¡buenos días!”
- *Say it:* begin the new melody at ¿ or ¡, not at the first capital

Before you move on

In **Roberto, ¿cómo estás?**, is **Roberto** inside the question? (**No.**) Where does the inverted mark go? (**At the start of the question or exclamation span.**) What does that placement tell a reader? (**Where to change the spoken melody.**)

11.5 Practice — “how are you?”, start to finish

No new words. This chapter’s atoms — *gracias*, *de nada*, *estar*, *¿cómo está?*, *regular* — now assemble into a real exchange, run formally and informally until the register swap is automatic. It picks up right where the introduction left off.

The exchange

Formal (a stranger, an elder, a customer):

— Buenos días. **¿Cómo está usted?** — **Bien, gracias.** ¿Y usted? — **Más o menos.** — [reply to a thanks, later in the chat] **De nada.**

Informal (a friend, a peer) — only the verb + pronoun change:

— ¡Hola! **¿Cómo estás?** — **Regular.** ¿Y tú? — Bien, gracias.

The glue pattern you just secured is **¿y usted?** / **¿y tú?** — “and you?” It bounces the question back without repeating the whole sentence.

What you’ve built this chapter

- **gracias** — thank you (← *grātia*, “grace”).
- **de nada** — you’re welcome (← “of a born-thing” → “of nothing”).
- **estar** — the state/location be-verb (← *stāre*, “to stand”).
- **¿cómo está usted?** / **¿cómo estás?** — how are you, formal / informal.
- **bien** / **regular** / **más o menos** — well / so-so / more-or-less.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the full *formal* exchange, both voices
- the same exchange *informally* — catch *está* → *estás*, *usted* → *tú*
- chain the two — introduce yourself *and* ask how they are: “Me llamo ... ¿Cómo está usted?”

Twice through: Run the formal exchange, greeting to answer, without stopping.

Before you move on

Which be-verb carries “how are you?” and why? (*estar* — current state.) Two words swap between formal and informal — which? (*está* → *estás*, and *usted* → *tú*.) What does *de nada* literally say? (“Of nothing.”) And if the person answering you says **vos** instead of *tú* — do you switch? (*No. You understand it and keep saying tú.*) Next chapter: **farewells** — hasta luego, hasta mañana, adiós.

Chapter 12

Goodbye

Modes: 🗣️ voice (4) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 4 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can end a conversation, and I know the word every softer goodbye is built from.

Goodbye — the chapter run end to end.

12.1 adiós — “goodbye,” or “to God”

You can greet, introduce yourself, and ask how someone is. Time to leave gracefully. The final, plainest parting is **adiós** — and, like the English *goodbye*, it’s a tiny prayer worn smooth.

Sounds you’ll need

- diphthong-io — the *-íos* is one glide, *ee-OHS*: *ah-DYOHS*, stress on the end (that’s what the accent on *ó* marks — remember the acute-accent lesson).

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

adiós is **a + Dios** — “to God.” It’s the front half of an old blessing, *a Dios te encomiendo*, “I commend you to God” — said to someone setting off, when a journey was dangerous and you left them in God’s keeping.

Every Romance sister kept the same farewell-prayer:

language	goodbye	literally
Spanish	<i>adiós</i>	“to God”
French	<i>adieu</i>	“to God” (<i>à Dieu</i>)
Italian	<i>addio</i>	“to God”
Portuguese	<i>adeus</i>	“to God”

And English is doing the **exact same thing** without telling you: **goodbye** is a crushed-down “*God be with ye.*” So *adiós* and *goodbye* are, at heart, the same sentence — a blessing for the road.

- **Dios** (“God”) ← Latin **Deus** — the *Deus* of English *deity*, *divine*, *adieu*, and (via Greek *Zeus*, same root) the whole sky-god family.

Grammar Lens: *adiós* is a *final* goodbye

adiós leans toward a **longer** parting — you won’t see them soon, or it’s the end of the day. For “see you later / tomorrow,” Spanish reaches for **hasta ...**, which the rest of this chapter is about — and *hasta* has a surprising origin.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “*adiós*” — *ah-DYOHS*, stress the end
- *adiós* / *adieu* / *addio* / *adeus* — four “to God” farewells
- English “goodbye” = “God be with ye” — the same prayer

Before you move on

What two words hide inside *adiós*? (*a* + *Dios* — “to God.”) What English goodbye is built the same way? (*Goodbye* ← “God be with ye.”) Is *adiós* for a quick “see you soon”? (No — it’s the longer/final parting; *hasta ...* comes next.) Next: **hasta**, and a word Spain borrowed from Arabic.

12.2 hasta — “until,” and Spain’s Arabic centuries

Spanish says “see you later” as **hasta luego** — literally “**until** later.” So the key word is **hasta**, “until.” And *hasta* carries the single most important fact about Spanish’s history: **for nearly 800 years, much of Spain spoke Arabic.**

Sounds you’ll need

- **silent-h** — Spanish **h** is always silent: **hasta** = *AHS-tah* (no breath on the *h* at all). Stress the front.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

hasta comes from Arabic **ḥattā**, “until, up to.” From **711 CE**, Muslim armies ruled much of the Iberian Peninsula — *al-Andalus* — and Arabic was the language of government, science, and poetry there for **centuries**, until 1492. Spanish absorbed roughly **four thousand** Arabic words in that time — more of its vocabulary than from any source except Latin itself.

Most of those loans are **nouns**, and you can spot a huge number by the frozen Arabic article **al-** (“the”) fused onto the front:

- **almohada** (pillow), **alcázar** (fortress), **alcalde** (mayor), **alfombra** (rug), **aduana** (customs), **álgebra**, **alcohol**.
- **azúcar** (sugar), **aceite** (oil), **naranja** (orange).

But **hasta** is rare and special: it is a **function word** — a preposition, part of the grammatical skeleton. Languages borrow nouns easily and grammar words almost never — so an Arabic *preposition* surviving in everyday Spanish shows how deep, how *intimate*, those centuries of contact were. (Its Latin rival *ad* “to”/*usque* “up to” simply lost.) You say a piece of al-Andalus every time you say goodbye.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “hasta” — *AHS-tah*, silent h

- “hasta” then Arabic *ḥattā* — the same word, 1,300 years apart

Before you move on

What language is *hasta* from, and what does it mean? (Arabic *ḥattā* — “until.”) Why is it remarkable that Spanish borrowed it? (It’s a *function word* / preposition — languages almost never borrow those; it shows how deep the Arabic centuries went.) How do you spot many Arabic nouns in Spanish? (The frozen *al-* article: *almohada*, *azúcar*, *álgebra*.)

12.3 hasta aquí / hasta la noche — point to the limit

You know **hasta** means “until” or “up to.” Give that small word one spatial endpoint and one temporal endpoint, using only one new word.

Grammar Lens: endpoints in space and time

Aquí means **here**. Put it after **hasta**:

hasta aquí — up to here

For a time endpoint, reuse **la noche**, “the night,” which you already have:

hasta la noche — until the night / until tonight

The same preposition points to a place or the end of a stretch of time. The next lessons will place new time words after it one at a time.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “aquí” — here
- “hasta aquí” — up to here
- “hasta la noche” — until tonight

Before you move on

What does **hasta** point to? (**An endpoint.**) Give one spatial and one temporal example. (**Hasta aquí; hasta la noche.**) What is the only new lexical item? (**Aquí**, “here.”)

12.4 Leaving — putting it together

One farewell that is final, and one word that opens all the others.
Nothing new in this lesson — only what you already have.

The exchange

Adiós — meant, and a little final. **Hasta** — “until,” and it is waiting for what comes next.

What you’ve built

You can close a conversation, and you have the word every softer goodbye is built from.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the whole exchange, both parts, without stopping
- it again, faster, and let it sound like speech rather than recital

Twice through:

Before you move on

Run it once more from memory. If a word does not come, go back one lesson rather than pushing on — this chapter is short on purpose.

Chapter 13

Until When

Modes: 🗣️ voice (4) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 4 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can pick the farewell that matches when I will next see someone.

Until When — the chapter run end to end.

13.1 hasta luego — the everyday “see you later”

This is the goodbye you’ll actually use most — friendly, casual, open-ended. **hasta luego**: “until later.” You already own **hasta** (“until”); today you add **luego** (“later”), and it has a very Latin backstory.

Sounds you’ll need

- diphthong-ue — **luego** = *LWEH-goh*: the *ue* is a *w*-glide, *lweh*-.
- The whole phrase: *AHS-tah LWEH-goh*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

hasta luego = “until later” → “see you later.”

- **hasta** = “until” (last lesson — Arabic *ḥattā*).
- **luego** = “later / then / soon,” from Latin **loco**, “at the place / at that point.” The idea slid from *place* → *point in time* → “then, next, soon.” So its cousins in English are all about **place**:

local, locus, location, locate, al-loc-ate. Spanish moved *loco* from *where* to *when*.

A nice contrast: **hasta luego** fuses an **Arabic** word and a **Latin** word in three syllables — the two great layers of Spanish, shaking hands as you leave.

Grammar Lens: the “hasta ...” family

hasta + a time word is Spanish’s whole toolkit of soft goodbyes. You’ll build the other two this chapter:

phrase	“until ...”	when
hasta luego	later	the default “see you”
hasta mañana	tomorrow	leaving for the day
hasta pronto	soon	you expect to meet again shortly

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “hasta luego” — *AHS-tah LWEH-goh*
- “luego” then English “local, location” — the *loco* “place” family
- “¡Adiós! ... no — ¡hasta luego!” — feel the difference: final vs. soon

Before you move on

What does *hasta luego* literally mean? (“Until later.”) What did *luego*’s Latin root *loco* first mean, and what English words keep it? (Place — *local, location, locus*.) Which two language layers meet in *hasta luego*? (Arabic *hasta* + Latin *luego*.) Next: **hasta mañana**.

13.2 hasta mañana — “see you tomorrow” (and the ñ returns)

Leaving for the day? **hasta mañana** — “until tomorrow.” It brings back a letter you studied in the writing lessons: the **ñ**. Here it is, living in a word you’ll say every evening.

Sounds you'll need

- enye-ny — **mañana** = *mah-NYAH-nah*: the **ñ** is the squished *ny* of “canyon” (your ñ writing lesson — the tilde is a tiny second *n*, remember). Three soft *ah*’s: *ma-ÑA-na*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

hasta mañana = “until tomorrow” → “see you tomorrow.”

- **hasta** = “until” (Arabic *hattā*).
- **mañana** = “tomorrow” — **and** “morning.” One word for both, from Latin (**hōra**) **maneana**, “the **early** hour” (from *māne*, “in the morning”). The logic: the next “early hour” you’ll see is *tomorrow morning* → *mañana* came to mean both **morning** and **tomorrow**.

The ñ, in the wild. Recall the writing lesson: *ñ* is a frozen *nn* — a scribe’s shorthand for a doubled *n*. *mañana* comes from Latin *maneana*, whose *n+ea* palatalized (softened) into that single *ñ* sound. So the tilde is a little historical fossil sitting in the middle of “tomorrow.”

Grammar Lens: same word, two meanings — context decides

mañana means “morning” **or** “tomorrow”; the sentence tells you which. Paired with *hasta*, it’s always **tomorrow**: *hasta mañana*, “until tomorrow.”

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “mañana” — *mah-NYAH-nah*, squished *ñ*
- “hasta mañana” — until tomorrow
- “mañana” once as “morning,” then once as “tomorrow” — context decides

Before you move on

What two meanings does *mañana* carry? (Morning; tomorrow.) With *hasta*, which one? (Tomorrow.) What sound is the *ñ*, and what is its tilde, historically? (The *ny* of “canyon”; a frozen doubled-*n*.) Next: **hasta pronto**.

13.3 hasta pronto — “see you soon”

The last of the “hasta ...” trio: **hasta pronto**, “until soon” — for when you genuinely expect to meet again shortly. One new word, **pronto**, and it’s hiding in plain sight in English.

Sounds you’ll need

- **hasta pronto** = *AHS-tah PRON-toh* — a clean *pr*, a pure *o*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

hasta pronto = “until soon” → “see you soon.”

- **hasta** = “until” (Arabic *ḥattā*).
- **pronto** = “soon / quickly / ready,” from Latin **promptus**, “brought forth, ready at hand” (from *prōmere*, “to bring out”). Something *prompt* is brought out **without delay** — so *pronto* slid to “soon.”

You already know its English twin: **prompt** (on time; to bring out a response), plus **prompter**, **promptly**, and the computer **prompt** (the cursor “ready” for input). Italian borrowed *pronto* too — it’s what Italians say when they pick up the phone (“*Pronto!*” = “Ready!”).

Grammar Lens: the “hasta ...” trio, complete

You now have Spanish’s three soft goodbyes, sharpest to vaguest in time:

phrase	until...	nuance
hasta pronto	soon	you'll meet again shortly
hasta luego	later	the neutral default "see you"
hasta mañana	tomorrow	you're parting for the day
...and adiós for the long or final goodbye.		

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “hasta pronto” — *AHS-tah PRON-toh*
- “pronto” then English “prompt, promptly” — one family
- the trio — hasta pronto / hasta luego / hasta mañana

Before you move on

What does *hasta pronto* mean, and *pronto*'s English twin? (“Until soon”; *prompt*.) What Latin word is it from, and its literal sense? (*promptus*, “brought forth / ready.”) Order the three *hasta* goodbyes by time. (pronto → luego → mañana.) Next: put the whole farewell set together.

13.4 Practice — saying goodbye

No new words. This chapter's farewells — *adiós* and the three *hasta ...* goodbyes — now close a real conversation, and fold back into the whole arc you've built since *hola*.

Grammar Lens: choosing the right goodbye

The choice is about **when you'll meet again**:

you're...	say
parting for good / a long time	Adiós.
expecting to meet again shortly	Hasta pronto.
just “see you” (neutral default)	Hasta luego.
leaving for the day	Hasta mañana.

The exchange — start to finish

Everything from Chapters 1–5, in one conversation:

— ¡Hola! Buenos días. Me llamo Ana. ¿Cómo se llama usted?
 — Me llamo Luis. Mucho gusto. — ¿Cómo está usted? — Bien,
 gracias. ¿Y usted? — Bien. **Hasta mañana**, Luis. — **Hasta
 mañana**, Ana. **¡Adiós!**

What you’ve built this chapter

- **adiós** — the plain/final goodbye (“to God”; twin of *goodbye*).
- **hasta** — “until,” Spain’s everyday Arabic word (← *ḥattā*).
- **hasta luego** / **mañana** / **pronto** — see you later / tomorrow / soon, each an Arabic + Latin handshake.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the full conversation above, both voices — greeting to goodbye
- pick the goodbye — for a friend you’ll see tomorrow? (*hasta mañana*); for someone moving away? (*adiós*)

Twice through: Run the whole exchange, *hola* to *adiós*, without stopping.

Before you move on

Which goodbye for someone you won’t see for a long time? (*Adiós.*)
 Which everyday word for “until” did Spanish take from Arabic? (*hasta.*)
 You can now open *and* close a conversation in Spanish. Next chapter: **por favor** and **gracias**’ partner courtesies, then into every-

day verbs.

Chapter 14

A Coffee, Please

Modes: 🗣️ voice (3) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 3 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can ask for something politely.

A Coffee, Please — the chapter run end to end.

14.1 café — coffee, and a place to drink it

Before you can make a polite request, you need one small thing to request. **Café** gives you a useful noun and lets the written accent do a job you already understand.

Sounds you'll need

Say **ca-FÉ**. A vowel-final word would normally stress the second-to-last syllable, so the acute accent records the unexpected final stress.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Spanish **café** came through Italian **caffè** and Turkish **kahve** from Arabic **qahwah**. English **coffee** reached the same travelling word by a different European route. The drink and the word both crossed languages.



The route from Arabic qahwah through Turkish kahve and Italian caffè to

Spanish café

Café can name the drink or the place, just as English **coffee** and **café** divide those jobs. It is masculine: **el café**.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “café” — final stress
- “el café”
- the route — “qahwah → kahve → caffè → café”

Before you move on

Where does the stress fall? (**On the final é.**) Why is the accent written? (**It overrides the usual vowel-final stress.**) What route carried the word into Spanish? (**Arabic qahwah → Turkish kahve → Italian caffè → Spanish café.**)

14.2 por favor — “please,” i.e. “for a favour”

You can already thank (*gracias*) and reply (*de nada*). The third courtesy completes the set: **por favor**, “please” — literally “*for [a] favour.*” You’re asking someone to do you a kindness.

Sounds you’ll need

- **r-tap** — one soft tapped *r* in *por* and *favor*.
- **v-b** — Spanish *v* and *b* sound **identical** (a soft *b*): *favor* ≈ *fah-BOR*. (So *favor* and English *favour* look alike *and* the *v* even sounds like the *b* you’d hear in “harbour.”)

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

- **por** = “for / through / by,” from Latin **prō** (“for, on behalf of”) — the same *pro-* in English **pronoun**, **propose**, **protect**.
- **favor** = “a favour, goodwill,” from Latin **favēre**, “to be

favourable to, to support.” It’s the very word English borrowed: **favour, favorite, favorable, favouritism.**

So *por favor* literally says “**for a favour**” — [*do this*] as a kindness to me. English **favour, favorite, and favorable** keep the same Latin family visible without asking you to learn another language’s formula.

Grammar Lens: the courtesy set is complete

You now hold the three pillars of politeness:

- **por favor** — please (asking).
- **gracias** — thank you (receiving).
- **de nada** — you’re welcome (replying).

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “por favor” — *por fah-BOR*, soft *v/b*
- “Café, por favor” — “Coffee, please”
- “favor” then English “favour, favorite” — one family

Before you move on

What does *por favor* literally mean? (“For a favour.”) What Latin verb is *favor* from, and its English cousins? (*favēre* — favour, favorite, favorable.) Which three-word courtesy loop do you now own? (*Por favor* → *gracias* → *de nada*.) Next: your first regular **verb** — *hablar*, “to speak.”

14.3 Ordering — putting it together

Your first transaction: a thing you want, and the word that makes it a request. Nothing new in this lesson — only what you already have.

The exchange

— Un **café**, **por favor**. — Gracias.

What you've built

You can ask for something and stay polite doing it.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the whole exchange, both parts, without stopping
- it again, faster, and let it sound like speech rather than recital

Twice through:

Before you move on

Run it once more from memory. If a word does not come, go back one lesson rather than pushing on — this chapter is short on purpose.

Chapter 15

When You Don't Understand

Modes: 🗣️ voice (3) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 3 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can say that I did not understand, and ask for it more slowly.

The two sentences that rescue a conversation, and the thanks that closes it.

15.1 no entiendo — the most useful sentence a beginner owns

Everything so far assumed you understood what was said to you. This chapter is for when you did not.

What to know first

No entiendo. — “I don’t understand.”

Say it whole. You already have **no**; the rest comes with it for now, and the piece you are not yet meant to take apart will come apart later.

This is not an admission of failure. It is the sentence that keeps a conversation alive — the alternative is nodding at something you did not catch.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

The word hiding inside *entiendo* comes from Latin **intendere** — literally *to stretch toward*. To understand something was to lean into it.

English took the same word and kept it in several places: **intend** (to stretch your mind toward a thing), **intense**, and — through the same

family — **attention**, which is what you are stretching when you listen hard.

So *no entiendo* is, underneath, “I am not managing to stretch that far yet.” Which is exactly true, and much kinder than “I failed.”

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “No entiendo.” — calmly, not apologetically
- it again, to someone speaking too fast

Before you move on

Say it once from memory. Which English word shares its root?

15.2 más despacio — the request that makes the last sentence solvable

Everything so far assumed you understood what was said to you.
This chapter is for when you did not.

What to know first

Más despacio, por favor. — “More slowly, please.”

No entiendo stops the conversation. This restarts it. Together they are the whole repair kit: say what went wrong, then say what would fix it.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Despacio comes from **de spatio** — “of space.” Latin **spatium** is English **space**, and also **spatial**.

Doing something *de spatio* meant doing it with room around it, unhurried. The sense drifted from space into time, which is a journey English made too: we still say we need *space* when we mean we need *time*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “Más despacio.” — calmly, not apologetically
- it again, to someone speaking too fast

Before you move on

Say it once from memory. Which English word shares its root?

15.3 When you don’t understand — putting it together

Two sentences. Between them they rescue almost any conversation.

The exchange

— *(something too fast to follow)* — **No entiendo. Más despacio, por favor.** — *(again, slower)* — **Gracias.**

What you’ve built

Until now, a sentence you missed was the end of the conversation. It is not any more. You can say what went wrong and what would fix it, and then thank someone for doing it — which is the difference between speaking a language badly and not speaking it at all.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- both sentences, one after the other, without a pause between them
- them again, then “Gracias.” — the whole repair, start to finish

Twice through:

Before you move on

What do you say when you did not follow? And what do you ask for next? Which English words hide inside *entiendo* and *despacio*? (*Intend, intense, attention* — and *space*.)

Chapter 16

Your First Verb, and the Form That Means I

Modes: ⇄ voice (3) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 3 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can say what I do, in one word, with no pronoun at all.

One word, one whole sentence — and why English cannot do the same.

16.1 hablar — “to speak,” which used to mean “to tell tales”

Fixed phrases got you this far. **Hablar** (“to speak”) is the first verb you will take apart and put back together. Today: the word itself. Next lesson: one ending, and it becomes about you.

Sounds you’ll need

- **silent-h** — the **h** is **completely silent**: *hablar* = *ah-BLAR*. (Spanish *h* never makes a sound.)
- **v-b** — the *b* is a soft *b*; *hablo* = *AH-bloh*.

That silent *h* is not an accident of spelling. Latin’s initial **f-** weakened in a whole set of Spanish words and eventually fell silent altogether, but the scribes kept writing a letter where it used to be — and that letter is **h**. You are looking at the gravestone of an *f*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

hablar comes from Latin **fābulārī**, “to chat, to tell tales” — from **fābula**, “a story.” So *to speak*, in Spanish, is at root *to tell stories*. Notice Latin had a plainer verb available (*loquī*, “to speak,” which English keeps in **eloquent** and **loquacious**) — and Spanish chose the chattier, more colourful one.

That **fābula** is thoroughly English: **fable**, **fabulous** (“story-like”), **con-fabulate**, and **ineffable** (“un-speak-able”).

The single path you need today is **fābulārī** → **hablar**; later words will let you test how broadly that *f* → *h*- pattern reaches.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “hablar” — *ah-BLAR*, silent *h*
- “hablar” then English “fable, fabulous, ineffable” — the *fābula* root
- the sound law — “fābulārī” then “hablar”

Before you move on

What Latin word is *hablar* from, and what English word shares it? (*Fābulārī* ← *fābula* — **fable**.) What happened to its initial Latin *f*? (It weakened away, leaving the written but **silent** Spanish *h*-.) Next: swap the *-ar* for one letter, and *hablar* becomes *I speak*.

16.2 hablo — “I speak”

What is the word for “to speak”? (*Hablar*.) Say it once.

What to know first

- *hablar* — the verb, and the *fābula* behind it.

Grammar Lens: change the ending, change who is speaking

Hablar is the naming form — “to speak.” It is not yet about anybody. To make it about **you**, take off the **-ar** and put **-o** in its place:

hablar → **hablo** — *I speak*.

That is the whole operation. One ending, swapped.
And notice what you did not have to do: you did not add a word for *I*.
The **-o** is already carrying it.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

The **-o** is old and it is nearly untouched. Latin marked “I” on a verb with **-ō**, a long *o*: *amō*, “I love.” Two thousand years later Spanish still marks “I” with exactly that letter.

Most of Latin’s endings wore down on the way to Spanish. This one did not. When you say *hablo*, the last sound in your mouth is the same one a Roman used to say *I*.

Worth noticing. English gave up. *Speak* is *speak* whoever is doing it, which is why English cannot let go of its pronouns. You will meet that difference properly in the very next lesson.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “hablo”
- “hablo” again, and hear that the *-o* is the part meaning *I*

Before you move on

How do you turn *hablar* into “I speak”? (Drop **-ar**, add **-o**.) Which Latin ending is that **-o**? (*-ō* — the same one.) Next: why *hablo* is already a complete sentence.

16.3 *hablo* — one word, one whole sentence

Say “I speak” in Spanish. (*Hablo*.) Now count the words you said.

Grammar Lens: the pronoun you never needed

One word. And it is a complete, ordinary, grammatical Spanish sentence.

English needs two — *I* and *speak* — because English's ending is doing no work. Spanish needs one, because the **-o** already said *I* in the previous lesson.

Spanish does have a word for *I*. You will meet it. But putting it in front of *hablo* is a little like saying “**I, I speak**” — the information is already there, and repeating it is something Spanish does only when it wants to make a point.

The habit to build now. When you want to say *I speak*, say **hablo**. Not two words. One.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

This is not Spanish being clever. It is English having lost something. Old English marked its verbs properly — *ic sprece*, *pū sprecest*, *hē spricþ*. Those endings were as distinct as Spanish's are. Then English wore them down until almost nothing was left: today *speak*, *speak*, *speak*, *speak*, *speaks*. Four of the five are identical.

Once the endings stopped telling you who was speaking, the pronoun had to, and English could never put it down again. Spanish kept its endings. So Spanish kept the choice.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “hablo” — one word, and stop there
- it as an answer to a real question, as if someone just asked whether you speak

Before you move on

How many words is “I speak”? (**One** — *hablo*.) What is the name for leaving the pronoun out? (**Pro-drop**.) Why can't English do it? (Its endings wore away, so only the pronoun is left to carry the person.) Next chapter: the same verb, aimed at somebody else.

Chapter 17

Talking to a Friend

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can say what a friend does, using the tu form of an -ar verb.

The -as ending, and the one English ending that survives beside it.

17.1 hablas — “you speak,” to someone you know

Say “I speak.” (*Hablo.*) How many words? (One.)

What to know first

- tú — the “you” for a friend, a peer, someone at ease with you.

Grammar Lens: one more letter, and it is about the other person

Last chapter the ending was **-o**, and it meant *I*.

Swap it for **-as** and the sentence turns around to face the person you are talking to:

hablar → **hablas** — *you speak.*

Same verb. Same operation — drop the **-ar**, add an ending. Only the ending changed, and with it, who the sentence is about.

This is *tú*’s form: a friend, a peer. And as before, you need no separate word for *you*. **Hablas** on its own is the whole sentence.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Latin marked *you* with **-ās**, and Spanish kept it whole: *hablās* → **hablas**. Here is the piece worth holding on to. English has almost no verb endings left — but it does have one. **He speaks**. That lonely **-s**, the last ending standing in English, comes from the very same Latin-and-Germanic habit of putting an *s* sound on a verb to mark the person. English kept one *s* and lost the rest. Spanish kept the whole set. When you learn *hablas*, you are learning the system English is down to its last piece of.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “hablas”
- “hablo” then “hablas,” and feel the sentence turn from you to the other person

Before you move on

What is “you speak,” to a friend? (**Hablas**.) Which ending means *I*, and which means *you*? (**-o** and **-as**.) Which English ending is the last survivor of this system? (The **-s** in *he speaks*.) Next chapter: the same verb again, for *usted* — and for *he* and *she*.

Chapter 18

He, She, and the Polite You

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can say what someone else does, and address someone respectfully, with one form.

One form doing three jobs, and the vuestra merced fossil behind it.

18.1 habla — “he speaks,” and the polite “you speak”

Two forms so far. Which means *I speak*? (*Hablo.*) Which is *you speak*, to a friend? (*Hablas.*)

Grammar Lens: take the -s away again

Drop the **-ar**, add just **-a**:

hablar → **habla** — *he speaks, she speaks.*

That is the third form, and the third ending: **-o**, **-as**, **-a**.

Grammar Lens: the same form does a second job

Back when you met *usted*, you were told it takes the *he/she* form of the verb. Here is the first verb where you can actually see it happen.

usted habla — *you speak*, politely.

The same word, **habla**, covers *he speaks, she speaks*, **and** the respectful

you speak. Nothing extra to learn — it is one form doing three jobs, and that is a gift, not a complication.

Why? Because *usted* was never a word for *you* to begin with. It grew out of *vuestra merced*, “your grace” — and *your grace* is a **thing you talk about**, not a person you talk to. You would say “your grace **speaks**,” not “your grace speak.” The verb form is a fossil of that politeness.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Latin’s ending here was **-at**: *hablat*, “he speaks.” Spanish let the final **-t** fall away, as it let most final consonants fall away, and the bare **-a** is what was left standing.

French did the same thing and went further — it writes *parle* but the ending is now silent. Italian kept more: *parla*. Three languages, one Latin ending, three degrees of wear.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “habla”
- it for a friend’s brother, then for a stranger you are being polite to — same word both times

Before you move on

What is “he speaks”? (**Habla**.) Which form does *usted* take, and why? (**Habla** — because *usted* began as *vuestra merced*, “your grace,” something you talk *about*.) What did Latin’s **-at** lose? (Its **-t**.) Next chapter is a review — no new words at all.

Chapter 19

Review — The Three Forms Side by Side

Modes: 👁 eyes (1) ⇄ Hands-free start: none of the 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can hold all three singular -ar forms at once and choose between them without stopping.

The first paradigm table in the book, arriving only after all three of its cells are owned.

19.1 Review — the three forms, side by side

Nothing new in this chapter. Not one word. Say the three forms you already have, in any order they come.

Grammar Lens: the table you have earned

Three chapters, one form each. Now — and only now — they are worth seeing together:

who	ending	<i>hablar</i> →	meaning
I	-o	hablo	I speak
tú	-as	hablas	you speak (a friend)
él · ella · usted	-a	habla	he/she speaks · you speak (polite)

A table like this one at the *start* would have been three things at once

and you would have memorised it. Arriving here, it is a picture of something you can already do.

This is the whole engine. Every regular **-ar** verb in Spanish — and there are thousands — runs on these three endings. You have not learned one verb. You have learned the pattern that fits all of them.

What you've built

- Say what **you** do — *hablo*.
- Ask or state what a **friend** does — *hablas*.
- Say what **someone else** does, or address someone **politely** — *habla*.
- Do all three **without a pronoun**, because the ending carries it.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- all three in order — “hablo, hablas, habla”
- them out of order, as prompted: *she · I · a friend · politely*

Twice through: Until the ending arrives before you have to think about it.

Before you move on

Three endings — name them. (**-o, -as, -a.**) How many regular *-ar* verbs does this pattern fit? (**All of them.**) Next chapter you will not learn anything either — you will *use* this to say something you actually mean.

Chapter 20

Trabajar — Work, and the Torture Device Behind It

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🖱️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can say what I do for work with a second regular -ar verb.

tripalium, a three-stake device, is why work and travail are the same word.

20.1 trabajar — “to work,” and it once meant *torture*

A second **-ar** verb — snap it into the exact template you just learned. And *trabajar* has the darkest, best etymology in this chapter: it began as a word for **torture**, and it’s the secret origin of English **travel**.

Sounds you’ll need

- j-jota — the **j** is a raspy *h*-from-the-throat (the *jota*): *trabajar* = *tra-ba-HAR*.
- r-tap, b-soft — tapped *r*, soft *b*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

trabajar comes from Vulgar Latin **tripaliāre**, “to torture” — from **tripalium**, a Roman instrument of torture made of **three stakes** (*tri-* “three” + *pālus* “stake,” the root of English **pale** and **impale**).

The chain of meaning is grimly logical: *torture* → *torment* / *suffering* → *hard toil* → just **work**. And English took the very same word down a parallel road:

- **travail** — painful, laborious effort (and the pains of childbirth).
- **travel** — yes: journeying was once such an *ordeal* that “travail” (toil) became **travel** (to make a journey). Every time you *travel*, you’re etymologically being *tortured*.

So even plain **trabajo**, “I work,” hides the old idea of toil as torment — a dark little joke inside an everyday verb.

Grammar Lens: same -ar template

Drop **-ar**, add the ending — identical to *hablar*:

person	form	meaning
I (ending carries the subject)	trabajo	I work
tú	trabajas	you work
usted	trabaja	you (formal) work

Notice you didn’t learn a new ending — that’s the point. **One template, every regular -ar verb.**

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “trabajar” — *tra-ba-HAR*, raspy *j*
- “trabajo, trabajas, trabaja” — same endings as *hablo/hablas/habla*
- “trabajar” → travail → travel — torture became a journey

Before you move on

What did *trabajar* originally mean, and from what device? (“To torture,” ← *tripalium*, a three-stake tool.) What two English words come from the same root? (*Travail* and *travel*.) How do you say “I work”? (*Trabajo* — same -o ending.) Next: **estudiar**, “to study.”

Chapter 21

Estudiar — Studying Is Being Eager

Modes: ⇄ voice (1) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can say what I study, with a third regular -ar verb and no new pattern.

studere, to be eager - the root under student, studio and studious.

21.1 estudiar — “to study,” and the eagerness inside it

Your third **-ar** verb. By now the pattern should feel automatic — that’s exactly what we want. *estudiar* also hides a nicer feeling than the classroom suggests: at root it means **eagerness**.

Sounds you’ll need

- **st-no-e** — Spanish props up *st-* with an *e*: **es-tudiar** (the same reflex behind *estar, España, escuela*). *es-too-DYAR*.
- **diphthong-io** — the *-iar* glides: *es-too-DYAR*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

estudiar comes from Latin **studēre**, “to be eager, to apply oneself zealously.” A *studium* was **zeal, enthusiasm, devotion** — only later “study.” So to *study* is, at heart, to *throw yourself eagerly* at something.

That **studēre** is everywhere in English:

- **student** — literally “one who is *eager*.”
- **studio**, **studious**, **study** — the place, the trait, the act.
- Italian **studio** and the musical *studio* keep the “devoted practice” sense.

So *Estudio español* is “I *devote myself eagerly* to Spanish” — a nicer picture than mere schoolwork.

Grammar Lens: the template holds

Drop **-ar**, add the ending — for the third time:

person	form	meaning
I (ending carries the subject)	estudio	I study
tú	estudias	you study
usted	estudia	you (formal) study

Three verbs, one pattern: *hablo*, *trabajo*, *estudio*. The singular regular **-ar** present is now reusable rather than memorized verb by verb.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “estudiar” — *es-too-DYAR*
- “estudio, estudias, estudia” — the now-familiar endings
- “estudiar” then English “student, studio” — the *studēre* “eagerness”

Before you move on

What did *studēre* originally mean? (“To be eager / apply oneself.”) Its English cousins? (Student, studio, studious.) Say “I study” — and notice it uses the same *-o* as *hablo* and *trabajo*. (*Estudio*.) Next: put a verb and a noun together into your **first real sentence**.

Chapter 22

Espanol, and Your First Built Sentence

Modes: 🗣️ voice (2) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 2 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name the language and build a whole sentence from parts I chose myself.

Hispania to espanol, and the first sentence assembled rather than memorised.

22.1 español — the word for the language

You have practised writing this word's ñ. Now find out what is inside it — because *español* is not a Spanish-made word at all.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

español = “Spanish” — both the language and a Spaniard — from **Hispania**, the **Roman** name for the Iberian peninsula. The path *Hispania* → *hispaniolus* → *español* wore the word down, and there is the ñ again, exactly the *-ni-* squeeze you met in the writing lesson (*Hispaniolus* → *españ-ol*). Say it *es-pa-NYOL*.

Two footnotes worth having:

- English **Spanish**, **Hispanic** and **Hispania** are all the same root, so the English and Spanish names for the language are cousins, not translations of each other.
- *Hispania* itself may go back through Latin to a **Phoenician**

name for the coast, often read as “land of hyraxes” (or rabbits) — the Phoenicians having met an unfamiliar animal and reached for the nearest word they had.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “español” — *es-pa-NYOL*
- the path — “Hispania, hispaniolus, español”
- “español” then English “Hispanic” — same root

Before you move on

Where does *español* come from? (**Hispania**, the Roman name for Iberia.) What letter does its ending bring back, and from what Latin sequence? (**ñ**, from **-ni-** in *Hispaniolus*.) Next: put it behind a verb and build your first sentence.

22.2 Hablo español — your first real sentence

This is the moment this book has been building to. You take a **verb** you conjugated yourself and a **noun** you took apart yourself, and make a sentence **nobody handed you pre-assembled**.

What you’ve built — the sentence assembled

Snap two things you already own together:

Hablo (I speak, from *hablar*) + **español** (Spanish) = **Hablo español**.

That is a complete, grammatical Spanish sentence, and notice what is **not** in it: no separate subject word. The *-o* of *hablo* already says “I” — the pro-drop you just learned, doing real work in a real sentence. Now swap the pieces and watch it generate:

- **Estudio español.** — “I study Spanish.”

- **Trabajo.** — “I work.”
- **¿Hablas español?** — “Do you speak Spanish?” (the *¿* *?* pair opening and closing the question, as in the writing lesson).

Grammar Lens: languages go bare

One more thing missing from *hablo español*: **no “the,” no “a.”** After a verb like *hablar* or *estudiar*, a language name takes **no article** — *hablo español*, never *hablo el español*.

This matters because Spanish otherwise loves its articles far more than English does (*me gusta el café*, “I like coffee”). So this is a genuine exception you have to hold onto, and the rule of thumb is narrow: right after *hablar*, the language goes bare.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “Hablo español” — *AH-bloh es-pa-NYOL*
- swap the verb — “Estudio español”, “Trabajo”
- ask it — “¿Hablas español?” (raise the pitch; *¿* opens it)

Why it’s said this way

You met **no** long ago as the answer. It has a second job, and now you have a sentence to try it on: put *no* directly in front of the verb and the whole thing flips.

Hablo español → No hablo español.

That is all there is to it. English needs a helper — *do not* — and Spanish needs nothing: one small word, in front, and the sentence means its opposite.

Before you move on

Say “I speak Spanish,” then “I study Spanish.” (*Hablo español; estudio español.*) Why is there no separate subject word? (The *-o* ending carries “I.”) Why no “the” before *español*? (**Languages take no article** after a verb like *hablar*.) You just built a sentence from parts — that is the whole game from here.

Chapter 23

Synthesis — The Same Conversation, Twice

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can hold one short conversation both warmly and respectfully, changing only the verb ending.

The register choice carried entirely by one letter - and now with something real to say.

23.1 Synthesis — the same conversation, twice

Nothing new in this chapter either. This one is for **using** what you have — because knowing three endings is not the same as choosing the right one while a real person waits for you to finish.

Grammar Lens: what the ending is really saying

You are going to hold one short conversation twice — once with someone your own age, once with someone you want to show respect to. The **words** barely change. What changes is **one letter on the end of one verb**.

That letter is the whole message. *Hablas* says *I am at ease with you*. *Habla* says *I am being careful with you*. English would need a change of tone, or a “sir.” Spanish does it with an **-s**.

The exchange — with a friend

— ¡Hola! Me llamo Ana. — Me llamo David. Mucho gusto. —
 ¿**Hablas** español? — Sí, **hablo** español. ¡Gracias!

The exchange, again — being polite

— Buenos días. Me llamo Ana. — Me llamo David. Mucho
 gusto. — ¿**Habla** usted español? — Sí, **hablo** español. Gracias.

One letter. *Hablas* became *habla*, and the whole exchange changed its temperature. Your own line — *hablo* — never moved, because *you* are still you in both conversations.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- version one, both parts, start to finish
- version two — and catch the single letter that moved

Twice through: Run whichever version is harder.

Before you move on

What is the *only* thing that changed between the two conversations? (**One letter** — *hablas* → *habla*.) Why did *hablo* stay the same? (Because it is about **you**, and you did not change.) What does choosing *habla* over *hablas* actually tell the other person? (That you are being **respectful** — the grammar is carrying the manners.)

Chapter 24

Putting the -ar Verbs to Work

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can use several -ar verbs in real sentences.

The -ar present tense in action across the verbs of the last chapters.

24.1 Practice — making sentences with -ar verbs

A milestone chapter: for the first time you're not reciting fixed phrases, you're **building sentences from a pattern**. Drill the three verbs through the endings until *hablo / hablas / habla* is automatic.

Grammar Lens: conjugate on command

Run each verb through the three singular jobs you know: the ending alone for **I** → **tú** → **usted**:

- **hablar**: hablo · hablas · habla
- **trabajar**: trabajo · trabajas · trabaja
- **estudiar**: estudio · estudias · estudia

Same three endings (**-o** / **-as** / **-a**) every time — that's the whole regular **-ar** present, singular.

The exchange — say something real

— ¿**Hablas** español? — **Hablo** español. — ¿**Estudias** español? — **Estudio** español. — **Café, por favor.** — ¡Gracias!
— De nada.

What you’ve built this chapter

- **por favor** — please (← “for a favour”), completing *gracias* / *de nada* / *por favor*.
- **the singular regular -ar pattern** — drop *-ar*, add **-o** / **-as** / **-a**: the template behind *hablar*, *trabajar*, and *estudiar*.
- **hablar** (← *fābula*, fable; the f→h law), **trabajar** (← *tripalium*, torture → travail/travel), **estudiar** (← *studēre*, eagerness → student).
- **Hablo español** — your first self-assembled sentence (pro-drop, no article).

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- conjugate all three verbs for I / tú / usted, without stopping
- answer “¿Hablas español?” and “¿Estudias español?” about yourself
- request “Café, por favor” and run the full *gracias/de nada* loop

Twice through: Ask and answer “¿Hablas español? — Hablo español.”

Before you move on

What are the three singular *-ar* endings? (*-o* / *-as* / *-a*.) Give the “I” form of all three verbs. (*Hablo*, *trabajo*, *estudio*.) Why does *Hablo español* need no separate subject word? (The *-o* carries “I.”) You can now generate sentences — this book stops handing you phrases and starts handing you *rules*. Next chapter adds the *-er/-ir* verb families.

Chapter 25

Comer — the Second Verb Family, One Slot at a Time

Modes: 🗣️ voice (4) 👁️ eyes (1) 🖐️ Hands-free start: first 4 of 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can use all three singular forms of a regular -er verb, having built each one separately.

The -er singular, earned a slot at a time - and the yo ending that never changed.

25.1 comer — “to eat,” and the second verb family

Last chapter you learned the **-ar** verbs. Spanish has two more families — **-er** and **-ir** — and here’s the good news: they’re **almost the same**. Meet **comer** (“to eat”), your first **-er** verb.

Sounds you’ll need

- **r-tap** — one soft tap: *ko-MER*.
- The *c* before *o* is a hard *k*: *comer* = *ko-MER*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

comer derives from Latin **comedere**, “to eat up” — **com-** (intensifier, “completely”) + **edere**, “to eat.” That **edere** is the twin of English **eat** (both from the same ancient root), and it feeds a small English family:

- **edible** — fit to be eaten.
- **comestible** — a fancy word for food (straight from *comedere*).
- English **eat** itself — the Germanic cousin of Latin *edere*.

Grammar Lens: one family over, and one ending already yours

Hablar ended in **-ar**. *Comer* ends in **-er**, and that single letter is what makes it a different family.

Here is the good news, and it is worth having before you meet a single new form: **the *yo* ending does not change**. *Hablar* gave *hablo*. *Comer* will give *como*. The ending you already own works untouched. Only two slots in this family behave differently from the one you know, and you will meet them one at a time over the next three chapters — not here.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “comer” — *ko-MER*
- “comer” then English “edible, comestible, eat” — the *edere* family

Before you move on

What Latin verb is *comer* from, and its English cousins? (*Comedere* ← *edere* — edible, eat.) Which ending is the same in both families? (The ***yo*** ending, **-o**.) Next: the *yo* form — and it will cost you nothing.

25.2 como — “I eat,” and you already knew how

How do you say “I speak”? (*Hablo*.) And what is the verb for “to eat”? (*Comer*.)

Grammar Lens: the ending that did not change

Drop the **-er**, add **-o**:

comer → **como** — *I eat*.

That is the same operation and the same ending you used on *hablar*. A new verb family, and the *yo* slot cost you nothing at all. This is worth pausing on, because it is how most of the rest will go. Spanish's three families differ in **two** of their singular slots, never in the first one. Whatever the verb, "I" is **-o**. And as before, one word is the whole sentence: **como**. No pronoun.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

One warning, because this word is busy. **Como** is three things:

- **como** — *I eat*, the form you just built.
- **como** — *like, as*. (*Como tú* — "like you.")
- **cómo**, with the accent — *how?*, which you have used since your first conversations.

Same four letters, three jobs. The accent marks the question word; context sorts the other two. This is not a trap so much as a reminder that the accent in Spanish is doing real work.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "hablo" then "como" — the same ending, twice
- "como" alone, as a complete sentence

Before you move on

How do you say "I eat"? (**Como**.) Which slot never changes between verb families? (The **yo** slot — always **-o**.) What does *cómo* with an accent mean? (**How?**) Next: the slot that *does* change.

25.3 comes — "you eat," and the first real difference

Say "I eat." (*Como*.) Now say "you speak," to a friend. (*Hablas*.)

Grammar Lens: one vowel moves

In the *-ar* family, *tú* took **-as**. Here it takes **-es**:

comer → **comes** — *you eat*.

That is the whole difference. The **-s** that means *you* is still there, doing the same job it does in *hablas*. Only the vowel in front of it has moved from **a** to **e** — and it moved because the verb's own family vowel is **e**. The ending is agreeing with the family it belongs to.

So you are not learning a new ending so much as watching a familiar one take on the colour of its surroundings.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Latin had *amās* for “you love” and *comedis* for “you eat” — different vowels in the ending, exactly as Spanish has now. The split is not a Spanish invention; it is inherited, and it is why the families exist at all. What every one of them kept, across two thousand years, is the **-s**. If a Spanish verb form ends in *-s*, it is talking to *tú*. That single rule will carry you through every tense in this book.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “hablas” then “comes” — the same *-s*, a different vowel
- “como” then “comes” — and feel the sentence turn toward the other person

Before you move on

What is “you eat,” to a friend? (**Comes**.) What part of the ending is the same as in *hablas*? (The **-s**.) What changed, and why? (The vowel, to match the verb's own family.) Next: the last of the three.

25.4 come — “he eats,” and the polite “you eat”

Say “you eat,” to a friend. (*Comes*.) And what was the *usted* form of *hablar*? (*Habla*.)

Grammar Lens: take the -s off again

Drop the **-er**, add **-e**:

comer → **come** — *he eats, she eats*, and **usted come**, *you eat*, politely.

The relationship is the one you already know. In the *-ar* family, *hablas* became *habla* by losing its **-s**. Here *comes* becomes *come* the same way. And exactly as before, this one form does three jobs — *he*, *she*, and the respectful *you* — for the same reason it did last time: *usted* began life as *vuestra merced*, a thing you talk **about**.

Three slots, three chapters, and the shape of the family is now yours.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Latin's form here was *comedit*. Spanish let the final **-t** fall, precisely as it let it fall from *hablat* to give *habla*.

That is the useful part: the two families were not worn down by different forces. The same weather hit both. Which is why, once you know what happened to one, the other holds no surprises.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “habla” then “come” — the same move, one family over
- “come” for a friend's sister, then for a stranger you are being polite to

Before you move on

What is “she eats”? (**Come**.) How did it come from *comes*? (By losing the **-s**, exactly as *hablas* → *habla*.) What did Latin's *comedit* lose? (Its **-t**.) A short review closes this chapter; the third and last family follows.

25.5 Review — the -er family, all three

Nothing new. Say the three forms of *comer* you have built, in any order they come to you.

Grammar Lens: the table you have earned

Three slots, three lessons. Now they are worth seeing beside the family you already had:

who	-ar	-er	
I	-o	-o	<i>hablo</i> · como
tú	-as	-es	<i>hablas</i> · comes
él · ella · usted	-a	-e	<i>habla</i> · come

Read the middle two columns down and the whole -er family is one observation: **the *yo* slot is shared, and the other two swap a for e.**

That is the entire cost of a second verb family. Every regular -er verb in Spanish runs on it.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “como, comes, come” straight through
- “hablo, como” · “hablas, comes” · “habla, come” — the two families in step

Twice through:

Before you move on

Give the three -er endings. (-o, -es, -e.) Which one matches -ar exactly? (The **yo** ending.) How many regular -er verbs does this fit? (**All of them.**) Next chapter: the third family, and it is the smallest change yet.

Chapter 26

Vivir — the Family That Costs Nothing

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🖱️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can use the singular of a regular -ir verb, and say why it asked me to learn no new form.

In the singular the -ir endings ARE the -er endings; the families part company only in the plural.

26.1 vivir — “to live,” and the third family (that’s barely new)

The third and last verb family: **-ir**, and **vivir** (“to live”) is your first. Here’s the punchline — in the present tense, **-ir is almost identical to -er**. You’ve nearly finished learning the whole regular present.

Sounds you’ll need

- **v-b** — Spanish *v* = a soft *b*: *vivir* ≈ *bee-BEER*.
- **r-tap** — one tap on the final *r*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

vivir comes from Latin **vīvere**, “to live” — one of the most alive roots in English:

- **vivid** — “full of life.”
- **survive** (*super-vivere*, “to live beyond”), **revive** (“live again”).
- **vivacious**, **convivial** (“living together” — sociable), **viva!**, **vivarium**. (And *vita*, “life,” gives **vital**, **vitamin**.)

Grammar Lens: the family that costs nothing

The third family is the shortest lesson in this book, and it is short because of a fact rather than a shortcut.

In the singular, the *-ir* endings are the *-er* endings. Not similar. The same three:

vivo · vives · vive — *-o, -es, -e*, exactly as *como, comes, come*.

So the third family asks you to learn no new form at all. You already built these three endings one at a time in the last chapter; here they are, doing the same work on a different verb.

The two families do part company later, in the plural — and when they do, you will meet that difference on its own. It is not needed now, and mentioning it here would be borrowing trouble.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “vivir” — *bee-BEER*
- “como, comes, come” then “vivo, vives, vive” — identical endings
- “vivir” then English “vivid, survive, revive” — the *vivere* family

Before you move on

What Latin verb is *vivir* from, and two English cousins? (*vivere* — vivid, survive.) In the singular, how do *-er* and *-ir* endings compare? (They are **identical**: *-o / -es / -e*.) Say “I live.” (*Vivo*.) Next: a second verb in this family, and two words for asking questions.

Chapter 27

Beber, and Two Ways to Ask

Modes: ⇄ voice (4) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 4 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can say what I drink, and ask what and where with *que* and *donde*.

A second -er verb that needs no new pattern, and the two question words that turn the forms outward.

27.1 beber — “to drink,” and the pattern is yours

One more **-er** verb to make the pattern automatic — **beber**, “to drink.” Pair it with *comer* and you can talk about eating and drinking, the heart of any café or restaurant.

Sounds you’ll need

- **v-b** — both *b*’s are the soft Spanish *b*: *be-BER*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

beber comes from Latin **bibere**, “to drink” — a thirsty little root that soaked into English:

- **beverage** — a drink (via Old French *beverage*, from *bibere*).
- **imbibe** — to drink in (*in-* + *bibere*).
- **bibulous** — fond of drinking; **bib** — the cloth that catches drips; even **beer**’s cousins hover nearby.

Grammar Lens: no new grammar — that’s the point

beber is a regular **-er** verb, so it takes the endings you already own:

| yo | **bebo** | I drink |

| tú | **bebes** | you drink |

| él/ella/usted | **bebe** | he/she drinks / you (formal) drink |

Nothing new to learn — you’re just *reusing the machine*. With the word *café* from the previous chapter, you can already say:

Bebo café. — “I drink coffee.”

One new verb, one known noun, one sentence you built yourself.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “beber” — *be-BER*
- “bebo, bebes, bebe” — the familiar *-o/-es/-e*
- “Bebo café” — “I drink coffee”

Before you move on

What Latin verb is *beber* from, and its English cousins? (*bibere* — beverage, imbibe.) Did *beber* need any new endings? (No — it’s a regular *-er* verb.) Say “I drink.” (*Bebo*.) Next: start **asking** — *qué*, “what?”

27.2 qué — “what”, a new question word

You already know the question word *cómo*; now ask about a thing. The new question word is **qué**, “what” — and it puts to work two things from your writing chapter: the **accent** and the *¿* ?.

Sounds you’ll need

- k-hard — **qu** is a plain hard **k** (the *u* is silent): *qué* = *keh*.
- accent-mark — the **accent on é** marks this as the *question*

word (recall the diacrítica: *qué* = “what?”; *que* = “that”).
Question words wear the accent.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

qué comes from Latin **quid**, “*what*” — the neuter of *quis*, “who.” It’s a small function word with a few learned English descendants:

- **quiddity** — the “what-ness,” the essence of a thing.
- **quid pro quo** — “*what* for *what*,” this for that.
- the *qu-* question family it heads in Spanish: *qué*, *quién* (who), *cuál* (which) — Latin’s *qu-* interrogatives, the same *wh-* instinct as English (Latin *qu-* and English *wh-* are ancient cousins).

Grammar Lens: asking with a verb you know

Put **qué** in front of a verb, wrap it in **¿**?, and you have a real question:

¿Qué comes? — “What are you eating? / What do you eat?”
¿Qué bebes? — “What are you drinking?”

Remember the opening **¿** (from the writing lesson) warns the reader a question is coming; the accent on *qué* marks it as the question word. Answer with the verb you already conjugate and a noun you already know: *Bebo café*. (“I drink coffee.”)

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “qué” — *keh*, silent *u*
- “¿Qué comes?” / “¿Qué bebes?” — ask with verbs you know
- “qué” vs “que” — the accent marks the *question*

Before you move on

What Latin word is *qué* from? (*quid* — quiddity, quid pro quo.)
Why does *qué* carry an accent? (It’s the *question* word; *que* without

= “that.”) Ask “what are you eating?” (*¿Qué comes?*) Next: asking **where** — *dónde*.

27.3 dónde — “where?”

One more question word, and one more real question you can build: **dónde**, “where?” Pair it with *vivir* and you can ask the single most common getting-to-know-you question: *where do you live?*

Sounds you’ll need

- **d-soft** — the middle *d* is soft, near the *th* of *this*: *DON-deh*.
- **accent-mark** — like *qué*, the **accent on ó** marks the question word (*dónde* = “where?”; *donde* without = “where,” a relative — “the place *where*”).

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

dónde comes from Latin **de unde**, literally “*from whence*.” *unde* meant “from where,” and Spanish glued *de* onto the front and wore the pair down to *dónde*. (English once had the matching set *whence* / *where* / *whither* — “from where / at where / to where”; Spanish keeps that flavour in *de dónde* “from where”, *dónde* “where”, *adónde* “to where”.)

Grammar Lens: your first getting-to-know-you questions

Two question words + verbs you own = real conversation:

¿Dónde vives? — “Where do you live?” → *Vivo en Madrid*.
¿Dónde trabajas? — “Where do you work?”
¿Qué estudias? — “What do you study?”

Notice the little **en** (“in,” ← Latin *in*) in the answer — the first preposition, slipping in exactly where you need it. You’re now trading real questions and answers, not fixed phrases.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “dónde” — *DON-deh*, soft *d*
- “¿Dónde vives?” — “Where do you live?”
- answer — “Vivo en ...” with your city

Before you move on

What Latin phrase is *dónde* from, and what did it mean? (*De unde* — “from whence.”) Why the accent? (It marks the *question* word.) Ask “where do you live?” and answer it. (¿*Dónde vives?* — *Vivo en ...*) Next: put the questions and verbs together in practice.

27.4 Practice — asking real questions

You now have all three verb families **and** two question words. This is where it becomes a conversation: you can **ask** and **answer**, not just recite. Drill until the questions come without thinking.

Grammar Lens: three singular patterns

Conjugate *yo* → *tú* → *él/ella* — feel how little differs:

- **-ar** *hablar*: hablo · hablas · habla
- **-er** *comer*: como · comes · come
- **-ir** *vivir*: vivo · vives · vive

Endings: *-ar* → *-o/-as/-a*; *-er* and *-ir* → ***-o/-es/-e*** in these three singular forms. The plural forms can wait.

The exchange — use only what you know

— ¿**Dónde vives?** — **Vivo** en Sevilla. ¿Y tú? — **Vivo** en México. — ¿**Qué estudias?** — **Estudio** español. ¿**Qué bebes?** — **Bebo** café.

What you've built this chapter

- **comer** / **beber** (-er), **vivir** (-ir) — the two remaining verb families; singular endings **-o** / **-es** / **-e**.
- **qué** (← *quid*) and **dónde** (← *de unde*) — your first question words, each wearing the **accent** and opening with **¿**.
- **Real questions:** *¿Qué comes?* *¿Dónde vives?* *¿Dónde trabajas?* — and the first preposition, **en** (“in”), in the answers.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- conjugate all three families, yo/tú/él, back to back
- ask a friend where they live and what they drink; answer both
- ask what they study; answer “Estudio español”

Twice through: “¿Dónde vives? — Vivo en ... ¿Y tú?”

Before you move on

What are the singular endings for *-er/-ir* verbs? (*-o* / *-es* / *-e*.) Give the “I” forms of *comer*, *vivir*, *beber*. (*Como*, *vivo*, *bebo*.) Ask “what do you study?” and “where do you live?” (*¿Qué estudias?* *¿Dónde vives?*) You can now hold a simple back-and-forth — this book is fully in sentence territory. Next: **numbers** (uno, dos, tres) and telling someone your age and phone.

Chapter 28

Synthesis — Asking, and Answering

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can hold a short exchange about what someone drinks and where they live, using all three verb families.

Three families and two question words, and every word in the dialogue self-built.

28.1 Synthesis — asking, and answering

Nothing new in this chapter. Say “I eat” and “I live.” (*Como. Vivo.*)

What you’ve built

Something quietly enormous happened over the last four chapters, and it is worth saying out loud before you use it.

Spanish has **three** verb families. You now hold the singular of all three. That is not three facts — it is a machine: hand it any regular verb you meet for the rest of your life, and you can already say what you do with it, what a friend does, and what somebody else does.

Two question words turn that machine outward. ¿**Qué?** asks *what*. ¿**Dónde?** asks *where*. With them, the forms stop being an exercise and start being a conversation.

The exchange

— ¿**Qué** bebes? — **Bebo** café. ¿Y tú? — Yo también. ¿**Dónde** vives? — **Vivo en** Madrid.

Four lines, and every single word in them is something you built yourself. No new vocabulary was needed to get here — only the endings, one slot at a time.

Notice what the questions cost: nothing. You did not learn a question *form*. You put **¿qué?** or **¿dónde?** in front of a verb you already had.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the exchange above, both parts, without stopping
- it again, swapping in *comes* for *bebes*

Twice through: Run it until the question and the answer arrive together.

Before you move on

How many verb families do you hold? (**Three** — and that is all of them.) What did the question words cost you? (**Nothing** — they sit in front of forms you already had.) Ask where somebody lives. (*¿Dónde vives?*)

Chapter 29

Hablamos — the First Form That Is Not About One Person

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can say what we do, with the -amos ending.

-mos is Latin's -mus, barely changed in two thousand years.

29.1 hablamos — “we speak”

Say “I speak”, then “you speak” to a friend. (*Hablo. Hablas.*)

Grammar Lens: the first form that is not about one person

Every verb form you have met so far — in every tense — has been about **one** person. That changes here.

Drop the **-ar**, add **-amos**:

hablamos — *we speak*.

One word again, no pronoun, and now it covers you and somebody else. This is the form you will reach for constantly and have not had: *we speak, we work, we study*. Everything you could say about yourself, you can now say about a group you belong to.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

The **-mos** is remarkable for how little happened to it. Latin marked *we* with **-mus**: *amāmus*, “we love”. Spanish says *-mos*. One vowel changed in two thousand years, and nothing else — no consonant lost, no syllable worn away, no analogy pulling it out of shape. Compare what became of the third person, which lost its **-t** entirely (*hablat* → *habla*). Endings do not decay at the same rate, and this one barely decayed at all.

And Portuguese and Italian kept it too — *falamos*, *parliamo*. If you ever meet another Romance language, *-mos* or *-mo* will be waiting for you, doing the same job.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “hablo” then “hablamos” — one person, then a group
- “hablamos” alone, and notice it is still a whole sentence

Before you move on

How do you say “we speak”? (**Hablamos**.) Which Latin ending is that? (**-mus**, almost unchanged.) How many words? (**One** — still no pronoun.) Next: the form for *them*.

Chapter 30

Hablan — They, and Ustedes

Modes: ⇄ voice (1) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can say what they do, and address any group as ustedes.

ustedes is vuestras mercedes - so it takes the they form for the same reason usted takes the he form.

30.1 hablan — “they speak,” and “you all speak”

Say “we speak.” (*Hablamos.*) And what was the form for *he speaks?* (*Habla.*)

Grammar Lens: add the plural -n

Take *habla*, the form for one other person, and add **-n**:

hablan — *they speak.*

That is the whole operation, and it is the same one Spanish uses everywhere: a final **-n** on a verb means the subject is plural and is not you.

Grammar Lens: the form does a second job, exactly as *habla* did

ustedes — *you all.* And it takes **hablan**, the *they* form.

You have seen this exact move before. *Usted* takes the *he/she* form because it grew out of *vuestra merced*, “your grace” — a thing you talk

about. Ustedes is simply that phrase made plural, *vuestras mercedes*, “your graces”. Same origin, same consequence.

Where this is the ordinary word. Across all of Latin America, and in the Canary Islands and parts of Andalusia, **ustedes** is how you address *any* group — friends, family, strangers alike. There is no separate familiar plural. For most Spanish speakers alive, this lesson is the complete answer to “how do I talk to more than one person?”

Spain uses a different word for friends, and it has the next chapter to itself.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “habla” then “hablan” — one other person, then several
- “ustedes hablan”, addressing a group you have just met

Before you move on

What is “they speak”? (**Hablan.**) What does a final **-n** on a verb tell you? (The subject is **plural**, and not you.) And who does *ustedes* address in Latin America? (**Any** group at all.) Next: the word Spain uses instead, for friends.

Chapter 31

Habláis — the Form Spain Keeps

Modes: ⇄ voice (1) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can recognise the *vosotros* form and say where it is used.

vos + otros, added in Spain to keep the plural apart from a singular vos the Americas kept instead.

31.1 habláis — the form Spain keeps

How do you say “you all speak” to a group in Mexico? (*Ustedes hablan.*)

Grammar Lens: a second plural you

In Spain, addressing a group of **friends** uses a different word and a different verb form:

vosotros habláis — *you all speak*, informally.

vosotros — *you all*, familiar. Its ending is **-áis**, and it is the last of the six.

This is not an ornament. In Spain it is the ordinary, everyday way to speak to more than one friend, and a Spaniard hears *ustedes* to a group of friends as oddly formal — roughly as an English speaker hears *sir* from someone they know well.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

You met **vos** long ago: Latin's *plural* you, which drifted into the singular across much of the Americas.

That drift left Spain with a problem. If *vos* was being used for one polite person, what was left for an actual group? Spaniards added a word to disambiguate: **vos + otros**, “you **others**” — hence *vosotros*, and its feminine *vosotras*.

The Americas never needed the repair, because *ustedes* had already taken the plural job. So the split is not a difference of taste. **Two regions solved the same problem in two different ways**, and both solutions are still in use.

What you owe this form. Recognition, at minimum — you will meet it in every book, film and song from Spain. Produce it if you are learning for Spain; otherwise *ustedes* will carry you anywhere.

Your turn

- [YOU HEAR: “habláis”] → a Spaniard, talking to friends.
- *Say it*: “ustedes hablan” then “vosotros habláis” — the same sentence, two continents

Before you move on

What is *vosotros* built from? (**Vos + otros** — “you others”.) Why did Spain need it and the Americas not? (Because *vos* had drifted singular in the Americas, where *ustedes* already covered the plural.) Which will carry you anywhere? (**Ustedes.**)

Chapter 32

Review — the Whole Present Tense

Modes: 👁 eyes (1) ⇄ Hands-free start: none of the 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can produce all six present-tense forms of a regular -ar verb.

The first complete paradigm in the book - withheld for thirty-two chapters until every box in it was earned.

32.1 Review — the whole thing, at last

Nothing new in this chapter. Say “we speak”, then “they speak.”

Grammar Lens: the table this book has been withholding

Six forms. Every one of them built separately, on its own, in its own lesson.

who	<i>hablar</i> →
yo	hablo
tú	hablas
él · ella · usted	habla
nosotros	hablamos
vosotros (<i>Spain</i>)	habláis
ellos · ellas · ustedes	hablan

Most Spanish courses open with this table. This one has spent thirty-two chapters refusing to show it, because a table you cannot yet fill is a

picture of work still to do, and a table you can fill is a picture of ground you hold.

Read it now and there should be no surprises in it. That is the point.

And it is not one verb. Every regular *-ar* verb in Spanish — thousands of them — runs on these six endings, so this table is the present tense of a large part of the language.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- all six in order, top to bottom
- them out of order, as prompted: *they · we · I · a friend*

Twice through: Until the whole set runs without a gap in it.

Before you move on

Give all six endings. (**-o, -as, -a, -amos, -áis, -an.**) How many regular *-ar* verbs does this fit? (**All of them.**) And why did the table wait until now? (Because every box in it had to be yours first.)

Chapter 33

Synthesis — the Same Sentence, Two Continents

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can choose between vosotros and ustedes by where I am, and say that neither corrects the other.

The first choice in this book decided by geography rather than meaning.

33.1 Synthesis — the same sentence, two continents

Nothing new here. Say *hablan*, then *habláis*.

Grammar Lens: a choice that is not about grammar

Every other choice this book has asked you to make has been about **meaning**. *Tú* or *usted* — how close are you to this person? *El* or *un* — does your listener already know which one you mean?

This one is different. It is about **where you are**.

— ¿**Habláis** español? — *asked in Madrid, to friends.* —
¿**Hablan** ustedes español? — *asked in Bogotá, to the same friends.*

Identical meaning. Identical register. The speaker chose by geography, and nothing else.

What you've built

This matters more than a regional footnote, because it settles what “correct Spanish” means in this book.

Neither of those sentences is the correction of the other.

Roughly 40 million people use *vosotros* daily; several hundred million have never used it in their lives and never will. A course that taught only *ustedes* would leave you unable to follow a Spanish film. One that taught only *vosotros* would leave you sounding strange in nineteen countries.

So you learn both, and you learn *which is which* — which is exactly what you have just done across four chapters.

If you must pick one to produce: **ustedes**. It is understood everywhere, Spain included, and in the Americas it is the only option.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the Madrid version, then the Bogotá version
- the one you would actually use, and say why

Twice through:

Before you move on

What decides between *habláis* and *hablan*? (**Where you are** — not what you mean.) Which is correct? (**Both.**) And which one will carry you everywhere? (**Ustedes hablan.**)

Chapter 34

Where -er and -ir Part Company

Modes: ⇄ voice (2) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 2 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can say what we eat and what we live, and explain why the singular hid the difference.

comemos and vivimos: one vowel apart, audible only because the ending is stressed.

34.1 comemos — “we eat”

Say “we speak.” (*Hablamos.*) And “I eat.” (*Como.*)

Grammar Lens: the same -mos, a different vowel

Drop the -er, add -emos:

comemos — *we eat.*

The **-mos** is the one you already have from *hablamos*. Only the vowel in front of it changed, from **a** to **e** — and it changed for the reason it always does: the ending takes the colour of its family.

That is the pattern for every plural ending you will meet. **-mos** and **-n** never change. The vowel before them does.

Something is about to happen that has not happened before. In the singular, -er and -ir were **identical** — *como/comes/come* and *vivo/vives/vive*, the same three endings twice over. That was a genuine saving, and it is about

to stop. The next lesson is where the two families finally part.

Your turn

- *Say it:* “hablamos” then “comemos” — the same *-mos*, a different vowel

Before you move on

What is “we eat”? (**Comemos.**) Which part of a plural ending never changes? (The **-mos.**) And what has been true of *-er* and *-ir* until now? (They were **identical** — which the next lesson ends.)

34.2 vivimos — where the two families part

Say “we eat.” (*Comemos.*) And “I live.” (*Vivo.*)

Grammar Lens: the saving ends here

Drop the **-ir**, add **-imos**:

vivimos — *we live.*

Not *vivemos*. **Vivimos.**

This is the first form in the whole book where *-er* and *-ir* do not match. For every singular form you learned, the two families shared endings exactly — and you were told that saving would end in the plural. This is where.

comemos — we eat. · **vivimos** — we live.

One vowel apart, and it is each family’s own vowel: the **e** of *comer*, the **i** of *vivir*. The families were never really the same; the singular endings simply happened to fall out identically.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Why did the singular hide the difference and the plural expose it? Stress. In *vivo*, *vives*, *vive*, the stress is on the **stem** and the ending is unstressed — and unstressed vowels wear toward each other until they

are indistinguishable. In *vivimos*, the stress lands on the **ending itself**, and a stressed vowel keeps its own quality.

So the families did not diverge here. They were always distinct, and the plural is simply the place where the stress lets you hear it.

Your turn

- *Say it*: “comemos” then “vivimos” — and hear the one vowel that separates them

Before you move on

What is “we live”? (**Vivimos**.) Why was the difference invisible in the singular? (The ending was **unstressed**, so the vowels wore together.) And what makes it audible here? (The **stress** falls on the ending.)

Chapter 35

Comeis and Vivis

Modes: ⇄ voice (1) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can recognise both *vosotros* forms and say that they are the second and last difference.

Latin's -tis, collapsed two ways: -eis for one family, -is for the other.

35.1 coméis and vivís — the second difference, and the last

Which form goes with *vosotros* for *hablar*? (*Habláis.*) And where is that word used? (*Spain.*)

Grammar Lens: two families, two endings, one lesson

coméis — *you all eat.* · **vivís** — *you all live.*

These two are taught together, and it is worth saying why, because this book has otherwise insisted on one form per lesson.

You already know the fact they demonstrate. The *-er* and *-ir* families differ in exactly **two** slots — *nosotros*, which you met last chapter, and *vosotros*, which is this one. Learning them apart would teach the same single fact twice and hide the pattern that makes it easy.

And after this, the two families agree again. *They eat* and *they live* take the same ending, as every singular form did.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Both descend from Latin's **-tis**: *comeditis*, *vivitis*. Spanish lost the **-t-** between vowels — as it lost most of them — and what was left collapsed differently in each family. The *-er* line kept two vowels, **-éis**. The *-ir* line kept one, **-ís**.

Same ending, same erosion, two outcomes. That is most of what sound change looks like.

Your turn

- [YOU HEAR: “coméis”, “vivís”] → a Spaniard, addressing friends.
- *Say it*: “comemos, coméis” then “vivimos, vivís” — the two differing slots, side by side

Before you move on

Give both *vosotros* forms. (**Coméis**, **vivís**.) In how many slots do the two families differ? (**Two** — and you have now met both.) What Latin ending is behind them? (**-tis**.)

Chapter 36

Comen and Viven — Agreeing Again

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can say what they eat and what they live, with one ending shared by both families.

After two chapters apart the families fall back into step and stay there.

36.1 comen and viven — agreeing again

What is “they speak”? (*Hablan.*) And who else does that form address? (*Ustedes.*)

Grammar Lens: one ending for both

Both families take **-en**:

comen — *they eat, ustedes eat.* **viven** — *they live, ustedes live.*

No split here. After two chapters of divergence the families fall back into step, and they stay there.

That is the shape of the whole system, and it is worth holding as one sentence:

-er and **-ir** are identical in four of the six slots. They differ only in *nosotros* and *vosotros*.

Two exceptions in a system of twelve forms. You have now met both, and everything else you already knew.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “comen, viven” — one ending, both families
- “ustedes comen”, addressing a group

Before you move on

Give *they eat* and *they live*. (**Comen, viven.**) In how many of the six slots do the two families agree? (**Four.**) Next chapter: all three families, whole.

Chapter 37

Review — the Present Tense, Whole

Modes: 👁 eyes (1) 🗣 Hands-free start: none of the 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can conjugate any regular Spanish verb in the present, in any of the three families.

Eighteen forms, every one built separately before it appeared in the grid.

37.1 Review — the present tense, whole

Nothing new in this chapter. Say “we eat” and “we live.”

Grammar Lens: eighteen forms, and you built each one

who	-ar	-er	-ir
yo	hablo	como	vivo
tú	hablas	comes	vives
él · ella · usted	habla	come	vive
nosotros	hablamos	comemos	vivimos
vosotros	habláis	coméis	vivís
ellos · ustedes	hablan	comen	viven

This is the present tense of the Spanish language. Not a summary of it, not the regular part of it with exceptions pending — every regular verb in Spanish sits in that grid, and there are thousands of them.

Two things are worth reading off it before you close the chapter:

- **The *yo* row is the same in all three families.** It always was. That is why the second and third families cost so little when they arrived.
- ***-er* and *-ir* differ in exactly two boxes — *nosotros* and *vosotros*. Four of their six forms are identical.**

So the whole grid is really one set of endings with a family vowel, plus two exceptions. That is the shape you have actually learned.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- one column straight down — *hablar*, all six
- one row straight across — *nosotros*, all three families

Twice through: Down a column, then across a row, until neither direction stalls.

Before you move on

How many forms are in the grid? (**Eighteen** — three families, six each.) Which row never varies? (***Yo***.) And how many boxes separate *-er* from *-ir*? (**Two**.)

Chapter 38

Numbers, and How Old You Are

Modes: 🗣️ voice (5) 🖐️ Hands-free start: all 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can count from one through ten and use singular forms of *tener* to ask and answer age with a number I know.

*Count from one through ten, move among *tengo*, *tienes*, and *tiene*, then ask and answer age with the number frame taught in the chapter.*

38.1 uno, dos, tres, cuatro, cinco — counting to five

Numbers are among the most reusable words in any language. Spanish keeps them close enough to Latin that English cousins can help you remember them. This lesson asks for only **five**: **uno, dos, tres, cuatro, cinco**.

Sounds you'll need

- diphthong-ue — **cuatro** begins *KWA*-.
- r-tap — give *tres* and *cuatro* one light tap, not an English *r*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Spanish	Latin source	English memory hook
uno (1)	<i>ūnus</i>	unit , unique
dos (2)	<i>duo</i>	duo , dual
tres (3)	<i>trēs</i>	trio , triple
cuatro (4)	<i>quattuor</i>	quart , quarter
cinco (5)	<i>quīnque</i>	quintet , quintuplet

The spellings changed, but the family resemblance remains. *Cinco* and *quintet* both descend from *quīnque*; Spanish changed the opening sound while English borrowed a more visibly Latin form.

Grammar Lens: uno becomes un or una

When **uno** stands alone, it means “one.” Before a noun it shortens:

- **un** before a masculine noun: **un café** — one coffee / a coffee.
- **una** before a feminine noun: **una noche** — one night / a night.

This shortening is called **apocope**: the end drops away. Spanish uses the same forms for “one” and “a/an”; context supplies the difference.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “uno, dos, tres, cuatro, cinco” — once up, once down
- “uno/unit, dos/duo, tres/trio, cuatro/quart, cinco/quintet”
- “un café, una noche” — hear *uno* shorten

Before you move on

Give 1–5 in Spanish. (*Uno, dos, tres, cuatro, cinco.*) Which English word helps you remember *cinco*? (*Quintet*, through Latin *quīnque*.) What happens to *uno* before a noun? (It becomes **un** or **una**.) Next: **six through ten**.

38.2 seis, siete, ocho, nueve, diez — and the calendar's old count

You can count to five. Add one small set and you reach ten: **seis, siete, ocho, nueve, diez**. Four English month names will help hold the last four in memory.

Sounds you'll need

- diphthong-*ie* — **siete** begins *SYE*-.
- diphthong-*ue* — **nueve** begins *NWE*-.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Spanish	Latin source	English memory hook
seis (6)	<i>sex</i>	sextet
siete (7)	<i>septem</i>	September , septet
ocho (8)	<i>octō</i>	October , octave
nueve (9)	<i>novem</i>	November
diez (10)	<i>decem</i>	December , decimal

Say the chain aloud: *siete–September, ocho–October, nueve–November, diez–December*. It is a memory path, not a second list to memorize.

Why it's said this way

The month names preserve an old Roman count in which **March was first**: September through December occupied positions seven through ten. When January and February stood before March, those names shifted to positions nine through twelve but kept their old numbers.

One tempting story is wrong: July and August were not new months inserted into the middle. The existing months **Quintilis** and **Sextilis** were later **renamed** for Julius Caesar and Augustus. The calendar moved; the numbered names stayed.

Numbers above ten belong to a later chapter. For now, stop cleanly at **diez**.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- count from *uno* through *diez*
- “siete/September, ocho/October, nueve/November, diez/December”

Before you move on

Give 6–10. (*Seis, siete, ocho, nueve, diez.*) Why does *December* carry the old word for ten? (The month names preserve a March-first count.) What happened to Quintilis and Sextilis? (They were renamed July and August.) Next: the verb **tener**, “to have.”

38.3 tener — “to have,” with two visible changes

Regular *comer* gave you *como, comes, come*. The common verb **tener**, “to have,” belongs to the same **-er** family, but its three singular forms change in two places. Learn only those three today.

Sounds you’ll need

- diphthong-**ie** — **ti**enes begins *TYE*-.
- **r-tap** — one light tap at the end of **tener**.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

tener descends from Latin **tenēre**, “to hold or keep.” Having is, at root, holding. English borrowed the same root many times:

- **tenant, tenure, tenacious** — holding land, office, or position.
- **contain, retain, maintain, sustain** — holding together, back, in hand, or up.

When you see *-tain* in English, think of Spanish **tener**.

Grammar Lens: the three singular forms

person	regular <i>comer</i>	irregular <i>tener</i>
yo	como	tengo
tú	comes	 tienes
él / ella / usted	come	 tiene

Two small changes do all the work:

1. **yo** adds **g**: *tengo*, not *teno*. 2. The other two singular forms change **e** → **ie**: *tienes*, *tiene*.

Later chapters will expand both patterns. For now, hold only **tengo**, **tienes**, **tiene** — the same three-person frame you already use for regular verbs.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “tener — tengo, tienes, tiene”
- “tener / tenant / retain” — the shared idea is *hold*
- compare “como, comes, come” with “tengo, tienes, tiene”

Before you move on

What did Latin *tenēre* mean? (“To hold.”) Give the three singular forms. (*Tengo, tienes, tiene.*) What are the two changes? (*g* appears in *tengo*; *e* becomes *ie* in *tienes/tiene*.) Next: use them to ask and answer about **age**.

38.4 ¿Cuántos años tienes? — asking age

You now have *tengo, tienes, tiene* and the numbers one through ten. Put them together and you can ask or answer age. Spanish frames age as something you **have**.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

¿Cuántos años tienes? “How old are you?” — literally, “How many years do you have?”

- **cuántos** means “how many.” Latin **quantus**, “how much,” also gives English **quantity**, **quantum**, **quantify**.
- **años** means “years.” Latin **annus** also gives **annual** and **anniversary**. Its doubled *nn* became Spanish **ñ**, exactly as your script lesson showed.
- **tienes** is the *tú* form of **tener**.

Keep the marks visible: opening **¿**, the accent in **cuántos**, and the letter **ñ** in **años** each carries information.

Grammar Lens: Spanish “has” years

English says “I **am** ten years old.” Spanish says:

— ¿Cuántos años **tienes**? — **Tengo diez años.**

The reusable frame is **Tengo + number + años**. Use a number you already know: *Tengo ocho años*, *Tengo nueve años*, *Tengo diez años*. Larger numbers wait until their own lesson; the grammar does not change.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “¿Cuántos años tienes?”
- “Tengo ocho años. Tengo nueve años. Tengo diez años.”

Before you move on

What does the question literally ask? (“How many years do you have?”) Which verb carries age? (*Tener*.) How do *cuántos* and *años* connect to English? (*Quantus* → quantity; *annus* → annual.) Next: combine counting, *tener*, and age in one short exchange.

38.5 Practice — counting, having, and age

This checkpoint asks for three small moves: count to ten, choose the right singular form of *tener*, and use the age frame. Every-

thing here has already appeared.

Grammar Lens: count and conjugate

- Count: **uno, dos, tres, cuatro, cinco, seis, siete, ocho, nueve, diez.**
- Change person: **tengo · tienes · tiene.**
- Remember the roots: *quīnque* helps with *cinco*; *decem* helps with *diez*; *tenēre*, “hold,” helps with *tener*.
- Keep the calendar correction: July and August were **renamed**, not inserted.

The exchange — use only what you know

— Hola. ¿Cómo te llamas? — Me llamo Ana. ¿Cuántos años tienes? — Tengo diez años. ¿Y tú? — Tengo nueve años.

The exchange reuses the name question you already know, then adds exactly one new capability: age with **tener**.

What you’ve built this chapter

- **uno through diez**, with Latin and English hooks instead of an isolated list.
- **un / una** before a noun, where standalone *uno* shortens.
- **tengo, tienes, tiene**, the three singular forms of **tener**.
- **¿Cuántos años tienes? — Tengo ... años**, with *quantus/quantity* and *annus/annual* showing where the words came from.

Numbers above ten and the plural forms of *tener* remain deliberately deferred.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- count 1–10 up, then down

- “tengo, tienes, tiene”
- ask and answer age with a number from 1–10

Twice through: “¿Cuántos años tienes? — Tengo nueve años.”

Before you move on

Count to ten. Give the three singular forms of *tener*. Ask “How old are you?” and answer with a number you learned. You can now move from a name exchange into one concrete personal detail. Next: the two Spanish ways to say “to be,” introduced one contrast at a time.

Chapter 39

Ser and Estar — Two Ways to Be

Modes: 🗣️ voice (5) 🖱️ Hands-free start: all 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can identify someone, state origin, check wellbeing, and give a location by choosing a learned singular form of ser or estar.

Identify Ana, state an origin with soy de, check a current state, and locate Ana with está en using only previously introduced vocabulary and singular forms.

39.1 ser — another way to say “to be”

You already use **estar** for a current state or location. Spanish also has **ser**. This chapter adds one job at a time; today, learn the verb and the three singular forms that match the person frame you already know.

Sounds you’ll need

- vowel-e — **ser** begins with the clear vowel in *mesa*.
- r-tap — the final **r** is one light tap: *SER*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Modern **ser** grew from a historical merger. Latin **esse** meant “to be,” while **sedēre** meant “to sit.” The infinitive and the present forms do not all come down the same path, so the modern verb cannot be predicted from one neat stem.

The **esse** family is still visible in English **essence**, **essential**, **entity**, **present**, and **absent**. That makes *essence* a useful memory hook for one major use of *ser*: identifying what someone or something **is**.

Grammar Lens: only three forms today

person	form	a small identifying frame
yo	soy	Soy Ana. — “I am Ana.”
tú	eres	Eres Ana. — “You are Ana.”
él / ella / usted	es	Usted es Ana. — “You are Ana.”

Say the set as **soy · eres · es**. These forms are **irregular**: do not try to remove *-er* and attach the regular endings from *comer*. A later lesson will build the plural-person frame.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “ser — soy, eres, es”
- “Soy Ana. Eres Ana. Usted es Ana.”
- “esse — essence — ser”

Before you move on

Which two Latin verbs fed *ser*? (*Esse* and *sedēre*.) Give the three forms learned today. (*Soy, eres, es*.) Why not predict them from the infinitive? (The verb is historically mixed and irregular.) Next: set *ser* beside *estar* using only identity and state frames you already have.

39.2 ser vs estar — identity or current state?

You now have two small sets: **soy, eres, es** and **estás, está**. Do not memorize a long rule list. Make one contrast: **ser identifies**; **estar places someone in a current state or location**.

Grammar Lens: the first contrast, from known material

question	what it asks	verb
¿Es usted Ana? — “Are you Ana?”	identity	ser
¿Está usted bien? — “Are you well?”	current state	estar

Only the verb and the job change. The first question identifies the person; the second checks how that person is now. Both **Ana**, **usted**, and **bien** are already part of your course, so the contrast adds no hidden vocabulary.

Grammar Lens: a memory hook, not a law

- **ser** recalls Latin *esse* and English **essence**: use it here to say who someone **is**.
- **estar** comes from Latin *stāre*, “to stand,” the family behind **state**: use it for the state or location in which someone stands.

“Permanent versus temporary” is only a rough beginner shortcut, not the rule. A location may last for centuries and still use *estar*; an identification may last one minute and still use *ser*. Ask instead: **am I identifying, or am I giving a state or location?**

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “¿Es usted Ana?” — identity, *ser*
- “¿Está usted bien?” — state, *estar*
- “identify: *ser*; state or location: *estar*”

Twice through: “¿Es usted Ana? ¿Está usted bien?”

Before you move on

Which verb identifies? (*Ser*.) Which gives a current state or location? (*Estar*.) Why is “permanent versus temporary” incomplete? (The

choice follows the kind of claim, not its duration.) Next: use *ser* for one specific identity fact — origin.

39.3 soy de... — saying where you are from

You can identify yourself with **Soy Ana**. Add one short word and you can state another identity fact: **Soy de...**, “I am from...”.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

de means “from” or “of.” It comes from Latin **dē**, “down from, away from.” English keeps that direction in **depart** and **descend**. You already learned that *dónde* grew from Latin *de unde*, “from where.” Spanish can put the still-living word **de** before **dónde** to ask explicitly about origin.

Grammar Lens: ser + de for origin

¿De dónde eres? — “Where are you from?” **Soy de Madrid.** — “I am from Madrid.”

The place name **Madrid** already appeared with *vivir*. Here, the new piece is the frame around it. Use **ser**, because this sentence states origin; it does not say where someone is located now.

Keep the two known questions separate:

question	asks about
¿De dónde eres?	origin — where you are from
¿Dónde vives?	residence — where you live

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “¿De dónde eres?”
- “Soy de Madrid.”
- “de — depart — descend”: the shared direction is *from*

Before you move on

What does *de* mean? (“From” or “of.”) Ask where one friend is from. (*¿De dónde eres?*) Answer with Madrid. (*Soy de Madrid.*) Next: reuse *dónde* and *en* to say where someone is located now.

39.4 *está en...* — saying where someone is

You have already asked **¿Dónde vives?** — **Vivo en Madrid** about where someone lives. Now use the same **dónde** and **en** with *estar* to ask about a current location.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

en already means “in,” “on,” or “at.” It descends from Latin **in** and is a cognate of English **in**. No new preposition is needed; only the surrounding verb changes.

Grammar Lens: *dónde* + *estar*, then *estar* + *en*

¿Dónde está usted? — “Where are you?” (formal) **Usted está en Madrid.** — “You are in Madrid.” **Ana está en Madrid.** — “Ana is in Madrid.”

The form **está** is already familiar from *¿Cómo está usted?* The phrase **está en...** simply gives that form a place. Location uses *estar* even when a place seems stable; the choice marks the kind of claim, not how long it lasts.

Compare origin and location without adding any new form:

sentence	meaning	verb
Ana es de Madrid.	origin	<i>ser</i>
Ana está en Madrid.	location	<i>estar</i>

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “¿Dónde está usted?”

- “Ana está en Madrid.”
- “en / in” — two cognates

Before you move on

Which verb locates someone? (*Estar*.) What already-known word introduces the place? (*En*.) Ask formal “Where are you?” (*¿Dónde está usted?*) Next: combine identity, origin, state, and location without adding another word or verb form.

39.5 Practice — identity, origin, state, and location

This checkpoint adds nothing. Use **ser** for identity and origin; use **estar** for a current state or location.

Grammar Lens: retrieve the two small form sets

- **ser**: soy · eres · es
- **estar** in the questions used here: estás · está

Plural forms remain deliberately deferred.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

- **ser**: *esse* + *sedēre*.
- **estar**: *stāre*, “stand.”
- **de**: Latin *dē*, “from.”
- **en**: Latin *in*, English *in*.

Grammar Lens: sort by the kind of claim

prompt	answer	why
¿Es usted Ana?	<i>ser</i>	identity
¿De dónde eres?	<i>ser</i>	origin
¿Está usted bien?	<i>estar</i>	current state
¿Dónde está Ana?	<i>estar</i>	location

The exchange — only known pieces

— Hola. ¿Es usted Ana? — Sí. Soy Ana. — ¿De dónde es usted? — Soy de Madrid. — ¿Dónde está Ana? — Está en Madrid. — ¿Está usted bien? — Bien, gracias.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “soy, eres, es”
- the four questions, naming each job
- the exchange once

Twice through: “¿Es usted Ana? ¿Está usted bien?”

Before you move on

Give the three learned forms of *ser*. (*Soy, eres, es*.) Which verb identifies and states origin? (*Ser*.) Which gives a state or location? (*Estar*.) Ask where one friend is from, then locate Ana in Madrid. Next: **ir**, “to go,” introduced in the same small-step frame.

Chapter 40

Going, and the Future You Can Already Say

Modes: 🗣️ voice (4) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 4 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can ask where someone is going, say what a singular person is going to do, and mark a known singular noun with *mi*, *tu*, or *su*.

*Complete ES-C10-practice, the canonical closing checkpoint, and demonstrate the chapter promise with singular *ir*, *ir a* plus a known infinitive, and *mi*, *tu*, or *su* before *café*.*

40.1 *ir* — “to go,” from more than one historical stem

You already match different verb forms with **tú** and **usted**, and you can ask ¿**Dónde...**?, “Where...?” Today, add one new verb and only its three singular-person forms.

Sounds you’ll need

- vowel-**i** — **ir** is one clear syllable, like *ear* without a glide.
- diphthong-**oy** — **voy** ends with the sound in English *boy*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

ir means “to go.” Its infinitive descends from Latin **īre**, also “to go.” The present forms below followed a different Latin verb, **vādere**, “to go forward” or “advance.” English **invade** and **evade** preserve that *vad*-family.

One modern verb built from historically different stems is called **suppletive**. English does the same thing when *go* changes to *went*, an old form borrowed from *wend*.

Grammar Lens: only three forms today

person	present of ir
yo	voy
tú	vas
él / ella / usted	va

Say the small set as **voy · vas · va**. The plural forms are deliberately left for a later lesson.

The known question word now gives you a useful prompt:

¿Dónde va usted? — “Where are you going?”

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “ir — voy, vas, va”
- “¿Dónde va usted?”
- “īre gives ir; vādere gives the present set”

Before you move on

What does *ir* mean? (“To go.”) Give the three forms learned today. (*Voy, vas, va.*) Why do they look unlike *ir*? (The infinitive and present set come through different Latin stems.) Next: place **a** and a known infinitive after this small set to talk about what is coming.

40.2 voy a + infinitive — moving toward the near future

You know **voy**, **vas**, **va** and the infinitives **hablar**, **comer**, **vivir**. This lesson joins those owned pieces with one short new word.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Spanish **a** means “to” or “toward.” It descends from Latin **ad**, “toward,” which English keeps in words such as **advance**.

Movement toward a place easily becomes movement toward a future event. English uses the same picture in “I am **going to** speak.” Spanish keeps **a** visible: **voy a hablar**.

Grammar Lens: ir + a + an unchanged infinitive

person	near-future frame	meaning
yo	voy a hablar	I am going to speak
tú	vas a comer	you are going to eat
usted	va a vivir	you are going to live

Only **ir** changes for the person. The second verb stays in its known dictionary form: **hablar**, **comer**, or **vivir**. No new plural person or infinitive is hidden in the pattern.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “voy a hablar”
- “vas a comer”
- “va a vivir”

Before you move on

What is the frame? (*Ir* in the present + **a** + an infinitive.) Does the second verb change for the person? (No.) What idea connects physical going with future time? (Motion toward a destination becomes motion toward an event.) Next: say whose already-known **café** it is.

40.3 mi, tu, su — whose café?

You already know **café**, and you distinguish informal **tú** from formal **usted**. Now put one small ownership word before that one known noun.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Spanish	Latin source	meaning in today's frame
mi	<i>meus</i>	my
tu	<i>tuus</i>	your, to one informal tú
su	<i>suus</i>	your, to formal usted ; also his or her

English **my** helps recall **mi**. Older English **thy**, “your,” helps recall Latin *tuus* and Spanish **tu**. The ownership word **tu** has no written accent; the person word **tú** that you already know keeps its accent.

Grammar Lens: put the ownership word before the noun

phrase	meaning
mi café	my coffee
tu café	your coffee, informal
su café	your coffee, formal; or his or her coffee

The situation tells you which person **su** points to. Every noun phrase in this lesson is singular. Forms used before plural things are left for a later step, so there is no new number pattern to learn here.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “mi café”
- “tu café” to *tú*
- “su café” to *usted*

Before you move on

Give the three ownership words. (*Mi, tu, su.*) Where do they go? (Before the noun.) Which one addresses *usted*? (*Su.*) Which Latin sources sit behind them? (*Meus, tuus, suus.*) Next: retrieve the chapter without adding a new word, form, or noun.

40.4 Practice — going, approaching events, and ownership

This checkpoint adds nothing. Retrieve **voy, vas, va**; build the near future with **a** and a known infinitive; then put **mi, tu**, or **su** before the known noun **café**.

Grammar Lens: the complete small chapter frame

- **ir**, singular: **voy · vas · va**.
- near future: **voy a hablar · vas a comer · va a vivir**.
- ownership before one singular known noun: **mi café · tu café · su café**.

Plural person forms of *ir* and possessives before plural nouns remain deferred.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

- **ir** continues Latin *īre*, while **voy, vas, va** continue *vādere*.
- **a** continues Latin *ad*, “toward”; motion toward a goal became motion toward a coming event.
- **mi, tu, su** continue Latin *meus, tuus, suus*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “voy, vas, va”
- “voy a hablar, vas a comer, va a vivir”

- “mi café, tu café, su café”

Twice through: “Voy a hablar. Su café.”

Before you move on

Give the singular *ir* set. (*Voy, vas, va.*) Build “You are going to eat” for one friend. (*Vas a comer.*) Say “my coffee” and formal “your coffee.” (*Mi café; su café.*) The next chapter can now extend the grammar from this small, closed frontier.

Chapter 41

Ser in the Plural

Modes: ⇄ voice (3) 👁 eyes (1) ⇄ Hands-free start: none of the 4 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can use all six present forms of *ser*, and say why no two of them look alike.

Two Latin verbs in one paradigm - and the seam between them is visible at eres.

41.1 somos — “we are”

Say “I am.” (*Soy.*) And “we speak.” (*Hablamos.*)

Grammar Lens: the -mos survives even here

somos — *we are.*

Look at what survived. *Ser* is the most irregular verb in Spanish — *soy*, *eres*, *es* share almost nothing — and yet the plural still ends in **-mos**, exactly as *hablamos* and *comemos* do.

That ending is the single most stable thing in the language. Even a verb that has thrown away everything else kept it.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

And here is why *ser*’s forms refuse to resemble each other: **it is not one verb.** It is two Latin verbs fused into a single paradigm.

- Latin *esse*, “to be”, gave *soy* and *somos* — the *s-* forms, and the rest of that family arrives over the next two lessons.

- Latin **sedēre**, “to sit”, gave *ser* itself, and the future and conditional.

So *somos* and *ser* are not irregular versions of each other. They are descendants of **different words**, brought together because Spanish needed one verb where Latin had two.

English did something very similar. *Am, is, are, was, be* — no two of those look related, because they are not: they come from three separate Old English verbs. Every language seems to build “to be” out of spare parts.

Your turn

- *Say it*: “hablamos, comemos, somos” — the same ending, three times

Before you move on

What is “we are”? (**Somos.**) Which ending did even this verb keep? (**-mos.**) And why do *soy* and *ser* look unrelated? (They **are** unrelated — two Latin verbs in one paradigm.)

41.2 son — “they are”

Say “we are.” (*Somos.*) And “they speak.” (*Hablan.*)

Grammar Lens: the final -n, again

son — *they are*, and **ustedes son**, *you all are*.

Three letters, and it is one of the two or three commonest words in the whole language. The rule you know holds even here: a final **-n** means the subject is plural and is not you.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Latin’s form was **sunt**. Spanish dropped the final **-t**, exactly as it dropped it from *hablat* to give *habla*, and *sunt* became *son*.

That is worth noticing because it is the same erosion you have already watched happen twice. Irregular verbs are not exempt from sound change; they are simply verbs where sound change ran on material that

had already been strange.

A word you may already know. English *sonata*, *sonnet* and *sound* have nothing to do with this — they come from Latin *sonāre*, “to sound”. *Son* the verb and *son* the noun in English are unrelated to each other and to both. Spanish is full of these collisions, and the way through is always the same: the root, not the spelling.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “somos, son” — the two plural forms you now hold
- “ustedes son”, addressing a group

Before you move on

What is “they are”? (**Son.**) What did Latin’s *sunt* lose? (Its **-t**, like every other final *-t*.) Who else does *son* address? (**Ustedes.**)

41.3 sois — the last of the six

Say “they are.” (*Son.*) And which region uses *vosotros*? (*Spain.*)

Grammar Lens: one syllable, and the paradigm closes

vosotros sois — *you all are*, in Spain.

One syllable, and with it the six forms of *ser* are complete: *soy*, *eres*, *es*, *somos*, *sois*, *son*.

As before, this is the form you need in order to **follow** Spain rather than to speak everywhere. In the Americas, *ustedes son* does the same job.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Latin had **estis**. Spanish wore away the *e-* at the front and the *-t-* in the middle, and *sois* is what was left — a word reduced almost to nothing but still doing its whole job.

That is the pattern with this verb throughout. *Ser* is short everywhere

because it is said constantly, and constant use grinds words down. The commonest verb in a language is almost always its most eroded one.

Your turn

- [YOU HEAR: “sois”] → Spain, addressing friends.
- *Say it*: “ustedes son” then “vosotros sois” — the same sentence, two continents

Before you move on

What is the *vosotros* form of *ser*? (**Sois**.) What Latin word is it worn from? (**Estis**.) And why is this verb so short everywhere? (Because it is said **constantly**, and constant use grinds words down.)

41.4 Review — all of ser

Nothing new. Say “we are”, then “they are.”

Grammar Lens: the table, and why it looks like that

who	<i>ser</i> →
yo	soy
tú	eres
él · ella · usted	es
nosotros	somos
vosotros	sois
ellos · ustedes	son

Most books present this as a table to memorise. You have built it a form at a time, and you can now read something off it that memorisation would never give you.

Five of the six begin with s-. One does not. *Eres* is the outlier, and it is the outlier because it comes from somewhere else — Latin *eris*, from *esse*’s own future stem, pulled in to fill a gap. The rest are the *s*-family: *sum*, *sumus*, *sunt*.

So the “irregularity” is not chaos. It is a seam between two verbs, and you can see exactly where it runs.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- all six, top to bottom
- the five *s*- forms, then *eres* on its own

Twice through:

Before you move on

Give all six forms of *ser*. (*Soy, eres, es, somos, sois, son.*) How many begin with *s*-? (**Five.**) And why does the sixth not? (It came from a **different Latin verb** — the seam is visible.)

Chapter 42

Estar in the Plural

Modes: 🗨 voice (3) 👁 eyes (1) 🖱 Hands-free start: first 3 of 4 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can use all six present forms of *estar*, and say why its plural is regular where *ser*'s is not.

One Latin verb against two - which is the whole reason one paradigm is plain and the other is not.

42.1 estamos — the other “we are”

Say “we are” with *ser*. (*Somos*.) And how do you ask a friend how they are? (¿*Cómo estás?*)

Grammar Lens: this one behaves

estamos — *we are*.

Drop the **-ar**, add **-amos**. That is the plain *-ar* ending you learned on *hablamos*, applied without alteration.

And that is the point of this lesson. You have just spent a chapter on *ser*, whose six forms come from two different Latin verbs and refuse to resemble each other. **Estar is not like that at all.** In the plural it is an ordinary *-ar* verb.

hablamos · *estamos* — the same ending, and no surprises.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

The reason is simple, and it is the reason for almost every irregularity you have met: **estar is one verb**. Latin *stāre*, “to stand” — and that is the whole ancestry. Nothing was fused into it, so nothing in it has a seam.

Ser is irregular because two verbs were welded together. *Estar* is regular because it never was.

That is worth carrying, because it predicts the rest. Where a Spanish verb looks chaotic, the usual explanation is not that it decayed strangely but that it is **more than one word wearing a single name**.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “hablamos, estamos” — the same ending
- “somos, estamos” — two verbs for *we are*, and only one of them is strange

Before you move on

What is “we are” with *estar*? (**Estamos.**) Which Latin verb is it from? (***Stāre***, “to stand”.) And why is it regular where *ser* is not? (Because it is **one** verb, not two.)

42.2 están — “they are”

Say “we are” with *estar*. (*Estamos.*) And “they speak.” (*Hablan.*)

Grammar Lens: the ending is regular, the accent is the clue

están — *they are*, and **ustedes están**, *you all are*.

The ending is **-an**, exactly as in *hablan*. But there is a written accent, and it is not decoration.

Estar is unusual in one specific way: it puts its stress on the **ending** rather than the stem, in every singular and plural form except *estamos*. You have already seen this without being told — *estás*, *está*, and now

están. The accent is simply Spanish writing that stress down, by the rule for written accents you learned long ago.

hablan — stress on the stem, no accent. **están** — stress on the ending, so an accent.

Same ending, different stress, and the spelling records it faithfully.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “hablan” then “están” — same ending, and hear the stress move
- “ustedes están”, addressing a group

Before you move on

What is “they are” with *estar*? (**Están**.) Why the accent? (The stress falls on the **ending**.) Which form of *estar* does not do that? (**Estamos**.)

42.3 estáis — and nothing surprises you

Say “they are” with *estar*. (*Están*.) And the *vosotros* form of *hablar*? (*Habláis*.)

Grammar Lens: predictable, and that is the news

vosotros estáis — *you all are*, in Spain.

If you guessed that before reading it, you have understood the chapter. The ending is *-áis*, the plain *-ar* one from *habláis*, and the accent is there for the reason it is always there with this verb: the stress sits on the ending.

That is now three forms in a row where knowing *estar* meant knowing nothing new. In the Americas, *ustedes están* does this job.

Your turn

- *Say it*: “habláis” then “estáis” — the same ending, twice

Before you move on

What is the *vosotros* form of *estar*? (**Estáis.**) Why the accent? (*Estar* stresses its **ending**.) And in Argentina? (***Ustedes están.***)

42.4 Review — both verbs for “to be”

Nothing new. Say *somos*, then *estamos*.

Grammar Lens: side by side, and the difference is history

who	<i>ser</i>	<i>estar</i>
yo	soy	estoy
tú	eres	estás
él · ella · usted	es	está
nosotros	somos	estamos
vosotros	sois	estáis
ellos · ustedes	son	están

Read the two columns down and the difference is not a matter of difficulty. It is a matter of **history**.

- ***Ser*** is two Latin verbs fused — *esse* and *sedēre* — so its forms have no common shape. Five begin with *s-*; *eres* does not, and that is the seam.
- ***Estar*** is one Latin verb, *stāre*. Its plural is a plain *-ar* paradigm, and the only oddity in the whole column is where the stress falls, which the written accent records honestly.

So the two hardest-looking verbs in Spanish are hard for opposite reasons: one because it is two words, and the other not really at all.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- one column down, then the other
- each row across — *soy, estoy · somos, estamos* — and hear which column surprises you

Twice through:

Before you move on

Which of the two verbs is regular in the plural? (***Estar.***) Why? (It is **one** Latin verb; *ser* is two.) And what is the only oddity in *estar*'s column? (Where the **stress** falls — which the accent records.)

Chapter 43

Tener in the Plural, and the Stem-Change Rule

Modes: 🔄 voice (1) 👁 eyes (1) 🔄 Hands-free start: none of the 2 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can use tener in every person, and state when a stem changes and when it does not.

The stem breaks exactly where it is stressed - so nosotros and vosotros never break, in any verb.

43.1 tenemos — and the stem change disappears

Say “I have” and “you have.” (*Tengo, tienes.*) And “we eat.” (*Comemos.*)

Grammar Lens: the break is gone

tenemos — *we have.* · **tenéis** — *you all have.*

Not *tenemos*. Look at what happened: *tienes* had the broken stem **ie**, and here it is plain **e** again — the ordinary *-er* endings, on the ordinary stem.

You already know why. It is the same reason *-er* and *-ir* looked identical in the singular and parted in the plural: **stress**.

Tienes stresses the stem, and a stressed **e** in that position breaks into **ie**. *Tenemos* stresses the *ending*, so the stem is unstressed and its vowel stays whole.

The stem change was never a property of the verb. It is a property

of **where the stress lands**, and these two forms are where the stress lands elsewhere.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “tienes” then “tenemos” — and hear the stress move off the stem
- “comemos, tenemos” — the same endings

Before you move on

What is “we have”? (**Tenemos.**) Where did the **ie** go? (Nowhere — it only ever appears when the **stem** is stressed.) Next: the form where the stress comes back.

43.2 **tienen** — the break comes back

Say “we have”, then “you have” to a friend. (*Tenemos, tienes.*) Which one has the broken stem?

Grammar Lens: the rule, stated once and for all

tienen — *they have*, and **ustedes tienen**, *you all have*.

The **ie** is back. And now you have seen it appear, vanish and return, which is enough to state the rule outright:

A stem change happens exactly where the stem is stressed, and nowhere else.

That is four forms with the break — setting aside the *yo* form, which has an oddity of its own — and two without: *nosotros* and *vosotros*. Always those two. In every stem-changing verb in the language. Learners are usually told to memorise a shape called “the boot” — the four stressed forms drawn as an outline around a table. **You do not need the boot.** You need to know where Spanish puts its stress, which you already do.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “tienes, tenemos, tienen” — break, no break, break
- the two forms that never break, for any verb

Before you move on

What is “they have”? (**Tienen.**) State the stem-change rule. (**The stem breaks exactly where it is stressed.**) Which two forms never break? (*Nosotros* and *vosotros.*)

Chapter 44

Ir in the Plural — a Verb That Is Not Ir

Modes: 🔄 voice (2) 🔄 Hands-free start: all 2 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can use *ir* in every person, and say why its present belongs to a different verb.

*The present of *ir* is regular for *vadere* - and the four commonest verbs are now complete.*

44.1 vamos — from a verb that is not *ir*

Say “I go.” (*Voy.*) And “we speak.” (*Hablamos.*)

Grammar Lens: -amos and -áis, on a stem you have not seen

vamos — *we go.* · **vais** — *you all go.*

The endings are ordinary. **-amos** and **-áis** are the plain *-ar* endings from *hablamos* and *habláis*.

What is strange is the stem. The infinitive is *ir*, and there is no *v* in it anywhere — yet every one of these forms begins with one.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

You met this shape two chapters ago and now you can use it as a tool.

Ir is not one verb. Latin had **īre**, “to go”, which gives the infinitive *ir* and little else. It also had **vādere**, “to advance, to make one’s way”,

which gives *voy, vas, va, vamos, vais* and one more — the entire present tense.

So the present of *ir* is not irregular. It is **regular for a different verb**, one whose infinitive Spanish stopped using. The endings behave perfectly; they are simply attached to a stem the dictionary form does not show you.

That is the third time this pattern has explained something: *ser* from *esse* and *sedēre*, and now *ir* from *īre* and *vādere*. **English does it too** — *go* and *went*, where *went* is really the past of *wend*.

The commonest verbs in a language are the likeliest to be made of more than one, because they are used so much that no single word's forms survive intact.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “hablamos, vamos” — the same ending, an unexpected stem
- “voy, vas, va, vamos, vais” — all one verb, and it is not *ir*

Before you move on

What is “we go”? (**Vamos.**) Which Latin verb do these forms come from? (**Vādere.**) And what does that make *ir*? (**Two verbs**, like *ser* — and like English *go* and *went*.)

44.2 van — and the four are done

Say “we go.” (*Vamos.*) And “they speak.” (*Hablan.*)

Grammar Lens: the last form

van — *they go*, and **ustedes van**, *you all go*.

Latin's form was *vadunt*. Spanish wore it down to three letters, and the rule still holds visibly: a final **-n**, and the subject is plural and not you.

What you've built

Four chapters ago you could conjugate any *regular* verb in the present, and none of the irregular ones. Now the four commonest verbs in Spanish are complete in every person:

ser · **estar** · **tener** · **ir** — *to be, to be, to have, to go*.

And each one taught something that outlives it:

- **ser** — two Latin verbs fused, so the seam shows at *eres*.
- **estar** — one verb, so it is regular; the accent only marks stress.
- **tener** — the stem breaks exactly where it is stressed, in **every** stem-changing verb, which is why *nosotros* and *vosotros* never break.
- **ir** — its present belongs to a different verb entirely.

Three of those four are about the same underlying thing: **a verb that looks chaotic is usually more than one word**, and the places it looks regular are the places one word survived intact.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “somos, estamos, tenemos, vamos” — the four, in the *we* form
- “son, están, tienen, van” — the four, in the *they* form

Twice through: Until all four run without a gap.

Before you move on

What is “they go”? (**Van.**) Name the four verbs you have just completed. (*Ser, estar, tener, ir.*) And what do three of them have in common? (Each is **more than one Latin verb**, or its stem change follows the stress.)

Chapter 45

Verbs That Break in the Middle — the Stem Changers

Modes: 🗣️ voice (5) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can express singular wanting and ability, compare the learned e-to-ie and o-to-ue changes, and say our with a known singular noun.

Complete ES-C11-practice, the canonical closing checkpoint, and demonstrate singular querer and poder, the learned vowel-change contrast, and nuestro or nuestra before a known singular noun.

45.1 querer — wanting with one familiar vowel change

You already say **tienes** and **tiene**, where the middle **e** opens into **ie**. Today, reuse that visible change in one useful verb and keep the same three-person frame you already own.

Sounds you'll need

- diphthong-ie — begin **quiero** with one smooth *kye*- syllable.
- r-tap — end the infinitive **querer** with one light tap.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

querer means “to want.” With a person as its object, it can also express love, but wanting is the meaning used in this lesson.

It descends from Latin **quaerere**, “to seek or ask.” English keeps the same searching idea in **query**, **quest**, **inquire**, and **require**. Wanting something begins as seeking it.

Grammar Lens: only the three singular forms

person	present of querer
yo	quiero
tú	quieres
él / ella / usted	quiere

Say the small set as **quiero** • **quieres** • **quiere**. The **e** → **ie** that you saw in **tienes**, **tiene** is visible again. The plural persons are deliberately left for a later step.

Place one known infinitive after the form of **querer**:

- **Quiero hablar.** — “I want to speak.”
- **Quieres comer.** — “You want to eat.”
- **Quiere vivir.** — “He, she, or formal you wants to live.”

The second verb stays in its known infinitive form.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “querer — quiero, quieres, quiere”
- “Quiero hablar”
- “quaerere — query — querer”

Before you move on

What does *querer* mean? (“To want.”) Give the three learned forms. (*Quiero, quieres, quiere.*) Which Latin verb and English cousin help explain it? (*Quaerere*, “seek”; *query* or *quest*.) Next: add the other

singular vowel change with **poder**.

45.2 poder — ability with the o → ue change

Quiero hablar says what you want to do. Now change the first verb to say what you are able to do. The second verb will remain a known infinitive.

Sounds you'll need

- diphthong-ue — **puedo** begins *pwe-* with one smooth glide.
- r-tap — end **poder** with one light tap.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

poder means “to be able”; in a sentence it often translates as “can.” It descends through Latin **potere** from **posse**, “to be able.” English **power**, **potent**, **potential**, and **possible** belong to the same family. Ability is the power to do something.

Grammar Lens: the three singular forms

person	present of poder
yo	puedo
tú	puedes
él / ella / usted	puede

Say **puedo · puedes · puede**. In these three learned forms, the stem **o** opens into **ue**. Plural persons wait.

Follow the form of **poder** with one unchanged infinitive:

- **Puedo hablar.** — “I can speak.”
- **Puedes comer.** — “You can eat.”
- **Puede vivir.** — “He, she, or formal you can live.”

Compare **Quiero hablar** with **Puedo hablar**: only the first verb changes the meaning from want to ability.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “poder — puedo, puedes, puede”
- “Puedo hablar”
- “poder — power — possible”

Before you move on

What does *poder* mean? (“To be able; can.”) Give the three learned forms. (*Puedo, puedes, puede.*) What English word is its close cousin? (*Power.*) Next: compare only the singular forms you have actually learned.

45.3 e → ie and o → ue — compare the singular forms

You now own three small singular sets: **tengo, tienes, tiene**; **quiero, quieres, quiere**; and **puedo, puedes, puede**. Compare only those learned forms before extending the pattern later.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

On the road from Latin to Spanish, many short **e** and **o** vowels opened when stressed: **e → ie** and **o → ue**. That history helps explain why a verb’s stem can look different across its forms.

It is a clue, not a machine that predicts every form. Learn each verb’s small set, then use the shared history to organize what you remember.

Grammar Lens: two changes, one learned frame

person	tener / querer, e → ie family	poder, o → ue
yo	tengo / quiero	puedo
tú	tienes / quieres	puedes
él / ella / usted	tiene / quiere	puede

The comparison says exactly this:

- **querer** shows **ie** in all three forms learned here.
- **poder** shows **ue** in all three forms learned here.
- **tener** reminds you that a common verb may combine more than one change: **tengo** has its known **g**, while **tienes** and **tiene** show **ie**.

No plural form and no new verb is part of today's generalization.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “quiero, quieres, quiere”
- “puedo, puedes, puede”
- “stressed e and o often opened to ie and ue”

Before you move on

Which change appears in *querer*? (**e** → **ie**.) In *poder*? (**o** → **ue**.) Why is the history useful but not a complete prediction rule? (It organizes learned forms, but individual verbs can combine or resist changes.) Next: one possessive that agrees with a known noun's gender.

45.4 nuestro, nuestra — “our” with singular gender agreement

You put **mi**, **tu**, or **su** before the known noun **café**. Now add “our” and let it match one contrast you learned much earlier: masculine **día** beside feminine **noche**.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

nuestro and **nuestra** mean “our.” They descend from Latin **noster**, also “our.” **Paternoster** means “Our Father,” and English **nostrum** originally meant “our thing.”

The change from *noster* to **nuestro** also displays the historical **o** → **ue**

opening you just used to organize **poder**.

Grammar Lens: match singular gender

known noun

el día, masculine

la noche, feminine

“our” phrase

nuestro día

nuestra noche

Like **mi**, **tu**, and **su**, the new word goes before the noun. Unlike those earlier forms, it shows the noun’s gender: **nuestro** before a masculine singular noun, **nuestra** before a feminine singular noun.

Only these two singular forms belong to this lesson. Plural agreement and the separate word for “your” to a group wait.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “nuestro día”
- “nuestra noche”
- “noster — nuestro — Paternoster”

Before you move on

Which form goes before masculine *día*? (*Nuestro*.) Before feminine *noche*? (*Nuestra*.) What Latin source explains the pair? (*Noster*, “our.”) Next: retrieve the whole chapter without adding a form.

45.5 Practice — wanting, ability, and our known nouns

This checkpoint adds nothing. Retrieve two three-form verbs, compare their two vowel changes, and choose **nuestro** or **nuestra** before one known singular noun.

Grammar Lens: the complete small chapter frame

- wanting: **quiero** · **quieres** · **quiere** plus a known infinitive.
- ability: **puedo** · **puedes** · **puede** plus a known infinitive.
- the contrast: **e** → **ie** in the learned *querer* set; **o** → **ue** in the learned *poder* set.
- singular “our”: **nuestro día** · **nuestra noche**.

Plural persons and plural possessive agreement remain deferred.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

- **querer** continues Latin *quaerere*, “seek,” the family of **query**.
- **poder** continues the Latin ability family behind **power** and **possible**.
- stressed Latin **e** and **o** often opened into Spanish **ie** and **ue**.
- **nuestro**, **nuestra** continue Latin *noster*, “our.”

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “quiero hablar; puedo hablar”
- “quieres comer; puedes comer”
- “nuestro día; nuestra noche”

Before you move on

Give the two singular sets. (*Quiero, quieres, quiere; puedo, puedes, puede.*) Which vowel contrast organizes them? (**e** → **ie** beside **o** → **ue**.) Say “our day” and “our night.” (*Nuestro día; nuestra noche.*) The next chapter can now build from this closed singular frontier.

Chapter 46

Hacer, Decir, and the -go Verb Club

Modes: 🗣️ voice (3) 👁️ eyes (1) 🦋 Hands-free start: first 2 of 4 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can use the three learned singular forms of *hacer* and *decir* and compare *tengo*, *hago*, and *digo* without predicting unseen verbs.

Complete ES-C12-practice, the canonical closing checkpoint, and demonstrate the chapter promise with known words and only the learned singular person frame.

46.1 *hacer* — doing or making with three singular forms

You already use **tengo**, **tienes**, **tiene**, and you already know **café** and the question word **qué**. Reuse that small frontier for one verb that covers both English “do” and “make.”

Sounds you’ll need

The **h** in **hacer** is silent, just as it is in **hola**. In **hago**, the written **g** has the hard sound heard before **a**.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

hacer means “to do” or “to make.” It descends from Latin **facere**, with the same making root preserved in English **fact**, **factory**, and **manufacture**. Much of early Castilian changed word-initial Latin **f** into

an **h** sound that later became silent, leaving the spelling as a historical trace.

Grammar Lens: only the three singular forms

person	present of <i>hacer</i>
yo	hago
tú	haces
él / ella / usted	hace

Say the bounded set as **hago · haces · hace**. Only the learned **yo** form contains **g**. Compare it with the familiar **tengo**, but do not extend the comparison beyond forms you already own.

Use the forms with one known object:

- **Hago café.** — “I make coffee.”
- **Haces café.** — “You make coffee.”
- **Hace café.** — “He, she, or formal you makes coffee.”

You can also ask **¿Qué haces?** — “What are you doing?” Plural persons and weather expressions wait for later lessons.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “hacer — hago, haces, hace”
- “¿Qué haces? Hago café.”
- “facere — fact — factory — hacer”

Before you move on

What two English verbs does *hacer* cover? (“Do” and “make.”) Give the three learned forms. (*Hago, haces, hace.*) Which Latin source and English cousin help explain it? (*Facere; fact* or *factory.*) Next: add **decir** without widening the person frame.

46.2 decir — saying with the same small person frame

You can ask **cómo**, say **hola**, and retrieve **hago**, **haces**, **hace**.
Keep those three persons fixed while adding the verb “to say.”

Sounds you’ll need

In **dig**o, the **g** before **o** is hard. Keep the **i** in all three learned forms short and clear: **dig**o, **dices**, **dice**.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

decir means “to say” or “to tell.” It descends from Latin **dīcere**, “to say.” English keeps the same root in **diction**, **dictionary**, **predict** (“say beforehand”), and **verdict** (“a true saying”).

Grammar Lens: one more three-form set

person	present of decir
yo	dig o
tú	dices
él / ella / usted	dice

Say **dig**o · **dices** · **dice**. The **yo** form has **g**, while the other two learned forms do not. Do not build a full table or a general vowel-change rule from this small set yet.

Now combine it only with known language:

- **Digo hola.** — “I say hello.”
- **Dices hola.** — “You say hello.”
- **Dice hola.** — “He, she, or formal you says hello.”
- **¿Cómo dices “hola”?** — “How do you say ‘hello’?”

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “decir — digo, dices, dice”

- “Digo hola. ¿Cómo dices hola?”
- “dicere — diction — decir”

Before you move on

What does *decir* mean? (“To say” or “to tell.”) Give the three learned forms. (*Digo, dices, dice.*) Which Latin source and English cousin help explain it? (*Dicere; diction, dictionary, or predict.*) Next: compare only the three **yo** forms you have actually learned.

46.3 tengo · hago · digo — compare only what you know

Three learned verbs now place **g** in the **yo** form: **tengo, hago, digo**. Compare those three without guessing the form of any unseen verb.

Grammar Lens: one visible corner

infinitive	meaning	learned yo form	learned tú form
tener	to have	tengo	tienes
hacer	to do / make	hago	haces
decir	to say / tell	digo	dices

The shared observation is narrow: each learned **yo** form ends in **-go**, while each learned **tú** form does not. This is a memory organizer for three known forms, not permission to manufacture new ones.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

The three modern forms did not arise by attaching one productive Latin **-go** ending. Older stem sounds changed in different ways, and analogy helped common verbs converge on a familiar shape. That mixed history explains why the group is useful to remember but unsafe as a prediction rule.

Later lessons can introduce other verbs on their own evidence. For now, the complete comparison is exactly **tengo · hago · digo**.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “tengo — hago — digo”
- “tienes — haces — dices”
- “a memory organizer, not a prediction machine”

Before you move on

Which three learned **yo** forms end in **-go**? (*Tengo, hago, digo.*) May this comparison predict an unseen verb? (No.) Why not? (Different sound histories and analogy converged on the same shape.) Next: retrieve the whole chapter without adding any word or form.

46.4 Practice — doing, making, and saying in the singular

This checkpoint adds nothing. Retrieve two bounded three-form sets, use them with known words, and compare only **tengo**, **hago**, **digo**.

Grammar Lens: the complete small chapter frame

- doing or making: **hago** · **haces** · **hace**.
- saying or telling: **digo** · **dices** · **dice**.
- the learned **yo** comparison: **tengo** · **hago** · **digo**.
- known-word use: **Hago** café. **Digo** hola. ¿Cómo **dices** “hola”?

Plural persons, weather nouns, homework vocabulary, and unseen verbs remain outside this checkpoint.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

- **hacer** continues Latin *facere*, the making family of **fact** and **factory**.

- **decir** continues Latin *dicere*, the saying family of **diction** and **predict**.
- inherited sound changes and analogy made three known **yo** forms converge on **-go**; the resemblance does not predict forms you have not learned.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “hago, haces, hace”
- “digo, dices, dice”
- “tengo, hago, digo”
- “Hago café. Digo hola.”

Before you move on

Give both three-form sets. (*Hago, haces, hace; digo, dices, dice.*) Which three learned **yo** forms share **-go**? (*Tengo, hago, digo.*) Why is that comparison a memory aid rather than a prediction rule? (Its mixed history does not license unseen forms.) The next chapter may now introduce its own verbs one at a time.

Chapter 47

Poner — Putting, and the Root Under Position

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🗋️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can say what I put, with the -go yo form and regular forms elsewhere.

pongo in the yo slot, pones and pone everywhere else.

47.1 poner — putting or placing with three singular forms

You already know **hago**, **haces**, **hace** and the careful comparison **tengo** · **hago** · **digo**. Add one verb on its own evidence: **poner**, “to put” or “to place.”

Sounds you’ll need

The **g** in **pongo** has the familiar hard sound. Tap the final **r** of **poner** lightly; do not turn it into the stronger written **rr** sound.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

poner descends from Latin **pōnere**, “to put or place.” English keeps the same placing family in **position**, **compose** (“place together”), and **deposit** (“place down”). The two shapes **pon-** and **pos-** are historical relatives, so *poner* and *position* are cousins even though their endings differ.

Grammar Lens: only the three singular forms

person	present of <i>poner</i>
yo	pongo
tú	pones
él / ella / usted	pone

Say the bounded set as **pongo · pones · pone**. The learned **yo** form joins the known comparison because it ends in **-go**. That resemblance helps memory; it still does not predict an unseen verb.

For now, practise the forms and their meaning without importing a new object. Later lessons can add the nouns needed for expressions such as setting a table or putting on clothing. Plural persons and reflexive **ponerse** also wait.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “poner — pongo, pones, pone”
- “pōnere — position — poner”
- “a learned comparison, not a prediction rule”

Before you move on

What does *poner* mean? (“To put” or “to place.”) Give its three learned forms. (*Pongo, pones, pone.*) Which Latin source and English cousin help explain it? (*Pōnere; position, compose, or deposit.*) Next: learn **salir** inside the same three-person frame.

Chapter 48

Salir — Leaving

Modes: ⇄ voice (1) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can say that I leave, and use the regular forms for anyone else.

salgo in the yo slot; sales and sale behave normally.

48.1 salir — leaving with three singular forms

You can retrieve **pongo**, **pones**, **pone**, and you already use **de** with a place name. Keep that frontier while adding **salir**, “to leave” or “to go out.”

Sounds you’ll need

The **g** in **salgo** is hard. Keep the **l** clear in every form: **salgo**, **sales**, **sale**.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

salir descends from Latin **salīre**, “to leap” or “to jump.” The older image of leaping outward developed into the everyday meaning “to go out.” English **salient** first carried the sense “leaping” or “springing,” and a **sally** is a sudden movement outward. Those cousins preserve the same motion without requiring a long list of uncertain relatives.

Grammar Lens: one more singular set

person	present of salir
yo	salgo
tú	sales
él / ella / usted	sale

Say **salgo** · **sales** · **sale**. Only the learned **yo** form contains **g**. Compare it with **pongo** because both forms are now known, not because one form could have predicted the other.

Reuse the known word **de** and the familiar place name Madrid:

- **Salgo de Madrid.** — “I leave Madrid.”
- **Sales de Madrid.** — “You leave Madrid.”
- **Sale de Madrid.** — “He, she, or formal you leaves Madrid.”

Plural persons, dating expressions, house vocabulary, and the noun for “exit” wait until their own lessons.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “salir — salgo, sales, sale”
- “Salgo de Madrid.”
- “salire — salient — salir”

Before you move on

What does *salir* mean? (“To leave” or “to go out.”) Give the three learned forms. (*Salgo, sales, sale.*) What did Latin *salire* mean? (“To leap” or “to jump.”) Name one English cousin. (*Salient* or *sally.*) Next: add **venir** and compare it only with already-learned **tener**.

Chapter 49

Venir — Coming

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can say that I come, and hear the stem break in the other two forms.

vengo, then vienes and viene with the ie break.

49.1 venir — coming with three singular forms

You can say **salgo de Madrid**, and you already know **tengo**, **tienes**, **tiene**. Now learn **venir**, “to come,” inside exactly the same three singular persons.

Sounds you’ll need

The **g** in **vengo** is hard. In **vienes** and **viene**, let **ie** move as one smooth vowel sequence.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

venir descends from Latin **venīre**, “to come.” English **convene** means “come together”; an **event** is something that “comes out”; and **adventure** passed through the idea of what may “come to” a person. The recurring **ven-** or **vent-** shape marks this old coming family.

Grammar Lens: one known comparison, still singular

person	present of venir	known tener comparison
yo	vengo	tengo
tú	vienes	tienes
él / ella / usted	viene	tiene

Say **vengo** · **vienes** · **viene**. The learned singular forms line up closely with **tengo** · **tienes** · **tiene**: the **yo** form ends in **-go**, while the other two show **ie**. This comparison describes two complete learned sets; it does not introduce a plural “boot” table or license guesses about other verbs.

Now contrast leaving and coming with known **de** and Madrid:

- **Salgo de Madrid.** — “I leave Madrid.”
- **Vengo de Madrid.** — “I come from Madrid.”
- **Vienes de Madrid.** — “You come from Madrid.”

Plural persons and free-standing arrival vocabulary wait for later lessons.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “venir — vengo, vienes, viene”
- “Vengo de Madrid.”
- “vengo / tengo — vienes / tienes”

Before you move on

What does *venir* mean? (“To come.”) Give its three learned forms. (*Vengo, vienes, viene.*) Which learned verb provides the close comparison? (*Tener: tengo, tienes, tiene.*) Which Latin source and English cousin help explain it? (*Venīre; convene, event, or adventure.*) Next: compare all six learned **yo** forms only after retrieving this chapter’s three verbs.

Chapter 50

Review — Six Verbs, One Ending

Modes: 🗣️ voice (2) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 2 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name all six -go verbs and say why the list is closed.

The club is complete at six - and it was never a club, only six unrelated verbs that converged.

50.1 Review — six verbs, one ending

Nothing new in this chapter. Say the *yo* forms of the three verbs you have just met: *poner, salir, venir*.

What you've built

The set is closed. Six of the commonest verbs in Spanish put an unexpected **-go** on the *yo* form and nowhere else:

verb	<i>yo</i>	and the rest behaves
tener	tengo	normally
hacer	hago	normally
decir	digo	normally
poner	pongo	normally
salir	salgo	normally
venir	vengo	normally

Six verbs, one oddity, and it lives in exactly one slot. That is a much smaller thing to carry than “six irregular verbs.”

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Here is what the six chapters could not show you separately.

They are not a family. Nobody decided these six belonged together. They came from different Latin verbs, by different routes, and arrived at the same ending by accident — a *g* that was already in some of the stems, and a sound change that pulled the others into line behind them. The club is a result, not a rule. Spanish learners are taught “the -*go* verbs” as though someone had drawn up a membership list; what actually happened is that six unrelated words drifted into the same shape and then reinforced each other.

That is worth knowing for a practical reason: it tells you the list is **closed**. A pattern with a cause keeps recruiting. A pattern that is an accident stops.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- all six *yo* forms in one breath — *tengo, hago, digo, pongo, salgo, vengo*
- for each, the plain infinitive it came from

Twice through: Until the six run together as one list.

Before you move on

How many verbs take -*go*? (**Six.**) In how many slots? (**One** — the *yo* form.) And why does the list not grow? (Because it was never a rule — six unrelated verbs happened to converge.)

50.2 Practice — putting, leaving, and coming in the singular

This checkpoint adds nothing. Retrieve the three bounded singular sets first. Only then widen the memory comparison from three learned **yo** forms to six.

Grammar Lens: the complete frame for this chapter

- putting or placing: **pongo** • **pones** • **pone**.
- leaving or going out: **salgo** • **sales** • **sale**.
- coming: **vengo** • **vienes** • **viene**.
- known-word contrast: **Salgo de Madrid. Vengo de Madrid.**
- known singular comparison: **vengo / tengo** • **vienes / tienes** • **viene / tiene**.

Now that all three new verbs have been taught, the learned **yo** comparison can grow to exactly **tengo** • **hago** • **digo** • **pongo** • **salgo** • **vengo**. It remains a retrieval aid, not a rule for predicting any unseen verb.

Plural persons, full boot diagrams, reflexive clothing expressions, house and table nouns, clock times, dinner vocabulary, and other unseen contexts remain outside this checkpoint.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

- **poner** continues Latin *pōnere*, the placing family of **position**.
- **salir** continues Latin *salīre*, the leaping family of **salient**.
- **venir** continues Latin *venīre*, the coming family of **convene**.
- different inherited histories and analogy let the six known **yo** forms converge on **-go**; the shared shape does not make a productive prediction rule.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “pongo, pones, pone”
- “salgo, sales, sale”
- “vengo, vienes, viene”
- “tengo, hago, digo, pongo, salgo, vengo”

Before you move on

Give all three new singular sets. (*Pongo, pones, pone; salgo, sales, sale; vengo, vienes, viene.*) Which six learned **yo** forms now share **-go**? (*Tengo, hago, digo, pongo, salgo, vengo.*) Why is the list a memory aid rather than a prediction rule? (Different histories converged on one shape.) The next chapter may now introduce a new time frame without borrowing any plural form from this chapter.

Chapter 51

Synthesis — You, and Somebody Else

Modes: 🗣 voice (1) 🗣 Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can say the same thing about myself and about someone else, and know which of the two is irregular.

The oddity lives only in the yo slot - the form a beginner says most.

51.1 Synthesis — you, and somebody else

Nothing new here. Say three of the six *-go* forms, whichever come first.

Grammar Lens: the odd slot is the one about you

Here is the practical shape of what you have, and it is worth noticing before you use it.

These six verbs are irregular **only when you talk about yourself**. Every one of them behaves normally the moment the sentence is about anybody else:

salgo — but *sales, sale*. **pongo** — but *pones, pone*. **vengo**
— but *vienes, viene*.

So the cost of the whole set is one form each, and it is the form you will use most, because most of what a beginner says is about themselves. That is a good trade, and it is not an accident of teaching order: the verbs that wore down oddly are the ones people said constantly.

The exchange

The same two sentences, once about you and once about a friend. Watch which word changes shape and which does not:

Salgo. — *I'm leaving.* **Sales.** — *You're leaving.*

>

Vengo. — *I'm coming.* **Viene.** — *He's coming.*

One word each time, no pronoun, and the only surprise is in the first line of each pair.

What you've built

Six of the most common verbs in the language, in the person you speak in most. You can now say that you have, do, say, put, leave and come — about yourself, in one word, with no pronoun.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- each pair above — first about yourself, then about someone else
- all six *yo* forms, then all six *tú* forms, and hear the difference vanish

Twice through:

Before you move on

Which slot in these six verbs is irregular? (**Only** the *yo* form.) How many words does “I’m leaving” take? (**One** — *salgo*.) Why is that one form worth the trouble? (Because it is the one you will say most.)

Chapter 52

Deriving the Rest

Modes: ⇐ voice (2) 👁 eyes (1) ⇐ Hands-free start: first 1 of 3 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can produce the plural of any irregular verb in this book from rules, and conjugate a verb I was never shown.

Three rules generate the whole present tense - and a system, unlike a table, works on words it has never seen.

52.1 queremos, quieren — work them out first

Before you read on: you have the singular of *querer*, and you have the stem-change rule. **What is “we want”?** Say your answer out loud, then continue.

Grammar Lens: you were right

queremos — *we want.* · **quieren** — *they want.* **podemos**
— *we can.* · **pueden** — *they can.*

If you said *queremos* rather than *quieremos*, you did not remember it. You **derived** it, from a rule you were given one chapter ago: the stem breaks exactly where it is stressed, so *nosotros* never breaks. And *quieren* breaks, because there the stress is back on the stem. That is the difference between a course that hands you tables and one that hands you rules. Four forms you had never seen, and none of them needed teaching.

A test you can run yourself. You have *puedo* and *puedes*.

Without being told, what are *we can* and *they can*?

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the *yo*, *nosotros* and *ellos* forms of *querer* — break, no break, break
- the same three for *poder*

Before you move on

What is “we want”? (**Queremos.**) Why no break? (The stress is on the **ending.**) And could you have produced these without this lesson? (**Yes** — which is the point of it.)

52.2 hacemos, hacen — and the club has no plural at all

Name the six *-go* verbs. And say where in each one the *-go* appears.

Grammar Lens: an oddity that was only ever in one slot

You were told, when the club closed, that the **-go** lives in the *yo* form and nowhere else. Here is what that is worth:

hacemos · **hacéis** · **hacen** — plain *-er* endings.
ponemos · **ponéis** · **ponen** — plain *-er* endings. **sal-**
imos · **salís** · **salen** — plain *-ir* endings.

Nothing to learn. The *-go* club has no plural forms of its own, because the thing that made it a club was never in the plural to begin with. Two of the six do something in the plural, and it is **not** the *-go*:

decimos but **dicen** · **venimos** but **vienen**

Those are stem changes, and they follow the rule you already have — the stem breaks where it is stressed, and *nosotros* is never stressed on the stem. So even the exceptions are not exceptions.

What you've built

Two rules — **the -go is yo-only**, and **stems break under stress** — now generate the entire present tense of every irregular verb in this book, in every person.

That is what a rule buys that a table does not: the table stops at the forms printed on it.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- all six *-go* verbs in the *we* form — and hear that none is odd
- “decimos, dicen” and “venimos, vienen” — the two that break, and why

Before you move on

How many special plural forms does the *-go* club have? (**None** — the *-go* was only ever in *yo*.) Which two do something in the plural, and what? (*Decir* and *venir* — a **stem change**, following the stress.) How many rules now generate every irregular present in this book? (**Two**.)

52.3 Synthesis — a verb you have never met

Nothing new in this chapter, and nothing to memorise. Say the six endings of a regular *-er* verb.

What you've built

Everything you hold about the present tense now fits in three lines:

1. **Three families**, six endings each; **-er** and **-ir** differ only in *nosotros* and *vosotros*. 2. **A stem breaks exactly where it is stressed** — so *nosotros* and *vosotros* never break. 3. **A -go sits in the yo form and nowhere else.**

That is the whole system. Not a summary of it — the system. And a system, unlike a table, works on words it has never seen.

The exchange

Here is a verb this book has not taught you: **beber**, “to drink” — you have met the word, but never its full set.

Do not look anything up. It is a regular **-er** verb, so:

bebo · bebes · bebe · bebemos · bebéis · beben

Six forms, and the only thing you needed was rule 1.

Now one that uses all three rules. **Salir** is an **-ir** verb, and it is in the **-go** club. Rules 1 and 3 give you every form, and you can produce them before reading on:

salgo · sales · sale · salimos · salís · salen

One odd form, in the one slot rule 3 names. The other five are plain **-ir**.

Four broken, two whole, and the two whole ones are the two the stress leaves alone. Every time.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- all six of *beber*, without looking
- all six of *salir*, and name the only odd one

Twice through: Until deriving is faster than remembering.

Before you move on

State the three rules. (**Three families · stems break under stress · the -go is yo-only.**) Which two forms never break? (*Nosotros, vosotros.*) And what can you do now that a table could not give you? (**Conjugate a verb nobody taught me.**)

Chapter 53

La Casa — Your First Everyday Noun

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🖱️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can say *la casa* and *tengo una casa*, using the article and gender rules I already hold.

Complete ES-C43-casa: produce *la casa* and *tengo una casa*, and say what *casa* meant in Latin.

53.1 la casa — “house,” and “home”

You have spent a long time learning what to **do** with nouns — their gender, their articles, their agreement. This chapter and the next few hand you some nouns to do it with.

Sounds you’ll need

- **s-sound** — the *s* in *casa* is a plain, unvoiced *s*. Spanish has no *z* buzz here: *KAH-sah*, never *KAH-zah*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la casa — *the house*, and just as often *home*.

Latin **casa** meant something humbler than a house: a **hut**, a cottage, the small shelter a farm worker lived in. The grand Latin word for a proper house was *domus* — which is where **domestic** and **dome** come from. And *domus* lost. Across the whole west of the Roman world the

humble word won and the grand one faded: Spanish *casa*, Italian *casa*, Portuguese *casa*.

French took the same word somewhere stranger. *Casa* wore down until it stopped being a noun at all and became the little word **chez** — so *chez moi* is, underneath, “at the house of me.”

Italian kept a small one too: *casino* is *casa* plus a diminutive ending — literally “little house.”

Grammar Lens: a feminine noun, behaving exactly as promised

Casa ends in *-a* and is feminine, so it takes **la**. That is the common case, and it is worth having one plain example on hand before you meet the awkward ones.

la casa — the house. *Tengo una casa.* — I have a house.

Nothing new is happening here. That is the point: the machinery has been ready for a long time, and this is the first ordinary thing to run through it.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “la casa” — *KAH-sah*, a clean *s*
- “Tengo una casa”

Before you move on

What is “the house”? (***La casa.***) What did *casa* mean in Latin? (A **hut** — the humble word that outlived the grand one.) Next: a masculine noun whose Latin ancestor was a piece of a tree.

Chapter 54

El Libro — And a Word Made of Tree Bark

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can say *el libro* and *tengo un libro*, and contrast it with *la casa* as a gender pair.

Complete ES-C43-libro: produce el libro and tengo un libro, and say what Latin liber originally named.

54.1 el libro — “book”

Say “the house.” (*La casa.*) Why *la* and not *el*? (*Casa* is feminine.) Here is one that goes the other way.

Sounds you’ll need

- **r-tap** — a single flick of the tongue: *LEE-broh*. One tap, not a roll.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el libro — *the book*.

Latin **liber** did not mean “book.” It meant the **inner bark of a tree** — the thin, pale layer just under the rough outside, which is what Romans wrote on before they had anything better.

So the word travelled the way these words usually do: from the **material**, to the **thing made of it**, to the thing itself long after the material

is gone. Nobody has written on bark for two thousand years, and the word has not noticed.

English took the same root and kept it in the places books live:

- **library** — and French *livre*, Italian *libro*.
- **libretto** — Italian for “little book,” the words of an opera.

English’s own word went the same route from a different tree: **book** is related to **beech**, whose bark the Germanic peoples wrote on. Two languages, two trees, the same idea.

Grammar Lens: a masculine noun to sit beside the feminine one

Libro ends in *-o* and is masculine, so it takes **el**.

el libro — the book. *Tengo un libro.* — I have a book. *la casa* — the house. *Tengo una casa.* — I have a house.

Two nouns, one of each gender, side by side. That pairing is worth more than either noun alone: from here on, when something in Spanish depends on gender, you have a plain example of both to test it against.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “el libro” — one tap on the *r*
- “Tengo un libro” then “Tengo una casa” — hear the article follow the noun

Before you move on

“The book”? (***El libro.***) “The house”? (***La casa.***) What was *liber* before it was a book? (Tree **bark**.) Next: a noun you can build yourself, out of a verb you already have.

Chapter 55

La Comida — A Noun You Can Build

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🗋️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can build comida from comer with -ida, and know that nouns made this way are feminine.

Complete ES-C43-comida: derive comida from comer and say what gender the -ida ending guarantees.

55.1 la comida — “food,” built from a verb you have

Say “to eat.” (*Comer.*) Keep it in mind — this chapter’s noun is made out of it, in front of you.

Sounds you’ll need

- **d-soft** — the *d* between vowels is soft, close to the *th* in English *this*: *ko-MEE-thah*, not a hard *d*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la comida — *food*, and also *a meal*.

Take *comer*, drop the ending, add **-ida**:

comer → **comida** — literally *the eaten thing*.

That ending is not decoration. It is a working tool: it takes a verb and

hands you back a noun for the **result** of that verb. You will meet it again and recognise it when you do.

This is the first Spanish noun you did not have to be given. You could have built it. That is a different kind of possession from memorising a list, and it is the reason the ending is worth more here than the word.

Comer itself comes from Latin **comedere** — *ed-* is “eat,” the same ancient root as English **eat**, with *com-* (“thoroughly”) in front. So *comida* is, at the bottom, “the thoroughly-eaten thing.”

Grammar Lens: -ida nouns are feminine

Nouns built this way end in *-a* and are **feminine**, every time. So the ending gives you two things at once: the word, and its gender.

la comida — the food. *Hago la comida.* — I make the meal.

Set your three nouns side by side and the pattern is doing all the work:

noun	gender	article
<i>libro</i>	masculine	el
<i>casa</i>	feminine	la
<i>comida</i>	feminine	la

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “comer” then “comida” — hear the verb inside the noun
- “Hago la comida”

Before you move on

What verb is hiding inside *comida*? (**Comer.**) What does the *-ida* ending give you besides the word? (Its **gender** — always feminine.) Next: what happens to these three nouns, and to their articles, when there is more than one of something.

Chapter 56

Las — The Plural Article That Behaves

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🗋️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can say *las casas* and *las comidas*, putting the plural -s on both the article and the noun.

Complete ES-C44-las: produce *las casas* and *las comidas* and say how many new rules the chapter added.

56.1 las casas — “the houses”

You learned this in your first chapter: a noun ending in a vowel adds **-s**. So what is “houses”? (*Casas*.) Now — what is “**the** houses”?

Grammar Lens: the article does what the noun does

las — *the*, for more than one feminine thing.

la casa → **las casas** — the houses. *la comida* → **las comidas** — the meals.

The **-s** lands on **both** words. That is not two rules; it is one rule applied where it belongs. You have already seen Spanish do this — *buenas noches* is *buenas* copying *noche*’s number — and it is the same instinct throughout the language: **the words around a noun agree with it**, so when the noun goes plural, they follow.

So *las* is not a word to memorise. It is *la* obeying the rule you already hold.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “la casa” then “las casas” — hear the *-s* twice
- “las comidas”

Before you move on

“The houses”? (***Las casas.***) Where did the *-s* go? (**Both** words.)
Next: the masculine one, which does not do the obvious thing — and the reason will be familiar.

Chapter 57

Los — The One That Does Not Add -s

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can say *los libros* and explain why the masculine plural article is not *els*.

Complete ES-C44-los: produce *los libros*, give all four articles, and say why *el* does not simply take an *-s*.

57.1 los libros — “the books”

Last chapter: *la casa* → *las casas*. Apply the same move to *el libro* and say what you get, out loud, before reading on.

Grammar Lens: not els

If you said *els libros*, you did exactly the right thing and Spanish did not.

los — *the*, for more than one masculine thing.

el libro → **los libros** — the books.

The noun behaved. The article did not: *el* became **los**, not *els*. Out of four articles this is the only one that changes more than its ending, and it is worth two minutes rather than a shrug.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

You have met this exact story before, three chapters ago, wearing different clothes.

El is not a whole word that lost its way. It is a **worn-down** one: Latin *illum* gave *elo*, and *elo* lost its final vowel to become *el*. The plural came from *illos* — and it did **not** lose that vowel. It kept it, dropped the front instead, and arrived as **los**.

So the pair is not *el* + *s*. It is two forms of one Latin word that wore down in two different directions:

	singular	plural
masculine	<i>elo</i> → el	<i>illos</i> → los
feminine	<i>illam</i> → la	<i>illas</i> → las

This is the same shape as *el* and *lo*, which you met when the object pronouns started: the masculine forms lost a vowel where the feminine ones had none to lose. One sound change, showing up for the third time. An “irregular” article turns out to be a regular word that was worn down twice.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “el libro” then “los libros”
- “el, la, los, las” — the whole set, in order

Before you move on

“The books”? (**Los libros**.) Why not *els*? (*El* is worn down from *elo*; the **plural kept the vowel**.) Next: the plural rule your first chapter promised and did not give you.

Chapter 58

-es — The Plural Chapter One Promised

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can form the plural of a word ending in a consonant, and say why the extra vowel is there.

Complete ES-C44-plural-es: pluralise espanol, name the word that has carried this rule since long before the chapter, and say why -s alone will not do.

58.1 -es — the plural your first chapter owed you

Say “you,” formally. (*Usted.*) Now say it to a group. (*Ustedes.*) Hold both of those in your mouth for a moment.

Grammar Lens: you have been doing this for fifty chapters

Your first chapter gave you half a rule and said the rest was for later. This is later.

A word ending in a vowel adds -s. A word ending in a consonant adds -es.

And you already know the second half, because you have been saying it since the day you learned to address a group:

usted → *ustedes*.

That is not a special word. That is the consonant rule, and nobody told you. Here it is again on something you also hold:

español → *españoles* — Spanish people, Spanish speakers.
los españoles — with the plural article from last chapter.

Why it's said this way

The extra *e* is not decoration and not an exception. Try saying *ustedes* out loud. Then *españols*.

Spanish does not let a word end in that pile of consonants. So when the plural *-s* would land somewhere unsayable, the language puts in the vowel it needs to get the *-s* out — and that vowel is *e*.

Which means the rule is really **one** rule with a repair attached: *add -s; if you cannot say it, make room*. That is a better thing to hold than two rules, because it will keep explaining things long after this chapter.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “usted” then “ustedes” — the rule you already had
- “los españoles”
- try “usteds” and hear why the *e* exists

Before you move on

Vowel ending — which plural? (**-s**.) Consonant ending? (**-es**.) And why? (A bare *-s* there would be **unsayable**.) Next: the four articles in one place, now that every one of them has been earned.

Chapter 59

Review — All Four Words for The

Modes: 👁 eyes (1) 🗉 Hands-free start: none of the 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can give el, la, los and las and state the plural rule including its consonant repair.

Complete ES-C44-repaso-articulos: give the four articles in order and state the plural rule in one sentence.

59.1 Review — all four words for “the”

Nothing new here. Before the table: how many words does Spanish have for “the”?

What you’ve built

Four. And you have now met every one of them separately, which is why they are allowed to appear together.

	singular	plural
masculine	el libro	los libros
feminine	la casa	las casas

English has one word here and Spanish has four, so it is easy to read this table as three extra things to carry. It is not. It is **two** questions you were already answering — *which gender?* and *how many?* — laid out in a grid.

The first chapter of this book taught the top row. The last two chapters taught the bottom one. Nothing in this table arrived without being built.

Grammar Lens: the two plural rules

And underneath the grid, one rule with a repair:

Add -s. If the word ends in a consonant and the -s would be unsayable, add -es instead.

- *casa* → *casas*, *libro* → *libros*, *comida* → *comidas* — vowels, plain -s.
- *usted* → *ustedes*, *español* → *españoles* — consonants, -es.

You held the first half from chapter one and the second half from *ustedes* without knowing it had a name.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “el, la, los, las” until the order is automatic
- “el libro, los libros, la casa, las casas”

Twice through: Until the grid is a reflex rather than a lookup.

Before you move on

Four articles — say them. (***El, la, los, las.***) Two questions decide which? (**Gender** and **number.**) Next: what happens to *a* when there is more than one — and the answer is not what you would expect.

Chapter 60

Synthesis — More Than One

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can contrast a bare plural with a definite plural, and know that the indefinite article is dropped rather than pluralised.

Complete ES-C44-sintesis-mas-de-uno: say tengo libros and tengo los libros and explain what separates them.

60.1 Synthesis — more than one

Say “I have a book.” (*Tengo un libro.*) Now say “I have books,” and notice where you hesitate.

Grammar Lens: the article that leaves

The hesitation is the right instinct. *The* pluralised neatly — *el* became *los*. *A* cannot, because “a” and “more than one” disagree by definition. English solves this by swapping in another word: *a book* → *some books*, or just *books*. Spanish takes the shorter road:

*Tengo **un** libro.* — I have a book. *Tengo **libros**.* — I have books.

The article simply goes. Not replaced, not pluralised — dropped. A bare plural noun is a complete, ordinary Spanish phrase.

This is the mirror image of everything you have been doing. For fifty chapters Spanish has made you say *more* than English: two genders, four articles, six verb endings. Here, for once, it says less.

The exchange

Read this aloud and watch the two plurals doing different jobs.

— ¿Tienes libros? — Sí, tengo libros. — ¿Y los libros de la casa? — Los libros de la casa, no.

Bare *libros* means “books, some books, books in general.” *Los libros* means “**the** books” — particular ones, already known to both of you.

That is the same distinction English makes and never explains: *do you have books?* is a different question from *do you have the books?* You have simply never had to choose it deliberately before.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “Tengo un libro” then “Tengo libros” — hear the article vanish
- “libros” then “los libros”, twice, until the two feel like different questions

Before you move on

“I have books”? (*Tengo libros* — no article.) “I have the books”? (*Tengo los libros*.) Which article pluralises and which one leaves? (**The** pluralises; **a** leaves.) Next: the small words that let you stop naming a thing you have already named.

Chapter 61

Lo — Saying It Without Naming It

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can replace a masculine noun already named with *lo*, in front of the verb.

*Complete ES-C42-lo: turn *Tengo el libro* into *Lo tengo*, and name the article that shares *lo*'s Latin ancestor.*

61.1 lo — “it”

Say “my name is” in Spanish. (*Me llamo.*) Where does that little *me* sit — before the verb, or after it?

Grammar Lens: a slot you have been using all along

Before the verb. You have known that since your fourth chapter, and you have been doing it every time you say your name. Here is a second word for that same slot.

lo — *it*, standing in for something masculine.

Watch what it does:

*Tengo **el libro**.* — I have the book. ***Lo** tengo.* — I have it.

The noun leaves; *lo* takes its place; and it goes where *me* goes — in front of the verb. Not one new rule. One new word for a slot you already own.

Notice that this only became possible last chapter. A pronoun replaces a noun, so it needs a noun to replace — which is why these three ordinary words came first.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Lo should look faintly familiar, and it should also look wrong. It is almost *el*, but not quite. That is not a coincidence, and the near-miss has a cause.

Latin *ille*, “that one,” changed shape depending on the job it was doing. As the **object** of a verb it was **illum**. Spanish got both its article and its object pronoun out of that one word — and then wore it down twice, differently, because the two jobs put the stress in different places:

- Leaning on a noun, unstressed, it lost its vowel: *illum* → *elo* → *el*.
- Standing alone in the verb’s slot, it kept the vowel: *illum* → *lo*.

So *el* and *lo* are the same ancient word, split by the work it was asked to do. English did something similar with *he* and *him*: one word, two shapes, and the shape tells you the job.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “Tengo el libro” then “Lo tengo” — hear the noun disappear
- “me llamo” then “lo tengo” — the same slot, twice

Before you move on

What does *lo* mean? (**It** — for something masculine.) Where does it go? (**Before** the verb.) Next: the same job, done by a word that never changed its shape at all.

Chapter 62

La — The Pronoun Carries What Left

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can replace a feminine noun with *la*, and explain that the pronoun carries a gender the sentence no longer states.

Complete ES-C42-la: turn Hago la comida into La hago and say what decides between lo and la.

62.1 la — “it,” for a feminine noun

Say “I have it,” about the book. (*Lo tengo.*) Now guess the feminine version before you read on.

Grammar Lens: the form you probably guessed

la — *it*, standing in for something feminine.

Hago la comida. — I make the meal. **La hago.** — I make it.

If you guessed *la*, you were not lucky. You were doing what the shape of Spanish invites you to do: *el* and *la* mark the two genders everywhere else, so the object pronouns mark them the same way.

The pronoun agrees with the **noun it replaces** — not with you, and not with the verb. *El libro* is masculine, so *lo*. *La comida* and *la casa* are feminine, so *la*.

That last point is worth pausing on. *La* here is not agreeing with anything present in the sentence. The noun is **gone**; the pronoun is carrying its gender on its behalf. This is the first time in Spanish that a word has had to remember something that is no longer being said.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Last chapter had a small mystery: why *lo* and not *el*, when both come from the same Latin word? Here that mystery quietly disappears.

The feminine object form in Latin was **illam**. Worn down as an article it gave *la*. Worn down as a pronoun it gave — *la*. Both routes arrived at the same place, because the vowel that got lost on the masculine side (*elo* → *el*) was never at risk on the feminine side.

So the masculine pair split into two shapes and the feminine pair did not. Not an exception to memorise: a single sound change that happened to bite one word and not the other.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “Hago la comida” then “La hago”
- “lo tengo” then “la hago” — one syllable carries the whole difference

Before you move on

Which pronoun replaces a feminine noun? (**La**.) What decides it — you, the verb, or the noun? (The **noun**, even though it is no longer there.) Next: the same slot, for the two people actually talking.

Chapter 63

Me and Te — The Two People Talking

Modes: 🗣️ voice (2) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 2 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can say *te quiero* and *me quieres*, and tell the doer form apart from the object form.

Complete ES-C42-te: produce te quiero and me quieres, and name the English pair that matches tu and te.

63.1 me quieres — “you love me”

Say “my name is.” (*Me llamo.*) That *me* has been in your mouth for more than fifty chapters. This chapter gives it nothing new to look like — only something new to do.

Grammar Lens: the same word, a simpler job

In *me llamo*, the *me* points back at the speaker: *I call myself*. That is a special use, and it was the one you needed first.

Here is the ordinary one:

***Me* quieres.** — You love **me**.

Now *me* is not pointing back at anybody. It is simply the person the verb lands on — the same job *lo* does for a book and *la* does for a meal.

Lo tengo. — I have it. *Me quieres.* — You love me.

Same slot, in front of the verb. Same kind of work. The only difference is that *me* is a person and *lo* is a thing, which is a fact about the world rather than a fact about Spanish.

Notice what this chapter did **not** ask you to learn: a form. You already had it. Some of the ground you gain in a language is like this — not new material, but an old piece turning out to reach further than you were told.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Me comes from Latin **mē**, and Latin got it from something far older. English **me** is not a translation of it and not a borrowing from it — the two are the **same inherited word**, sitting in two languages that split thousands of years ago and never bothered to change it.

Words this short and this used are the ones that survive intact. That is why your very first Spanish pronoun was also the easiest one you will ever meet.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “me llamo” then “me quieres” — the same syllable, two jobs
- “lo tengo” then “me quieres” — hear that the slot never moves

Before you move on

Say “you love me.” (***Me quieres.***) Where did the pronoun go? (**Before** the verb, as always.) Next: the answering half of that sentence.

63.2 te quiero — “I love you”

Say “you love me.” (*Me quieres.*) Now turn it around in your head: what would “I love you” need?

Grammar Lens: the partner of **tú**

te — *you*, when you are the one it happens to.

Te quiero. — I love you.

Tú is for the one doing; *te* is for the one it lands on. Spanish keeps those apart with two different shapes, the same way it keeps *el* and *lo* apart, and the same way English keeps *I* and *me* apart.

Me quieres. — You love me. ***Te quiero.*** — I love you.

Two words each, and a complete exchange. Read them aloud one after the other: the pair is a conversation.

One thing worth knowing before you use it. *Querer* means *to want*, and you have been using it that way for a long time. But *querer* pointed at a **person** does not mean wanting them — it means **loving** them. *Quiero un libro* is “I want a book”; *te quiero* is “I love you.” So the sentence is built entirely out of pieces you already had. What is new is not a form — it is that the verb changes its meaning depending on whether its object is a thing or a person.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Te is Latin **tē** — the object form of **tū**, which you already have. English used to do this exactly. Old English had **thou** for the doer and **thee** for the one it happened to — and, this is the striking part, those are **the same two words**. *Tú/te* and *thou/thee* are one ancient pair, inherited twice. English later dropped both and let *you* cover the two jobs; Spanish kept them apart.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “Te quiero” then “Me quieres” — a whole exchange in four words
- “tú” then “te”, and “thou” then “thee” — the same split twice

Before you move on

Say “I love you.” (***Te quiero.***) And “you love me.” (***Me quieres.***) Which English pair matches *tú* and *te*? (**Thou** and **thee**.) Next: all four of these in one place, for the first time.

Chapter 64

Review — Four Pronouns, One Slot

Modes: 👁 eyes (1) ⇄ Hands-free start: none of the 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can name me, te, lo and la and say which of them a noun decides.

Complete ES-C42-repaso-objeto: give all four pronouns and identify the single question that chooses between them.

64.1 Review — four pronouns, one slot

Nothing new in this chapter. Before the table: where does an object pronoun go?

What you've built		
Four chapters, four words, and now they can stand together — because you built each one separately and none of them is new here.		
the one it happens to	pronoun	example
me	me	<i>me quieres</i> — you love me
you	te	<i>te quiero</i> — I love you
it (masculine)	lo	<i>lo tengo</i> — I have it
it (feminine)	la	<i>la hago</i> — I make it
Read down the last column. The verb never moved. The pronoun never		

moved. Only the first word changed, and it changed for one reason at a time.

Grammar Lens: the single question

Choosing between these looks like four decisions. It is one:

Who or what is the verb landing on?

- If it is you speaking → *me*.
- If it is the person you are speaking to → *te*.
- If it is a thing or somebody else → *lo* or *la*, and the **noun** decides which, not you.

That last clause is the whole of the difficulty. *Me* and *te* are about the conversation, so you always know them. *Lo* and *la* are about the noun, so they are only as reliable as your grip on its gender. That is why the three nouns came first: *el libro* and *la comida* are not vocabulary here so much as the two test cases you run every new pronoun against.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the four in order, then the four examples
- “Te quiero” and “Me quieres” back to back, as if two people were speaking

Twice through: Until the choice arrives before the sentence does.

Before you move on

Four pronouns — say them. (***Me, te, lo, la.***) Which two are decided by a noun rather than by you? (***Lo*** and ***la.***) Next chapter has no new forms either — it asks what these words are actually **for**.

Chapter 65

Synthesis — Saying It Once

Modes: ⇄ voice (1) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can answer a yes/no question about a thing already named without naming it again.

Complete ES-C42-sintesis-decirlo-una-vez: answer Tienes el libro and Haces la comida with lo tengo and la hago, and say what was wrong with the grammatically correct version.

65.1 Synthesis — saying it once

Answer out loud: ¿Tienes el libro? Say yes, and do not use the word *libro*.

The exchange

Here are the same two exchanges, twice. Read both versions aloud.

Version one:

— ¿Tienes el libro? — Sí, tengo el libro. — ¿Haces la comida?
— Sí, hago la comida.

Version two:

— ¿Tienes el libro? — Sí, lo tengo. — ¿Haces la comida? —
Sí, la hago.

Every sentence in version one is correct. Not one of them is a mistake. And no speaker of Spanish would say them.

Grammar Lens: what the pronoun is actually for

These four words do not make you more **correct**. They make you sound like somebody having a conversation instead of somebody completing an exercise.

A conversation carries what has already been said. English does the same thing and you have never noticed: you would not answer *do you have the book?* with *yes, I have the book*.

So this is the first place where knowing the form is not the skill. **The skill is noticing that the thing has already been named** — and no table can drill that.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- both versions of the book exchange, and hear the difference
- “Sí, lo tengo” and “Sí, la hago” until no decision is needed

Before you move on

¿Tienes el libro? (Sí, lo tengo.) ¿Haces la comida? (Sí, la hago.)

And what were these four words for? (**Not** repeating what has already been said.) Next: the past tense — and you will find these four words sit in exactly the same place there.

Chapter 66

Nos — Us, and the Word Inside -mos

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can say *nos quieren*, and say what *nosotros* is made of.

Complete ES-C45-nos: produce *nos quieren* and name the verb ending that is the same ancient word.

66.1 nos — “us”

Say “you love me.” (*Me quieres.*) And “I love you.” (*Te quiero.*) Both of those are about **one** person on the receiving end. Here is more than one.

Grammar Lens: the third person in the room

nos — *us*.

Nos quieren. — They love **us**.

Same slot as always, in front of the verb. *Me* is one person speaking; *nos* is that person and somebody else.

Me quieren. — They love me. *Nos quieren.* — They love us.

One letter of difference, and the difference is how many people you are speaking for.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Nos is Latin **nōs**, which meant both *we* and *us* — the language had not yet split them into two words.

You have been carrying it for a long time without being shown. The *-mos* ending on *hablamos*, *comemos*, *tenemos* is that same **nōs**, worn down and glued to the back of the verb. Every time you said “we speak,” you were saying *nos* twice: once in the ending, and once by not needing to say it at all.

And the word for “we” itself:

nosotros — *we*, literally **nos** + **otros**, “we **others**.”

Spanish added *otros* to the plain *nos* somewhere in the Middle Ages, to make clear the speaker meant *this* group and not the person being addressed. Nothing else in the family did it quite this way, and the seam is still visible in the word.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “Me quieren” then “Nos quieren”
- “hablamos” and hear the *nos* at the end of it

Before you move on

Say “they love us.” (***Nos quieren.***) What is *nosotros* made of? (***Nos*** + ***otros*** — “we others.”) Next: the plural of *lo* and *la*, and you will not need to be told what they are.

Chapter 67

Los and Las — Them, Derived

Modes: 👁 eyes (1) 🗉 Hands-free start: none of the 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can make any direct object pronoun plural, and say why the pronoun is tidier than the article.

Complete ES-C45-los-las: produce *los tengo* and *las hago*, and explain why *lo* needed no repair in the plural when *el* did.

67.1 los and las — “them”

Tengo el libro becomes *lo tengo*. Now: *Tengo los libros*. Say the short version out loud **before** reading on.

Grammar Lens: you were right

los — *them*, masculine. **las** — *them*, feminine.

Tengo los libros. → **Los** *tengo.* — I have them. *Hago las comidas.* → **Las** *hago.* — I make them.

Add -s. That is the whole lesson, and you did it yourself in the warm-up. Two chapters have now asked you for a plural and this is the first one that behaved exactly as you would guess. That is worth noticing rather than passing over: most of what is ahead of you in Spanish is like this, and the memorable exceptions are memorable because they are rare.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

There is one genuinely satisfying thing here.

The **article** could not do this. *El* did not become *els*; it became *los*, because *el* is a worn-down *elo* that had lost its vowel and the plural had kept it.

The **pronoun** never lost that vowel. *Lo* is *illum* with the vowel intact — which is exactly why it was not *el* in the first place. So when the plural came, *lo* had nothing to repair:

	singular	plural
article	el (worn down)	los
pronoun	lo (vowel kept)	los

The two arrive at the same place from different directions, and the pronoun takes the plain road. An irregularity in one column and none in the other, from one Latin word, decided entirely by which one got leaned on.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “lo tengo” then “los tengo”; “la hago” then “las hago”
- “el / los” then “lo / los” — one pair changed shape, one did not

Before you move on

“I have them,” about books? (**Los tengo.**) About meals? (**Las hago.**) How do you make an object pronoun plural? (Add **-s.**) Next: one more form, and it belongs to one part of the world.

Chapter 68

Os — You All, in Spain

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🖱️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can use *os* for a group in Spain and *los* or *las* everywhere else.

Complete ES-C45-os: say os quiero and its non-peninsular equivalent, and name the older word os is worn down from.

68.1 os — “you all,” in Spain

Which word for “you all” is used in Spain, and which everywhere else? (*Vosotros* in Spain; *ustedes* everywhere.) That split is about to appear one last time.

Grammar Lens: the object form of vosotros

os — *you all*, as the one it happens to.

Os quiero. — I love you all.

Two letters, the shortest word in the set. It pairs with *vosotros*, so it lives exactly where *vosotros* lives: Spain, and nowhere else in daily speech.

Across the Atlantic, “you all” as an object is **los** or **las** — the same forms you learned last chapter, because *ustedes* is grammatically a *they*-word:

Os quiero. — I love you all. **(Spain)** **Los quiero.** — I love you all. **(everywhere else)**

Neither is a mistake for the other. Several hundred million speakers will never say *os* in their lives, and forty million say it every day.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Os was **vos**, and the *v* simply fell off in the object slot — a word this small, said this often, and never stressed, wears faster than the rest of the language.

That same *vos* is still visible in two places you have met. It is the front of **vosotros** (*vos* + *otros*, “you others,” built exactly like *nosotros*). And it survives **whole** as a subject pronoun in Argentina and much of Central America, where *vos* replaces *tú*.

So one Latin word left three descendants alive in three different conditions: worn to *os* in Spain, glued into *vosotros* in Spain, and standing intact as *vos* across the Río de la Plata. Same word, three fates, decided by geography.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “Os quiero” then “Los quiero” — the same sentence, two continents
- “vos”, “os”, “vosotros” and hear one word in three states

Before you move on

“I love you all,” in Spain? (***Os quiero.***) Elsewhere? (***Los quiero.***) What is *os* worn down from? (***Vos.***) Next: all eight of these in one place.

Chapter 69

Review — All Eight

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can give all eight direct object pronouns and say which four depend on a noun.

Complete ES-C45-repaso-ocho: give the eight pronouns and identify the four that a noun decides.

69.1 Review — all eight

Nothing new here. Before the grid: where does an object pronoun sit, and has that ever changed?

What you've built

Never, in nine chapters. Here is the complete set:

	singular	plural
me	me	nos
you	te	os (<i>Spain</i>)
it / them — masculine	lo	los
it / them — feminine	la	las

Eight cells, built one at a time, and this is the first page on which they have all appeared together. That is deliberate. A grid handed to you on the day you met the first one would have been eight things to memorise; here it is a picture of ground you already hold.

Count the genuinely new **shapes** you had to learn across those chapters: *me* was already yours from chapter four, *te* was one, *nos* one, *os* one, *lo* one, *la* one — and *los* and *las* were free, because you produced them yourself from an *-s*.

Grammar Lens: two questions

Reading the grid as eight decisions is the hard way. It is two:

1. **Who is on the receiving end** — me, you, or something else? 2. **How many, and if it is a thing, which gender?**

The second question only bites in the bottom two rows, because only there does a noun decide. *Me*, *te*, *nos* and *os* are settled by the conversation itself: you always know who is talking.

So the difficulty is not eight-eighths of this table. It is one quarter of it.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the eight in grid order, twice
- “me quieres, te quiero, nos quieren, os quiero”

Twice through: Until the grid is a reflex rather than a lookup.

Before you move on

How many direct object pronouns are there? (**Eight**.) How many of them depend on a noun? (**Four**.) Next: what all eight are for, in a conversation that would be unbearable without them.

Chapter 70

Synthesis — The Conversation Without Them

Modes: ⇄ voice (1) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can carry a four-turn exchange using pronouns, and say what a pronoun promises the listener.

Complete ES-C45-sintesis-sin-repetir: run the exchange with pronouns and say what goes wrong when the gender points at nothing.

70.1 Synthesis — the conversation without them

¿Tienes los libros? Answer yes without saying *libros*.

The exchange

Four turns, with the pronouns:

— ¿Tienes los libros? — Sí, los tengo. — ¿Y las comidas? —
Las hago hoy.

Now the same four turns without them:

— ¿Tienes los libros? — Sí, tengo los libros. — ¿Y las comidas?
— Hago las comidas hoy.

Read the second version aloud, all four lines. It is not wrong anywhere. It is exhausting, and by the fourth line it sounds like somebody being careful with a stranger rather than talking.

Grammar Lens: what a pronoun buys, and what it costs

The pronoun buys speed, and it is paid for with **attention**.

Los tengo is only clear because both of you remember what *los* points at. If the last three sentences were about meals and you say *los tengo*, your listener hunts for a masculine thing and finds none. A pronoun is a promise that the thing is still in the room.

That is the real skill, and it is not on the grid: **hold what has been said, and point back at it accurately**. English asks the same of you and you have done it since you were three, which is why nobody taught it to you. Here the pointer must also agree in gender and number — which is why *lo* and *la* were the hard quarter of that table.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- both versions of the four-turn exchange, and hear the second one tire
- “los tengo” and “las hago” until the gender arrives with the noun, not after it

Before you move on

¿Tienes los libros? (Sí, los tengo.) ¿Y las comidas? (Las hago.)

What does a pronoun promise? (That the thing it points at is **still in the room**.) Next: the past tense.

Chapter 71

Le — To Him, To Her, To You

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can say *le digo*, and know that *le* does not mark gender.

Complete ES-C46-le: produce *le digo*, say how many genders *le* has, and name the Latin case it comes from.

71.1 le — “to him,” “to her,” “to you”

Lo and *la* answer the question **what**. This chapter answers a different one: **to whom**.

Grammar Lens: the other question

le — *to him, to her, to you* (with *usted*).

Le digo. — I tell **him**. Or her. Or you.

Some verbs land on a thing: you have it, you make it, you want it. Others land on a **person you are aiming at** — you tell them, you speak to them, you give them something. Spanish uses a different pronoun for the second kind, and *le* is it.

Same slot. Still in front of the verb. Nothing about the shape of a sentence has changed in eleven chapters.

And here is the relief: *le* does **not** mark gender.

Le digo. — I tell him. **and** I tell her. **and** I tell you.

After four chapters of choosing between *lo* and *la* by the gender of a noun, this one asks you for nothing. One form covers three people. If you need to say which, you add it in words — but the pronoun itself does not care.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Lo and *le* are the same Latin word again — and this time the difference is not wear, it is **grammar**.

Latin changed a word's ending to show its job in the sentence. *Ille*, “that one,” had one form for the thing an action hit and another for the person it was aimed at:

- **illum** — the one the verb acts on → Spanish **lo**.
- **illī** — the one it is aimed at → Spanish **le**.

Latin called these the accusative and the dative. Almost all of that system collapsed on the way to Spanish; nouns lost their endings entirely. But in these small, constantly-used pronouns, **two of the cases survived**, and you are looking at them.

English had the same distinction and lost it more completely. It survives in a word order rather than a shape: *I told **him** the story* — *him* is doing exactly what *le* does, and English simply stopped marking it.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “Lo tengo” then “Le digo” — what, then to whom
- “Le digo” three times, meaning him, then her, then usted

Before you move on

Say “I tell him.” (***Le digo***.) And “I tell her.” (***Le digo*** — the same.) Which Latin case is *le*? (The **dative**, *illī*.) Next: its plural, and a discovery about how little of this system is actually new.

Chapter 72

Les — And What the Second System Costs

Modes:  voice (1)  Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can say *les digo* and name the four pronouns that are identical in both object systems.

Complete ES-C46-les: produce *les digo* and say how many genuinely new words the indirect set adds.

72.1 les — “to them,” and what this system really costs

Lo became *los*. So what does *le* become? Say it before you read on.

Grammar Lens: right again, and then something better

les — *to them, to you all.*

Le digo. — I tell him. → **Les digo.** — I tell them.

Add *-s*. That is the second time an object pronoun has pluralised without argument, and it will not be the last.

Now the part worth the chapter. You have just met the sixth and last indirect object pronoun — and you have only ever been **taught two of them.**

What you've built

Here are the two sets, side by side:

	direct (<i>what</i>)	indirect (<i>to whom</i>)
me	me	me
you	te	te
him / her / you	lo, la	le
us	nos	nos
you all (<i>Spain</i>)	os	os
them / you all	los, las	les

Look down the two columns. **Four of the six rows are identical.** *Me*, *te*, *nos* and *os* do not change at all — the same word does both jobs, and Spanish never asks you to choose.

So a “whole second system” turns out to cost exactly **two new words**: *le* and *les*. Everything else you already owned, and you owned it before you knew there were two systems to own it in.

This is worth holding onto beyond this chapter. A grammar book will show you two complete tables and it will look like twelve things. Count what is actually **different** and it is two.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “le digo” then “les digo”
- “me, te, nos, os” and note that this list is finished for both systems at once

Before you move on

“I tell them”? (***Les digo.***) How many new words did the whole indirect system cost you? (**Two.**) Next: how to know which of the two a verb is asking for.

Chapter 73

Which One Is the Verb Asking For?

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can decide between the direct and indirect pronoun by asking one question of the verb.

Complete ES-C46-cual-pide: state the test, apply it to *hablar* and *tener*, and say why *le veo* is not an error in *Madrid*.

73.1 Which one is the verb asking for?

You have two sets now. The obvious worry is that you will have to learn, verb by verb, which set each one wants. You do not.

Grammar Lens: ask the verb one question

Does the verb do something *to* this, or aim something *at* this?

That is the whole test.

Tengo el libro → **Lo** *tengo*. The having lands **on** the book.
Direct. *Hablo a Ana* → **Le** *hablo*. The speaking is aimed **at** Ana. Indirect.

Say the sentence in English with the little word *to* in front of the person.
If it fits, Spanish wants the indirect one:

- I speak **to** her → *le hablo*. **Fits.**

- I have **to** the book → nonsense. So *lo tengo*.

English hides this by dropping the *to*: you say *I told him*, not *I told to him*. Put it back, and if it survives, the pronoun is *le*.

Why it's said this way

One thing the test will not settle, said now rather than met later as a shock.

In much of Spain, speakers use *le* for a **male person** even where the grammar calls for *lo*: *le veo* rather than *lo veo*. It has a name, *leísmo*, it is old, it is accepted for people, and roughly a fifth of the Spanish-speaking world does it.

So if you hear *le* where this chapter predicts *lo*, neither of you has misunderstood. The test above is right everywhere.

Your turn

- *Say it*: “Lo tengo” then “Le hablo” — which question does each answer?

Before you move on

What one question tells you which set to use? (Does the verb act **on** it, or aim **at** it?) What is it called when Spain uses *le* for a man where the rule says *lo*? (***Leísmo*** — and it is fine.) Next: both sets in one place.

Chapter 74

Review — Two Systems, Two New Words

Modes: 👁 eyes (1) ↔ Hands-free start: none of the 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can give both object pronoun sets and say which row is the only one where they differ in shape.

Complete ES-C46-repaso-dos-sistemas: give the six indirect pronouns and count the distinct shapes across both tables.

74.1 Review — two systems, two new words

Nothing new. Two questions before the tables: where does an object pronoun go, and what single question chooses between the two sets?

What you've built		
	direct — <i>what</i>	indirect — <i>to whom</i>
me	me	me
you	te	te
him / her / usted	lo, la	le
us	nos	nos
you all (<i>Spain</i>)	os	os
them / ustedes	los, las	les
Twelve cells. Two of them are new since the last review , and you		

produced one of those yourself by adding an *-s*.

Do the arithmetic once and it will stay done. Fourteen chapters of object pronouns have asked you to learn, as shapes: *te, lo, la, nos, os, le*. Six words. *Me* you had from chapter four; *los, las* and *les* you derived. Six words, spread across fourteen chapters, with a review and a synthesis at each joint — that is what a gentle ramp costs and what it buys.

Grammar Lens: the one asymmetry

Read the third row again, because it is the only place the two columns disagree in shape rather than spelling:

direct: **lo / la** — two forms, gender marked. indirect: **le** — one form, gender not marked.

Spanish cares about the gender of a thing being acted on and does not care about the gender of a person being aimed at. There is no deep reason for it; Latin's dative simply had one form where its accusative had two, and Spanish inherited the asymmetry whole.

It is good news. The row that carries all the difficulty in one column carries none in the other.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the direct six, then the indirect six, and hear how much is the same
- “lo tengo, le hablo, los tengo, les hablo”

Twice through: Until the shared four stop feeling like two separate lists.

Before you move on

How many pronouns are shared between the two sets? (**Four.**) Which row differs? (**Him / her / usted** — *lo* and *la* against *le*.) Next: both sets in one conversation, where you have to choose fast.

Chapter 75

Synthesis — The Thing and the Person

Modes: ⇄ voice (1) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can use both sets in one exchange and say what decides between them.

Complete ES-C46-sintesis-dar-y-decir: run the four-turn exchange and say what separates lo from le.

75.1 Synthesis — the thing and the person, in one sentence

Two pronouns, one question. *Lo* or *le* — what decides?

The exchange

Read this aloud and watch the two sets take turns.

— ¿Tienes el libro? — Sí, **lo** tengo. — ¿Y Ana? — **Le** digo hoy.

Four turns. The book gets *lo*, because the having lands on it. Ana gets *le*, because the telling is aimed at her.

Nothing in the sentence shape tells you which. Same slot, two letters each, one Latin ancestor. **The only thing separating them is what you mean.**

That is new. Every choice so far could be settled by looking at something — a noun's ending, its article, where the stress falls. This one cannot.

Grammar Lens: choosing at speed

In a real conversation you do not have time to run a test. So do not aim for the test — aim for the **feeling** of the two verbs:

- Verbs that **hold, make, want, see** land on a thing. Those take *lo, la, los, las*.
- Verbs that **tell, speak, give, ask** are aimed at a person. Those take *le, les*.

Say enough sentences and the verb starts arriving with its pronoun attached, which is what fluency here actually is. The test is scaffolding for when you are unsure, not the method.

And when you get it wrong you will be understood: *lo digo* and *le digo* are both ordinary sentences. You will have said something slightly other than you meant, and the person will ask.

Your turn

- *Say it:* “lo tengo, le digo, los tengo, les hablo” until each verb brings its own pronoun

Before you move on

¿Tienes el libro? (**Sí, lo tengo.**) “I tell her today”? (**Le digo hoy.**) What decides between *lo* and *le*? (**What you mean** — nothing on the page.) Next: what happens when a sentence needs **both** at once.

Chapter 76

Me Lo — Both at Once

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🖱️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can put two object pronouns in front of one verb, in the right order.

Complete ES-C47-me-lo: produce te lo digo and me la haces, and say which pronoun leads.

76.1 me lo — both at once

You have a pronoun for the **thing** and a pronoun for the **person**.
A sentence often needs both. What happens then?

Grammar Lens: they stand together, in one order

They queue up in the same slot, both still in front of the verb:

Me lo dices. — You tell **it to me**. *Te lo digo.* — I tell **it to you**.

Two small words, one after the other, and then the verb. Nothing has moved.

The order never varies. The person comes first, then the thing:

indirect, then direct. *Me lo*, never *lo me*.

That is the entire rule, and it is worth noticing what it saves you. English lets you choose — *give it to me* or *give me it* — and the choice carries a faint difference in emphasis you have to feel your way into. Spanish

took the choice away. There is one order, it is always right, and you never have to decide.

A fixed order is a smaller thing to learn than a free one.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “Me lo dices” then “Te lo digo” — hear the pair stay glued
- “me la haces”

Before you move on

“I tell it to you”? (*Te lo digo.*) Which pronoun leads? (The **person** — indirect first.) Next: the one combination Spanish refuses to say, and what it says instead.

Chapter 77

Se Lo — The Pair That Does Not Exist

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🗋️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can turn *le* or *les* into *se* in front of *lo*, *la*, *los* or *las*.

Complete ES-C47-se-lo: produce *se lo digo*, name the four words that trigger the change, and count the readings *se lo digo* allows.

77.1 se lo — the pair that does not exist

Person first, then thing. So “I tell it to him” should be *le* plus *lo* plus *digo*. Say that out loud: ***le lo digo***.

Grammar Lens: nobody says that

Your mouth probably objected before your grammar did. *Le lo* is two nearly identical syllables in a row, and Spanish will not say it.

In front of *lo*, *la*, *los* or *las*, the pronouns *le* and *les* become *se*.

~~*Le lo digo*.~~ → ***Se lo digo***. — I tell it to him. ~~*Les la hago*.~~ → ***Se la hago***. — I make it for them.

Everything else about the sentence is unchanged. The order is still person then thing. The slot is still in front of the verb. **Only the first word’s shape changes**, and it changes for one reason: what follows it.

Note what *se* does **not** tell you. *Le* already refused to mark gender, and *se* goes further — it does not mark number either:

Se lo digo — to him. To her. To you. To them. To you all.

Five readings, one word. Context does all the work, and if you need to be precise you add it in words rather than in the pronoun.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “le lo digo” once, badly, and then “se lo digo” — feel why
- “Se lo digo” and “Se la hago”

Before you move on

“I tell it to him”? (***Se lo digo.***) What happened to *le*? (It became ***se*** in front of *lo*.) Next: **why** it became *se* — and it is not the reason almost everyone assumes.

Chapter 78

Why Se? — Gelo, and a Collision

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can say why *le* becomes *se*, and that this *se* is not the reflexive one.

Complete ES-C47-por-que-se: name the Old Spanish form, and say whether the *se* of *se lo digo* is the *se* of *se llama*.

78.1 Why se? — and why it is not the se you know

You have known a word *se* since almost the beginning: *se llama*, “he calls **himself**.” Now you have met a second *se*, in *se lo digo*. The obvious conclusion is that they are the same word doing a second job.

They are not. They are two different words that arrived at the same spelling, and knowing that removes a confusion most learners carry for years.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Old Spanish did not say *se lo*. It said **gelo**.

That came from the two Latin pronouns you already know, run together and worn down: *illī* (the dative, giving *le*) plus *illum* (the accusative, giving *lo*) → **gelo**. One squeezed word for “to-him it.”

So the medieval sentence was *gelo digo*, and it was regular. There was no substitution and no rule to learn.

Then two things happened:

1. **The word split back into two** — *gelo* was re-analysed as *ge* + *lo*, matching the two-pronoun pattern everywhere else in the language.
 2. **The sound *ge* drifted** until it was pronounced exactly like *se* — and once two words sound identical, spelling follows.
- By the sixteenth century *ge lo* had become *se lo*, and the trail was cold.

Why it's said this way

This matters for a practical reason, not a historical one.

The reflexive *se* in *se llama* means **himself**. If the *se* in *se lo digo* were that word, the sentence would have to mean something reflexive — and learners who assume it do spend years trying to make “he tells it to himself” fit sentences where it plainly does not.

It does not fit because it is not that word. One *se* is Latin *sē*, “himself”; the other is *illī*, “to him.” Unrelated, and collided by accident of sound. Two words wearing one shape is something this language does often — *ser* is built from two Latin verbs, *ir* borrows its present from a third. Here it happens to two of the smallest words in Spanish, which is where it is hardest to notice.

Your turn

- *Say it*: “se llama” then “se lo digo” — two different words, one sound

Before you move on

What was *se lo* before it was *se lo*? (***Gelo***.) Is it the reflexive *se*? (**No** — a different word that came to sound the same.) Next: all of it together.

Chapter 79

Review — The Pairs

Modes: 👁 eyes (1) ⇄ Hands-free start: none of the 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can generate every permitted pair of object pronouns from two facts.

Complete ES-C47-repaso-dobles: state the two facts that generate the table and say how many new pronouns the arc added.

79.1 Review — the pairs

Nothing new. Two facts before the table: which pronoun leads, and what happens to *le* in front of *lo*?

What you've built

Every pair Spanish permits, in one place:

person	+ thing	gives
me	lo / la / los / las	me lo, me la, me los, me las
te	”	te lo, te la, ...
le / les	”	se lo, se la, se los, se las
nos	”	nos lo, nos la, ...
os	”	os lo, os la, ...

Read the whole table as **two facts**, because that is all it is:

1. The person comes first. Always. 2. *Le* and *les* turn into *se* in front of the thing. Only there.

Every other row is just the two pronouns you already had, standing next to each other with nothing done to either of them.

Grammar Lens: how little is actually new

Count the new material in this whole arc: **one order, and one substitution.** No new pronoun, no new form, no new position in the sentence. Four chapters, two facts, and one of the two turned out to be an accident of medieval pronunciation rather than a rule at all.

That is worth saying plainly, because *se lo* has a reputation. It is usually taught as the moment Spanish object pronouns become genuinely hard. It is instead the moment they stop growing: this is the last new thing the system does.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “me lo, te lo, se lo, nos lo, os lo” — the whole first column
- “se lo digo, se la hago” and notice that only the middle row changed

Twice through:

Before you move on

Which row is the only one that changes? (*Le* and *les* → *se*.) How many new pronouns did you learn here? (**None.**) Next: all of it in a conversation, at speed.

Chapter 80

Synthesis — Two at a Time

Modes: 👁 eyes (1) ⇌ Hands-free start: none of the 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can carry a four-turn exchange in which almost no noun appears.

Complete ES-C47-sintesis-dos-a-la-vez: produce se la hago and say how many words in it name anything.

80.1 Synthesis — two at a time

“I tell it to him,” in three words. (*Se lo digo.*)

The exchange

— ¿Tienes el libro? — Sí. ¿Te lo digo? — Sí, y se lo dices a Ana. — Y la comida — se la hago hoy.

Look at the last three lines. After the first sentence names the book, **not one noun does any work**. *Te lo, se lo, se la* — six words that name nothing, and the conversation is perfectly clear to both speakers.

That is what all of this has been for. Fifteen chapters of object pronouns exist so that a conversation can stop repeating itself, and this is the point where the machinery is complete enough to see it happen.

Grammar Lens: two words carrying a whole sentence

Se la hago is three words and it means “I make **the meal** for **her**, today.” Two of the three are pronouns; between them they carry a person and

a thing, neither of which is named anywhere in the sentence.

English cannot compress like this. *I'll make it for her* needs five words and still spells out *for*. Spanish puts both jobs in front of the verb, in a fixed order, and gets on with it.

The cost is the one you already know, doubled. Two pronouns are two promises that both things are still in the room. When you lose track of one of them, the sentence does not become wrong — it becomes about somebody else, and nobody will notice until it matters.

So the practice that pays here is not conjugation. It is keeping a conversation's furniture in mind while you talk.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the four-turn exchange straight through
- “te lo digo, se lo dices, se la hago” until the pairs feel like single words

Twice through:

Before you move on

“I make it for her”? (*Se la hago.*) How many nouns are in that sentence? (**None.**) And what does each pronoun promise? (That its thing is **still in the room.**) Next: the past tense.

Chapter 81

The Preterite — Your First Past Tense

Modes: 🗣️ voice (3) 🗋️ Hands-free start: all 3 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can use the singular completed past of ser or ir and the known regular -ar verb hablar.

Complete ES-C14-practice and distinguish fui/fuiste/fue from hablé/hablaste/habló using known words, context, and written stress.

81.1 fui — one past set shared by ser and ir

You already use **ser** for identity and **ir** for going. Spanish now gives both verbs one completed-past set. This lesson keeps the same three singular persons you know: **fui**, **fuiste**, **fue**.

Grammar Lens: three singular forms, two verbs

person	completed past of ser or ir
yo	fui
tú	fuiste
él / ella / usted	fue

Say **fui** · **fuiste** · **fue**. Each form can belong to either verb. The surrounding words decide which meaning is possible:

- **Fui a Madrid.** — “I went to Madrid.” The known **a** plus a destination points to **ir**.

- **Fue Roberto.** — “It was Roberto.” Identification points to **ser**.

Fui and **fue** are one-syllable words, so standard Spanish spelling gives them no written accent. Plural forms wait until a later lesson.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

The shared set continues the Latin perfect family of “be,” including Latin **fuī**, “I have been.” Sound change and analogy reshaped the inherited forms. Spanish **ir** then came to share this past family with **ser**: a case of **suppletion**, where one verb draws forms from more than one historical root. English **go** / **went** uses the same broad strategy, although not the same words.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “fui, fuiste, fue”
- “Fui a Madrid.”
- “Fue Roberto — identification, so ser.”

Before you move on

Give the three shared forms. (*Fui, fuiste, fue.*) Which two verbs share them? (*Ser* and *ir.*) What decides the meaning? (Context.) What older family supplied the forms? (The Latin perfect family of “be.”) Next, reuse the known verb **hablar** to build a regular singular past.

81.2 **hablé** — a regular singular past from a known verb

You know **hablar** and its present singular **hablo**, **hablas**, **habla**. To say that the speaking was completed, keep **habl-** and learn three new endings: **hablé**, **hablaste**, **habló**.

Grammar Lens: present beside completed past

person	present	completed past
yo	hablo	hablé
tú	hablas	hablaste
él / ella / usted	habla	habló

Say **hablé · hablaste · habló**. This is a complete singular pattern, not a preview of plural forms. Notice the exact changes:

- **hablo** → **hablé** changes the final vowel and moves stress to the end.
- **hablas** → **hablaste** adds the past ending **-aste**.
- **habla** → **habló** changes the final vowel and moves stress to the end.

Grammar Lens: two accents, one natural stress pattern

The written accents in **hablé** and **habló** show final stress. Without those marks, words ending in a vowel normally stress the next-to-last syllable. **Hablaste** already follows that ordinary pattern — **blas** is next to last — so it needs no written accent. The mark records the stress; it is not the only change that makes a form past.

Now reuse known words:

- **Hablé español.** — “I spoke Spanish.”
- **¿Hablaste español?** — “Did you speak Spanish?”
- **Habló español.** — “He, she, or you-formal spoke Spanish.”

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

The regular **-ar** past continues material from the Latin first-conjugation perfect, visible in forms such as **amāvī**, **amāvistī**, **amāvit**. Centuries of sound change and analogy produced the Spanish family **-é**, **-aste**, **-ó**. The history explains a family resemblance; it is not one tidy letter-by-letter erosion for every modern ending.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “hablé, hablaste, hablé”
- “Hablo español. Hablé español.”
- “hablé and hablé carry written accents; hablaste does not”

Before you move on

Give the three learned past forms. (*Hablé, hablaste, hablé.*) Which two carry written accents, and why? (*Hablé* and *hablé*; the marks show final stress.) What older family lies behind the endings? (The Latin first-conjugation perfect.) Next: choose between the two past patterns using only known words.

81.3 Practice — two singular ways to talk about a completed past

This checkpoint adds nothing. Retrieve the shared singular set and the regular **hablar** set, then use context and spelling to keep them apart.

Grammar Lens: the complete frame for this chapter

- shared past of **ser** and **ir**: **fui** • **fuiste** • **fue**.
- regular past of **hablar**: **hablé** • **hablaste** • **hablé**.
- context: **Fui a Madrid** expresses **ir**; **Fue Roberto** expresses **ser**.
- time contrast: **Hablo español** is present; **Hablé español** is completed past.
- spelling: **hablé** and **hablé** show final stress with a written accent; **hablaste** needs none.

Plural persons, additional past-tense verb classes, new time words, and new place or person vocabulary wait for later lessons.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

The **fui** family continues Latin perfect “be” material and became shared by **ser** and **ir**. The regular **-ar** endings continue Latin first-conjugation perfect material, reshaped by sound change and analogy.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “fui, fuiste, fue”
- “hablé, hablaste, hablé”
- “Fui a Madrid. Fue Roberto.”
- “Hablo español. Hablé español.”

Before you move on

Give both singular sets. (*Fui, fuiste, fue; hablé, hablaste, hablé.*) How does context separate **ser** from **ir**? (A destination points to going; identification points to being.) Which regular forms carry written accents? (*Hablé* and *hablé.*) The next chapter can add another past family without borrowing plural forms or unseen vocabulary from this checkpoint.

Chapter 82

The Regular Preterite

Modes: 🔄 voice (2) 🔄 Hands-free start: all 2 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can say what I did with a regular -er or -ir verb, and place the written accent correctly.
-er and -ir agree again, and the accent marks the stressed final vowel.

82.1 comí — one regular -er singular past

You know present **como**, **comes**, **come** and the singular **-ar** past. To make a completed past from **comer**, keep **com-** and learn three forms: **comí**, **comiste**, **comió**.

Grammar Lens: present beside completed past

person	present	completed past
yo	como	comí
tú	comes	comiste
él / ella / usted	come	comió

Say **comí · comiste · comió**. Keep the limit visible: these are the same three familiar singular persons. Plural forms wait.

Grammar Lens: final stress in two forms

Comí and **comió** carry written accents because their stress falls on the final vowel. **Comiste** follows ordinary next-to-last stress, so it needs no mark. The three forms by themselves make complete utterances:

- **Comí.** — “I ate.”
- **¿Comiste?** — “Did you eat?”
- **Comió.** — “He, she, or you-formal ate.”

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Spanish **comer** continues Latin **comedere**. Its regular past endings also continue Latin perfect material, including forms with **-ī, -istī, -it**. Sound change and analogy reshaped that material across Romance into Spanish **-í, -iste, -ió**. The resemblance is real, but it is not one tidy chain in which every modern ending merely drops a letter.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “comí, comiste, comió”
- “Como. Comí.”
- “comí and comió carry final-stress accents”

Before you move on

Give the three learned **comer** forms. (*Comí, comiste, comió.*) Which carry written accents? (*Comí* and *comió.*) What shaped the modern endings? (Latin perfect material, sound change, and analogy.) Next: reuse the same endings with a known **-ir** verb.

82.2 viví — reuse one past pattern with an -ir verb

You know present **vivo, vives, vive**, and you just learned past **comí, comiste, comió**. Keep **viv-** and reuse those three past endings: **viví, viviste, vivió**.

Grammar Lens: one -ir singular past

person	present	completed past
yo	vivo	viví
tú	vives	viviste
él / ella / usted	vive	vivió

Say **viví** · **viviste** · **vivió**. Reuse known **en** for a small contrast:

- **Vivo en Madrid.** — “I live in Madrid.”
- **Viví en Madrid.** — “I lived in Madrid.”
- **¿Viviste en Madrid?** — “Did you live in Madrid?”
- **Vivió en Madrid.** — “He, she, or you-formal lived in Madrid.”

The written accents in **viví** and **vivió** show final stress. **Viviste** already has ordinary next-to-last stress and needs no mark.

Grammar Lens: -er and -ir meet in this past

person	comer	vivir
yo	comí	viví
tú	comiste	viviste
él / ella / usted	comió	vivió

The shared endings are **-í** in the first row, **-iste** in the second, and **-ió** in the third. The presents differ, but these two singular past rows converge on one ending set. That is a fact about the forms you have learned, not permission to guess plural forms; those wait.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Spanish **vivir** continues Latin **vīvere**. Its modern past endings belong to the same Romance history as the **comer** endings: Latin perfect material was reshaped by sound change and analogy. The shared **-iste** is a useful family resemblance, not proof of one simple letter-by-letter erosion.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “viví, viviste, vivió”
- “Vivo en Madrid. Viví en Madrid.”
- “comí and viví share -í; comió and vivió share -ió”

Before you move on

Give the three learned **vivir** forms. (*Viví, viviste, vivió.*) Which past endings do **comer** and **vivir** share? (*-í, -iste, -ió.*) Which two carry written accents? (*Viví* and *vivió.*) Next, keep the singular limit but let the stem change.

Chapter 83

The Strong Preterites

Modes: ⇄ voice (3) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 3 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can use **tuve**, **hice** and **estuve**, and hear that their stress sits on the stem.

Latin's own perfect, carried through on verbs too heavily used to be rebuilt.

83.1 **tuve** — let the strong stem carry the stress

You know present **tengo**, **tienes**, **tiene**. Its completed past changes the stem to **tuv-** and uses **tuve**, **tuviste**, **tuvo**. Unlike **comí** and **comió**, none of these three forms carries a written accent.

Grammar Lens: one strong singular pattern

person	present	completed past
yo	tengo	tuve
tú	tienes	tuviste
él / ella / usted	tiene	tuvo

The strong stem **tuv-** takes **-e**, **-iste**, **-o**. Say **tuve** · **tuviste** · **tuvo**. Stress remains in the stem, so normal spelling needs no accent mark. Reuse known **café**:

- **Tuve café.** — “I had coffee.”
- **¿Tuviste café?** — “Did you have coffee?”

- **Tuvo café.** — “He, she, or you-formal had coffee.”

“Strong” describes the stem-stressed historical pattern. It does not mean that the meaning is forceful. Plural endings wait.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Tener continues Latin **tenēre**. Its past also belongs to an older strong history associated with Latin **tenuī**. Spanish sound change and analogy reshaped that material into the **tuv-** family. **Tenuī** → **tuve** is therefore a historical relationship, not a promise that every letter passed across intact.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “tuve, tuviste, tuvo”
- “Tuve café.”
- “comí has final stress; tuve has stem stress”

Before you move on

Give the three learned **tener** forms. (*Tuve, tuviste, tuvo.*) Which endings attach to **tuv-**? (*-e, -iste, -o.*) Why are there no written accents? (The strong stem carries the stress.) What shaped **tuve** historically? (Older strong-perfect material, sound change, and analogy.) Next: reuse the strong endings with **hacer**.

83.2 hice — the strong pattern with one third-person swerve

You know present **hago, haces, hace** and strong past **tuve, tuviste, tuvo**. **Hacer** reuses the strong endings: **hice, hiciste, hizo**. Watch the third form: the stem is **hiz-** there, not **hic-**.

Grammar Lens: hacer in the completed past

person	completed past	stem plus ending
yo	hice	hic- + -e
tú	hiciste	hic- + -iste
él / ella / usted	hizo	hiz- + -o

Say **hice** · **hiciste** · **hizo**. These are strong, stem-stressed forms with no written accents. **Hizo** is an irregular stem alternation inside this family; it is not a general rule that **c** must become **z** before **o**. Reuse known **café**:

- **Hice café.** — “I made coffee.”
- **¿Hiciste café?** — “Did you make coffee?”
- **Hizo café.** — “He, she, or you-formal made coffee.”

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Hacer continues Latin **facere**, and **hice** continues the history of its strong perfect **fēcī**. Long sound changes help explain Spanish **h-** and the changed vowel and consonant; this is not a direct spelling recipe. The pattern links **hice** historically to strong **tuve**, while each verb keeps its own stem.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “hice, hiciste, hizo”
- “Hice café.”
- “hizo is a learned hiz- alternation, not a general c-before-o rule”

Before you move on

Give the three learned **hacer** forms. (*Hice, hiciste, hizo.*) What changes in the third form? (**Hic-** becomes **hiz-**.) Is that a general **c-before-o** spelling rule? (No; learn it inside this irregular family.) What older form lies behind **hice**? (Latin **fēcī**, through substantial historical change.) Next: add strong **estar** without adding plural

forms.

83.3 **estuve** — a third known verb joins the strong pattern

You know present **estoy**, **estás**, **está** and the strong past pairs **tuve**, **tuviste**, **tuvo** and **hice**, **hiciste**, **hizo**. Now use the same strong endings with **estuv-**: **estuve**, **estuviste**, **estuvo**.

Grammar Lens: **estar** in the completed past

person	completed past
yo	estuve
tú	estuviste
él / ella / usted	estuvo

Say **estuve** · **estuviste** · **estuvo**. The strong stem **estuv-** takes **-e**, **-iste**, **-o**. These forms carry no written accents. Reuse known **bien**:

- **Estuve bien.** — “I was well.”
- **¿Estuviste bien?** — “Were you well?”
- **Estuvo bien.** — “He, she, or you-formal was well.”

Grammar Lens: three strong singular rows

- yo: **tuve** · **hice** · **estuve**.
- tú: **tuviste** · **hiciste** · **estuviste**.
- él / ella / usted: **tuvo** · **hizo** · **estuvo**.

All three rows use the learned strong endings. Only **hacer** changes its stem shape from **hic-** to **hiz-** before third-person **-o**. Plural forms and other irregular verbs still wait.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Estar grew from a Romance verb related to Latin **stāre**, “stand.” But modern **estuve** is not a direct, tidy wearing-down of Latin **stetī**. Histor-

ical analogy helped reshape its past beside other strong forms, including the **-uv-** pattern visible in **tuve**. This explains the family resemblance without pretending that each modern letter came straight from one Latin form.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “estuve, estuviste, estuvo”
- “Estuve bien.”
- “tuve and estuve share -uv- through historical analogy”

Before you move on

Give the three learned **estar** forms. (*Estuve, estuviste, estuvo.*) Which known strong verb shares their **-uv-** shape? (*Tener: tuve.*) Why should **estuve** not be shown as a direct wearing-down of **steti**? (Analogy reshaped the Spanish family.) Next: retrieve all six bounded patterns.

Chapter 84

Synthesis — You Can Hear Which Past It Is

Modes: 🗣️ voice (2) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 2 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can tell a regular preterite from a strong one by ear, and say why only one of them carries an accent.

The accent is the stress written down: ending-stressed regular, stem-stressed strong.

84.1 Practice — six singular patterns, no hidden vocabulary

This checkpoint adds nothing. Retrieve only the three singular persons of each learned row. Every word in the short sentences is already known.

Grammar Lens: the complete frame for this chapter

Regular rows:

- yo: hablé · comí · viví.
- tú: hablaste · comiste · viviste.
- él / ella / usted: habló · comió · vivió.

Strong rows:

- yo: tuve · hice · estuve.

- **tú:** tuviste · hiciste · estuviste.
- **él / ella / usted:** tuvo · hizo · estuvo.

The **-er** and **-ir** rows share **-í**, **-iste**, **-ió**. The three strong rows share **-e**, **-iste**, **-o**, but their stems must be learned: **tuv-**, **hic-/hiz-**, **estuv-**. Plural persons, more strong verbs, and new time or setting vocabulary remain outside this checkpoint.

Grammar Lens: let spelling show the stress

- Regular **comí**, **comió**, **viví**, **vivió** carry written accents for final stress.
- Strong **tuve**, **tuvo**, **hice**, **hizo**, **estuve**, **estuvo** carry no written accents; stress remains in the strong stem.
- **Comiste** and **viviste** need no accent because their ordinary stress is already next to last.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

The regular **-er/-ir** endings continue Latin perfect material reshaped across Romance. **Tuve** and **hice** continue older strong-perfect histories, also reshaped rather than copied letter for letter. **Estuve** shows especially clear analogical remodeling beside the **-uv-** family of **tuve**.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “hablé, comí, viví”
- “tuve, hice, estuve”
- “Hice café. Viví en Madrid. Estuve bien.”
- “comí and comió have accents; tuve and tuvo do not”

Before you move on

Give the regular **comer** and **vivir** sets. (*Comí, comiste, comió; viví, viviste, vivió.*) Give the three strong sets. (*Tuve, tuviste, tuvo; hice,*

hiciste, hizo; estuve, estuviste, estuvo.) Which rows share endings? (-er/-ir share one regular set; the strong rows share another.) The next chapter can add a new past contrast without borrowing any plural form here.

84.2 Synthesis — you can hear which past it is

Nothing new in this chapter. Say *comí*, then *tuve*.

Grammar Lens: the stress tells you everything

Say those two again and listen to where your voice lifts.

comí — the stress lands on the **ending**. *tuve* — the stress lands on the **stem**.

That is not a detail. It is the whole difference between the two kinds of past in this chapter, and it is audible before you know anything else about the verb.

- **Endings stressed** → the regular preterite. It needs a written accent, because Spanish marks a stressed final vowel: *comí, viví*.
- **Stem stressed** → a strong preterite. It needs **no accent at all**: *tuve, hice, estuve*.

So the accent is not extra spelling to remember. It is the stress, written down. If a preterite has no accent, the stress moved back onto the stem, and you are looking at one of the strong ones.

What you've built

The two kinds have two histories.

The regular preterite is Spanish doing what Spanish does: one set of endings, and — as in the present and the imperfect — **-er** and **-ir** agreeing with each other rather than going separate ways.

The strong preterites are older. They are Latin's own perfect, carried through with the stress where Latin had put it, on verbs used too heavily ever to be rebuilt. Which is the same reason the imperfect has only three irregulars: the words people say constantly are the ones that keep their

odd shapes.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *comí, viví* — and feel the lift on the last syllable
- *tuve, hice, estuve* — and feel it move back

Twice through: Until you can place a preterite by ear before you place it by rule.

Before you move on

Where does the stress fall in a strong preterite? (**On the stem.**)
What does a missing accent tell you? (That it is one of the strong ones.) And why do the strong ones exist at all? (They are Latin's own perfect, kept intact on verbs used too much to be rebuilt.)

Chapter 85

The Imperfect — What Used to Happen

Modes: 🗣️ voice (3) 🗋️ Hands-free start: all 3 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can describe an ongoing or habitual past with a regular verb from any family.

-aba and -ia, and -er and -ir agreeing once again.

85.1 hablaba — let a past action stay open

Hablé español presents speaking as a completed past event. A different past, the **imperfect**, can leave the action open: **Hablaba español** — “I was speaking Spanish” or “I used to speak Spanish.” The sentence does not say where the action ended.

Grammar Lens: three familiar persons

person	open or habitual past
yo	hablaba
tú	hablabas
él / ella / usted	hablaba

Say **hablaba** · **hablabas** · **hablaba**. The first and third forms are identical; the surrounding conversation or an explicit person tells you who is speaking. Plural persons wait.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Spanish **-aba** continues the Latin imperfect family in **-ābam**. Historical sound change reshaped the complete Latin forms, but the **b** remains a useful audible bridge between **-ābam** and Spanish **-aba**.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “hablaba, hablabas, hablaba”
- “Hablé español. Hablaba español.”
- “-ābam and -aba share b”

Before you move on

Give the three learned forms. (*Hablaba, hablabas, hablaba.*) What can the imperfect do? (Leave a past action ongoing or habitual.) Which Latin family stands behind **-aba**? (**-ābam**.) Next: build the same gentle frame with **comer**.

85.2 comía — hear both vowels

Comí presents eating as completed. **Comía** leaves it open or habitual: “I was eating” or “I used to eat.” One accent separates the two forms in writing and in sound.

Grammar Lens: the singular -er row

person	open or habitual past
yo	comía
tú	comías
él / ella / usted	comía
Say comía · comías · comía . As with hablaba , the first and third forms match. Plural persons wait.	

Grammar Lens: co-mí-a

The accent in **-ía** keeps **i** and **a** in separate syllables: **co-mí-a**, three beats. It appears in every form learned here. Compare final stress in **comí** with the middle stress and extra syllable in **comía**.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

The **-er** imperfect continues a Romance reshaping of Latin **-ēbam** material. Among the changes, an intervocalic **b** was lost; later Spanish spelling marks the stressed **í** that keeps **i-a** apart. This is a layered history, not a single instruction to delete one letter.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “comía, comías, comía”
- “Comí. Comía.”
- “co-mí-a”

Before you move on

Give the three learned forms. (*Comía, comías, comía.*) What does the accent do? (Keeps **i** and **a** apart.) Which Latin family lies behind the ending? (**-ēbam**, reshaped through Romance.) Next: test whether **vivir** can reuse this row.

85.3 vivía — reuse the complete -er row

An earlier chapter let **comer** and **vivir** share one completed-past row. They converge again here. Replace **com-** in **comía**, **comías**, **comía** with **viv-**.

Grammar Lens: one row reused

person	comer	vivir
yo	comía	vivía
tú	comías	vivías
él / ella / usted	comía	vivía

Say **vivía** · **vivías** · **vivía**. **-er** and **-ir** share **-ía**, **-ías**, **-ía**. The accent still keeps **i-a** apart. Plural persons wait.

Grammar Lens: one known contrast

- **Viví en Madrid.** — presents living there as a completed stretch.
- **Vivía en Madrid.** — puts us inside that past stretch or treats it as background.

Both are past. The speaker chooses how to frame the event.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Vivir continues Latin **vīvere**. Its infinitive belongs to the Spanish **-ir** class, but the imperfect has converged with **-er**. That shared row is a reliable fact about these learned forms, not a claim that the two conjugations are identical everywhere.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “vivía, vivías, vivía”
- “comía and vivía share -ía”
- “Viví en Madrid. Vivía en Madrid.”

Before you move on

Give the three **vivir** forms. (*Vivía, vivías, vivía.*) Which class shares them? (**-er**.) What contrast can **viví** / **vivía** make? (Completed stretch versus an open or background past.) Next: learn **ver** before asking it to enter this tense.

Chapter 86

Ver — Seeing

Modes: ⇄ voice (1) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can say what I see, with a verb whose stem keeps a letter Latin had.

videre, and the e that other verbs dropped but ver kept.

86.1 ver — learn the verb before its past

Ver means “to see.” Its written **v** uses the Spanish sound you already know: it is not contrasted with a separate English-style **v** sound. Say **ver**.

Grammar Lens: three present forms

person	present
yo	veo
tú	ves
él / ella / usted	ve

The **tú** and third-person forms resemble the familiar **-er** row. The **yo** form keeps an extra vowel: **veo**. Reuse known **café**: **Veo café** — “I see coffee.”

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Spanish **ver** continues Latin **vidēre**, “to see,” through Old Spanish **veer**. Loss of the consonant between vowels helps explain the shorter

shape; the two adjacent vowels later contracted in the infinitive. English **video** belongs to the same Latin family, a memory bridge rather than a new Spanish word for this lesson.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “ver — to see”
- “veo, ves, ve”
- “ver comes through veer from vidēre”

Before you move on

What does **ver** mean? (“To see.”) Give its three learned present forms. (*Veo, ves, ve.*) Which Latin verb stands behind it? (**Vidēre.**) Next: add **ser** to the open past.

Chapter 87

The Only Three Irregulars

Modes: 🗣️ voice (3) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 3 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can use **era**, **iba** and **veía**, and know that no fourth irregular imperfect exists.

erat and ibat worn straight through from Latin, never tidied up.

87.1 era — an old root in an open past

You know present **soy**, **eres**, **es** and completed-past **fui**, **fuiste**, **fue**. The open or background past of **ser** uses a different short stem: **era**.

Grammar Lens: the singular ser row

person	open or background past
yo	era
tú	eras
él / ella / usted	era

Say **era** · **eras** · **era**. The first and third forms match, just as they did in the regular imperfect rows. ¿**Era usted?** asks “Was it you?” without adding a new noun. Plural persons wait.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Era continues Latin **eram**, an old form in the **esse** family. That is the family already connected to Spanish **ser** and English **essence**. The

preterite **fue** comes from another historical set, so **era** / **fue** is a real contrast inside one modern verb.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “era, eras, era”
- “¿Era usted?”
- “era comes from Latin eram”

Before you move on

Give the three learned **ser** forms. (*Era, eras, era.*) Which past form supplies background, **era** or **fue**? (**Era.**) Which Latin form stands behind it? (**Eram.**) Next: follow **ir** back toward its own older verb.

87.2 iba — ir returns to its inherited past

Present **voy** and completed-past **fui** came from different historical sets. For an open or habitual past, **ir** gives you **iba** — “I was going” or “I used to go.”

Grammar Lens: the singular ir row

person	open or habitual past
yo	iba
tú	ibas
él / ella / usted	iba

Say **iba ·ibas ·iba**. Reuse the destination frame: **Iba a Madrid** — “I was going to Madrid” or “I used to go to Madrid.” Plural persons wait.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Iba continues Latin **ībam**, from **īre**, the inherited verb behind the Spanish infinitive **ir**. Present **voy** contains material associated with **vādere**, while preterite **fui** comes from the Latin “be” perfect family. These

sources help explain the three learned sets; they do not mean that every form in every tense can be assigned to one source by a three-box rule.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “iba, ibas, iba”
- “Fui a Madrid. Iba a Madrid.”
- “iba continues *ībam* from *īre*”

Before you move on

Give the three learned forms. (*Iba, ibas, iba.*) Say “I was going to Madrid.” (*Iba a Madrid.*) Which Latin form stands behind **iba**? (**ībam**, from **īre**.) Next: put newly learned **ver** into the same past.

87.3 veía — keep the extra e you already met

You learned **ver** before its past: **veo**, **ves**, **ve**. Its imperfect keeps **ve-** and adds the familiar **-ía** row. That gives **veía** — “I was seeing” or “I used to see.”

Grammar Lens: the singular ver row

person	open or habitual past
yo	veía
tú	veías
él / ella / usted	veía

Say **veía** · **veías** · **veía**. Keep **í-a** in separate syllables. Plural persons wait.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Old Spanish **veer** displays the **ve-** shape clearly. The imperfect **veía** preserves that vowel before the familiar **-ía** material. It is useful to call this an exceptional learned row, but not to pretend that **ver** was already known before this chapter or that the history is merely “regular plus one

letter.”

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “veía, veías, veía”
- “Veo café. Veía café.”
- “veer helps explain ve-”

Before you move on

Give the three learned forms. (*Veía, veías, veía.*) Which vowel stays before **-ía**? (**e.**) Which earlier form displays it? (**Veer.**) Next: retrieve every row of this chapter and make a few bounded contrasts.

Chapter 88

Synthesis — Three Exceptions, and No Others

Modes: 🗣️ voice (2) 🗋️ Hands-free start: all 2 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can use the imperfect freely, knowing its complete irregular inventory is three verbs.

The exceptions are the words you use most - which is the reason they are exceptions.

88.1 Practice — keep the past open or close it

This checkpoint adds no vocabulary and no plural persons. Retrieve the seven learned singular rows, then choose whether a known sentence presents the past as completed or leaves it open as background, progress, or habit.

Grammar Lens: the complete frame for this chapter

Regular rows:

- yo: hablaba · comía · vivía.
- tú: hablabas · comías · vivías.
- él / ella / usted: hablaba · comía · vivía.

The three special rows:

- yo: era · iba · veía.

- **tú:** eras · ibas · veías.
- **él / ella / usted:** era · iba · veía.

The first and third forms match in every learned row. **Comer** and **vivir** share **-ía, -ías, -ía**. **Ver** keeps **ve-** before that material. Plural persons remain outside this checkpoint.

Grammar Lens: one scene, two frames

- **Hablé español.** — completed event. **Hablaba español.** — open, background, or habitual speaking.
- **Viví en Madrid.** — completed stretch. **Vivía en Madrid.** — we stand inside that past stretch.
- **Fui a Madrid.** — completed trip. **Iba a Madrid.** — motion was in progress or habitual.

The tense does not mechanically report how long something lasted. It frames the past from a different viewpoint.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

-aba continues the Latin **-ābam** family. **-ía** continues material from the **-ēbam** family after several Romance changes. **Era** continues **eram**; **iba** continues **ībam** from **īre**; and **veía** keeps the **ve-** shape also visible in Old Spanish **veer**. These are historical bridges, not recipes for generating unlearned forms.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “hablaba, comía, vivía”
- “era, iba, veía”
- “Hablé / hablaba · viví / vivía · fui / iba”

Before you move on

Give the six **yo** forms. (*Hablaba, comía, vivía, era, iba, veía.*) Which two regular classes share a row? (**-er** and **-ir**.) What is the core contrast? (The preterite presents a completed event; the imperfect leaves past action open, habitual, in progress, or in the background.) Chapter 17 can now build on **-ía** without borrowing a plural form here.

88.2 Synthesis — three exceptions, and no others

Nothing new in this chapter. Say *hablaba*, then *comía*.

What you've built

Here is the fact that no single lesson of this chapter could give you, and it is worth more than any of them.

The imperfect has exactly three irregular verbs in the entire language. *Ser, ir, ver.* That is the complete list — not “the common ones”, not “to start with”. Three.

Every other Spanish verb, without exception, takes **-aba** or **-ía** and behaves. After the preterite, which has a strong stem for what feels like every verb worth using, this is a tense that simply lets you get on with it.

So the honest instruction for the imperfect is short: learn *era, iba* and *veía*, and stop worrying.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

And the three are not random. They are the *most used verbs in the language* — to be, to go, to see — worn straight through from Latin *erat* and *ibat* without ever being tidied up.

That is how irregularity works everywhere: a form survives unchanged because it is said constantly, and speakers never have to reach for a rule to rebuild it. Rare verbs get regularised precisely because nobody remembers them well enough to keep the odd shape alive.

The exceptions are the words you use most. That is not bad luck — it is the reason they are exceptions.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *era, iba, veía* — the whole irregular inventory, in one breath
- *hablaba, comía, vivía* — and notice nothing surprises you

Twice through:

Before you move on

How many irregular imperfects are there? (**Three** — and that is all.) Which verbs? (*Ser, ir, ver.*) And why those three? (Because they are the ones people say constantly, so the old forms were never worn into a rule.)

Chapter 89

Hablaba and Hablo — Two Ways of Looking

Modes: 👁 eyes (1) 🗉 Hands-free start: none of the 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can say that the two past tenses differ in viewpoint rather than in time.

Complete ES-C48-dos-miradas: say whether the two pasts differ in when, and identify which one views an event from outside.

89.1 hablaba and habló — two ways of looking

You hold two past tenses. Say “I spoke” in both. (*Hablé. Hablaba.*)

Grammar Lens: not two times — two viewpoints

The obvious guess is that one is further back than the other. It is not. Both describe the same afternoon.

*Ayer **hablé** con Ana.* — Yesterday I spoke with Ana. *Ayer **hablaba** con Ana.* — Yesterday I was speaking with Ana.

Same day, same conversation, same two people. What changes is **where you are standing**.

- **Hablé** looks at the conversation from outside, finished, as one thing with edges. It happened, it is over, next.

- **Hablaba** puts you inside it, while it is still going on. No edges. It is the scenery, not the event.

This is why the choice cannot be made by a rule about time. It is made by what you are doing with the sentence: **reporting something that happened**, or **setting a scene where something else can happen**. Grammar books call this *aspect*. The word is not important. The habit is: when you reach for a past tense, you are being asked a question about your own point of view, and you answer it every time whether you notice or not.

Why it's said this way

English asks you the same question and lets you dodge it.

I spoke. I was speaking. I used to speak.

Those are three different viewpoints, and English marks them with extra words rather than with the verb itself. Because they are optional, you can say “I spoke” for almost anything and be understood.

Spanish put the choice **inside the verb**, so it is not optional. Every past sentence commits to a viewpoint before it commits to anything else. That is why this is the piece of Spanish that stays difficult longest for English speakers: not because it is complicated, but because it asks a question your first language let you leave unanswered.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “hablé” then “hablaba” — outside, then inside
- “estudié” then “estudiaba”

Before you move on

Do the two pasts differ in **when**? (**No** — in how you look at it.) Which one has edges? (The **preterite**.) Next: the word that lets both of them stand in one sentence.

Chapter 90

Cuando — Both Pasts in One Sentence

Modes: 🔄 voice (1) 🔄 Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can join a scene and an event with *cuando*, using the right tense for each.

Complete ES-C48-cuando: build *estudiaba cuando hablo Ana* and say which tense sets the room.

90.1 cuando — putting both pasts in one sentence

One tense is the scenery and one is the event. So far you have only been able to use one at a time. This chapter's word lets them share a sentence.

Sounds you'll need

- diphthong-ua — *cua* is one syllable, not two: *KWAN-doh*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

cuando — *when*.

From Latin **quandō**, and the *qu-* at the front is not decoration. It is the same question-marker sitting inside *qué*, *quién* and *cómo* — a family you have been collecting since your very first questions.

Latin built its question words from one root and Spanish kept the whole

set, so *cuándo* with an accent asks a question and *cuando* without one simply joins two things. Same word, and the accent is doing the same job it always does: marking the stressed, questioning one.

Grammar Lens: the scene and the thing that interrupts it

Now the two tenses can do their jobs side by side:

Estudiaba cuando habló Ana. — I **was studying** when Ana **spoke**.

Read what each tense is doing:

- *Estudiaba* — imperfect. The **scene**. Already going, no edges, and it does not stop being true when something else happens.
- *Habló* — preterite. The **event**. One thing, with edges, dropped into that scene.

This is the shape most Spanish stories are built from, and it is worth hearing the pattern rather than memorising a rule: **the imperfect sets the room, the preterite is what walks into it.**

Turn it around and the sentence changes meaning, not just style:

Estudié cuando hablaba Ana. — I studied while Ana was talking.

Now the talking is the room and the studying is the event. Neither version is more correct. They are about different things.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “Estudiaba cuando habló Ana”
- the reversed version, and notice the story changed

Before you move on

Which tense is the room? (The **imperfect**.) Which one walks into it? (The **preterite**.) Next: two verbs where the choice does not change the picture — it changes the **meaning**.

Chapter 91

Tenia and Tuve — When the Tense Changes the Meaning

Modes: 🔄 voice (1) 🔄 Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can say why *tuve una casa* means I got one, and predict what a state verb's preterite will mean.

Complete ES-C48-tenia-tuve: contrast *tenia* and *tuve*, and say what any state verb's preterite will mean.

91.1 *tenía* and *tuve* — when the tense changes the meaning

So far the two pasts have shown you the same event from two places. With one very common verb, they show you two **different** events.

Grammar Lens: having, and getting

Tenía una casa. — I **had** a house. ***Tuve una casa.*** — I **got** a house.

Read those twice. The second one is not “I had a house, viewed as finished.” It is a different verb in English altogether.

The reason follows from everything you already know. *Tener* means a **state** — having something is not an event, it is a condition that simply continues. So the imperfect, which has no edges, fits it perfectly: *tenía* is the ordinary way to say you had something.

Force that state into the preterite and you are demanding edges for something that does not have any. Spanish resolves the clash the only way it can: **it gives you the moment the state began**. The edge of *having* is *getting*.

Nothing irregular is happening. It is the same aspect rule you met two chapters ago, applied to a verb where the result is a new word in English.

Why it's said this way

This is worth more than one verb, because the same thing happens to every verb that names a state rather than an action. When you meet those verbs later, you will not need a list — you will already know what their preterite is going to mean: **the moment the state started**.

It also explains a frustration you may already have had. English “I had” covers both sentences above, so an English speaker reaching for *tuve* is often reaching for the wrong one. The fix is not to memorise which is which. It is to notice that you are describing a **state**, and states live in the imperfect unless you specifically mean the moment they began.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “Tenía una casa” then “Tuve una casa” — hear the English change
- the rule aloud — a state in the preterite gives you its beginning

Before you move on

Tenía una casa? (I **had** one.) *Tuve una casa?* (I **got** one.) And why? (A state forced into the preterite gives you the **moment it began**.) Next: all of it in one place.

Chapter 92

Review — One Question, Three Answers

Modes: 👁 eyes (1) ⇄ Hands-free start: none of the 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can state the single question that chooses between the two past tenses.

Complete ES-C48-repaso-dos-pasados: state the question, identify the scene verb, and name the pair that changes meaning.

92.1 Review — one question, three answers

Nothing new. Before the table: do the two past tenses differ in **when**?

What you've built		
Three chapters, one question, three ways it gets answered.		
what you are doing	tense	example
reporting an event, with edges	preterite	<i>hablé</i> — I spoke
setting a scene, no edges	imperfect	<i>hablaba</i> — I was speaking
naming a state	imperfect	<i>tenía</i> — I had
naming the moment a state began	preterite	<i>tuve</i> — I got
Rows one and two are the same event seen from two places. Rows three		

and four are not: there the tense changes what happened.

Grammar Lens: the question to actually ask

Not “*which tense is this?*” — that has no answer without you.

Am I telling you what happened, or what things were like?

What happened has edges: preterite. *What things were like* does not: imperfect. A story is mostly the second with the first dropped into it, which is what *cuando* let you build:

Estudiaba cuando habló Ana.

And when the verb names a state rather than an action, the same question still works — you are simply more likely to be describing what things were like, so the imperfect is the ordinary case and the preterite is the special one.

There is no list to memorise here, and that is deliberate. Lists of “preterite trigger words” exist in most courses and they fail exactly where the choice is interesting, because the same word can sit in either sentence. The question does not fail, because the question is the thing the language is actually asking.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “hablé / hablaba”, then “tenía / tuve”, and name the difference in each pair
- the question aloud before each one

Twice through: Until the question arrives before the verb does.

Before you move on

The one question? (**What happened**, or **what things were like?**) Which pair changes meaning rather than viewpoint? (*Tenía* and *tuve*.) Next: a whole small story, which is what all of this was for.

Chapter 93

Synthesis — A Small Story

Modes: ⇄ voice (1) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can narrate four sentences using both past tenses, with a background and a foreground.

Complete ES-C48-sintesis-una-historia: identify the two layers of the story and say why *tuve* belongs to the foreground.

93.1 Synthesis — a small story

Everything in this book so far has been sentences. A story is different: it needs a background and a foreground at the same time.

The exchange

Four sentences. Watch the tenses take turns.

*Yo **estudiaba** español. No **tenía** un libro. **Tuve** un libro en marzo. Y **cuando tuve** el libro, **hablé** con Ana.*

Now read only the imperfects: *estudiaba, tenía*. Those two sentences tell you **what things were like** — the situation, with no edges, going on for as long as it needed to.

Now read only the preterites: *tuve, hablé*. Those tell you **what happened** — two events, each with edges, in order.

The story is the two layers together. Neither layer is a story on its own: the imperfects alone are a description that never moves, and the preterites alone are a list of events with no world around them.

Grammar Lens: what you can now do

Notice the third sentence. *Tuve un libro* is not “I had a book” — it is the moment you **got** one, which is why it belongs in the foreground with *hablé* rather than in the background with *tenía*. The same verb appears in both layers of this story, doing two different jobs, and nothing about it is irregular.

That is the whole rung. From here you can narrate: not just report that something happened, but say what the world was like while it did.

It is worth naming the cost. Two tenses learned separately, then three chapters on nothing but the choice between them — because the forms were never the difficulty. English lets you leave this question unanswered; Spanish does not.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the four sentences straight through
- only the imperfects, then only the preterites, and hear the two layers

Twice through:

Before you move on

Which layer says what things were like? (The **imperfect**.) Which says what happened? (The **preterite**.) And what can you do now that you could not before? (**Tell a story** — not just report events, but say what the world was like while they happened.)

Chapter 94

The Future — Saying What Will Happen

Modes: 🗣️ voice (3) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 3 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can say what I will do, in the singular, across all three verb families.

The future endings ride on the whole infinitive, one family at a time.

94.1 hablaré — keep the infinitive, add the future

Voy a hablar español uses the near-future frame you already know. Spanish also has a one-word future: **Hablaré español** — “I will speak Spanish.” It can present a future prediction or intention without adding a new subject or object.

Grammar Lens: three familiar persons

Keep the whole infinitive **hablar**, then add one ending:

person	simple future
yo	hablaré
tú	hablarás
él / ella / usted	hablará

Say **hablaré · hablarás · hablará**. Each form has final stress, marked by an accent. Plural persons wait.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Late Latin and early Romance used more than one way to speak about the future. One influential construction placed an infinitive beside present forms of Latin **habēre**, “to have.” Through repeated use and sound change, descendants of those pieces became the endings in forms such as **hablaré**.

That history explains why the infinitive remains visible. It does **not** mean that a modern learner should attach the full modern verb **haber**, and it does not require the claim that every older future vanished at one moment.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “hablaré, hablarás, hablará”
- “Voy a hablar español. Hablaré español.”
- “infinitive plus historical habēre material”

Before you move on

Give the three learned forms. (*Hablaré, hablarás, hablará.*) What stays visible? (The whole infinitive.) What older verb contributed to the endings? (Latin **habēre**.) Next: test the same endings on **comer**.

94.2 comeré — the same endings keep -er

You built **hablaré** without removing **-ar**. Keep **comer** just as intact: **comeré** — “I will eat.”

Grammar Lens: the singular -er row

person	simple future
yo	comeré
tú	comerás
él / ella / usted	comerá
Say comeré · comerás · comerá . Compare hablaré / comeré :	

the infinitives differ, but the future endings do not. Plural persons wait.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

The historical infinitive-plus-**habēre** construction helps explain the shared endings: the verb-family vowel remains inside **hablar** or **comer**, rather than selecting a different ending set.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “comeré, comerás, comerá”
- “Hablaré. Comeré.”
- “Beberé café.”

Before you move on

Give the three learned forms. (*Comeré, comerás, comerá.*) Did the **-er** disappear? (No.) Which endings match **hablar**? (**-é, -ás, -á.**) Next: let **vivir** test the pattern once more.

94.3 viviré — one future row for three verb families

Hablaré kept **-ar**. **Comeré** kept **-er**. Predict the yo future of **vivir** before reading on. It is **viviré**.

Grammar Lens: the singular -ir row

person	simple future
yo	viviré
tú	vivirás
él / ella / usted	vivirá

Say **viviré · vivirás · vivirá**. Now the bounded pattern is complete: **hablaré, comeré, viviré**. The same three endings attach to all three whole infinitives. Plural persons wait.

Grammar Lens: meaning with known words

Viviré en Madrid says “I will live in Madrid.” Every lexical piece was available before this lesson; only the future form is new.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “viviré, vivirás, vivirá”
- “hablaré, comeré, viviré”
- “Viviré en Madrid.”

Before you move on

Give the three **vivir** forms. (*Viviré, vivirás, vivirá.*) Which verb families share the learned endings? (All three: **-ar**, **-er**, **-ir**.) Next: reuse the whole-infinitive frame for “would.”

Chapter 95

The Conditional — Saying What Would Happen

Modes: 🗣️ voice (3) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 3 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can say what I would do, in the singular, across all three verb families.

The same infinitive, a different auxiliary tense on the end.

95.1 hablaría — the whole infinitive meets -ía

Hablaré español places speaking in the future. **Hablaría español** means “I would speak Spanish” in an imagined or conditional situation. Today the situation can remain unstated; learn the form and its core “would” meaning first.

Grammar Lens: three familiar persons

Keep **hablar** whole, then add the learned singular conditional endings:

person	conditional
yo	hablaría
tú	hablarías
él / ella / usted	hablaría

Say **hablaría · hablarías · hablaría**. The first and third forms match. The accent keeps **í-a** in separate syllables, just as it did in **comía**. Plural persons wait.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

The conditional developed from an infinitive beside past or imperfect forms of the same “have” verb that helped form the Romance future. That is why the whole infinitive remains visible again and why the endings resemble the **-ía** row. The history passes through older Romance forms; modern **hablaría** is not made by attaching the complete modern word **había**.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “hablaría, hablarías, hablaría”
- “Hablaré español. Hablaría español.”
- “ha-bla-rí-a”

Before you move on

Give the three learned forms. (*Hablaría, hablarías, hablaría.*) What is the core meaning? (“Would speak.”) Which older construction stands behind the row? (An infinitive plus past forms of **haber**.) Next: give **comer** the same ending set.

95.2 comería — keep -er before “would”

Comeré means “I will eat.” Keep **comer** whole and exchange the future ending for **-ía**: **comería** — “I would eat.”

Grammar Lens: the singular -er row

person	conditional
yo	comería
tú	comerías
él / ella / usted	comería

Say **comería · comerías · comería**. Compare **hablaría / comería**: one bounded ending set serves both complete infinitives. Plural persons wait.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “comería, comerías, comería”
- “comeré, comería”
- “hablaría, comería”

Before you move on

Give the three learned forms. (*Comería, comerías, comería.*) Which piece stays whole? (**Comer.**) Which endings match **hablaría**? (**-ía, -ías, -ía.**) Next: complete the regular pattern with **vivir**.

95.3 viviría — the regular conditional closes its small frame

You can move from **comeré** to **comería**. Apply the same move to **viviré**: **viviría** — “I would live.”

Grammar Lens: the singular -ir row

person	conditional
yo	viviría
tú	vivirías
él / ella / usted	viviría
Say viviría · vivirías · viviría . The complete regular frame is now hablaría, comería, viviría . Plural persons wait.	

Grammar Lens: meaning with known words

Viviría en Madrid says “I would live in Madrid.” The lesson adds no new place or preposition.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “viviría, vivirías, viviría”

- “hablaría, comería, viviría”
- “Viviría en Madrid.”

Before you move on

Give the three **vivir** forms. (*Viviría, vivirías, viviría.*) Which regular verb families share the ending row? (All three.) Next: three already-known verbs change the stem but keep both sets of endings.

Chapter 96

One Stem, Two Tenses

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 👁️ eyes (1) 🖐️ Hands-free start: first 1 of 2 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can use the irregular stems that serve the future and the conditional alike.

hare, tendre, podre - stems shared by both tenses, so learning one buys the other.

96.1 haré · tendré · podré — three stems, two ending sets

Regular verbs keep the whole infinitive. Three common verbs you already know use a shorter or reshaped stem. Learn only these three today. In each row, the **same** stem serves the future and the conditional.

Grammar Lens: hacer becomes har-

person	future	conditional
yo	haré	haría
tú	harás	harías
él / ella / usted	hará	haría

Use the known noun in **Haré café** — “I will make coffee” — and **Haría café** — “I would make coffee.”

Grammar Lens: tener becomes tendr-

person	future	conditional
yo	tendré	tendría
tú	tendrás	tendrías
él / ella / usted	tendrá	tendría

The **d** in **tendr-** arose during the history of the compact future and conditional. Treat **tendr-** as the learned stem, not as permission to insert **d** into a new verb.

Grammar Lens: poder becomes podr-

person	future	conditional
yo	podré	podría
tú	podrás	podrías
él / ella / usted	podrá	podría

Podré hablar español says “I will be able to speak Spanish.” **Podría hablar español** says “I could / would be able to speak Spanish.”

These stems reflect inherited reductions and sound changes. The useful modern fact is bounded: **har-** · **tendr-** · **podr-**, each followed by the same endings you already learned.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “haré, haría”
- “tendré, tendría”
- “podré, podría”

Before you move on

Give the three learned stems. (**Har-**, **tendr-**, **podr-**.) Does each verb need separate future and conditional stems? (No; one stem serves both.) Do the endings change? (No.) Next: retrieve the complete twelve-atom chapter.

96.2 Practice — one infinitive frame, two futures of thought

This checkpoint adds no vocabulary and no plural persons. Retrieve the six regular singular rows, then the three learned irregular stems. Use the future for “will” and the conditional for the bounded core meaning “would.”

Grammar Lens: the regular frame

person	hablar	comer	vivir
yo future	hablaré	comeré	viviré
tú future	hablarás	comerás	vivirás
él / ella / usted future	hablará	comerá	vivirá
yo conditional	hablaría	comería	viviría
tú conditional	hablarías	comerías	vivirías
él / ella / usted conditional	hablaría	comería	viviría

All three regular infinitives remain whole. Future endings are **-é, -ás, -á**; conditional endings are **-ía, -ías, -ía**. Plural persons wait.

Grammar Lens: three learned stems

verb	learned stem	future yo	conditional yo
hacer	har-	haré	haría
tener	tendr-	tendré	tendría
poder	podr-	podré	podría

The stems change; the ending sets do not. Other irregular stems remain outside this chapter.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Romance future and conditional forms grew from constructions pairing an infinitive with forms of Latin **habēre**. Present material contributed to the future; past or imperfect material contributed to the conditional. Many paths and competing forms existed during the change, so this is a bridge for memory, not a one-step story or a recipe using modern **haber**.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “hablaré, comeré, viviré”
- “hablaría, comería, viviría”
- “haré/haría · tendré/tendría · podré/podría”

Before you move on

Give the three regular future yo forms. (*Hablaré, comeré, viviré.*) Give the three regular conditional yo forms. (*Hablaría, comería, viviría.*) Which three learned stems replace a whole infinitive? (**Har-, tendr-, podr-**.) What is the careful historical bridge? (Infinitive plus forms of Latin **habēre**, reshaped through Romance.) The next chapter can now begin without borrowing plural persons, new auxiliaries, or clock-time vocabulary.

Chapter 97

Synthesis — Promising, and Supposing

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can choose between a promise and a supposition, and say why the endings differ.

Haber glued on twice - present for the promise, past for the guess.

97.1 Synthesis — promising, and supposing

Nothing new in this chapter. Say *hablaré*, then *hablaría*.

Grammar Lens: the two endings are one word, twice

Three chapters ago you were told where these endings came from. Now it is worth seeing what that fact *buys* you.

Both are the verb **haber** — Latin *habēre*, “to have” — glued onto the back of the infinitive. Romance speakers stopped saying “I have to speak” as two words and fused it into one:

hablar + **he** (I have) → **hablaré** — I will speak. *hablar* + **había** (I had) → **hablaría** — I would speak.

That is the entire difference between the two tenses: **the same auxiliary, once in the present and once in the past**. Not two systems to learn — one system, looked at from two moments.

What you've built

And the meaning follows from the grammar rather than being extra to it.

Having to do something **now** is a commitment: **hablaré** is a promise, or a prediction you are standing behind. *Having had to* do it is a supposition — the obligation sits in a past that never arrived, so **hablaría** is hypothetical.

Promise from the present. Suppose from the past.

English hides the same move: *will* is the present of an old verb meaning *to want*, and *would* is its past. **Will/would** is the same pair as **-é/-ía**.

The exchange

— ¿**Hablarás** español en Madrid? — Sí, **hablaré** español.

>

— ¿Y sin práctica? — **Hablaría** español, pero no bien.

One letter-run apart, and the second speaker has moved from a commitment to a guess without changing a single other word.

Your turn

- *Say it: hablaré* then *hablaría*, and hear a promise turn into a guess

Twice through: Until the choice is about what you mean, not which ending it was.

Before you move on

What is glued onto the infinitive in both tenses? (**Haber** — the verb *to have*.) Which one is a promise, and which a supposition? (-é the promise, -ía the supposition.) And what is the English pair that works the same way? (**Will** and **would** — a present and a past of one old verb.)

Chapter 98

Wanting, Not Asserting

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🖱️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can tell an asserted event apart from a wanted one, and say why the verb changes.

Hablas español asserts; quiero que hables asserts nothing at all.

98.1 Hablas español · Quiero que hables español — fact or wanted event?

Hablas español can assert “You speak Spanish.” Now compare **Quiero que hables español** — “I want you to speak Spanish.” **Hables** does not report what is true. It presents the speaking as wanted and not yet asserted. That meaning contrast is the first small doorway into the **subjunctive**.

Grammar Lens: count the doers

meaning	Spanish	doers
I want to speak Spanish.	Quiero hablar español.	one: I want; I speak
I want you to speak Spanish.	Quiero que hables español.	two: I want; you speak

With one doer, keep the known infinitive **hablar**. With a different doer for the wanted event, use **que** and the new form **hables**. This is a bounded pattern for **querer**, not a rule for every clause in Spanish.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “Hablas español.”
- “Quiero hablar español.”
- “Quiero que hables español.”

Before you move on

Which form asserts the event? (**Hablas.**) Which presents it as wanted? (**Hables**, after **quiero que.**) What happens when the wanter and the speaker are the same? (Use the infinitive: **Quiero hablar.**) Next, build the three singular **-ar** forms one piece at a time.

Chapter 99

The Subjunctive, Regular

Modes: 🔄 voice (3) 🔄 Hands-free start: all 3 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can form the singular present subjunctive of a regular verb in any of the three families.

hable, coma, viva - the vowels swap sides, and -er and -ir agree again.

99.1 hable · hables · hable — the singular -ar row

You already used **hables** for one friend. Today add only the other two singular slots:

person	present subjunctive
yo	hable
tú	hables
él / ella / usted	hable

Plural forms wait. Say the small row: **hable · hables · hable**.

Grammar Lens: the yo stem, then a vowel swap

Start from present **hablo**. Remove **-o** to reveal **habl-**. Regular **-ar** verbs then use **e** in these subjunctive endings: **-e, -es, -e**. The family vowel has swapped from the familiar **a** to **e**. This recipe will matter later because a verb's special present **yo** stem can travel with it.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Spanish **subjuntivo** descends from Latin **subiūnctīvus**, “subjoined,” from **sub-** “under” plus **iungere** “join.” English **join**, **junction**, and **conjunction** belong to the same word family; **yoke** is a more distant cousin. The name helps you picture the wanted clause joined under **quiero que**. It is history, not a complete usage rule.

Your turn

Build each answer only from the learned singular row.

Before you move on

Give the three forms. (**Hable, hables, hable.**) Which present form supplies the stem? (**Hablo.**) What did the family vowel do? (**a → e.**) What does the name remember? (A clause **subjoined**, or joined under another.)

99.2 coma · comas · coma — let -er cross to a

Start from **como**, remove **-o**, and keep **com-**. A regular **-er** verb crosses to the **a** family:

person	present subjunctive
yo	coma
tú	comas
él / ella / usted	coma

Say only the singular row: **coma · comas · coma.**

Grammar Lens: meaning before machinery

Comes can assert “you eat.” **Quiero que comas** presents your eating as what I want. The **e → a** contrast helps you hear the two meanings. It does not mean that every **a** form is subjunctive; use the learned frame as a whole.

Your turn

Keep **comer** inside the learned singular frame.

Before you move on

Give the three forms. (**Coma, comas, coma.**) Which form asserts “you eat”? (**Comes.**) Which belongs after **quiero que**? (**Comas.**) Next, test whether regular **-ir** behaves differently.

99.3 viva · vivas · viva — -ir joins -er

Start from **vivo**, remove **-o**, then add the same **a** endings you just used with **comer**:

person	present subjunctive
yo	viva
tú	vivas
él / ella / usted	viva

Regular **-er** and **-ir** match in this singular row:

- **comer: coma · comas · coma.**
- **vivir: viva · vivas · viva.**

Plural differences wait.

Grammar Lens: meaning in a known frame

Vives en Madrid asserts where one friend lives. **Quiero que vivas en Madrid** makes that living a wanted event. Nothing new is being smuggled into the sentence: **en** and **Madrid** have appeared in the earlier location frame.

Your turn

Keep **vivir** inside the learned singular frame.

Before you move on

Give the three forms. (**Viva, vivas, viva.**) Which regular family matches **-ir** here? (**-er.**) Which form fits one friend after **quiero que**? (**Vivas.**)

Chapter 100

The Subjunctive Built From the Yo Form

Modes: 🗣 voice (3) 🗋 Hands-free start: all 3 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can build the subjunctive of an irregular verb from its yo form.

quiera, pueda, haga - each one is its own yo form with the vowel swapped.

100.1 quiera · quieras · quiera — keep the change you know

Present **quiero** already carries the stressed **e** → **ie** change. Remove **-o** to get **quier-**, then add the **-er/-ir** subjunctive endings:

person	present subjunctive
yo	quiera
tú	quieras
él / ella / usted	quiera

Say only this bounded singular row: **quiera · quieras · quiera.**

Grammar Lens: one known verb, one inherited stem

You are not learning a new list of stem-changing verbs. You are carrying one known change into one known row. **Quiero que quieras hablar**

español means “I want you to want to speak Spanish.” The sentence is deliberately narrow: no new person noun, object, or plural form.

Your turn

Carry only the known **quier-** stem into this row.

Before you move on

Give the three forms. (**Quiera, quieras, quiera.**) Which old change stays visible? (**e** → **ie.**) Where did the stem come from? (Known **quiero**, minus **-o.**)

100.2 pueda · puedas · pueda — one more known stem change

Present **puedo** already carries **o** → **ue**. Remove **-o** to get **pued-**, then add the same **a** row:

person	present subjunctive
yo	pueda
tú	puedas
él / ella / usted	pueda

Say **pueda · puedas · pueda**. No other **poder** forms enter today.

Grammar Lens: use it immediately

Quiero que puedas hablar español means “I want you to be able to speak Spanish.” Every word was already known except the single form **puedas**. This is the gentle pattern: learn one row, then spend it in the next sentence.

Your turn

Carry only the known **pued-** stem into this row.

Before you move on

Give the three forms. (**Pueda, puedas, pueda.**) Which old change stays visible? (**o** → **ue**.) Which form addresses one friend after **quiero que**? (**Puedas.**)

100.3 **haga · hagas · haga** — **hago** lends its stem

The known present **yo** form is **hago**. Remove **-o** and keep **hag-**:

person	present subjunctive
yo	haga
tú	hagas
él / ella / usted	haga

Say **haga · hagas · haga**. Only **hacer** enters this lesson; other special stems wait for later chapters.

Grammar Lens: spend the new form

Haces café can assert “you make coffee.” **Quiero que hagas café** says “I want you to make coffee.” The **g** is not a fresh exception: it was already in **hago**, the present form that supplied the stem.

Your turn

Carry only the known **hag-** stem into this row.

Before you move on

Give the three forms. (**Haga, hagas, haga.**) Where does **hag-** come from? (Known **hago**, minus **-o**.) Say the wanted event. (**Quiero que hagas café.**)

Chapter 101

Ojala — a Prayer That Outlived Its Religion

Modes: 🔄 voice (2) 🔄 Hands-free start: all 2 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can wish for something with ojala, and say where the word came from.

wa-sha' allah, carried through al-Andalus and kept long after.

101.1 ojalá + subjunctive — a wish borrowed through Arabic

Ojalá hables español means “I hope you speak Spanish” or “May you speak Spanish.” **Ojalá** expresses the wish by itself. It needs neither a main verb nor **que** before the subjunctive. Keep the first frame tiny:

Ojalá + subjunctive

That is a usable modern pattern. It does not make the Arabic source phrase new Spanish vocabulary.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

The Real Academia Española records **ojalá** from Hispanic Arabic **wa šá lláh**, “and God has willed.” Long contact in al-Andalus carried the expression into Spanish, where its sound and grammatical life changed. You met another Arabic-derived function word in **hasta**. The historical

phrase explains a route; only modern **ojalá** is available for your Spanish sentences.

Your turn

Use only modern **ojalá** as the Spanish trigger.

Before you move on

What follows **ojalá** in the learned frame? (The **subjunctive**.) Does it need **que**? (**No.**) Which historical language variety carried the word into Spanish? (**Hispanic Arabic**.) Is the older Arabic phrase usable as new Spanish vocabulary here? (**No.**)

101.2 Practice — assert the event or want it

This checkpoint adds no vocabulary, plural person, object pronoun, or new clause frame. First decide whether the event is asserted or wanted. Then retrieve only the singular rows you learned.

Grammar Lens: the bounded map

verb	yo / él / ella / usted	tú
hablar	hable	hables
comer	coma	comas
vivir	viva	vivas
querer	quiera	quieras
poder	pueda	puedas
hacer	haga	hagas

The repeated outer form is not a missing row: first- and third-person singular match. Every plural form waits.

Grammar Lens: two safe triggers

- Same doer: **Quiero hablar español.**
- Different doer: **Quiero que hables español.**

- Wish by itself: **Ojalá hables español.**

Do not extend these two frames to every emotion, doubt, command, or conjunction yet. More triggers belong in later micro-lessons.

Your turn

Decide the meaning first; then retrieve only the learned form.

Before you move on

What is the first meaning choice? (**Asserted event or wanted event.**) Give the three regular tú forms. (**Hables, comas, vivas.**) Give the three bounded special tú forms. (**Quieras, puedas, hagas.**) Name the two safe triggers. (**Quiero que** for a different doer; **ojalá** for a wish.) What still waits? (Plural persons, additional irregular verbs, and additional subjunctive triggers.)

Chapter 102

Synthesis — Claiming, and Not Claiming

Modes: 👁 eyes (1) ⇄ Hands-free start: none of the 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can choose the mood by deciding whether I am willing to assert the thing at all.

Indicative: this is so. Subjunctive: I am not saying this is so.

102.1 Synthesis — claiming, and not claiming

Nothing new in this chapter. Say *hablas*, then *hables*.

Grammar Lens: what the second one is actually doing

Those two forms are not two tenses. They are two **stances**.

Hablas español. — I am telling you this is so. **Quiero que hables español.** — I am not telling you anything is so.

In the first, you put a fact on the table and stood behind it. In the second, nothing has been claimed at all: the speaking has not happened, and might not. The mood is the difference, and the difference is about **what you are willing to assert**.

That is the whole of it, and it is worth holding onto, because every remaining use of this mood — and there are many — is a version of the same move. Wishing, doubting, denying, hoping: none of them puts a fact on the table.

Indicative: *this is so*. Subjunctive: *I am not saying this is so*.

The exchange

— ¿**Hablas** español? — Ana quiere que **hable** español. —
Ojalá hables mucho.

Three lines, three stances. The first asks about a fact. The second reports somebody's wish, so nothing is asserted. The third wishes it outright.

What you've built

Ojalá deserves a last look, because it explains itself.

It is Arabic — *wa-šā' allāh*, “and may God will it” — carried into Spanish over eight centuries of al-Andalus and kept long after the religion behind it stopped being the speaker's. A Spanish speaker saying *ojalá* today is uttering a prayer in a language they do not speak, to a God the sentence no longer names.

And it can only ever take this mood. Of course it can: a thing God has yet to will is, by definition, not a fact you can assert.

Your turn

- *Say it*: the three-line exchange, and name the stance of each line

Twice through: Until choosing the mood feels like choosing what you mean.

Before you move on

What does the indicative do that the subjunctive does not? (**Claim that something is so**.) Why can *ojalá* never take the indicative? (Because a thing not yet willed is not a fact.) And what language is *ojalá*? (**Arabic** — a prayer that outlived the religion behind it.)

Chapter 103

Lo Siento

Modes: 🗣️ voice (2) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 2 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can apologise in Spanish and choose between *lo siento* and *perdón*.

Say lo siento for regret and perdón for fault or for catching someone's attention, hearing sentir — I feel it — inside the first and dōnāre — to give completely — inside the second.

103.1 lo siento — “I’m sorry,” i.e. “I feel it”

You already know **por favor**, “please.” The next courtesy phrase is **lo siento**. Spanish does not say “I *am* sorry” as an adjective; it says something closer to “**I feel this.**”

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

- **lo** = “it” — a **neuter** pronoun. It does not point at any noun; it points at the **situation itself**. Spanish keeps this one leftover neuter slot precisely for “the whole business, unnamed.”
- **siento** = “I feel,” from **sentir**, “to feel,” from Latin **sentīre**. That root gave English a whole family: **sentiment**, **sense**, **consent** (“feel together”), **resent** (“feel back at”), and **sentence** (originally an *opinion*, something felt).

So **lo siento** is literally “*I feel it.*” You are naming a feeling — regret, sympathy — rather than declaring a state about yourself. That is why it stretches so easily: *lo siento mucho*, “I feel it a lot,” works both for

stepping on someone's foot and for hearing that their father died.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “siento” — I feel — then “lo siento,” I feel it / I’m sorry
- “lo siento mucho” — I’m so sorry
- “siento” then English “sentiment, sense, consent”

Before you move on

What does **lo siento** literally mean? (“**I feel it**” — *siento*, “I feel,” from Latin *sentire*.) What is the *lo* pointing at? (The **situation**, not a noun — it is the neuter “it.”) Next: Spanish’s *other* word for sorry, and when it is the right one.

103.2 perdón — the sorry that asks for something back

Lo siento names a feeling. Spanish keeps a **second** word for a different job — one that is not about your feelings at all, but about something you want from the other person.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

perdón (“pardon”), from the verb **perdonar** — Latin **per-** (“thoroughly”) + **dōnāre** (“to give”). Literally: “**to give completely**.” That *dōnāre* is English’s **donate**, **donor**, and **condone**; the *per-* is the same intensifier in **perfect** (“thoroughly made”) and **perturb**. So forgiveness, in Latin’s picture of it, is a **gift given all the way** — you hand over the debt rather than keeping a share of it.

Why it’s said this way

The two are not interchangeable, and the difference follows straight from the etymologies:

	lo siento	perdón
literally	“I feel it”	“give [it] completely”
points at	your feeling	their forgiveness
use for	regret, sympathy	fault, or getting past someone

So **perdón** is what you say to squeeze through a crowd or catch a waiter’s eye (English “excuse me”), and to ask forgiveness for something **you did** — often stronger than *lo siento*. **Lo siento** leans toward “I’m sorry that happened,” including things that are nobody’s fault at all. Be honest about the edges: native speakers use whichever fits, the boundary is soft, and mixing them is not a real mistake — just a shade off.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “perdón” — pardon / excuse me
- the pair — “lo siento” for regret, “perdón” for fault
- “perdón” then English “donate, condone” — the *dōnāre* root

Before you move on

What do the two halves of **perdonar** mean? (**Per-**, “thoroughly,” plus **dōnāre**, “to give” — to give completely.) Which word do you use to get past someone in a corridor? (**Perdón.**) Which leans toward sympathy rather than fault? (**Lo siento** — “I feel it.”)

Chapter 104

Days of the Week

Modes: 👁 eyes (2) ↔ Hands-free start: none of the 2 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name all seven days of the week in Spanish and say why the last two broke away from the planet names.

Run lunes to domingo straight through, then pair each weekend day against its English twin — sábado against Saturn’s day, domingo against the Sun’s.

104.1 lunes to viernes — the planets of the week, worn down

The Romans mapped the seven-day week onto the seven visible “wandering stars” — the planet-gods. Spanish kept that map, but handled the word “day” differently from its Romance cousins: where French still spells out “-di” (day) on every weekday, Spanish mostly just **dropped it**.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Each weekday began life as “[planet-god]’s diēs (day).” In Vulgar Latin, *diēs* was simply **dropped as a separate word** in most of these — what survived is just the planet’s own Latin genitive form. That’s why **martes**, **jueves**, **viernes** already end in -s: not because *diēs* wore down into one, but because **Martis**, **Iovis**, **Veneris** — the planets’ own genitive forms — end in -s in Latin already. **Lunes** has no such -s to inherit (*lūnae* doesn’t end in one), so it likely picked up the ending

by **analogy** with its four siblings:

Spanish	← Latin	planet-god	English echo
lunes	<i>lūnae diēs</i>	the Moon (<i>luna</i>)	<i>Monday</i> = Moon-day
martes	<i>Martis diēs</i>	Mars	<i>Tuesday</i> (Tiw, the Germanic war-god = Mars)
miércoles	<i>Mercurii diēs</i>	Mercury	<i>Wednesday</i> (Woden = Mercury)
jueves	<i>Jovis diēs</i>	Jupiter (<i>Jove</i>)	<i>Thursday</i> (Thor = Jupiter)
viernes	<i>Veneris diēs</i>	Venus	<i>Friday</i> (Frigg/Freya = Venus)

Compare **French**, which keeps *diēs* as its own visible syllable on every day — **lundi**, **mardi**, **jeudi** — while Spanish dropped it from four of its five weekdays. **miércoles** is the odd one out: some historians of the language think its extra “-coles” is a genuine surviving trace of *diēs* itself (fused in and reshaped) — though the exact sound changes are debated, unlike the plainer, better-understood story for its four siblings.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “lunes, martes, miércoles, jueves, viernes” — the work week
- each as “[planet]’s day, worn down” — “lunes = Moon, jueves = Jupiter”
- the bridge — “martes / Tuesday, both the war-god’s day (Mars / Tiw)”

Before you move on

Recall the weekday family:

- What did every Spanish weekday begin life as? (“**[Planet-god]’s diēs (day)**” — the same Latin phrase French keeps more visibly with *-di*.)
- Why do **martes, jueves, viernes** end in *-s*, and where does **lunes** get its *-s* from? (**From the planet’s own Latin genitive** — Martis/Iovis/ Veneris already end in *-s*; *lunes* likely picked it up **by analogy**, since *lūnae* has no *-s* of its own.)
- What’s debated about **miércoles**? (**Whether its “-coles” is a genuine surviving trace of diēs** — unlike the plainer, better-understood story for its four siblings.)
- Why do *martes* and *Tuesday* line up? (They name the same day for the war-god: *Mars* in Latin, *Tiw* in Germanic.)

104.2 sábado and domingo — the week’s religious edge

Five days named for planets — then two that broke the pattern entirely. The weekend is where **religion overwrote astronomy**, and Spanish keeps both rewrites in plain view.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Spanish	← Latin	meaning	note
sábado	<i>sabbatum</i>	“ Sabbath ”	the planet-god (Saturn) is gone — replaced by the Hebrew <i>shabbāt</i> , “to rest”
domingo	<i>diēs Dominica</i>	“the Lord’s day”	<i>Dominica</i> ← <i>Dominus</i> , “lord/master” — Spanish kept this one much less worn-down than French’s <i>dimanche</i>

Two different rewrites:

- **sábado** would have been “Saturn’s day” (as English **Saturday** still is — the one weekday English kept a Roman god for). Instead, Latin Christians borrowed the Jewish **Sabbath** (*Sabbatum* ← Hebrew *shabbāt*), and it became *sábado*. So English **Saturday** and Spanish **sábado** are the **same day, two different names** — the planet vs. the Sabbath.
- **domingo** drops Sun-worship entirely: where English keeps **Sunday**, Spanish made it *diēs Dominica*, “the Lord’s day” (*Dominus* → English **dominion, dominate, dame**). Spanish kept **domingo** recognizably close to *Dominica* — compare French’s more worn-down **dimanche**, where the *di-* (day) fossil jumped to the front of the word.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the full week — “lunes, martes, miércoles, jueves, viernes, sábado, domingo”

- “sábado = Sabbath, domingo = the Lord’s day” — religion, not planets
- the pair-ups — “sábado / Saturday (Sabbath vs. Saturn)”, “domingo / Sunday (Lord vs. Sun)”

Before you move on

Give all seven Spanish days. (*Lunes ... domingo*.) Where does **sábado** come from, and its English contrast? (The **Sabbath**, *Sabbatum*; English kept *Saturday* = Saturn’s day.) What does **domingo** mean literally? (“The **Lord’s** day,” *diēs Dominica*.)

Chapter 105

Black, White, Red, and Blue

Modes: 🗣️ voice (4) 🖱️ Hands-free start: all 4 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name black, white, red and blue in Spanish and say which of them Spanish borrowed rather than inherited.

Say negro, blanco, rojo and azul, then sort them by origin: negro inherited from Latin, blanco traditionally linked to the Germanic Visigoths, rojo a cousin of English red by a different Latin branch, and azul carried in from Arabic lāzaward.

105.1 negro, blanco — two colours, and one of their histories

Two colours you can put to work immediately. One of them has the most ordinary history imaginable. The other does not — which is why it gets its own lesson next.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

negro (“black”) ← Latin **niger**. Nothing surprising: the same Latin root gives English **denigrate** (“to blacken someone’s name”) and the rest of the Romance family’s words for black — French *noir*, Italian *nero*, Portuguese *negro*. Latin’s word for black stayed put, in every daughter language.

Hold that in mind as the baseline. It is what a colour word normally does.

The two words in use

blanco (“white”) is the pair to it: *el gato negro*, *el gato blanco*. Both behave like any Spanish adjective — they follow the noun and agree with it (*la casa blanca*).

But hear what you would have expected and did not get. Latin’s word for white was **albus**, and by the *negro* pattern Spanish “white” should be something like *albo*. It is not. Where **blanco** actually came from — and what became of *albus* — is the next lesson.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “negro, blanco”
- with a noun — “el gato negro, la casa blanca”
- “negro” then English “denigrate” — the *niger* root

Before you move on

Say black and white. (*Negro*, *blanco*.) Where does *negro* come from, and what English word shares it? (Latin **niger** — *denigrate*.) What would you have expected Spanish’s “white” to be, given Latin *albus*? (Something like *albo* — and it isn’t. That is next lesson’s puzzle.)

105.2 blanco — the colour Spanish did not inherit

Negro came straight down from Latin, like almost every other everyday word you have met. **Blanco** did not come down at all. It walked in.

What to know first

- negro, blanco — the two colour words.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

blanco comes from **Germanic *blank** — “**shining, gleaming**.” It is a **loan**, traditionally attributed to contact with the **Visigoths**, the Germanic people who ruled Spain for centuries after Rome collapsed. Be careful how firmly you hold that last part: no surviving Gothic text actually preserves this word, so the Visigothic route is a **plausible traditional account**, not a documented one. What *is* well attested is the parallel case next door — **French** took the very same Germanic word (*blanc*) from a **different** Germanic people, the **Franks**. Two Romance sisters, the same borrowed word for white, two separate borrowings. Why would a borrowed word beat Latin’s own? Because **blank* was not a pale word: it meant **bright, gleaming**. Colour terms lose out to vivid ones all the time — English’s own *bright* is doing the same job in “bright white.”

Why it’s said this way

Latin’s white did not vanish. It stopped being the **everyday** word and survived in corners:

word	meaning	the white inside
alba	dawn	the sky going <i>white</i>
<i>albo</i> (rare, poetic)	white, pale	a fossil, mostly literary now
<i>álbum</i> (Eng. <i>album</i>)	album	a <i>blank white</i> tablet
<i>albino</i>	albino	white-skinned

That is the normal fate of a displaced word: not death, but retreat into technical and poetic corners. *El alba* is still every Spanish speaker’s word for dawn.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the pairing — “negro from Latin, blanco from Germanic”
- “el alba” — dawn — and hear the old Latin white inside it
- “blanco” then French “blanc” — the same loan, twice over

Before you move on

Where does **blanco** come from, and what did it mean? (**Germanic** ***blank**, “shining” — traditionally linked to the Visigoths, though not directly attested.) Which other language borrowed the same word, from whom? (**French** *blanc*, from the **Franks**.) Where did Latin’s *albus* end up? (In **alba** “dawn,” *álbum*, *albino* — no longer the everyday colour word.)

105.3 rojo — the same family as *red*, by a different branch

So far the sorting has been simple: *negro* inherited, *blanco* borrowed. **Rojo** needs a third box — inherited, yes, but not from the word you would guess.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

rojo (“red”) ← Latin **russus**, an everyday, expressive Latin word for red. That is a **different specific Latin word** from the one behind French *rouge* (← **rubeus**). Latin had several reds and the daughter languages did not all pick the same one.

Both *russus* and *rubeus*, though, descend from the very same ancient root: PIE *h₁rewd^h*- — which is also the root of English **red**, **rust**, **ruddy**, and of Latin *ruber* itself (English **rubric**, once written in red ink).

So *rojo*, *rouge* and *red* are **cousins**, not copies: three descendants of one very old family, arriving by three different branches. Nobody borrowed this one from anybody.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “rojo”
- the cousins — “rojo · rouge · red”, three branches, one root
- the three so far — “negro inherited, blanco borrowed, rojo cousin”

Before you move on

Is **rojo** from the same Latin word as French *rouge*? (**No** — *rojo* ← *russus*, *rouge* ← *rubeus*.) Are they related at all? (**Yes** — cousins, via the shared PIE root *h₁rewd^h*-, which also gives English **red**.) Next: the one colour in this chapter that came from outside Europe entirely.

105.4 azul — a stone from Afghanistan, in your everyday vocabulary

Three colours in, three different histories: inherited, borrowed from a neighbour, inherited by a different branch. The fourth comes from outside the Indo-European family altogether.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

azul (“blue”) ← Arabic لازورد (*lāzaward*), “**lapis lazuli**” — the deep blue stone, mined for centuries in what is now Afghanistan and ground into the most expensive pigment in the medieval world. Spanish picked the word up during the centuries of Arabic-speaking rule in Iberia (**al-Andalus**). English has the same source at one more remove, in **azure**, and the stone keeps its own name: **lazuli**.

So Spanish’s word for blue is, underneath, the name of a **rock** — which is common for blue. Blue is the last basic colour term most languages acquire, and when they do, they usually name it after the thing that was reliably that colour.

Why it’s said this way

Here is the contrast worth keeping. **French** has *azur* too — but only as a **secondary, poetic** word (the sky’s blue, the *Côte d’Azur*); its everyday blue is the Germanic loan *bleu*. In **Spanish** it is the reverse: **azul is the plain, unremarkable, everyday word**, with no Germanic rival competing for the job at all.

Same borrowed word, two languages, opposite outcomes — a reminder that where a word came from tells you nothing about how ordinary it now feels.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- all four — “negro, blanco, rojo, azul”
- sort them — “negro inherited, blanco Germanic, rojo cousin of red, azul Arabic”
- “azul” then English “azure” — the same lapis lazuli

Before you move on

Name the four colours and sort them by origin. (*Negro* — Latin *niger*; *blanco* — Germanic **blank*; *rojo* — Latin *russus*, cousin of red; *azul* — Arabic *lāzaward*.) What did *lāzaward* actually name? (**Lapis lazuli**, the stone.) How does *azul*’s role differ from French *azur*’s? (**Azul is Spanish’s everyday blue**; French’s *azur* is only poetic, with *bleu* doing the daily work.)

Chapter 106

Parents and Siblings

Modes: 🗣️ voice (3) 🖱️ Hands-free start: all 3 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name my parents and my siblings in Spanish and explain why hermano is not built on Latin’s word for brother.

Give el padre, la madre, el hermano and la hermana, trace hermano back through germānus to germen, the seed, rather than to frāter, and separate its silent h from the once-spoken h of hijo and hacer.

106.1 el padre, la madre — among the oldest words there are

“Father” and “mother” are some of the **oldest reconstructible words in human language** — older than Latin, older than Rome. Spanish kept them close to the Latin original, and they are secretly the *same words* as English **father** and **mother**.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

- **el padre** (“father”) ← Latin **pater** ← PIE *ph₂tēr*.
- **la madre** (“mother”) ← Latin **māter** ← PIE *méh₂tēr*.

Why it’s said this way

Padre and English *father* both descend independently from the **same** PIE word — they’re siblings, not parent and child. Latin (and Spanish

after it) kept the original *p* and *t* largely intact; the Germanic branch that gave English took a separate road through **Grimm’s Law**, which shifted the **inherited** **p** → **f** and **t** → **th**:

PIE ancestor	Latin → Spanish	Germanic → English
<i>ph₂tēr</i>	<i>pater</i> → padre	father
<i>méh₂tēr</i>	<i>māter</i> → madre	mother

So *padre* and *father* aren’t lookalikes borrowed late, and neither one comes *from* the other — they’re the **same inherited PIE word**, one branch keeping the *p*, the other shifting it to *f*. The Latin root also gives Spanish and English their “of a parent” adjectives: **paternal**, **paternidad**, **patrón** and **maternal**, **maternidad**. (A further Latin-only offshoot, *māter* → *māteria*, “the stuff a tree-mother produces,” gives Spanish *materia* and, separately, *matriz* — “womb” — via Latin *mātrix*.)

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “el padre, la madre”
- the sound-law — “padre keeps p; father shifts to f — same word”
- “padre → paternal; madre → maternal”

Before you move on

Give “father” and “mother” with their articles. (**el padre, la madre**.) Does *padre* turn into English *father* directly? (**No** — both descend independently from the same PIE word; the Germanic branch shifted **p** → **f** and **t** → **th** via **Grimm’s Law**, while Latin/Spanish kept the original sounds.) Name an English cousin of each. (*padre* → paternal; *madre* → maternal.)

106.2 el hermano, la hermana — brother and sister, from a different word entirely

You might expect Spanish “brother” to come from Latin **frāter**, the way French’s *frère* does. It does not. Spanish’s siblings took a completely different word — one about **seeds**.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Classical Latin could say **frāter germānus**, literally “a brother **of the same stock/blood**” — distinguishing a *full* brother from a half-brother, or from a “brother” in some looser sense.

Then something ordinary and strange happened: in everyday Latin the **adjective** took over the whole job and the **noun quietly dropped out**. (English does this all the time — a *mobile phone* becomes a *mobile*, a *cellular telephone* becomes a *cell*.) What survived is the modifier:

- **el hermano** (“brother”) ← Latin **germānus**.
- **la hermana** (“sister”) ← Latin **germāna**.

So Spanish’s everyday word for brother is, grammatically, a leftover adjective.

Why it’s said this way

Germānus traces back to **germen**, “sprout, bud, seed” — the same root that gives English **germ**, **germinate**, and **germane** (originally “closely related,” from the same seed, before it loosened into just “relevant”).

So calling someone your *hermano* is, at the etymological root, calling them “**sprung from the same seed**.” (And no, this has nothing to do with *Germany* — that name is a separate, unrelated puzzle.)

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “el hermano, la hermana” — brother, sister
- the root chain — “germen, seed” → “germānus, of the same seed” → “hermano”

- “hermano” then English “germinate, germane”

Before you move on

Does Spanish *hermano* come from Latin *frāter*? (**No** — from **germānus**, “of the same stock/seed,” an adjective that swallowed the noun *frāter* it used to modify.) What does its root *germen* mean, and what English words share it? (**Seed, sprout** — *germ, germinate, germane*.) Next: the silent *h* on the front, which is not the *h* you think it is.

106.3 the *h* in hermano — a letter that was never spoken

Germānus starts with a **g**. *Hermano* starts with an **h**. Something has to explain that — and the obvious explanation is the wrong one.

What to know first

- el hermano, la hermana — the words and the *germen* root.

Why it’s said this way

You may already know that Spanish often turns a Latin initial **f** into a silent **h** — *filius* → **hijo** (“son”), *facere* → **hacer** (“to do”). **Hermano is not that**, and the difference is worth getting right.

Germānus is stressed on its **third** syllable (*ger-MĀ-nus*), which leaves the opening *ger-* **unstressed**. Latin’s **g** before a front vowel had already softened toward a *y*-like sound in everyday speech — and in that unstressed position it simply **fell away entirely**, giving Old Spanish *ermano*, with **no *h* at all**. That is the form actually recorded centuries ago.

The **h** you see today was added **later, in spelling only**, to mark the word’s old link to Latin *g-*. Compare:

word	what happened to the sound	was the <i>h</i> ever spoken?
hijo, hacer	Latin <i>f-</i> → a real breathy <i>h</i>	yes , for centuries
hermano	Latin <i>g-</i> simply dropped	no , never
Same silent letter today; two completely different backstories, only one of which involves a sound at all.		

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “*germānus*” then “*ermano*” then “*hermano*” — the three stages
- the honest distinction — *hijo/hacer*’s *h* was once truly spoken; *hermano*’s *h* never was

Before you move on

Is *hermano*’s *h* the same kind of change as *hijo*’s or *hacer*’s? (**No.**) What actually happened to *germānus*’s opening? (Its **g** dropped away in an **unstressed** syllable, giving Old Spanish *ermano*.) So where did the *h* come from? (**Spelling** — added later to mark the Latin link, never pronounced.)

Chapter 107

Head and Hand

Modes: 🗣️ voice (2) 🖐️ Hands-free start: all 2 lessons.

***By the end of this chapter:** I can name the head and the hand in Spanish and get la mano’s gender right despite its -o ending.*

Say la cabeza and la mano, use me duele la mano, and explain the feminine article on a word that ends in -o by way of Latin’s fourth declension.

107.1 la cabeza — “the head”

Spanish’s word for “head” is the boring, expected one — and that’s exactly what makes it interesting, once you see what French did instead.

You’ll want to know: la cabeza

la cabeza — the head. Feminine, so **la**.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Latin’s word for “head” was **caput**. Spanish’s *cabeza* comes straight from it (by way of Vulgar Latin *capitia*), and *caput* shows up all over English too:

English	literally
captain	the “head” of a ship/unit
capital	the “head” city, or “head” sum of money
decapitate	to remove the head
capitulate	to arrange under “headings” — hence, to yield

Why it’s said this way

French had the exact same Latin word available — and **dropped it**. French *tête* (“head”) comes instead from **testa**, Latin for an **earth-ware pot**: Roman soldiers joked about the skull the way English speakers say “noggin” (a small mug), and in Gaul that joke eventually **replaced** the real word entirely. Spanish never made that swap — *cabeza* is *caput*, plain and simple, still standing after two thousand years.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “la cabeza” — the head
- “me duele la cabeza” — “my head hurts”
- the English family — “captain, capital, decapitate”
- the contrast — Spanish kept *caput*; French swapped it for a pot joke

Before you move on

Say “the head.” (*La cabeza* — feminine.) What Latin word is it from? (**Caput**.) Give an English word from the same root. (**Captain, capital, decapitate...**) What did French do instead? (**Replaced caput with *testa*, “pot”** — soldiers’ slang for the skull that took over completely.)

107.2 la mano — “the hand”

You’ve been trusting “-o words are masculine, -a words are feminine” since your first chapters. Here’s the word that breaks it — and everyone learning Spanish has to memorize this one by name.

Grammar Lens: la mano and its gender

la mano — the hand. **Feminine**, despite ending in **-o**.

Almost every Spanish noun ending in *-o* is masculine (*el libro, el gato...*). *Mano* is the single most common exception, and it’s actually **doubly** irregular. Latin **manus** (“hand”) belonged to the **4th declension** — a group of *-us* nouns that were mostly **masculine** (*fructus* “fruit,” *exercitus* “army,” *senātus* “senate”). *Manus* was one of a small handful of exceptions that were **feminine** instead (alongside *domus* “house” and *anus* “old woman”). So *mano* broke the rule **twice over**: an exception within Latin’s own mostly-masculine 4th declension, and then an exception again against Spanish’s usual *-o* = masculine pattern.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Mano comes from Latin **manus**, “hand” — and that root is buried inside an enormous number of English words:

English	literally
manual	done by hand
manufacture	made by hand (<i>manus</i> + <i>facere</i> , “to make”)
manuscript	written by hand (<i>manus</i> + <i>scribere</i>)
maintain	hold in the hand (<i>manū tenēre</i>)
manage	to handle

Manufacture is worth pausing on: it literally means “made by hand” — and today it names precisely the opposite.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “la mano” — feminine, despite the -o

- “me duele la mano” — “my hand hurts”
- the family — “manual, manufacture, maintain — all a hand”
- the irony — “manufacture = made by hand”

Before you move on

Say “the hand,” and name its gender. (*La mano* — **feminine**, despite ending in *-o*.) Why is *mano* feminine when most *-o* words aren’t? (**It’s doubly irregular** — Latin’s 4th declension, where *manus* belongs, was mostly **masculine**; *manus* was one of a few feminine exceptions there, and then an exception again against Spanish’s usual *-o*=masculine rule.) Give an English word built on *manus*. (**Manual, manufacture, manuscript, maintain, manage.**)

Chapter 108

The Seasons

Modes: ⇄ voice (1) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can name the four seasons in Spanish and explain how verano moved from spring to summer.

Run primavera, verano, otoño, invierno, unpack primavera as prīma vēra, and show verano growing out of that same vēr before its meaning slid across to summer.

108.1 la primavera, el verano, el otoño, el invierno — three plain, one surprising

Three of Spanish’s four seasons are exactly what you’d expect from Latin. The fourth hides a genuine surprise: its **meaning itself** drifted from one season to another.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

- **la primavera** (“spring”) ← Latin **prīma vēra**, literally “**first spring**” (*vēr*, “spring,” + *prīma*, “first”). Italian still says the identical phrase, *primavera*, unchanged. (Old French once said *primevère* too, before switching to *printemps*.)
- **el otoño** (“autumn”) ← Latin **autumnus** — the same root behind French *automne* and English *autumn* itself.
- **el invierno** (“winter”) ← Latin **hībernum** (*tempus*), “the **wintry** [season]” — the same root as French *hiver* and English **hibernate**, “to spend the winter.”

Why it's said this way

You might expect *verano* (“summer”) to come from Latin *aestas*, “heat” — the way French *été* does. It doesn’t. The standard account (per Spanish etymological dictionaries) traces **verano** to Latin *vērānum* (*tempus*), “**of spring**” — built on the very same *vēr*, “spring,” behind *primavera*.

So how did a word meaning “spring-ish” end up naming **summer**? The honest answer is a **shift in meaning over time**, not a sound change — though the exact story is murkier than a tidy one-line explanation. The traditional, simplified account says that as *primavera* (“first spring”) rose to become the standard word for spring, *verano*’s meaning drifted forward into the season right after, summer; the fuller picture likely also involves Vulgar Latin agricultural usage (a “vernal” grazing or working period that stretched from late spring into early summer), so the drift may not be purely a case of one word simply vacating a job for the other. Either way, two Spanish words both rooted in *vēr*, “spring,” ended up naming two different seasons.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “primavera, verano, otoño, invierno” — the four seasons
- “primavera = prima vera, first spring”
- the surprise — “verano **ALSO** comes from *vēr*, ‘spring’ — but its meaning moved to summer”
- “invierno ~ hibernate”

Before you move on

What does **primavera** literally mean? (“**First spring**” — *prīma vēra*.) Does **verano** come from Latin *aestas*, like French *été*? (**No** — from *vērānum*, “of spring,” the same *vēr* root as *primavera*; its meaning **shifted** toward summer over time — traditionally linked to *primavera* taking over the job of naming spring, though the fuller history is murkier than that alone.) What English word is **invierno** the cousin of? (**Hibernate**.)

Chapter 109

Water, Wine, and Bread

Modes: 🗣️ voice (3) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 3 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name water, wine and bread in Spanish and say why a *compañero* is someone who shares bread with me.

Say el agua, el vino and el pan, then open compañero into com- plus pānis and follow the root out to panadería and panadero.

109.1 el agua — water, and an article that is not what it looks like

One of the least changed words in Spanish, carrying one of its most misunderstood rules. The “masculine” article on this feminine noun is not a mistake and not an exception to gender.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

agua (“water”) ← Latin **aqua** — almost unchanged in two thousand years. Compare French, where the *very same word* was worn all the way down to a bare “**eau**,” just the sound “oh.” Same starting point, same span of time, wildly different amounts of erosion: how fast a language wears its words down is not fixed.

English kept the whole Latin word too, but as a **learned borrowing** rather than an inherited everyday one: **aquatic, aquarium, aqueduct, aqualung**.

Grammar Lens: el agua's article and gender

Notice: **el agua**, not *la agua* — yet *agua* is genuinely **feminine**. You can prove it: *el agua fría*, “the cold water,” keeps the feminine adjective ending, and the plural is *las aguas*, never *los aguas*.

The rule is **phonological**, not grammatical. Spanish swaps *la* for *el* directly before a **singular** feminine noun beginning with a **stressed a-sound**, to avoid running two identical vowels together (*la agua*). It is the same instinct that makes English pick “an apple” over “a apple.”

	singular	plural
the water	el agua	las aguas
the eagle	el águila	las águilas
the axe	el hacha	las hachas

Only the article changes. The noun's gender never moves.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “el agua” — water, feminine, but takes *el*
- the proof — “el agua fría” and “las aguas”
- the contrast — “agua” barely changed; French's “eau” wore all the way down

Before you move on

Is **agua** masculine or feminine? (**Feminine** — *el* replaces *la* only because *agua* begins with a **stressed a**.) How would you prove it? (*El agua fría*; *las aguas*.) How does Spanish's erosion of *agua* compare with French's? (**Much less** — Spanish kept nearly the whole word; French wore it to “eau.”)

109.2 el vino — one word, three separate arrivals in English

The second drink is grammatically boring — plain masculine, plain *el vino*, no stressed-*a* trick. Its history makes up for that.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

vino (“wine”) ← Latin **vīnum** — which held its shape well, as French’s *vin* did too.

English shares the very same root by **more than one road**, and the roads are worth separating, because they show three different ways a word can travel:

English word	how it got there
wine	<i>vīnum</i> borrowed directly into old Germanic, very early
vine, vinegar	borrowed centuries later, secondhand via French (<i>vin</i> + <i>aigre</i> , “sour wine”)
vineyard	not borrowed at all — English built it at home from the already-borrowed <i>wine</i> plus native <i>yard</i>

So *wine* and *vine* are the same Latin word twice, arriving a thousand years apart by different routes, and *vineyard* is a homemade compound made out of the first arrival. One Latin noun; three English histories.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “el agua, el vino” — the two drinks
- “vino” then English “wine, vine, vinegar” — one root, three roads

Before you move on

What Latin word gives *vino*? (**Vīnum**.) Name three English cousins and say how each arrived. (**Wine** — direct, early, into Germanic; **vine/vinegar** — later, via French; **vineyard** — built at home from *wine* plus *yard*.) And why is it *el agua* but *las aguas*? (The *el* is a sound rule for a stressed *a*, singular only.)

109.3 el pan — bread, and the friend who shares it

Spanish’s word for bread hides the same lovely word-story you’d find in English’s “companion” — except Spanish kept **both halves**, the bread and the friendship.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el pan (“bread”) ← Latin **pānis**. Masculine: *el pan*.

Why it’s said this way

The Latin root **pān-** (“bread”) gives Spanish its own word for a close friend:

- **compañero / compañera** (“companion, friend, partner”) ← *com-* (“with”) + *pānis* — literally “**one you share bread with**.” Spanish built this word from the very same recipe as English **companion** and **company** (which come from the identical Latin pieces) — but where English only kept the *friendship* sense, Spanish still visibly uses the **same root** for the actual **bread** (*pan*) too.
- **panadería** (“bakery”) and **panadero** (“baker”) — both transparently built on *pan*.

So *pan* and *compañero* are the same word-family doing double duty in Spanish: name the food, and name the friend you’d share it with.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “el pan” — bread
- “compañero” — literally, one you share bread with
- “panadería, panadero” — bakery, baker

Before you move on

Give “bread” with its article. (**El pan.**) What does *compañero* literally mean, and what’s it built from? (“**One you share bread with**” — *com-* + *pānis*.) Does English keep this same double meaning? (**No** — English’s *companion* only kept the friendship sense; Spanish still uses the same root for the actual bread, *pan*, too.)

Chapter 110

The Months

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can name the twelve months in Spanish and explain why *diciembre* carries the Latin word for ten.

Recite enero through diciembre, tie marzo back to martes through Mars, and place septiembre and diciembre against the Roman year that started in March.

110.1 los meses — the calendar's gods and Caesars

Spanish's twelve months are a **procession of Roman gods and emperors**, barely changed from Latin. Two things you already know pay off immediately: *marzo* is the war-god you met in *martes*, and *septiembre–diciembre* are the Latin numbers 7–10 from the counting chapters.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Spanish	← Latin	who / what
enero	<i>Iānuārius</i>	Janus , the two-faced god of doors & beginnings
febrero	<i>Februārius</i>	<i>Februa</i> , the Roman purification festival
marzo	<i>Martius</i>	Mars , the war-god — <i>the same Mars as martes</i> (Tuesday)! perhaps <i>aperire</i> , “to open” (buds opening)
abril	<i>Aprīlis</i>	Maia , goddess of growth
mayo	<i>Māius</i>	Juno , queen of the gods
junio	<i>Iūnius</i>	originally <i>Quīntilis</i> , “the 5th [month]” — renamed for Julius Caesar after his death
julio	<i>Iūlius</i>	originally <i>Sextilis</i> , “the 6th [month]” — renamed for the emperor Augustus
agosto	<i>Augustus</i>	“ 7th ” (<i>septem</i>)
septiembre	<i>september</i>	“ 8th ” (<i>octō</i>)
octubre	<i>octōber</i>	“ 9th ” (<i>novem</i>)
noviembre	<i>november</i>	“ 10th ” (<i>decem</i>)
diciembre	<i>december</i>	

Two payoffs land at once:

- **marzo = Mars = martes.** The month and the weekday honor the *same* war-god — *Martius* (his month) and *Martis diēs* (his day). Spot one, you know the other.
- **The 7–10 months.** *Septiembre* through *diciembre* still carry *septem*, *octō*, *novem*, *decem* — because the old Roman year

originally began in **March**, with September genuinely the 7th month. Centuries before Caesar, two new months (Januarius, Februarius) were added at the front to cover the winter, which pushed every later month's number out of step with its name — September became the 9th month while still being *named* “7th.” **Julius** and **Augustus** had nothing to do with that shift: they simply got two already-existing months — *Quintilis* and *Sextilis*, literally “5th” and “6th” — **renamed** in their honor after the fact. The names stuck; the months themselves were never new.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the twelve — “enero, febrero, marzo, abril, mayo, junio, julio, agosto, septiembre, octubre, noviembre, diciembre”
- the tie-back — “marzo / martes — both Mars, the war-god”
- “septiembre = 7, diciembre = 10” — the old March-start year

Before you move on

Which god links *marzo* and *martes*? (**Mars**, the war-god — his month and his day.) Why is *diciembre* Latin for “ten”? (**The Roman year began in March**, and adding January/February at the front later pushed every month's number out of step with its name.) Did Julius Caesar and Augustus **add** new months to the calendar? (**No** — *julio* and *agosto* were already-existing months, *Quintilis* and *Sextilis* (“5th”/“6th”), simply **renamed** in their honor.)

Chapter 111

Noon and Midnight

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can say that it is noon or midnight in Spanish and break both words into their two living halves.

Say es mediodía and es medianoche, split each into medio/media plus día/noche, and set them against French’s worn-down midi and minuit.

111.1 mediodía, medianoche — noon and midnight, spelled out in full

Two hours that don’t get a number — they get a name. And Spanish keeps that name far more transparent than its French cousin does.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Spanish	← Latin	literally
mediodía	<i>medius diēs</i>	“ mid-day ” (<i>medio</i> “middle” + <i>día</i> “day”)
medianoche	<i>media nox</i>	“ mid-night ” (<i>media</i> “middle” + <i>noche</i> “night”)

Both halves are **fully alive, ordinary Spanish words on their own: medio/media** (“middle” — cousin of English *medium*, *mid*, *mid-*

dle) and **día/noche** (“day/night,” words you already know). Compare French, which took the same Latin phrase down a bumpier road: *minuit*’s second half, **-nuit**, is still the plain, everyday French word for “night” — just as recognizable as Spanish’s *noche*. But *midi*’s second half, **-di**, wore down into an opaque fragment: the ordinary French word for “day” is *jour*, not *di* — that piece survives only as a fossil, tucked inside weekday names like *lundi* and *mardi*. So the erosion split unevenly: French kept “night” transparent and lost “day,” while Spanish kept both.

They don’t need *horas* the way a normal Spanish time (*son las tres*) never does either — they simply stand in for the hour on their own:

Es mediodía. — “It is noon.” **Es medianoche.** — “It is midnight.”

(Fun aside: English **noon** comes from Latin *nōna hōra*, “the **ninth** hour” — originally mid-afternoon, it drifted earlier over the centuries to mean midday. Spanish kept the tidier, transparent “mid-day” instead.)

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “mediodía” (noon), “medianoche” (midnight)
- break them — “medio + día”, “media + noche” — both halves still ordinary words
- “Es mediodía. Es medianoche.” — they stand in for the hour
- the contrast — French kept “night” (*nuit*) but wore “day” down to a fossil (*-di*)

Before you move on

What do *mediodía* and *medianoche* literally mean, and from what Latin? (“Mid-day” ← *medius diēs*; “mid-night” ← *media nox*.) Are both halves still recognizable, ordinary Spanish words? (**Yes** — *medio/ media* “middle,” *día/noche* “day/night.”) Did French erode its phrase evenly? (**No** — French’s *-nuit* stayed just as transparent as Spanish’s *noche*, but its *-di* wore down to an opaque fossil, since

the everyday French word for “day” is actually *jour*.) How do you say “it is noon”? (*Es mediodía*.)

Chapter 112

Telling Time

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🖱️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can tell the time in Spanish and choose correctly between *es la una* and *son las dos*.

Say es la una, son las dos, son las diez, and explain why one o'clock takes a singular verb while every other hour takes a plural one.

112.1 la hora — Spanish's barely-changed Latin hour

You've now seen this Latin word take three different paths: French wore it down to *heure*, German borrowed it centuries later as *Uhr*. Spanish's path is the simplest of all — it barely changed.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

hora ← Latin **hōra** ← Greek **hōrā**, “a season, a time of day” (the Greek goddesses of the seasons were the *Hōrai*). Spanish kept the word almost exactly as Latin had it — just a silent **h** in spelling, a fossil of a Latin *h* that was already weak and barely pronounced by the time Spanish inherited the word (the same non-story as French *heure* or English *hour*'s silent *h*). Be careful not to confuse this with *hijo* and *hacer*'s silent *h* — those come from a completely different, later Spanish sound change (Latin **f-** → Old Spanish aspirated *h-* → eventual silence), not from an already-weak Latin *h* the way *hora*'s is. Two different roads to the

same “silent letter” result. Compare its cousins: French wore *hōra* down further to *heure*; German didn’t inherit the word at all, but borrowed it later as *Uhr*; English took the same Latin *hōra* and made *hour*.

language	word	what happened
Spanish	hora	inherited almost unchanged, just a silent <i>h</i>
French	heure	inherited, but worn down further
German	Uhr	not inherited — borrowed later, separately
English	hour	inherited via French, silent <i>h</i>

Grammar Lens: Son las and telling time

Spanish uses **ser** (“to be”) plus the **feminine plural article** (agreeing with the unspoken *horas*) to tell time — and famously switches number for “one”:

Es la una. — “It is one o’clock.” (singular — *la una*, “the one”) **Son las dos.** — “It is two o’clock.” (plural — *las dos*, “the two”) **Son las diez.** — “It is ten o’clock.”

Literally “**it is the one**” / “**they are the two/ten**” — the hour count itself is implied by the article and number, without needing to say *hora(s)* at all in everyday speech (unlike French’s *il est deux heures*, which spells out “hours” every time).

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “hora” — silent *h*, a fossil of an already-weak Latin *h*
- “Es la una. Son las dos. Son las diez.”
- “hora / heure / hour” — one Latin root, three different fates

Before you move on

What Latin (and Greek) word is *hora* from? (*hōra* ← Greek *hōrā*.) How did Spanish's path differ from French's and German's? (**Spanish** inherited it almost unchanged; **French** wore it down further to *heure*; **German** didn't inherit it at all and borrowed *Uhr* separately, much later.) How do you say "it is one o'clock" vs. "it is two o'clock"? (*Es la una* — singular; *Son las dos* — plural.)

Chapter 113

The Weather

Modes: 🗣️ voice (3) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 3 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can talk about the weather in Spanish and know why llueve refuses to join hace.

Ask about el tiempo, answer hace calor, hace frío, hace sol, then switch to llueve — a verb of its own, whose ll- is the same sound change that gave llamar.

113.1 el tiempo — one word doing two jobs

Ask a Spanish speaker *¿qué tiempo hace?* and you are literally asking “**what time does it make?**” — because *tiempo* does not split “time” from “weather” the way English does.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el tiempo = both “**time**” and “**weather**” — from Latin **tempus**, which already carried this same double sense. Nothing was merged in Spanish; the two meanings simply arrived together and stayed.

English inherited the word too, through borrowing, but kept **only the time half**: **temporal**, **contemporary**, **tempo**, **temporary**. So the double meaning is not a Spanish oddity — it is the older state of affairs, and English is the one that narrowed.

How does a Spanish speaker know which is meant? **Context alone**, and it is never ambiguous in practice: *no tengo tiempo* is “I have no time,” *¿qué tiempo hace?* is “what’s the weather like?”

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “el tiempo” — time, or weather, depending on context
- “¿qué tiempo hace?” — what’s the weather like?
- “tiempo” then English “tempo, temporal” — the *tempus* family

Before you move on

What two things does **el tiempo** mean? (**Time** and **weather**.) Which Latin word gives it, and did it already mean both? (**Tempus** — yes, both.) Which language narrowed the meaning, Spanish or English? (**English** — it kept only “time.”) Next: how to actually answer *¿qué tiempo hace?*

113.2 hace calor, hace frío, hace sol — the weather Spanish *makes*

You can ask *¿qué tiempo hace?* Now answer it. Three of Spanish’s commonest weather answers all take the same verb you already know — *hacer*, “to make.”

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

- **calor** ← Latin **calor**, “heat, warmth” → English **calorie**, **caloric**, **cauldron**.
- **frío** ← Latin **frigidus**, “cold” (the middle syllable syncopated away) → English **frigid**, **refrigerate**.
- **sol** ← Latin **sol**, “sun,” unchanged → English **solar**, **solstice**, **parasol**.

Here is the part worth noticing: all three are **nouns**, not adjectives. *Calor* is “heat,” not “hot.” That is exactly why Spanish reaches for **hacer**: you cannot *be* a noun, but the world can **make** one.

hace calor — “it’s hot,” literally “**it makes heat**” **hace frío** — “it’s cold,” literally “**it makes cold**” **hace sol** — “it’s sunny,” literally “**it makes sun**”

French does the same thing with the same logic (*il fait chaud*); English is the outlier, forcing weather into “it **is** hot” with an adjective.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “hace calor. hace frío. hace sol.”
- the literal reading — “it makes heat, it makes cold, it makes sun”
- “calor” then English “calorie”; “frío” then “refrigerate”

Before you move on

Say “it’s hot,” “it’s cold,” “it’s sunny.” (*Hace calor, hace frío, hace sol.*) Why does Spanish use *hacer* rather than a “to be” verb? (Because *calor*, *frío* and *sol* are **nouns** — the weather **makes** heat, it does not *be* hot.) Give an English cousin of *frío*. (**Frigid, refrigerate.**)

113.3 llueve — the one weather word that will not join *hacer*

Hace calor, hace frío, hace sol — three answers, one pattern. Now try rain, and the pattern breaks. Rain does not get made in Spanish; rain has a verb of its own.

Grammar Lens: rain brings its own verb

llueve = “it’s raining.” Not *hace lluvia*, not “it makes rain” — just **llueve**, a single word that is a complete sentence.

It comes from **llover**, “to rain,” and *llover* is **impersonal**: it has no subject at all, not even a “it” you could point to. Compare the two shapes side by side:

pattern	example	what carries the weather
hacer + noun	<i>hace calor</i>	the noun (<i>calor</i> , heat)
dedicated verb	<i>llueve</i>	the verb itself

English does exactly the same split, which makes it easy to feel: you say “it **is** hot” with an adjective, but “it **rains**” with a verb built for the job. Spanish just draws the line in the same place.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

llover ← Latin **pluere**, “to rain.” Recognise that **pl-** → **ll-** shift? It is the **same regular sound change** that gave you **llamar** (← *clamāre*), **llave** (← *clāvem*, “key”) and **llama** (← *flamma*, “flame”). Latin’s *cl-*, *fl-* and *pl-* clusters all became Spanish *ll-*.

So *llueve* is not an exception you have to memorise twice: it is a predictable descendant of *pluere* (the same root English keeps in **pluvial** and the **pluviometer**, a rain gauge), and it is the one weather word with enough of its own life to refuse the *hacer* frame.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “¿qué tiempo hace?” then “hace calor. hace frío. hace sol.”
- “llueve” — one word, a whole sentence, no *hacer*
- the family — “llamar, llave, llama, llover” — four Latin clusters, one Spanish *ll-*

Before you move on

Which weather word does **not** use *hacer*, and why? (**Llueve** — rain has its own impersonal verb, *llover*.) What Latin word is *llover* from? (**Pluere**.) What sound change turned its *pl-* into *ll-*, and what other words show it? (Latin *cl-/fl-/pl-* → Spanish *ll-* — *llamar*, *llave*, *llama*.) And what does *el tiempo* mean? (**Time** and **weather**, from *tempus*.)

Chapter 114

Numbers Eleven to Twenty

Modes: ⇄ voice (4) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 4 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can count from eleven to twenty in Spanish and say where the fused Latin teens stop and the ten-and-X ones begin.

Run once to quince as fused Latin compounds, then dieciséis to diecinueve as a ten-and-X template, say why Latin's own subtractive 18 and 19 did not survive, and close on veinte.

114.1 once — quince: five words with a seam you can no longer see

Spanish counts past ten in **two completely different ways**, and the join between them is a real boundary in the language, not a place someone drew a line. Today: the first five, which you simply have to learn as words.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Spanish	← Latin
once	<i>undecim</i> (“one-ten”)
doce	<i>duodecim</i> (“two-ten”)
trece	<i>tredecim</i> (“three-ten”)
catorce	<i>quattuordecim</i> (“four-ten”)
quince	<i>quindecim</i> (“five-ten”)

Every one of these *was* a compound — a number plus **-decim** (“ten,”

the same root as *diez*). But these five are the numbers people say most often, and heavy use wears words smooth. Centuries of everyday speech fused each pair into a single, **opaque** word: no Spanish speaker hears “one-ten” in *once* any more than an English speaker hears “two-ten” in *twelve*.

Listen for the ghost, though. The **-ce** ending on *doce*, *trece*, *catorce*, *quince* is all that survives of Latin’s *-decim*. It is the same “ten” you already say in **diez**, ground down to two letters.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “once, doce, trece, catorce, quince”
- just the endings — “-ce, -ce, -ce, -ce” — the worn-down *ten*

Before you move on

Count eleven to fifteen. (*Once, doce, trece, catorce, quince*.) What are these five, structurally? (**Fused Latin compounds** — number plus *-decim*, “ten.”) Which piece of each word is the old “ten”? (The **-ce** ending — *diez* worn down.) Next: the numbers where the seam is still wide open.

114.2 dieciséis — diecinueve: where the seam reopens

You just learned five numbers whose insides had been ground smooth. Now say **fifteen** and then **sixteen** — *quince*, *dieciséis* — and hear the language change gear. From here you are not memorising words; you are following a rule.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Spanish	literally
dieciséis	<i>diez y seis</i> , “ten and six”
diecisiete	<i>diez y siete</i> , “ten and seven”
dieciocho	<i>diez y ocho</i> , “ten and eight”
diecinueve	<i>diez y nueve</i> , “ten and nine”

No fusion. You can hear **diez** plainly at the front of every one, and the number you already know sitting right behind it.

Grammar Lens: a formula, not a list

This is the structural difference that makes 15/16 a real boundary in Spanish rather than a convenient place to pause:

	11-15	16-19
how you get the word	remember it	build it
the “ten” inside	worn to <i>-ce</i>	still spelled <i>dieci-</i>
can you hear the parts?	no	yes

So *once* through *quince* are **vocabulary**, and *dieciséis* through *diecinueve* are **grammar**: one template, *dieci-* + *digit*, filled four times. Learn the template once and all four are already yours.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “dieciséis, diecisiete, dieciocho, diecinueve”
- the seam out loud — “diez y seis” then “dieciséis”
- the boundary — “quince” (remembered), “dieciséis” (built)

Before you move on

Count sixteen to nineteen. (*Dieciséis, diecisiete, dieciocho, diecinueve*.) Are these fused or transparent? (**Transparent** — plain “ten and X.”) Which of the two groups do you have to memorise, and which can you generate? (**Memorise 11-15; generate 16-19** from *dieci-* plus the digit.)

114.3 duodēvigintī — the quirk Spanish threw away

Dieciocho and *diecinueve* look like the least interesting words in the chapter — just two more ten-and-X compounds. They are actually the most interesting, because of what Latin said instead.

What to know first

- *dieciséis* — *diecinueve* — the *dieci-* plus digit template.

Why it's said this way

You would expect *dieciocho* and *diecinueve* to carry on whatever Latin did for 18 and 19. Latin did something else entirely. Its everyday words for those two numbers were **subtractive** — counted *down* from twenty:

number	Latin	literally
18	duodēvigintī	“two from twenty”
19	ūndēvigintī	“one from twenty”

(You still meet this habit in English clock-talk: “ten **to** four.”)

Spanish did not inherit either word. It built *dieciocho* and *diecinueve* fresh, on exactly the same simple template as 16 and 17 — quietly **regularising away** an irregularity that existed in its own parent language. Languages are usually described as wearing down and getting messier; here is a clean case of one tidying up.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- Latin's way — “two from twenty” — then Spanish's — “dieciocho”
- “dieciocho, diecinueve” — addition, not subtraction

Before you move on

How did Latin say 18 and 19? (**Subtractively** — *duodēvigintī*, “two from twenty,” and *ūndēvigintī*, “one from twenty.”) Did Spanish keep that? (**No** — it built *dieciocho* and *diecinueve* on the regular ten-and-X template.) So which language is the irregular one here? (**Latin** —

Spanish simplified.)

114.4 veinte — the number the teens were counting toward

Latin's own 18 and 19 were counted *down from twenty*. So it is worth meeting twenty itself — the number the whole run has been aiming at.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

veinte (“twenty”) ← Latin **vīgintī**. It was worn down by ordinary sound change — the *g* softened away, the vowels shifted — but notice what did **not** happen to it: it was never **fused** out of two separate words the way *once* through *quince* were. *Vīgintī* was already a single word for a single round number, so there is no seam inside *veinte* to look for. Three different histories, then, in one short chapter:

words	what happened
<i>once</i> - <i>quince</i>	two words fused into one
<i>dieciséis</i> - <i>diecinueve</i>	two words built into one, seam visible
<i>veinte</i>	one word, simply worn

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “once, doce, trece, catorce, quince” — the five fused Latins
- “dieciséis, diecisiete, dieciocho, diecinueve” — built, not fused
- “veinte” — twenty, worn but never fused

Before you move on

Count eleven to twenty. Where is the boundary between remembering and building, and why is it there? (**After** *quince* — 11-15 are fused Latin compounds, 16-19 are *dieci-* plus a digit.) Did Spanish inherit Latin's subtractive 18 and 19? (**No** — it regularised them.) Was

veinte fused from two words? (**No** — Latin *vīgintī* was already one word; it was only worn down.)

Chapter 115

Dog and Cat

Modes: 🗣️ voice (2) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 2 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name a dog and a cat in Spanish and say which of the two words still has no agreed origin.

Say gato and perro, trace cattus back toward Egypt, then admit that perro — which pushed out the older can — has no settled etymology at all.

115.1 gato — the word that travelled with the animal

Some etymologies can be followed all the way home. This one runs from your mouth back to ancient Egypt, and every step of it is documented.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

gato (“**cat**”) ← Latin **cattus**. But *cattus* was **not** Classical Latin’s word for cat. That was **fēlēs**, which survives today only in the scientific name *Felis catus* and in English **feline**.

Cattus entered Latin **later**, arriving with the animal itself as domestic cats spread along **Roman trade routes** from where they were domesticated — **Egypt**, around 2000 BCE. The word is most likely **Afro-Asiatic** in origin (compare Nubian **kadis**, “cat”).

So word and creature travelled together, out of Africa into Europe, and the newcomer pushed *fēlēs* out almost everywhere: Spanish *gato*, Italian *gatto*, French *chat*, Old Irish *cat*, Welsh *cath*, English *cat*. When a thing

arrives from abroad, its name usually arrives with it.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “el gato” — the cat
- the trail — “kadis, cattus, gato”
- the word it replaced — “fēlēs,” now only in “feline”

Before you move on

What was Classical Latin’s actual word for cat, and where does it survive? (**Fēlēs** — in *Felis catus* and English *feline*.) Where did *cattus* most likely come from? (An **Afro-Asiatic** word, travelling with the domesticated cat out of **Egypt**.) Next: the other animal in this chapter, whose history nobody can trace at all.

115.2 perro — the word nobody can explain

Gato could be traced all the way to Egypt. **Perro** is the opposite kind of word, and it is worth knowing that such words exist: completely ordinary, used a thousand times a day, and **nobody knows where it came from**.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

perro (“dog”). Roll the *rr*: *PEH-rrro*.

The word Spanish **should** have inherited is **canis** — the same root as English **canine**, French *chien*, Italian *cane*. And it did survive, as the now-archaic Spanish **can** (still readable in old poetry and in *canino*). But at some point *perro* pushed *can* almost entirely out of everyday use — and *perro* itself has no agreed origin.

Why it’s said this way

Three serious proposals, none confirmed:

proposal	the case for it	the problem
onomatopoeia — a growl, or a shepherd's call " <i>perr, perr</i> "	matches how herding calls become names elsewhere	no early written evidence
pre-Roman Iberian substrate	the <i>-rro</i> ending is a known marker of likely pre-Latin words in Spanish	the substrate languages are barely recorded
Persian <i>persus</i> , a hunting-dog breed	such breeds did spread in the late Empire	the sound match is loose

Notice what makes this a **good** open question rather than a shrug: each proposal predicts different evidence, and the evidence needed simply has not survived. *Perro* remains one of Spanish's genuinely unsolved puzzles, and a useful reminder that "we don't know" is a real answer in etymology, not a gap in your notes.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "el perro, el gato" — dog and cat
- "can" — the archaic word *perro* replaced, from Latin *canis*
- the contrast — "gato, traced to Egypt; perro, unsolved"

Before you move on

What archaic Spanish word did *perro* replace, and what is its Latin source? (**Can**, from **canis** — the root of English *canine*.) Does *perro* have a confirmed etymology? (**No** — onomatopoeic, pre-Latin substrate and Persian proposals all remain unconfirmed.) And *gato*'s origin, by contrast? (**Traceable** — Latin *cattus*, probably Afro-Asiatic, travelling out of Egypt.)

Chapter 116

Green and Yellow

Modes: 🗣️ voice (2) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 2 lessons.

***By the end of this chapter:** I can name green and yellow in Spanish and explain why amarillo is built on the word for bitter.*

Say verde and amarillo, tie verde to virēre, to flourish, and amarillo to amarellus, a little bitter — the same root as everyday amargo.

116.1 verde — the colour named after being alive

After *azul*'s long journey from Afghanistan, here is a colour that stayed exactly where it started. It is also the one that names a **process** rather than a thing.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

verde (“**green**”) ← Latin **viridis** (worn down through *virdis*), which comes from the verb **virēre**, “**to be green, to flourish, to be vigorous.**”

So the adjective is built on a **verb of thriving**. Latin did not name the colour of leaves; it named what leaves are *doing*, and let the colour follow. The same root gives *vigour* its neighbours in English: **verdant**, **verdure**, and the green-tinged **verdigris** (“green of Greece”).

One careful non-connection: **verde is not a cousin of English green**. *Green* comes from a completely separate **Germanic** root, tied to *grow* and *grass* — which, funnily enough, is the same idea arrived at independently. Two families, two words, one metaphor: green is the colour of things that are growing.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “verde” — green
- the root — “virēre, to flourish” → “verde”
- “verde” then English “verdant” — and *not* “green”

Before you move on

What Latin verb gives **verde**, and what does it mean? (**Virēre**, “to be green, to flourish.”) Is *verde* related to English *green*? (**No** — *green* is Germanic, from the same family as *grow* and *grass*; the two languages reached the same metaphor separately.) Next: a colour that is not named after a colour at all.

116.2 amarillo — the colour that started as a taste

Verde was exactly what you would expect from Latin. This one is not. Latin had three perfectly good words for yellow, and Spanish took none of them.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

amarillo (“**yellow**”) does **not** trace to *flāvus*, *gilvus* or *lūteus* — Latin’s actual yellow words. It comes from Late Latin **amarellus**, “**a little bitter**,” a diminutive of **amarus**, “**bitter**.”

A colour named after a **taste**. The bridge is medicine: yellow was the colour of **bile** and of **jaundice** (which Spanish still calls *ictericia*, but which folk speech long tied to bitterness), and of a great many bitter-tasting plants. A word meaning “somewhat bitter” came to mean “the yellowish look of a bitter thing,” then simply “yellowish,” and by Spanish’s Golden Age it had dropped the taste entirely and kept only the colour.

You can still check the family in a living word: **amargo** (“bitter”) is *amarillo*’s cousin, straight from the same *amarus*. Say them together and the shared *amar-* is right there.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “verde, amarillo” — green and yellow
- “amarillo, amargo” — hear the shared *amar-*
- the path — “a little bitter” → “yellowish” → “yellow”

Before you move on

Does **amarillo** come from a Latin word for yellow? (**No** — from *amarellus*, “a little bitter,” a diminutive of *amarus*.) What everyday Spanish word is its cousin? (**Amargo**, “bitter.”) And *verde*? (From **virēre**, “to flourish” — a colour named after being alive, as this one is named after a taste.)

Chapter 117

Synthesis — Saying Something About Your Own Life

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can describe things around me with the nouns and colours I hold, choosing un rather than el.

Fourteen chapters of nouns and colours, combined for the first time - and the article that makes it possible.

117.1 Synthesis — saying something about your own life

Nothing new in this chapter. Say the words for *dog* and for *black*.

What you've built

Something has been accumulating quietly for fourteen chapters and has never once been put to work.

You have six colours. Parents and brothers and sisters. A head and a hand. Water, wine and bread. The seasons, the months, the hours. Hot weather and cold. Numbers to twenty. A dog and a cat.

That is not a vocabulary list any more. It is **enough to describe the room you are sitting in**, and this chapter is the first that asks you to.

Grammar Lens: the word that made this possible

Notice which article you need here, because it is not the one you have used most.

el perro — *the* dog. A particular one. The one we were talking about. **un perro** — *a* dog. Any dog. One you are mentioning for the first time.

Describing your own life means introducing things your listener does not know about yet — and that is exactly the job **un** does. Almost every sentence below needs it.

The exchange

— ¿Tienes **un** perro? — Sí, **tengo un perro negro**. ¿Y tú?
— **Tengo un gato blanco**.

Every word in those three lines is one you built yourself, across fourteen chapters that never asked you to combine them. Nothing here is new. What is new is that it is a **conversation** rather than a list.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the exchange above, both parts
- it again about a real animal you know, with a real colour

Twice through: Until you are describing rather than translating.

Before you move on

Which article introduces something your listener does not yet know about? (**Un**.) And which points at something you have both already mentioned? (**El**.) Say one true sentence about an animal, with its colour.

Chapter 118

Pensar — Thinking Is Weighing

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can say what I think, and break pensar’s stem the way a stem-changer requires.

Run pensar through the $e \rightarrow ie$ boot, and find the scales still inside pensive and peso.

118.1 pensar — “to think”, and it started out meaning “to weigh”

You can already run an *-ar* verb: *hablo, hablas, habla*. Here is one that takes those same endings and then cracks its stem in the middle, the way *querer* did.

Sounds you’ll need

- diphthong-*ie* — under stress the *e* breaks open: **pienso** = *PYEN-so*.
- The *s* is always a clear hissing *s*, never an English *z* buzz.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

pensar (“to think”) ← Latin **pēnsāre**, “to weigh” — the repeating form of *pendere*, “to hang, to weigh out”. A Roman hung goods on a balance; the same verb slid across to weighing an idea. English kept the whole family, and most of it still smells of money and

scales:

- **pensive** — turning something over on the balance.
- **compensate** — *com-* “together” + weigh: settle one weight against another.
- **expense, dispense, pension** — payments were literally *weighed out*.
- **peso** — a coin whose name simply means “a weight”.
- **pansy** — from French *pensée*, “a thought”.

English reaches for the same picture without noticing it: you *weigh your options*, and an argument *carries weight*.

Grammar Lens: the same endings, a broken stem

The endings are the ordinary *-ar* set. Only the stressed *e* changes:

person	form	stem
yo	pienso	broken
tú	piensas	broken
él/ella/usted	piensa	broken
nosotros	pensamos	plain
ellos/ustedes	piensan	broken

Pensamos keeps the plain *e* because there the stress lands on the ending, not the stem — exactly the rule *querer* taught you.

Two small habits come with the verb: *pensar* **en** something means “think about” it (*pienso en ti*), and *pensar* followed by a bare infinitive means “plan to” (*pienso hablar* — I mean to speak).

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “pensar” then the set — “pienso, piensas, piensa, pensamos, piensan”
- “Pienso en ti” — I am thinking of you
- “pensar” then English “pensive, compensate, peso” — the weighing family

Before you move on

What did *pēnsāre* mean literally, and name two English cousins. (**To weigh**; *pensive*, *compensate*, *expense*, *peso*.) Which form keeps the plain *e*, and why? (*Pensamos* — the stress falls on the ending.) Which little word follows *pensar* for “think about”? (**En.**) Next: **entender**, which cracks the same way.

Chapter 119

Entender — Understanding Is Stretching Toward

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🗋️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can say what I understand, and see the verb inside the *no entiendo* I have used since chapter 14.

The second e→ie stem-changer, and the moment a chapter-14 formula turns out to have parts.

119.1 entender — “to understand”, built out of stretching

Pensar broke its stem under stress. So does this one — and you have already been using it. **No entiendo** has been in your mouth since the repair kit, where you learned it as one frozen block. This is the verb it came from.

Sounds you’ll need

- diphthong-**ie** — **entiendo** = *en-TYEN-do*.
- **d-soft** — the *d* between vowels is soft, close to the *th* of English *this*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

entender (“to understand”) ← Latin **intendere**: **in-** (“toward”) + **tendere** (“to stretch”). Understanding something was *stretching your*

attention toward it — leaning in.
tendere stretches right across English:

- **intend, intent, intense, intention** — the very same *in-* + stretch.
- **attend, attention** — *ad-* “toward”, stretch that way.
- **extend, contend, pretend, tension, tendon, and tent**, which is stretched cloth.

So *entiendo* and *I intend* are the same two Latin pieces landing in different places: Spanish went to “I grasp it”, English to “I mean to”.

Careful with a false friend. Spanish **pretender** is *not* English *pretend*. It means “to aim at, to be after” — *pretende ser médico*, “he means to become a doctor”. Same pieces, different landing.

Grammar Lens: an -er verb that cracks, and a calmer twin

Ordinary -er endings, stressed *e* broken to *ie*:

person	form	stem
yo	entiendo	broken
tú	entiendes	broken
nosotros	entendemos	plain
ellos/ustedes	entienden	broken

Spanish has a second verb for this job: **comprender** ← Latin *comprehendere*, “to seize together” (→ English **comprehend, apprehend, comprehensive**). It is a plain -er verb with no crack at all: *comprendo, comprendes, comprende*. Both mean “understand”. *Entender* is the everyday one; *comprender* leans a little more formal, and more toward grasping a whole thing than catching a word.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “No entiendo” — I don’t understand
- “entiendo, entiendes, entendemos, entienden”

- “pienso” then “entiendo” — the same crack, twice
- “entender” then English “intend, intense, attention” — the stretching family

Before you move on

What does *tendere* mean, and what does *in-* add? (**To stretch**; “to-ward”.) Give the *yo* and *nosotros* forms. (*Entiendo, entendemos.*) Of *entender* and *comprender*, which one breaks its stem? (**Entender.**) And what does Spanish *pretender* mean? (**To aim at**, not to pretend.) Next: **leer**.

Chapter 120

Leer — Reading Is Gathering

Modes: ⇄ voice (1) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can say what I read, with a verb whose stem does not break.

legere, the root that gathers: collect, select, elect, and intellect.

120.1 leer — “to read”, and before that, “to gather”

Two cracked verbs down. Here is a calm one — nothing breaks in the middle. The only difficulty is in your mouth: two *e*’s in a row that must stay two.

Sounds you’ll need

- hiatus-ee — **leer** is two syllables, *le-ER*, never one long English *ee*.
- **leo** is likewise two beats, *LE-o*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

leer (“to read”) ← Latin **legere**, “to gather, to pick out, to choose” — and only afterwards “to read”. A reader picks letters out of a row the way a farmhand picks olives off a branch.

That gathering root runs through an enormous amount of English:

- **legible**, **legend** (“things to be read”), **lecture**, **lectern**, and

worn right down, **lesson**.

- built with prefixes: **collect** (*col-* “together”), **select** (*se-* “apart”), **elect** (*e-* “out”), **intellect** (*inter-* “between” — choosing between things).
- **diligent** and **elegant**, both of which meant “picking carefully”.

One honest limit: Greek *légein* (“to speak, to gather”) — which gives English *logic*, *dialogue*, *catalogue* — is a **cousin** of *legere* from the same ancient root, not its parent. Same family, separate journeys.

Grammar Lens: a plain -er verb, with a mouthful

Nothing irregular happens. Drop *-er*, add the ordinary endings:

person	form	said
yo	leo	LE-o
tú	lees	LE-es
él/ella/usted	lee	LE-e
nosotros	leemos	le-E-mos
ellos/ustedes	leen	LE-en

Every one of those is a syllable longer than an English speaker expects. Give each *e* its own beat and the word comes out right.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “leer” — *le-ER*, two beats
- “Leo un libro” — I read a book
- “No entiendo” then “Leo, pero no entiendo” — I read, but I don’t understand
- “leer” then English “legible, collect, select, elect”

Before you move on

What did *legere* mean before it meant “to read”? (**To gather, to pick out.**) Give two English words built on it with a prefix. (*Collect,*

select, elect, intellect.) How many syllables in *leo*? (**Two** — *LE-o.*)
Next: **escribir**, the other half of literacy.

Chapter 121

Escribir — Writing Is Scratching

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🖱️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can say what I write, and explain the propped-up e- in front of it.

scribere, to scratch, and Spanish refusing to begin a word with sc-.

121.1 escribir — “to write”, which once meant “to scratch”

Leer gathers letters off a page. This is the other half of the same skill — and its root remembers a time when writing was done with a sharp point in wax.

Sounds you’ll need

- **st-no-e** — Spanish will not begin a word with *sc-*, *sp-*, *st-*, so it props one up with an **e-**: *es-crí-BIR*.
- **b-soft** — between vowels the *b* is soft, lips barely touching.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

escribir (“to write”) ← Latin **scribere**, whose first sense was “to scratch, to incise”. Writing was cutting a line into wax or stone before it was ever ink on paper.

The English family is huge, and every member still works with a pen:

- **scribe, scribble, script, scripture.**

- **describe** (*de-* “down”) and **description**; **prescribe** (*prae-* “before”) and **prescription**; **subscribe** (*sub-* “under” — you signed at the bottom); **inscription**; **transcript**; **postscript**.
- **manuscript** — *manus* “hand” + *scriptum*: written by hand.
- **conscription** — being *written into* an army.

The Spanish past participle is **escrito** (“written”), which is English **script** wearing different clothes.

Grammar Lens: an -ir verb, and a productive spelling rule

Escribir is a plain -ir verb, the family *vivir* opened:

person	form	ending
yo	escribo	-o
tú	escribes	-es
él/ella/usted	escribe	-e
nosotros	escribimos	-imos
ellos/ustedes	escriben	-en

That propped-up **e-** is a rule you can run yourself, not a quirk of one word: Latin *schola* became **escuela**, *spatha* became **espada** (sword), *stāre* became **estar**, *Hispania* became **España**. It is also why a Spanish speaker learning English says *eh-Spain*.

Now you can state a plan out loud: *Pienso escribir* — “I mean to write.”

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “escribo, escribes, escribe, escribimos, escriben”
- “Leo y escribo español” — I read and write Spanish
- “Pienso escribir” — I mean to write
- “escribir” then English “scribe, describe, manuscript” — the scratching family

Before you move on

What did *scribere* mean first? (**To scratch, to incise.**) Why does Spanish say *escuela* and *España*? (It refuses to open a word with *sc-* or *sp-*, so it props an **e-** in front.) Say “I read and write Spanish”. (*Leo y escribo español.*) And what does *legere* mean, from the lesson before? (**To gather, to pick out.**) Next chapter: taking, asking, helping — and a verb that runs backwards.

Chapter 122

Review — Four Verbs of the Mind

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🗋️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can hold all four mind-verbs at once and name the physical act inside each one.

Four abstractions, four labourers: weighing, stretching, gathering, scratching.

122.1 Review — four verbs of the mind

Nothing new in this chapter. Name the four verbs of the last four chapters: to think, to understand, to read, to write.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Here is the thing none of the four chapters could show you on its own. Every one of these four “mental” verbs began as something you do with your **body**:

- **pensar** — Latin *pēnsāre*, to **weigh**. Thinking is putting things on a balance. English kept the scales in *weigh your options*, and in *pensive*.
- **entender** — Latin *intendere*, to **stretch toward**. Understanding is reaching. English kept the reach in *attention*.
- **leer** — Latin *legere*, to **gather, pick out**. Reading is picking grain from a field. English kept the gathering in *collect, select, elect*.

- **escribir** — Latin *scribere*, to **scratch**. Writing is scratching a surface, which is exactly what it was.

Four abstractions, four labourers. No language invents a word for thinking; it borrows one from the hands and lets the meaning drift indoors.

And a hidden joint. *Intellect* is Latin *inter* + *legere* — “to gather **between**.” The root of **leer** is sitting inside the English word for the mind itself.

What you’ve built

Four verbs, and with them the four things you do with a language: take it in (*leer*), work on it (*pensar*), get it (*entender*), put it back out (*escribir*).

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the four verbs in order — to read, to think, to understand, to write
- for each one, the body word underneath it

Twice through:

Before you move on

What did *entender* physically mean? (**To stretch toward.**) What do all four have in common? (Each was a **body** word before it was a mind word.) Next chapter you will use them to say something you actually think.

Chapter 123

Synthesis — What You Understand, and What You Don't

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can report which part of what I heard landed and which did not, instead of only signalling that I am lost.

The chapter-14 distress signal becomes a sentence with moving parts.

123.1 Synthesis — what you understand, and what you don't

Say the sentence you learned in the repair kit, the one that rescues a conversation. (*No entiendo.*)

Grammar Lens: the formula was a verb all along

You have been saying **no entiendo** since the repair kit, and until four chapters ago it was a single frozen block — two sounds that meant *I'm lost*, with no moving parts.

It has parts now. **Entiendo** is *entender*, and *entender* is Latin *intendere*, “to stretch toward.” Which means the sentence you have been using to admit defeat has never actually said *I failed*. It says:

I am not managing to stretch that far.

That was true the whole time. You just could not see it yet.

And the moment a formula has parts, it turns. *No entiendo* stops being the only thing you can say and becomes one option among several.

The exchange

Back in the repair kit, all you could do:

— No entiendo. Más despacio, por favor.

Now, the same moment, with the parts working:

— Perdón — **leo** un poco, pero **no entiendo**. — Más despacio, por favor. **Ahora entiendo**. Gracias.

Same trouble. But the second speaker is no longer only failing — they are reporting **which** part works and which does not. That is the difference between a distress signal and a conversation.

What you've built

Four verbs is not four words. It is the ability to say **where** you are in a language: what you take in, what you work on, what lands, what you can produce.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the repair-kit version — the distress signal on its own
- the version above, where you say what *does* work before what doesn't

Twice through: Run the second one until it sounds like a person, not a repair kit.

Before you move on

Which verb was hiding inside *no entiendo*? (*Entender*.) What did it physically mean? (**To stretch toward**.) What can you say now that you could not say back then? (Not just that you are lost — **which part** is lost.)

Chapter 124

Tomar — Taking, and a Word With No Past

Modes: 🔄 voice (1) 🔄 Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can say what I take, and explain why this everyday verb has no agreed origin.

tomar, the honest gap — and coger, the verb Latin actually left.

124.1 tomar — “to take”, and nobody knows where it came from

Every verb so far ran straight back to a Latin root you could name. Here is one that does not — and the gap is the useful part.

Sounds you’ll need

- r-tap — one soft tap of the tongue: *to-MAR*.
- vowel-o — a short, pure *o*, with no English glide toward *ow*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

tomar (“to take”) is a plain *-ar* verb: **tomo**, **tomas**, **toma**, **tomamos**, **toman**. It is one of the most common verbs in the language, and its origin is **genuinely unsettled**.

The leading proposal derives it from Latin *autumāre*, “to take as, to

assert”, worn down through an intermediate *tumar*; a rival one points to a pre-Roman Iberian word Latin never recorded. Neither is proved, and careful dictionaries say so. “We don’t know” is a real answer in etymology.

It carries a second everyday sense across Latin America: **to drink**. A waiter asking *¿Qué vas a tomar?* is asking what you would like.

Why it’s said this way

Latin’s own “gather up” verb survived perfectly well: **coger** ← **col-ligere**, which is *com-* (“together”) + *legere* — the very root you met in *leer*. English took that same Latin word twice: **collect** straight from the Latin, and **coil** by way of French.

In Spain *coger* is the plain everyday word: *coger el autobús*, catch the bus. In much of Latin America — Argentina, Mexico and well beyond — it is **coarse slang for sex**, and using it innocently will derail a conversation. *Tomar* is safe on both sides of the Atlantic, which is a large part of why it won.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “tomo, tomas, toma, tomamos, toman”
- “Tomo un café” — I’ll have a coffee
- “Tomo el autobús” — the safe way to say it anywhere
- “coger” then English “collect, coil” — one root, and one place to be careful

Before you move on

Does *tomar* have a confirmed etymology? (**No** — *autumāre* and a pre-Roman source are both unproved.) What Latin verb gives *coger*, and which root sits inside it? (*Colligere*, holding *legere*, “to gather”, from *leer*.) Why reach for *tomar* instead? (*Coger* is coarse slang across much of Latin America.) Next: **preguntar**, and the two different asks.

Chapter 125

Preguntar — Asking, and Sounding a Depth

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🖱️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can ask a question with *preguntar*, and choose it over *pedir*.

percontari, to sound a depth with a pole; and why English's one ask becomes two Spanish verbs.

125.1 *preguntar* — “to ask”, by sounding the water with a pole

English gets by with one verb, *ask*. Spanish splits the job in two, and picking the wrong half is a reliable beginner mistake. Here is the first half.

Sounds you'll need

- **pr-cluster** — *pre-* is one crisp beat, *preh*, with a tapped *r*.
- **g-hard** — the *g* before *u* is hard, as in English *gun*: *pre-goon-TAR*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

preguntar (“to ask a question”) ← Vulgar Latin **praecunctāre**, itself a reshaping of classical **percontārī**, “to inquire”. And *percontārī* was built on **contus**, “a punting pole”: to *percontor* was to push a

pole down through water and find out how deep it was.

Asking is taking a sounding. Unlike almost every other word here, *preguntar* left English nothing — the pole word died out — yet English rebuilt the same metaphor on its own: you *sound someone out*, you *probe*.

The verb is a plain *-ar* one: **pregunto, preguntas, pregunta, preguntamos, preguntan**. Its noun is **la pregunta** (fem.), and note that Spanish *makes* a question rather than asking one: *hacer una pregunta*.

Grammar Lens: one English “ask”, two Spanish verbs

Spanish sorts asking by **what you are after**:

what you want	verb	example
information	preguntar	<i>Te pregunto la hora</i> — I’m asking you the time
a thing or a favour	pedir	<i>Pido un café</i> — I’m asking for a coffee

Ask for a coffee with *preguntar* and you have said “I question a coffee”. The line is simple: a question takes *preguntar*, a request takes *pedir*. **pedir** ← Latin **petere**, “to make for, to aim at” — and *that* root stocked English generously: **petition, appetite, compete, impetus, perpetual, centripetal**. It cracks a third way, *e* → *i*: **pido, pides, pide, pedimos, piden**. Recognise *pido* for now; the pattern gets its own lesson later.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “pregunto, preguntas, pregunta, preguntamos, preguntan”
- “Te pregunto la hora” — I’m asking you the time
- “Pido un café” then “Tomo un café” — I ask for one, I have one
- “pedir” then English “petition, appetite, compete” — the aiming family

Before you move on

What did *percontārī* picture literally? (**Sounding water with a pole.**) Which verb asks for a coffee, and which asks the time? (*Pedir* for the coffee; *preguntar* for the time.) What Latin root is *pedir* from, and one English cousin? (*Petere*, “to aim at” — *petition*, *appetite*, *compete*.) Next: **ayudar**, which is the same word as English *aid*.

Chapter 126

Ayudar — the Same Word as Aid

Modes: ⇄ voice (1) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can say that I help, and hear English aid inside the Spanish word.

adiutare straight through to aid, and the -di- that also gave hodie -> hoy.

126.1 ayudar — “to help”, and it is English “aid” in disguise

You can ask a question now. The next thing to ask for is a hand — and this verb is one you already own in English without knowing it.

Sounds you’ll need

- vowel-a — a clean, open *a*: *a-yoo-DAR*.
- r-tap — one tap at the end, not an English *r*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

ayudar (“to help”) ← Latin **adiūtāre**, the repeating form of **adiuvāre**: **ad-** (“toward”) + **iuvāre** (“to help, to delight”). To help was to move toward someone.

English borrowed that identical verb through Old French *aidier* and calls it **aid**. So *ayudar* and *aid* are not merely cousins — they are the **same**

word by two different roads. The family came with it:

- **aide**, and **aide-de-camp**, an officer who helps.
- **adjutant** — the officer whose whole job is assisting.
- **adjuvant** — a substance that helps another drug work.
- **coadjutor** — one who helps alongside.

The shape change is a rule, not an accident. Latin **-di-** before a vowel turned into Spanish **y**: *adiūtāre* → **ayudar**, *hodiē* → **hoy** (“today”), *podium* → *poyo*. Once you have that, the word stops looking arbitrary.

Grammar Lens: a plain -ar verb, and how to ask for a hand

Nothing breaks; the endings are the ones you started with:

person	form	meaning
yo	ayudo	I help
tú	ayudas	you help
nosotros	ayudamos	we help
ellos/ustedes	ayudan	they help

Its noun is **la ayuda** (fem.), “help” — the word on relief packages worldwide. Two sentences worth owning: *¿Me ayudas?* (“will you help me?” — Spanish uses the plain present where English needs *will*) and, politely, *¿Puedo ayudarle?*

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “ayudo, ayudas, ayudamos, ayudan”
- “¿Me ayudas?” — will you help me?
- “Te pregunto” then “Me ayudas” — I ask you, you help me
- “ayudar” then English “aid, adjutant, adjuvant” — one word, two roads

Before you move on

What two Latin pieces build *adiuvāre*? (**Ad-** “toward” + **iuvāre** “to help”.) What everyday English word is *ayudar*, arriving by French? (**Aid.**) What sound-law turned *adiūtāre* into *ayudar*, and which other word shows it? (Latin **-di-** became Spanish **y**; *hodiē* → *hoy*.) Next: **gustar**, the verb that runs backwards.

Chapter 127

Review — Three Verbs That Behave

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can use all three verbs and say what they have in common: the sentence is about the one doing it.

Three origins - tidy, reshaped, and genuinely unknown - and the shared shape about to be broken.

127.1 Review — three verbs that behave

Nothing new here. Name the three verbs of the last three chapters: to take, to ask, to help.

What you've built

All three work the way you expect, and it is worth naming that out loud **before** the next chapter, where one does not.

In each of them, **you** are the one doing it. You take. You ask. You help. The person doing the verb is the person the sentence is about — exactly as in English, and exactly as in every verb you have met since *hablo*.

Hold on to that. It is about to be worth money.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Three origins, three very different kinds of story:

- **ayudar** is the tidy one. Latin *adiūtāre* → English **aid**. Same word, two roads, and you can still hear it.
- **preguntar** is the reshaped one — *percontārī*, to sound a depth with a pole. Asking as measuring how deep something goes.
- **tomar** is the honest gap. It has **no agreed origin at all**. The verb Latin actually handed down for “take” was *coger*, and *coger* turned coarse across much of Latin America — so an everyday word had to come from somewhere, and nobody is sure where.

Not every word has a clean story. A course that pretended otherwise would be inventing them.

Your turn

- *Say it*: the three verbs, then one sentence with each

Twice through:

Before you move on

Which one has no settled origin? (*Tomar*.) In all three, who is the sentence about? (**The one doing it.**) Next chapter: a verb where that stops being true.

Chapter 128

Gustar — the Verb Built the Other Way Round

Modes: 🔄 voice (1) 🔄 Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can build a gustar sentence the way Spanish builds it, with the thing liked as the subject.

me gusta el libro is the book pleasing me, so the verb agrees with the book.

128.1 gustar — the verb that runs backwards

Back in the introductions you learned **mucho gusto** — “much pleasure”. Here is the verb that noun belongs to, assembled the opposite way round from English. It is the single thing in Spanish that trips English speakers up hardest.

Sounds you’ll need

- **g-hard** — a hard *g* before *u*: *goos-TAR*.
- **s-clear** — a clean hissing *s*, never a *z* buzz.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

gustar ← Latin **gustāre**, “**to taste**”. English kept the root and stayed close to the tongue:

- **gusto** — doing something with relish, that is, with a taste for it.

- **gustatory** — of the sense of taste.
- **disgust** — *dis-* “away” + taste: what you spit back out.
- **degustation**, a tasting menu; and through French, **ragout**.

Spanish’s own **el gusto** — the *gusto* of *mucho gusto* — still holds both senses: taste on the tongue, and pleasure taken in a thing. The verb followed the second: *gustar* means “**to please**”.

Grammar Lens: the thing you like is the subject

English says **I** like the book: the liker is the subject. Spanish has no such sentence. It says **Me gusta el libro** — “the book is pleasing **to me**”.

Everything follows from that:

- *el libro* is the **subject**, which is why the verb is *gusta*, third person.
- *me* is the person it happens **to**, not the one doing anything.

So the verb agrees with the **thing**, never with you:

what you mean	Spanish	why
I like the book	Me gusta el libro	one book, so <i>gusta</i>
I like books	Me gustan los libros	many books, so <i>gustan</i>
I like reading	Me gusta leer	one action, so <i>gusta</i>

To change who is pleased, change the little word in front, not the verb: **me** (to me), **te** (to you), **le** (to him, her, *usted*), **nos** (to us), **les** (to them).

Careful. There is no *yo gusto el libro*. *Yo gusto* is a real sentence — it means “**I** am pleasing” — just not the one you were reaching for.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “Me gusta el café” then “Me gustan los libros” — the verb follows

the thing

- “Te gusta tomar café” — you like drinking coffee
- “Me gusta ayudar” — I like helping
- “gustar” then English “gusto, disgust, gustatory” — the tasting family

Before you move on

In *me gusta el libro*, what is the subject? (**El libro.**) Why is it *me gustan los libros*? (The verb agrees with *los libros*, which is plural.) What did *gustāre* mean, and name an English cousin. (**To taste; gusto, disgust.**) And what would *yo gusto* actually mean? (**I am pleasing.**)

Chapter 129

Synthesis — What You Like, and Who Does the Liking

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can say what I like without translating I like word by word, and hear mucho gusto as the same word.

*Liking started at the tongue; and the chapter-5 phrase turns out to be *gustar*'s noun.*

129.1 Synthesis — what you like, and who is doing the liking

Say “I like coffee” in Spanish. Then answer this: in that sentence, which word is the **subject**?

Grammar Lens: the sentence that will not let you be the subject

Me gusta el café. The coffee is the subject. The coffee does the pleasing. You are the one it happens *to*.

English puts you in charge: *I like coffee* — I am the subject, the coffee just sits there. Spanish reverses it.

Two chapters ago, all three verbs were about **the one doing it**. That is why this chapter had to sit next to them.

Translate *I like* word by word and you build a sentence Spanish does

not have — which is why this is a chapter about saying an idea, not a word.

The exchange

— ¿Te gusta el café? — Sí, **me gusta** mucho. ¿Y a ti? — A mí también. **Mucho gusto.**

That last line is a joke you can now get. *Mucho gusto* — the phrase you learned long ago for “pleased to meet you” — is the **same word**. It has always meant *much pleasure*. You have been saying *gustar*’s noun since your third conversation in this book.

What you’ve built

Gustar is Latin *gustāre*, **to taste** — English *gusto*, *disgust*. Liking, in Spanish, started at the tongue.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the exchange above, both parts
- it again, and as you say *me gusta*, notice that you are **not** the subject

Twice through: Until *me gusta* arrives without translating *I like* first.

Before you move on

Who is the subject of *me gusta el café*? (**El café.**) What did *gustar* mean first? (**To taste.**) And what has *mucho gusto* meant all along? (**Much pleasure** — the same word.)

Chapter 130

Hearing, Sleeping, Walking, Running

Modes: 🗣️ voice (4) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 4 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can say I hear, sleep, walk and run in Spanish, write *oír*’s *y* where the spelling demands it, and break *dormir*’s *o* to *ue* the way a boot verb does.

Run the chapter’s four verbs together and sort them by what they do to their stems: correr, caminar and andar leave theirs alone, dormir breaks o to ue, oír grows a g in oigo and writes y in oyes. Then name each verb’s source in turn — audire, dormire, Gaulish camminus, currere — and set the two words with no settled origin, andar and perro, against them.

130.1 *oír* — “to hear”, and the *y* that appears from nowhere

Say *Me gusta el café* once — the coffee is pleasing to me, and the coffee is the subject. Now a verb about the ears, and one of the most bent-out-of-shape words in the language.

Sounds you’ll need

- **accent-i** — the accent on *í* keeps the vowels apart: *o-EER*, two beats.
- **y-glide** — the *y* in *oyes* is the consonant of English *yes*: *O-yes*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

oír (“to hear”) ← Latin **audīre**, “to hear”. Spanish wore it right down: the *d* between vowels dropped away and *au-* collapsed to *o-*.

English never inherited it but borrowed it repeatedly, and the family keeps the *aud-* Spanish threw away: **audio**, **audible**, **audition**, **auditorium**, **audit**, **audience** — the people doing the hearing.

Then the surprise. **Obey** is Latin **oboedīre**, *ob-* (“toward”) + *audīre*: obeying is literally **listening toward** someone. **Obedient** comes with it.

Why it’s said this way

Spanish splits what English leaves joined. **Oír** is what your ears do whether you meant it or not. **Escuchar** is on purpose.

Escuchar has its own root: Latin **auscultāre**, “to listen to”, built on *auris*, “ear”. A doctor **auscultates** a chest; and when Old French wore *auscultāre* down to *escouter*, English borrowed it as **scout** — one sent out to listen. English can draw the line when it wants. Spanish makes you.

Grammar Lens: the -go yo-form, and a spelling rule

person	form
yo	oigo
tú	oyes
él/ella/usted	oye
nosotros	oímos
ellos/ustedes	oyen

Two separate things. The *yo*-form grows the hard **-g-** you know from *tengo*, *hago* and *digo*; *oír* joins that club.

The rest is **spelling**, not sound. Spanish will not write an unstressed **i** stranded between two vowels, so *oi-es* is impossible and the letter becomes **y**: *oyes*, *oye*, *oyen*. *Oímos* keeps its accent because there the *i* is stressed.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “oigo, oyes, oye, oímos, oyen”

- “¿Me oyes?” — can you hear me?
- “Me gusta oír” — hearing is pleasing to me
- “oír” then English “audio, audience, obey”

Before you move on

Which Latin verb is behind *oír*, and what has *obey* to do with it? (**Audīre**; *oboedīre* is “to listen toward”.) Why *oyes* and not *oies*? (Spanish will not leave an unstressed *i* between two vowels.) Which of *oír* and *escuchar* do you choose to do? (**Escuchar**.) And in *me gusta el café*, what is the subject? (**El café**.)

130.2 dormir — “to sleep”, and the boot’s other vowel

Run *oír* once more: *oigo*, *oyes*, *oye*, *oímos*, *oyen* — and remember that the *y* in *oyes* is a spelling rule, not a new sound. Now a verb whose stem cracks the way *pensar*’s did, but on a different vowel.

Sounds you’ll need

- **diphthong-ue** — under stress the *o* breaks open: **duermo** = *DWER-mo*.
- **r-tap** — one soft flick of the tongue in *dormir*, nothing like an English *r*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

dormir (“to sleep”) ← Latin **dormīre**, “to sleep” — one of the rare verbs Spanish inherited almost untouched. English took the root only through French and Latin, and every borrowing still points at a bed:

- **dormitory**, and its clipped **dorm** — the room where sleeping is done.
- **dormant** — from the French participle *dormant*, “sleeping”. A dormant volcano is a sleeping one.
- **dormer** — the window let into a roof, named for the

sleeping-loft behind it.

Spanish keeps its own branch: **el dormitorio** for the bedroom, and *la bella durmiente* for Sleeping Beauty.

The **dormouse** looks like the obvious member of this family, and careful dictionaries will not commit. An Anglo-Norman *dormeus*, “sleepy”, is the best guess, but the trail goes cold. Treat it as likely rather than proved.

Grammar Lens: the boot again, with o→ue

person	form	stem
yo	duermo	broken
tú	duermes	broken
él/ella/usted	duerme	broken
nosotros	dormimos	plain
ellos/ustedes	duermen	broken

Pensar broke **e→ie** under stress. *Dormir* breaks **o→ue** under exactly the same condition, and for exactly the same reason: the stress falls on the stem in four of these forms and on the ending in *dormimos*, so only *dormimos* keeps its plain *o*.

That is the whole of the rule. Spanish has two stressed vowels that will not sit still — *e* becomes *ie*, *o* becomes *ue* — and once you can hear where the stress lands, you can predict which forms crack without memorising a list.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “duermo, duermes, duerme, dormimos, duermen”
- “pienso” then “duermo” — *e* to *ie*, *o* to *ue*, one rule
- “No duermo bien” — I don’t sleep well
- “dormir” then English “dormitory, dormant, dormer” — the sleeping family

Before you move on

Which form of *dormir* keeps its plain *o*, and why? (*Dormimos* — the stress lands on the ending.) Name two English cousins of *dormire*. (*Dormitory*, *dormant*, *dormer*.) What did *pēnsāre*, behind *pensar*, mean literally? (**To weigh.**) And what is the *yo*-form of *oír*? (**Oigo.**)

130.3 caminar — “to walk”, from a word Rome borrowed from the Celts

Duermo, *duermes*, *duerme* — the *o* cracking to *ue*. Relax: the two verbs here do nothing of the kind. The interest is in where they came from.

Sounds you’ll need

- **k-hard** — the *c* before *a* is a hard *k*: *ka-mi-NAR*.
- **vowel-a** — a short clean *a*, the same in every syllable.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

caminar (“to walk”) was built on the noun **el camino**, “the road” — and *camino* is not a Latin word at all. Latin **camminus** was a loan from **Gaulish**, the Celtic language of pre-Roman France, from a word for a step or a way. It stocked the roads of every Romance language: *camino*, Portuguese *caminho*, Italian *cammino*, French *chemin*. Here the cousin web runs out, and that is worth saying plainly: this root reached English only inside borrowed French phrases. The Celtic layer did reach English by other doors — Latin also took Gaulish *carrus*, a wagon, behind **car** and **cargo**. *Camminus* never crossed.

A false friend that looks certain. Latin also had **camīnus**, “hearth”, from Greek *kaminos* — and *that* gave English **chimney**. Two nearly identical Latin words, no relation.

Grammar Lens: two plain verbs, and which to reach for

Spanish has a second everyday verb here, **andar**. Both take ordinary *-ar* endings and neither breaks its stem.

person	caminar	andar
yo	camino	ando
tú	caminas	andas
él/ella/usted	camina	anda
nosotros	caminamos	andamos
ellos/ustedes	caminan	andan

Caminar is walking as the thing you are doing. **Andar** is wider: to go about, and by extension to work at all — *no anda*, of a machine, means “it isn’t running”. Either serves for a walk.

Why it’s said this way

Camino has a clean history. *Andar* does not. It comes down from Medieval Latin **andāre**, and where *andāre* came from is **genuinely disputed**: *ambulāre* (“to walk about”) and *ambitāre* (“to go around”) are both proposed and neither is proved. If *ambulāre* is right, **amble** and **ambulance** are cousins — but that “if” carries real weight.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “camino, caminas, camina, caminamos, caminan”
- “ando, andas, anda, andamos, andan”
- “Camino una hora” — I walk for an hour
- “el camino” then “camino” — the road, and I walk it

Before you move on

Which language did Latin borrow *camminus* from? (**Gaulish**.) Which English word comes from the *other* Latin *camīnus*, the hearth? (**Chimney** — unrelated.) Is *andar*’s origin settled? (**No**.) Say “I walk for an hour”. (*Camino una hora*.) And the *nosotros* form of *dormir*? (*Dormimos*.)

130.4 correr — “to run”, and the root that runs through half of English

You can walk two ways now — *camino* and *ando*. Speed it up. This last verb of the chapter is the plainest to conjugate and the richest to trace.

Sounds you’ll need

- **rolled-rr** — the double *r* is a full trill: *ko-RRER*. It is a different letter from a single *r*, and swapping them swaps words.
- **vowel-o** — a short pure *o*, no glide toward English *ow*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

correr (“to run”) ← Latin **currere**, “to run”. English borrowed this root harder than almost any other, and the descendants have spread so far from running that they no longer look related:

- **current** — water that runs; **currency**, money running hand to hand.
- **curriculum** — a *running*, a racecourse. A course of study is a track you run.
- **courier**, a runner; **course**, **cursor**, **cursive** — writing that runs.
- **corridor** — a place for running along, by way of Italian.
- with prefixes: **occur** (*ob-*, to run up against), **recur**, **incur**, **precursor**, **excursion**.

And a cousin from the lesson before: Gaulish *carrus*, behind English **car** and **cargo**, comes from the very same Proto-Indo-European root **kers-**, “to run”. Latin took one road and Celtic another; English holds both ends.

Grammar Lens: a plain -er verb, and four verbs together

Correr breaks nothing and grows nothing: **corro**, **corres**, **corre**, **corremos**, **corren**. That makes it the clean case the chapter’s others stand out against:

verb	what it does to its stem
correr	nothing — <i>corro, corres, corre</i>
caminar, andar	nothing — <i>camino, ando</i>
dormir	breaks <i>o</i> to <i>ue</i> under stress — <i>duermo</i> , but <i>dormimos</i>
oír	grows <i>-g-</i> in <i>oigo</i> , and writes <i>y</i> in <i>oyes, oye, oyen</i>
Only two of the four misbehave, and each misbehaves by a rule you can state.	

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “corro, corres, corre, corremos, corren”
- “El perro corre” — the dog runs
- “Camino, no corro” — I walk, I don’t run
- “Corro el sábado” — I run on Saturday; Spanish uses the bare article where English says *on*
- “Oigo, duermo, camino, corro” — the whole chapter in four words
- “correr” then English “current, curriculum, corridor” — the running family

Before you move on

Name each verb’s source in turn: *oír*, *dormir*, *caminar*, *correr*. (**Audīre**; **dormīre**; Gaulish *camminus*, by way of *el camino*; **currere**.) Which of the four leave their stems alone? (*Caminar*, *andar* and *correr*.) Say “the dog runs”. (*El perro corre*.) Two words here have no settled origin — which? (*Andar*, and *perro*, whose three proposals all lack the evidence to decide between them.) And which English everyday word is a cousin of *correr* through Celtic? (**Car**.)

Chapter 131

Opening, Closing, Sitting Down, Standing Up

Modes: 🗣️ voice (4) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 4 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can say I open, close, sit down and stand up in Spanish, and use the reflexive pronoun that makes *sentarse* and *levantarse* land the action back on me.

Say the chapter in one breath — abro el libro, me siento, cierro el libro, me levanto — then separate the two features it taught: sentarse is reflexive and a stem-changer, levantarse is reflexive only. Name the shared recipe behind both body-position verbs (a Latin present participle, sedēns and levāns), pick abierto out as the one irregular participle, and reach back to la mano for why the article stays feminine.

131.1 abrir — “to open”, and the one part of it that misbehaves

Say *corro* and *camino* once — two verbs that gave you no trouble. This one is nearly as easy, and its one misbehaving piece is a word you will read on a shop door before you ever say it.

Sounds you’ll need

- **b-soft** — between vowels the *b* barely closes the lips: *a-BREER*.
- **r-tap** — a single flick for the final *r*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

abrir (“to open”) ← Latin **aperīre**, “to open, to uncover”. The *p* softened to *b* between vowels on the way into Spanish — the slide that turned *sapere* into *saber* and *lupus* into *lobo*.

English took the root through two doors and does not notice they are one word:

- straight from Latin *apertūra*: **aperture**, the opening a lens makes.
- through French *ouvrir* and its participle *ouvert*: **overt** (“out in the open”) and **overture**, an opera’s opening.
- **aperitif**, a drink that *opens* the appetite; Spanish, **el aperitivo**.

The cousin that is not one. *April* looks like it belongs here — the opening month. That is old folk etymology and is not accepted: the better proposals point at an Etruscan *Apru*, borrowed from Aphrodite, or at an Italic word meaning “the next one”. A hook this pretty is the kind to check.

Grammar Lens: regular everywhere but the participle

In the present, *abrir* is a plain *-ir* verb, the family *escribir* belongs to: **abro, abres, abre, abrimos, abren**. Nothing breaks, nothing grows. The **past participle** is where the irregularity lives. A regular *-ir* verb would give *abrido*. Spanish says **abierto**, straight down from Latin *apertum*, keeping the *e* that broke to *ie* under stress long ago.

You will meet that participle long before the tense it belongs to, because it is a word on doors: **ABIERTO** on the sign, **está abierto** for “it is open now”. *Escribir* does the same with **escrito**. Both refuse the regular ending because both inherited a Latin participle whole.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “abro, abres, abre, abrimos, abren”
- “Abro el libro” then “Está abierto”
- “abrir” then English “aperture, overt, overture”

- “correr” then English “current, curriculum” — still there from before

Before you move on

What is the past participle of *abrir*, and what would a regular verb have given? (**Abierto**; *abrido*.) Name two English words from *aperire*. (*Aperture, overt, overture, aperitif*.) Is *April* one? (**No** — folk etymology.) Which other verb keeps an inherited Latin participle? (*Escribir* → *escrito*.) And which Latin verb is behind *correr*? (**Currere**.)

131.2 cerrar — “to close”, from the bar across the door

Abro, abres, abre — and the sign saying **ABIERTO**. Here is the sign on the other side of the day, and a verb that cracks its stem.

Sounds you’ll need

- **soft-c** — *c* before *e* is soft: a *th* across most of Spain, an *s* across Latin America.
- **rolled-rr** — the double *r* is fully trilled: *se-RRAR*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

cerrar (“to close”) ← Late Latin **serāre**, “to bolt, to fasten”, from the noun **sera**: the **bar you drop across a door**. Closing here is a physical object being put in place, not an abstraction.

Its Romance siblings kept the pressure: Italian *serrare*, French *serrer*, “to squeeze, to tighten”. English holds one of that branch, **serried**, as in ranks pressed shut against each other. Reference works generally connect *sera* to Latin **serere**, “to join in a row”, which would make **series** and **insert** distant relatives — usual, but not certain.

Why it’s said this way

Latin had a perfectly good verb for closing: **claudere**. English is full of it — **close, closet, closure, clause, cloister, include, exclude, conclude, recluse**.

Spanish let it go. For shutting a door it took *serāre* instead, and kept

claudere only in words scholars borrowed back much later: **incluir, excluir, concluir, clausura**. That inversion is worth sitting with: the bigger English family belongs to the verb Spanish gave up. A cousin web maps what each language kept, and these two kept opposite halves.

Grammar Lens: e→ie, and the sign on the door

person	form
yo	cierro
tú	cierras
él/ella/usted	cierra
nosotros	cerramos
ellos/ustedes	cierran

Dormir broke **o→ue**. *Cerrar* breaks **e→ie** — the same boot, the other vowel, the same trigger: stress on the stem. *Cerramos* is plain because there the stress moves to the ending.

Its participle, unlike *abierto*, is regular: **cerrado**. The two signs on one door are built differently — *abierto* inherited whole from Latin, *cerrado* made by rule.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “cierro, cierras, cierra, cerramos, cierran”
- “Abro el libro” then “Cierro el libro”
- “ABIERTO” then “CERRADO” — the two signs
- “aperire, aperture” then “serare, serried” — the two doors’ roots

Before you move on

What was a *sera*, and does *cerrar* come from *claudere*? (**The bar dropped across a door**; and **no** — Spanish kept *claudere* only in *incluir, excluir, concluir*.) Which form of *cerrar* keeps its plain *e*, and why? (*Cerramos* — the stress moves to the ending, as in *dormimos*.) Which participle is irregular, *abierto* or *cerrado*? (*Abierto*.) And what did *intendere*, behind *entender*, mean literally? (**To stretch**

toward.)

131.3 sentarse — “to seat oneself”, which is how Spanish thinks about sitting down

Two things in hand. *Cierro* — the *e* cracking to *ie*. And *me llamo*, “I call **myself**”, where the little *me* bounced the action back onto you. This verb needs both at once.

Sounds you’ll need

- **diphthong-*ie*** — the stressed *e* breaks: **me siento** = *me SYEN-to*.
- **s-clear** — a clean hissing *s*, never a *z* buzz.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

sentar ← Vulgar Latin *sedentāre*, built not on the Latin verb but on its **present participle**: *sedēns*, “sitting”, from *sedēre*, “to sit”. Spanish made a new verb out of being in a sitting state.

Sedēre is one of the great English suppliers, and hardly any descendant still looks like sitting: **sedentary**, **sediment**, **sedate**; **session** and **siege** (an army sitting down outside a city); **preside**, **reside**; **assess**, **obsess**, **possess**. By way of Greek *hedra*, “seat”, it also gives **cathedral** and **chair**.

Then the other branch. English **sit**, **seat**, **settle**, **saddle** and **nest** come down from the very same root, *sed-*, through Germanic rather than Latin. Neither borrowed from the other: they are siblings, exactly as *padre* and *father* are, each branch reshaping the sounds its own way.

Grammar Lens: seating someone, and seating yourself

Plain **sentar** means to seat somebody *else*. To sit down yourself, you send the action back with the pronoun that made *me llamo* “I call myself”:

person	form
yo	me siento
tú	te sientas
él/ella/usted	se sienta
nosotros	nos sentamos
ellos/ustedes	se sientan

Two patterns run at once, and you have both. The pronoun changes with the person — *me, te, se, nos, se* — and the stem breaks *e→ie* wherever the stress lands on it, leaving *nos sentamos* plain. The pronoun stands before a conjugated verb and clips onto an infinitive, hence the name **sentarse**.

Two verbs, one shape. *Me siento* is also the *yo*-form of *sentirse*, “to feel”: *me siento bien* is “I feel fine”. Only what follows tells them apart.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “me siento, te sientas, se sienta, nos sentamos, se sientan”
- “me llamo” then “me siento” — the same little me, twice
- “Cierro el libro y me siento” — I close the book and sit down
- “sentarse” then English “session, sedentary, preside”

Before you move on

What does *sentarse* say literally, and which Latin form was it built on? (**To seat oneself**; the participle *sedēns*.) Are English *sit* and Latin *sedēre* parent and child, or siblings? (**Siblings** — separate branches of one root, like *father* and *padre*.) Which form keeps its plain *e*, and what was a *sera*? (*Nos sentamos*; **the bar across a door**.)

131.4 levantarse — “to raise oneself”, and how Spanish says “stand”

Me siento put you in the chair, the little *me* bouncing the action back onto you. Now get out of it. The pronoun works the same way; this time the stem does not crack at all.

Sounds you’ll need

- **v-b** — Spanish *v* and *b* are one sound: *le-ban-TAR*.
- **nasal-n** — a clean *n* before the *t*, not swallowed.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

levantar ← Vulgar Latin *levantāre*, from *levāns*, the present participle of *levāre*, “to raise, to lighten” — itself from *levis*, “light, not heavy”. Notice the shape: a Latin **present participle**, made into a new verb — the identical recipe that gave *sentar* from *sedēns*. Spanish built both of its body-position verbs out of a word for the state rather than the act. *Levāre* is everywhere in English: **lever**, **elevate**, **elevator** for raising; **levity**, **levitate**, **alleviate**, **relieve** for lightening; **leaven**, what raises the bread, and **levy**, a tax *raised*. And **the Levant**, from French *levant*, “rising”: from western Europe it lay where the sun came up. English **light**, the opposite of heavy, is the Germanic cousin of *levis*, as *sit* is of *sedēre*.

Grammar Lens: raising a thing, raising yourself, standing still

Levantar on its own raises something else. **Levantarse** raises *you*:

Spanish	what it means
Levanto la mano	I raise my hand
Levanto la cabeza	I lift my head
Me levanto	I get up, I stand up

The endings are ordinary *-ar* throughout — **me levanto**, **te levantas**, **se levanta**, **nos levantamos**, **se levantan** — and nothing breaks. So the chapter has now shown its two features apart: *sentarse* is reflexive **and** a stem-changer; *levantarse* is reflexive **only**.

For standing as a *state*, Spanish uses no verb. It says **estar de pie** — “to be on foot”, *el pie* being the foot. English’s single “stand” splits in

two: *me levanto* for getting up, *estoy de pie* for being up.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “me levanto, te levantas, se levanta, nos levantamos, se levantan”
- “Levanto la mano” then “Levanto la cabeza” then “Me levanto”
- “Estoy de pie” — I am standing
- “Abro el libro, me siento, cierro el libro, me levanto”
- “levantar” then English “lever, elevate, Levant”

Before you move on

Say the chapter’s four verbs, then say how you are standing. (*Abro, cierro, me siento, me levanto; estoy de pie.*) What do *sentar* and *levantar* share in their making, and which also breaks its stem? (Both from a Latin **present participle**, *sedēns* and *levāns*; *sentarse* breaks *e→ie*.) Name the two roots on that door, and which participle is irregular. (**Aperīre** and **serāre** — *not claudere; abierto.*) Why *la* mano? (*Manus* was feminine in Latin.)

Chapter 132

Telling What Happened

Modes: 🗣️ voice (4) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 4 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can tell a short connected story about something that happened — ordering the events with *luego*, giving a reason with *porque*, and choosing the imperfect for the scene and the preterite for the events.

Tell a four-sentence story out loud: Llovía. Me levanté, luego bebí café. No corrí, porque llovía mucho. Me senté y leí. Every word in it has been taught in this book, and the two pasts divide the work between scene and event.

132.1 luego — a word you already have, doing a job you have not seen it do

Nothing new to learn here — you have said **luego** every time you said *hasta luego*. What is new is that it can stand alone, between two events, and put them in order.

Sounds you'll need

- diphthong-ue — *ue* is one glide, not two syllables.
- g-soft-gw — between vowels the *g* softens; **luego** is *LWEH-gho*, not the hard stop English puts in *go*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

You already know where it comes from: Latin **locō**, the ablative of **locus**, “place” — “in that place”, a word about *where* that slid into a word about *when*. That is why *hasta luego* is “until later”.

What you have not been shown is how much else *locus* is holding up. It gives **local**, **locate**, **location**, **locus**, **allocate**, **dislocate**. And through French *lieu*, “place”, it gives **lieutenant** — literally the officer *holding the place* of another.

A leftover worth knowing. *Desde luego* means “of course”. It was built on an older sense of *luego*, “**immediately**”, so its literal force was nearer “from this moment on”. The bare word has since drifted to “later”; the phrase kept the old sense.

Grammar Lens: luego between two events

Out of the farewell, *luego* is not glued to a verb. It marks the join between two events and sits at the front of the second:

Me siento. Luego leo.	I sit down. Then I read.
Bebo café y luego escribo.	I drink coffee and then I write.
Me levanto y luego corro.	I get up and then I run.

Two events, in order, with one word doing the ordering — and it is a word you have been saying since chapter five.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “hasta luego” then just “luego” — same word, standing alone
- “Me siento. Luego leo.”
- “Me levanto y luego corro.”
- “luego” then English “local, locate, lieutenant”

Before you move on

What job does *luego* do here that it does not do in *hasta luego*? (It **joins two events in order**, instead of sitting inside a fixed farewell.) Which English officer's title hides the same *locus*? (**Lieutenant** — the one holding another's place.) Which older sense of *luego* is frozen inside *desde luego*? (**Immediately** — not “later”.)

132.2 *porque* — “because”, and the reason a sequence turns into a story

With *luego* you can put two events in order. But order is not yet a story. *I sat down, then I read* tells nobody **why**. One more word closes that gap, and it is two words wearing a single coat.

Sounds you'll need

- **k-hard** — *qu* before *e* is a plain *k*; the *u* is silent. **porque** = *POR-keh*.
- **r-tap** — a single flick of the tongue, not the rolled *rr*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

porque = **por** + **que**, fused.

por descends from Latin *prō*, “for, in front of, on behalf of” — the same *prō* standing at the front of **provide**, **proceed**, **protect**, **propose**, and surviving whole in the English phrase *quid pro quo*.

que descends from Latin *quid*, “what” — and then quietly took over every job Latin had given *quod*, without taking its form.

And this is the good part. That Latin *qu-* is one branch of the Proto-Indo-European interrogative root **k^wo-*. The other branch went into Germanic, where **k^w-* softened to *hw-* — Grimm's Law turning a stop into a breath — and came out as English **who**, **what**, **when**, **where**, **why**.

So Spanish *que* and English *what* are not borrowed from one another. They are **siblings** — the same ancient question-word, walked down two different roads. *Quid pro quo* puts both Latin halves of *porque* side by side in an English sentence.

Grammar Lens: porque, por qué, el porqué

Three spellings, three jobs, and they are genuinely distinct in writing:

written	stress	job
porque	one word, no accent	because — gives the reason
por qué	two words, accent on <i>qué</i>	why — asks for the reason
el porqué	one word, accent, with <i>el</i>	the reason — a noun

¿**Por qué** te levantas? — **Why** do you get up? *Me levanto porque corro.* — I get up **because** I run. *No entiendo el porqué.* — I don't understand **the reason**.

The accent is not decoration. It marks *qué* as the questioning one, exactly as it does on other question words.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “porque” — *POR-keh*, silent *u*
- “Me siento porque leo.” — I sit down because I read.
- “Me levanto y luego corro, porque hace sol.”
- the three shapes — “porque, por qué, el porqué”

Before you move on

What two Latin words are fused inside *porque*? (*prō* and *quid*.) Are Spanish *que* and English *what* parent and child, or siblings? (**Siblings** — Latin *qu-* and Germanic *wh-* from one root, **kʷo-*.) Which of the three spellings asks a question? (*Por qué* — two words, accent on *qué*.)

132.3 llovía / llovió — the same rain, told two ways

You already have both past tenses. The imperfect — *hablaba*, *comía* — came in chapter sixteen, with its three irregulars. Noth-

ing here is a new form. What is new is **which one to reach for**, and that turns out to be the whole trick of telling a story.

Sounds you'll need

- double-l-y — *ll* is a *y* glide: **llovía** = *yo-VEE-a*.
- accent-i — the accent splits the vowels: *llo-VÍ-a*, three beats.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

The name is the lesson, and it is worth having.

Imperfecto is Latin *imperfectus*: *in-* (“not”) plus *perfectus*, “carried all the way through” — itself *per-* (“through”) plus *facere* (“to do, to make”). That *facere* is everywhere in English: **fact**, **factory**, **effect**, **manufacture**, and **perfect** itself, which still means *finished through*. So the imperfect is the **not-carried-through** tense. Not unfinished in quality — unfinished in *time*. It shows an action still running, with no edge on it. That is not a label bolted on afterwards; it is a description of the job.

Grammar Lens: the scene and the events

Take one fact — it rained — and watch the tense decide what *kind* of fact it is:

Llovía.	It was raining. (<i>no edge — the weather that day</i>)
Llovió.	It rained. (<i>edged — a thing that happened</i>)

Neither is more correct. They answer different questions. A told story needs both, in a division of labour that never varies:

The **imperfect paints the scene** — what was going on, what things were like. The **preterite drops the events into it** — what then happened.

Llovía. Luego me levanté. — It was raining (*scene*). Then I got up (*event*).

English has no separate form for this, which is the only reason it feels hard. English leans on *was -ing* and *used to* and lets context carry the rest. Spanish decided it once, in the ending.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the pair — “llovía” then “llovió”
- scene, then event — “Llovía. Luego me levanté.”
- “No corrí, porque llovía.” — the reason is a scene, the running an event
- “Comía pan porque llovía.”

Before you move on

What does *imperfectus* literally say, and which English word shares its second half? (**Not carried through; perfect** — and *fact, factory*.) In a story, which tense paints the background and which drops in the events? (**Imperfect** paints; **preterite** drops in.) Which of *llovía* and *llovió* has an edge on it? (**Llovió** — a thing that happened.)

132.4 contar — to tell a story, which is also to count it up

Three pieces are in your hands: *luego* to order events, *porque* to explain them, the imperfect to hold the background still. This lesson adds no fourth piece — it puts the three together, under the verb that names the act.

Sounds you’ll need

- diphthong-ue — the stem breaks under stress: **cuento** = *KWEN-to*, but **contamos** stays plain.
- k-hard — *c* before *o* is a hard *k*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

contar means **to count** — and **to tell a story**. One verb, both jobs, and not a pun.

It descends from Latin *computāre*, “to reckon up”: *com-* (“together”) plus *putāre*, which meant “to prune”, then “to settle an account”, then

simply “to reckon”. *Putāre* gives **amputate, dispute, deputy**; *computāre* gives **count, compute, account**.

English carries the same double sense — to **recount** an event, to give an **account** of yourself — but those are the very same word, borrowed through Old French from *computāre*. Spanish’s relatives, not an independent echo.

The independent echo is **tell**: Germanic, unrelated, and it *also* once meant “to count” — hence a bank **teller**, and *all told*. Two unrelated languages, one thought: **a story is a reckoning-up of events in order**.

Grammar Lens: the backbone of a told story

Contar breaks *o* to *ue* under stress:

person	form
yo	cuento
tú	cuentas
él/ella/usted	cuenta
nosotros	contamos
ellos/ustedes	cuentan

Here is the shape of a told story:

Llovía. Me **levanté**, luego **bebí** café. No **corrí**, **porque** **llovía** mucho. Me **senté** y **leí**.

>

It was raining. I got up, then I drank coffee. I didn’t run, because it was raining hard. I sat down and read.

Watch the two pasts divide the work. **Llovía** — imperfect, holding the scene still. **Me levanté, bebí, me senté, leí** — preterite, dropping events in. *Luego* orders them; *porque* explains one.

That is a narration, and every word in it is one this book has taught you.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “cuento, cuentas, cuenta, contamos, cuentan”
- “Cuento hasta cinco.” — I count to five. Same verb.
- the scene, then the event — “Llovía. Luego me levanté.”
- the whole thing — “Llovía. Me levanté, luego bebí café. No corrí, porque llovía mucho.”
- “contar” then English “count, account, recount, teller”

Before you move on

Contar does two jobs — which two, and what Latin verb explains both? (**Count** and **tell**; *computāre*, “to reckon up”.) Which English word carries the same double sense? (**Recount** — or *an account*; and *tell* itself, as in a bank *teller*.) In your story, which tense held the rain and which one poured the coffee? (**Imperfect** *llovía*; **preterite** *bebí*.) Name the two joining words you used. (*Luego* for order, *porque* for reason.)

Chapter 133

Traer — Bringing, and Latin for Dragging

Modes: 🔄 voice (1) 🔄 Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can say what I bring, and choose traer over llevar by where I am standing.

trahere, to drag - the root under tractor, attract and abstract.

133.1 traer — “to bring”, and the direction baked into it

Me levanto, and now *estoy de pie*. Up, and carrying something. The verb for that has a direction inside it that English leaves open.

Sounds you’ll need

- r-tap — one flick of the tongue: *tra-ER*, two beats.
- g-hard — the *g* of *traigo* is hard, as in English *go*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

traer (“to bring”) ← Latin **trahere**, “to drag, to pull”. Bringing started out as hauling.

Latin built a second stem, *tract-*, and English helped itself to both: **tractor**, **traction**, **attract**, **contract**, **subtract**, **extract**, **distract**,

retract — and **abstract**, *abs-* + *trahere*, something “dragged away” from anything particular.

Then the worn-down half, through French: **trace**, **train** (what is dragged along behind), **trail**, **portray** ← *prōtrahere*, “to draw forth”, and **retreat** ← *retrahere*, “to draw back”.

Grammar Lens: the hard g, for the second time

person	form
yo	traigo
tú	traes
él/ella/usted	trae
nosotros	traemos
ellos/ustedes	traen

Oír grew a hard **-g-** in *oigo* and nowhere else in its present. *Traer* does the identical thing: **traigo**, and then four ordinary *-er* endings. One club, two members so far, and neither one announces itself.

Why it's said this way

English lets one verb wander: *bring me the bread*, *bring it to the café* — same word, opposite journeys. Spanish will not.

Traer moves a thing **toward you**. **Llevar** moves it **away**. *Traigo el pan* is the bread arriving here; *llevo el pan* is the bread leaving with me. You choose by where you are standing, never by what you are carrying. And **llevar** ← Latin **levāre**, “to raise” — the verb already behind *levantarse*. To carry a load was first to lift it.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “traigo, traes, trae, traemos, traen”
- “Traigo el pan” then “Llevo el pan” — here, then away
- “oigo” then “traigo” — the same hard g
- “traer” then English “tractor, attract, abstract”

Before you move on

Which way does *traer* carry a thing, and which verb goes the other way? (**Toward you**; *llevar*.) What did *trahere* mean, and name two English words from it. (**To drag**; *tractor, attract, abstract, retreat*.) Which form of *traer* misbehaves, and which verb showed you that same misbehaviour first? (**Traigo**; *oigo*.) And say you are standing. (*Estoy de pie*.)

Chapter 134

Consequir — Getting Is Following Until You Have It

Modes: ⇄ voice (1) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can say what I get, and make the e-to-i stem change.

consequi, to follow after - the root of sequence and consequence.

134.1 consequir — “to get”, by following a thing until you have it

Traigo carries a thing that is already yours. *Coger* grabs what is in front of you. This verb is for the getting that took some work.

Sounds you’ll need

- **g-hard** — the *gu* in *consequir* is one hard *g*; the *u* is silent.
- **s-clear** — a clean hissing *s*: *con-se-GEER*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

consequir (“to get, to obtain, to manage to”) ← Latin **cōnsequī**: *com-* (“along with”) + **sequī**, “to follow”. You got a thing by following it until it was yours.

Sequī is one of Latin’s great English suppliers: **sequence**, **sequel**, **consequence**, **subsequent**, **consecutive**; **second**, from *secundus*, “the

one following”; **execute** and **prosecute**; **obsequious**, following someone about; and through French, **pursue**, **ensue** and **suit**.

Spanish also keeps the formal partner **obtener** ← *obtinēre*, “to hold onto” — English **obtain**. It behaves exactly like *tener*, so its *yo*-form is *obtengo*. *Conseguir* is the everyday one.

Grammar Lens: the third crack, and a silent u that leaves

person	form
yo	consigo
tú	consigues
él/ella/usted	consigue
nosotros	conseguimos
ellos/ustedes	consiguen

You have met *dormir* breaking **o**→**ue** and *pido* quietly breaking **e**→**i**. Here is that third pattern in full: stress on the stem turns *e* into *i*, and *conseguimos* stays plain because the stress moved to the ending.

Now the spelling. Spanish writes *gu* only to keep a *g* hard in front of *e* and *i*. Once the *e* becomes *i*, there is nothing in front to guard against, so the *u* has no job and goes: **consigo**, not *consiguo*. Two changes, one form, and only one of them is a sound.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “consigo, consigues, consigue, conseguimos, consiguen”
- “Traigo el café” then “Consigo el café” — carried, then obtained
- “sequi, sequence, second” then “conseguir”

Before you move on

What did *sequi* mean, and name two English words from it. (**To follow**; *sequence*, *second*, *consequence*, *pursue*.) Why is it *consigo* and not *consiguo*? (The *u* only guards a hard *g* before *e* and *i*.) Name the three stem cracks you now have, with a verb for each. (*Cerrar* **e**→**ie**, *dormir* **o**→**ue**, *conseguir* **e**→**i**.) And which Latin verb is behind *traer*? (**Trahere**.)

Chapter 135

Jugar — Playing Was Joking

Modes: ⇄ voice (1) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can say what I play, with the only u-to-ue verb in Spanish.

iocari, to joke - and Latin's own play-verb ludere left Spanish entirely.

135.1 jugar — “to play”, and the only verb of its kind

Consigo cracked its *e* to *i*. Here is a verb that cracks a vowel no other verb in Spanish cracks — and it started life as a joke.

Sounds you'll need

- j-jota — the *j* is scraped at the back of the throat: *khoo-GAR*.
- diphthong-ue — *juego* is three beats, *KHWE-go*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

jugar (“to play”) ← Latin **iocārī**, “to joke, to jest”, built on the noun **iocus**, “a joke”. Playing and joking were one word, and Spanish kept the joking one for both.

English holds *iocus* in several shapes: **joke**; through French **jocular**; **juggler**, from *ioculātor*, an entertainer; and **jeopardy**, from Old French *jeu parti*, “an evenly divided game” — a position so balanced that either side might lose. The Spanish family stays close: **el juego**, a game; **el**

juguete, a toy.

Why it's said this way

Latin's ordinary word for playing was **lūdere**, and Spanish dropped it exactly as it dropped *claudere* for shutting doors. English kept the whole family instead: **illusion**, **allude**, **elude**, **delude**, **collude**, **prelude**, **interlude**, **ludicrous**.

Claudere and *lūdere* tell one story: the large English family belongs to the Latin verb Spanish walked away from.

Grammar Lens: the fourth crack, with one member

person	form
yo	juego
tú	juegas
él/ella/usted	juega
nosotros	jugamos
ellos/ustedes	juegan

Dormir breaks **o→ue**. *Jugar* breaks **u→ue**, and it is the **only verb in Spanish that does**: the *o* of *iocārī* had already slid irregularly to *u*, so the crack landed on a vowel no other verb offers. *Jugamos* stays plain, because the stress moves to the ending.

One more habit: Spanish plays **at** a thing rather than simply playing it. *El fútbol* is football, and you say *juego al fútbol*, with *a + el* fused into *al*. With a companion rather than a game it is *con*: *juego con el perro*, I play with the dog.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “juego, juegas, juega, jugamos, juegan”
- “Juego con el perro”
- “duermo” then “juego” — o to ue, then u to ue
- “iocus, joke, jocular, juggler”

Before you move on

What did *iocārī* mean, and which English words carry it? (**To joke**; *joke, jocular, juggler, jeopardy*.) What is unusual about *juego* among Spanish verbs? (**U→ue**, and no other verb does it.) Which two Latin verbs did Spanish drop while English kept their families? (*Claudere* and *lūdere*.) And which vowel does *conseguir* break? (**E to i**.)

Chapter 136

Conocer — Coming to Know

Modes: ⇄ voice (1) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can say who and what I am acquainted with, and choose *conocer* over *saber*.

cognoscere, whose *-sc-* means *BEGIN to know*; English *know* is its Germanic sibling.

136.1 *conocer* — “to meet”, because knowing has a first moment

Juego — the one *u*→*ue* in the language. Now the chapter’s last verb, and its oddity is not in the vowel but in what the word means.

Sounds you’ll need

- **soft-c** — *conoces* has a soft second *c*: a *th* in Spain, an *s* elsewhere.
- **k-hard** — but *conozco* is *ko-NOTH-ko*, soft then hard, back to back.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

conocer ← Latin **cognōscere**, *com-* + *(g)nōscere*. Its *-sc-* is Latin’s “**begin to**” marker, so *nōscere* was never “to know” — it was “**to come to know**”. Latin said *nōvī*, “I have come to know”, for actually knowing a thing.

Spanish built its verb from the *beginning* half. That is the whole lesson: *conocer a alguien* is **to meet** someone, and Spanish puts a small **a** before a person who is the object — *conozco a María*.

The root fills English: **cognition**, **recognize**, **incognito**, and through French **notice**, **notion**, **notorious** and **noble**, “the knowable one”. English **know** and **ken** are its Germanic siblings — the same standing that *padre* has beside English *father*, neither one borrowed from the other.

Grammar Lens: conocer and saber

what you know	verb
a person, a city, a book	conocer
a fact, or how to do something	saber

English says *know* for both. Spanish will not: **conocer** is being **acquainted** — you have met the thing. **Saber** is having the information. *Conozco Madrid* means I have been there; *sé dónde está* means I have the fact.

The *yo*-form keeps a hard cluster the rest lost: **conozco**, **conoces**, **conoce**, **conocemos**, **conocen**. Every *-cer* verb after a vowel does the same, and it is a third kind of odd *yo*-form beside *traigo* and *oigo*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “conozco, conoces, conoce, conocemos, conocen”
- “Conozco a María” then “Conozco Madrid”
- “traigo, consigo, juego, conozco” — the chapter’s four *yo*-forms
- “padre, father” then “conocer, know” — siblings, not borrowings

Before you move on

Say the chapter’s four verbs in the *yo*, then say what each one does to itself. (*Traigo* grows a hard *g*; *consigo* breaks *e→i* and loses a silent *u*; *juego* breaks *u→ue*, alone in the language; *conozco* keeps a hard cluster.) Name their four Latin roots and what each meant. (**Trahere** to drag, **cōnsequī** to follow, **iocārī** to joke, **cognōscere**

to begin to know.) Which verb do you use for a person, and which for a fact? (*Conocer*; *saber*.) And which of the four moves a thing toward you? (*Traer* — *llevar* goes away.)

Chapter 137

Review — All Four Stem Changes

Modes: ⇄ voice (1) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can name all four stem-change patterns and the single verb that owns one of them.

The system closes at four - and u-to-ue has exactly one member.

137.1 Review — the four stem changes, all of them

Nothing new in this chapter. Say a verb whose stem breaks under stress — any one you have met.

What you've built

Something finished in the last two chapters and it is worth stopping for. Spanish has **four** stem-change patterns. Not five, not a dozen — four. You met the first two long ago with *querer* and *poder*, and the last two in the chapters you have just finished. That is the whole system, and you now hold all of it:

the change	the verb that taught it	what breaks
e → ie	<i>querer</i>	→ <i>quiero</i>
o → ue	<i>poder</i>	→ <i>puedo</i>
e → i	<i>conseguir</i>	→ <i>consigo</i>
u → ue	<i>jugar</i>	→ <i>juego</i>

This table is allowed here because every row in it is something you can

already do. It is a picture of the ground you hold, not a list to memorise.

Grammar Lens: the pattern with one member

The fourth row is strange, and worth knowing precisely.

u → ue happens in exactly one verb in the entire language: *jugar*.

Not “mostly one.” One. Every other Spanish verb with a *u* in its stem leaves it alone. So you are not learning a pattern here so much as a single fact with a pattern’s shape — which is easier, not harder, and is the kind of thing a course should tell you instead of letting you brace for more.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- one verb from each of the four rows
- the four changes themselves, as sounds — *e-ie*, *o-ue*, *e-i*, *u-ue*

Twice through: Until naming the pattern is faster than working it out.

Before you move on

How many stem-change patterns are there? (**Four** — and that is all of them.) Which one has a single member? (**u → ue**, only *jugar*.) Next chapter is not about forms at all — it is about three places where English gives you one word and Spanish makes you choose.

Chapter 138

Synthesis — The Choices English Never Makes You Make

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can choose correctly between three verb pairs where English offers only one word.

preguntar/pedir, traer/llevar, conocer/saber - the decision carries the meaning.

138.1 Synthesis — the choices English never makes you make

Nothing new here. Two verbs to say aloud first: *traer, conocer*.

Grammar Lens: one English word, two Spanish verbs

Three times now you have met a pair of verbs where English makes do with one. They arrived chapters apart and have never been put side by side:

English gives you	Spanish makes you choose	the question you must answer
to ask	<i>preguntar · pedir</i>	asking a question , or asking for a thing ?
to bring / take	<i>traer · llevar</i>	toward the speaker, or away?
to know	<i>conocer · saber</i>	a person or place , or a fact ?

None of these is a vocabulary problem. In each one, the word is easy and the **decision** is the work — and the decision is information English speakers are simply never required to supply.

What you've built

When you pick *traer* over *llevar*, you have told your listener **where you are standing**. When you pick *conocer* over *saber*, you have told them whether you have *met* the thing or only heard of it. The grammar is carrying meaning that English would need a whole clause to add. You are not translating any more. You are choosing.

The exchange

— ¿**Conoces** Madrid? — Sí, **conozco** Madrid. Pero no **sé** dónde está el café.

Two “knows” in two lines, and not interchangeable. The first is acquaintance — *I have been there*. The second is a fact. English uses **know** for both and loses the difference.

Your turn

- *Say it*: the exchange above, both parts

Twice through: Until the choice happens before you notice making it.

Before you move on

What does choosing *traer* tell your listener? (**Where you are standing**.) What does choosing *conocer* tell them? (That you have **met** it, not just heard of it.) And which of the three pairs did you learn

first? (*Preguntar* and *pedir* — long before the other two.)

Chapter 139

Waiting, Answering, Buying

Modes: 🗣️ voice (3) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 3 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can say I wait, answer and buy in Spanish — three verbs whose endings never surprise me — and I know that *esperar* alone carries wait, hope and expect, so context does the work English hands to three separate verbs.

*Run **espero**, **contesto** and **compro** — three verbs that break nothing, whose whole difficulty is meaning — and give each root and its sense: **spērāre** to hope, **contestārī** to call witnesses, **comparāre** to procure. Refuse the lookalike: English **compare** descends from a different Latin **comparāre** built on **compār**, so it is not a relative. Then buy — **compro el pan, el vino y un café, por favor** — and reach back for what **pānis** gave **compañero**, which English words **vīnum** reached, why **café** is masculine, and what **por favor** says word for word.*

139.1 **esperar** — one verb for waiting, hoping and expecting

Four verbs that each did something odd to themselves — *juego* the strangest of them. Here is one that does nothing odd at all, and is still the hardest word in these two chapters.

Sounds you'll need

- **st-no-e** — the *e-* is a run-up: *es-pe-RAR*, never *spe-*.
- **r-tap** — one flick for the *r* in the middle.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

esperar ← Latin **spērāre**, “to hope”, from **spēs**, “hope”. That front *e-* is the same run-up that turned *scribere* into *escribir* and *studēre* into *estudiar*: Spanish will not start a word with *s* plus a consonant.

English took the root by its negative: **despair** ← **dēspērāre**, *dē-* + *spērāre* — literally **to un-hope** — and with it **desperate**, and **desperado**, which English shaped from Spanish *desesperado*. **Prosper** is traditionally read as *prō* + *spēs*, “according to one’s hope”, though that reading is the traditional one rather than a settled one.

Spanish keeps the hope in plain sight: **la esperanza**. So does **Esperanto** — its inventor published as *Doktoro Esperanto*, “Doctor One-Who-Hopes”.

Grammar Lens: three English verbs, one Spanish word

Spanish	what it means
Espero a María	I am waiting for María
Espero el pan	I am expecting the bread
Espero que sí	I hope so

One verb, three English words, and nothing in the Spanish tells them apart. Context does all of it, and a learner has to stop translating and start reading the situation. *Hope* and *expect* were never far from waiting: to wait for a thing is to think it is coming.

Note the small **a** before a person, the same one that stands in *conozco a María*. And after three chapters of cracking stems, *esperar* is perfectly regular: **espero, esperas, espera, esperamos, esperan**.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “espero, esperas, espera, esperamos, esperan”
- “Espero a María” then “Espero el pan” then “Espero que sí”
- “spērāre, esperanza” then English “despair, desperate”

Before you move on

Give the three English verbs *esperar* covers. (**Wait, hope, expect.**) What does *dēspērāre* take apart into? (*Dē-* + *spērāre*, **to un-hope.**) Name two other Spanish verbs whose *e-* is a run-up, with their Latin roots. (*Escribir* ← *scrībere*, *estudiar* ← *studēre*.) Would you use *conocer* or *saber* for a city? (*Conocer*.) And what did the *-sc-* inside *cognōscere* mark? (**Beginning** — to *come* to know.)

139.2 contestar — “to answer”, from a Roman courtroom

Pregunto pushes the pole down to sound the water. *Espero* waits. Now the other half of a conversation — and a word that began as an oath.

Sounds you’ll need

- **s-clear** — a clean *s* in the middle: *con-tes-TAR*.
- **stress-final** — the beat lands on the last syllable, with no written accent.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

contestar (“to answer”) ← Latin **contestārī**, “to call witnesses”: *com-* + *testārī*, from **testis**, “a witness”. In Roman law, *contestārī litem* was the formal opening of a lawsuit — both sides calling their witnesses so the argument could begin.

From that one act the two languages walked in opposite directions. **English kept the fight**: to *contest* a thing is to dispute it. **Spanish kept the reply** — first “say back what the other side said”, then simply *answer*.

The *testis* family is shared: **testify, testimony, testament, attest, protest, detest**.

Grammar Lens: contestar and responder

Spanish has a second answering verb, and it is built on a different promise.

responder ← Latin **respondēre**, *re-* + **spondēre**, “to pledge

solemnly”. Answering is pledging *back*. English holds that whole branch: **respond, response, responsible, sponsor, and spouse**, from *spōn-sus*, “one who has been pledged”.

verb	where it lives
contestar	the everyday one: a question, the phone, a letter
responder	weightier — responding <i>to</i> something

Both are regular, one *-ar* and one *-er*: **contesto, contestas, contesta, contestamos, contestan; respondo, respondes, responde**. The noun is the odd part: the answer is **la respuesta**, borrowed from *responder*, never from *contestar*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “contesto, contestas, contesta, contestamos, contestan”
- “Te pregunto la hora y me contestas”
- “testis, testify, contest” then “contestar”

Before you move on

What did *contestārī* mean literally, and what did English make of it? (**To call witnesses; contest.**) What does *respondēre* take apart into? (*Re-* + *spōndēre*, **to pledge back.**) Which verb asks for information and which asks for a thing? (*Preguntar; pedir.*) And name the three English verbs inside *esperar*. (**Wait, hope, expect.**)

139.3 comprar — “to buy”, and a cousin that is not one

You can ask, answer and wait. Now pay for the bread, with a verb whose obvious English relative turns out to be a stranger.

Sounds you'll need

- **pr-cluster** — *-pr-* is one beat: *kom-PRAR*, never *kom-pe-rar*.
- **vowel-o** — a short pure *o*, with no glide toward *ow*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

comprar (“to buy”) ← Latin **comparāre**: *com-* + **parāre**, “to make ready, to furnish, to procure”. Latin already used it for buying — you procured a thing — and the middle syllable wore away, *comparāre* to *comprar*.

Parāre stocked English well: **prepare**, **repair**, **apparatus**, **apparel**, **separate**, **parade**, and **emperor**, from *imperāre*, “to give orders”. Spanish keeps *preparar*, and *parar*, “to stop”.

That *com-* is the same one already inside *compañero* — “the one you share bread with” — and inside *conseguir*, *conocer* and *contestar*.

Why it's said this way

English **compare** looks like the obvious relative. It is not one.

Latin had **two** verbs spelled *comparāre*. One is *com-* + *parāre*, “procure”, and Spanish *comprar* comes from it. The other is built on **com-pār**, “equal, matched”, and means “to set side by side” — that is the one English *compare* comes from. Two different words that fell together in spelling.

Comprender is a stranger too: it is *comprehendere*, “to seize together”. Same prefix, unrelated second halves. A resemblance is a question, never an answer.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “compro, compras, compra, compramos, compran”
- “Compro el pan y el vino”
- “Un café, por favor”
- “parāre, prepare, repair” then “comprar”

Before you move on

Run the chapter: *espero*, *contesto*, *compro* — three verbs that break nothing, whose difficulty is meaning. Give each root and what it meant. (**Spērāre** to hope, **contestārī** to call witnesses, **comparāre** to procure.) Is English *compare* a relative of *comprar*? (**No** — a different Latin *comparāre*, built on *compār*, “equal”.) Now buy: *compro el pan*, *el vino y un café*, *por favor* — then say what *pānis* gave *compañero*, which English words *vīnum* reached, why *café* is masculine, and what *por favor* is word for word. (**One who shares bread**; *wine*, *vine*, *vinegar*; *café* arrived as a masculine loan out of Arabic *qahwa*; “for a favour”.) And which verb gets a thing by following it? (*Conseguir*.)

Chapter 140

Saying Why

Modes: 🗣️ voice (4) 🖱️ Hands-free start: all 4 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can give a reason for what I think and what I plan — stating an opinion with *creo que*, running forward to its consequence with *así que*, and naming an obligation with *debo*.

Answer *¿Por qué no corres?* in four moves — *Creo que llueve. No corro porque llueve, así que leo. Debo estudiar. Opinion, cause, consequence, obligation, each with its own word, and every word in it taught by this book.*

140.1 creer — to put your heart somewhere

You have **pensar** — to think, and underneath it *pēnsāre*, “to weigh”. Spanish has a second verb for the inside of your head, and it does a different job. Where *pensar* weighs, this one commits.

Sounds you’ll need

- **hiatus-ee** — the two *e*’s do not merge: **creer** = *kreh-EHR*, two beats.
- **r-tap** — a single flick, not the rolled *rr*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

creer = “to believe”, and in everyday use “to think” in the sense of *hold an opinion*.

It comes from Latin *crēdere*, “to entrust, to believe” — and *crēdere* is a compound so old that Latin had already forgotten it was one. It is PIE **kred-dʰeh₁-*: “to put **kred-*”.

What is that first half? Traditionally, the **heart** word — the root of Latin *cor*, *cordis* and of English **heart**. Be honest that the step is **disputed**: that root normally appears as **kē-*, never **kred-*. The compound is not in doubt; only what it was built on.

Taking the traditional reading:

from <i>crēdere</i>	from <i>cor</i> , <i>cordis</i>
credit, creed, credo	cordial, courage
credential, incredible	record, accord, discord

To **record** is to bring something back to the *cor* — for a Roman the seat of **memory**, not of feeling. To have **courage** is to have heart.

Grammar Lens: creer que

Creer almost always drags a **que** behind it, and then a whole clause:

Creo que llueve.	I think it’s raining.
Creo que hace frío.	I think it’s cold.
No creo que llueva.	I don’t think it’s raining.

Look hard at that third row. *Creo que llueve* — but *no creo que llueva*. Negating *creer* flips the clause into the **subjunctive** from chapter eighteen: stop vouching for something and Spanish stops using the tense that states facts.

Pienso is the weighing; *creo* is where it landed. Treat that as a way to feel the difference, not a rule — both take *que* and a clause, and a speaker may use either. But *creo que* is the ordinary opening for an opinion.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “creer” — *kreh-EHR*, two beats, not one
- “Creo que llueve.”
- the pair — “pienso” (I weigh) then “creo” (I hold)

- “creer” then English “credit, creed, cordial, record”

Before you move on

What shape is *crēdere*, under the surface? (**A compound** — **kred-* + *d^heh₁-*, “to put **kred-*”.) What is the traditional reading of that first half, and why hedge it? (**Heart** — but the heart root is **kēr*, never **kred-*, so the step is disputed.) *Pensar* weighs; what does *creer* do? (It **lands** — it holds the opinion the weighing produced.)

140.2 *así que* — “so”, and a word you have been saying since yes

Porque runs from a claim back to its reason. This runs the other way — from the reason forward to what follows. Same two facts, opposite arrow, and you need both to explain anything.

Sounds you’ll need

- **s-clear** — a clean hiss in *así*, never a *z* buzz.
- **k-hard** — *qu* is a plain *k*; the *u* is silent.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

así = “so, thus, in that way”. *así que* = “so, and therefore”.

Así is Latin *sīc*, “thus” — with an *a-* that Spanish added later, the same one it put on *apenas* and *afuera*. And you have met *sīc* before: it is the whole of Spanish *sí*, “yes”. Latin *sīc* meant “thus, in this way”, and saying *thus* in answer to a question is how a language gets a word for yes.

So *sí* and *así* are the same Latin adverb, one bare and one with the *a-* attached. English borrowed it raw and never translated it: *sic*, the mark an editor puts after a quoted mistake — “thus it stood”.

Grammar Lens: the two arrows

The pair is worth drilling as a pair, because they carry the same two facts in opposite orders:

No corro porque llueve.	I'm not running because it's raining.
Llueve, así que no corro.	It's raining, so I'm not running.
<i>Porque</i> points backwards to the cause. <i>Así que</i> points forwards to the consequence. Which you reach for depends only on which fact you want to say first — and that is a choice about emphasis, not about grammar.	
Hace frío, así que bebo café.	It's cold, so I drink coffee.
Creo que llueve, así que leo.	I think it's raining, so I read.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “sí” then “así” — the same Latin word, one with an *a-* on the front
- “Llueve, así que no corro.”
- the same two facts the other way — “No corro porque llueve.”
- “Creo que hace frío, así que bebo café.”

Before you move on

Which Latin adverb is hiding in both *sí* and *así*? (*Sīc*, “thus”.) Which way does *porque* point, and which way *así que*? (*Porque* **backwards** to the cause; *así que* **forwards** to the consequence.) What does an editor’s *sic* mean? (**Thus it stood** — the same word, borrowed whole.)

140.3 deber — to owe, and therefore to ought

You can now say what you think and what follows from it. This verb adds the third move in any explanation: what somebody **ought** to do about it. It gets there from an unexpected direction — money.

Sounds you'll need

- **b-soft** — between vowels the *b* softens: **deber** = *deh-BEHR*.
- **r-tap** — one flick at the end, not a roll.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

deber does two jobs: “to owe”, and “ought to, should”.

Latin *dēbēre* explains both, because it is a compound: *dē-* (“from”) plus *habēre* (“to have”). To *dēbēre* something is **to have it from someone** — which is exactly what owing is. You are holding what is theirs.

English helped itself to this verb four times over — three of them from the participle *dēbitum* rather than the verb — and the spellings record each route:

English	how it came
debt	through French, then re-spelled to show the Latin <i>b</i>
debit	straight from Latin bookkeeping
due	through French <i>deü</i> , the <i>b</i> worn away
duty	built on <i>due</i>

One more came the long way round, and not by borrowing. French turned *dēbēre* into *devoir*, “duty”. English **translated** the phrase *mettre en devoir* — to put oneself under an obligation — half-way, as *put in dever*, and the last two words later fused into **endeavour**.

Grammar Lens: debo + infinitive

Deber is regular, and for “ought to” it takes a bare infinitive straight after it — no *que*, no preposition:

person	form
yo	debo
tú	debes
él/ella/usted	debe
nosotros	debemos
ellos/ustedes	deben

Debo estudiar. — I ought to study. **Llueve, así que debo leer.** — It's raining, so I ought to read.

The obligation is softer than a command and firmer than a wish, which is the register an explanation usually wants.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “debo, debes, debe, debemos, deben”
- “Debo trabajar.”
- “Hace frío, así que debo beber café.”
- “Creo que llueve, así que debo leer.”
- “deber” then English “debt, debit, due, duty”

Before you move on

What two Latin pieces build *dēbēre*, and what do they say together? (*Dē-* + *habēre* — “to have **from** someone”, which is owing.) Name two of the four English words it became. (Any of **debt**, **debit**, **due**, **duty**.) What follows *debo* — a *que*, or a bare infinitive? (**A bare infinitive**: *debo estudiar*.)

140.4 explicar — to unfold

Three pieces are in your hands: *creo que* to state an opinion, *así que* to run forward to what follows, *debo* to say what ought to happen. This lesson puts all three in a row, under the verb that names the act.

Sounds you’ll need

- k-hard — *c* before *a* is a hard *k*: **explicar** = *eks-plee-KAR*.
- l-clear — a clean *l* in the *pl*, no vowel slipped in between.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

explicar = Latin *explicāre*: *ex-* (“out”) + *plicāre* (“to fold”). **To explain is to unfold** — something was folded shut, and you open it.

Plicāre is one of the great suppliers of English. Some came from Latin directly, some through French, and the sound changed on the way:

straight from Latin	through French
explicate	explicit, application
complicated (<i>com-</i> + fold)	employ, deploy
duplicate	display — a doublet of <i>deploy</i>

And **simple** is *sim-plex* — “**one**-fold”. Something simple has been folded only once. Something **complicated** has been folded *together*, over and over, which is why it needs unfolding. The metaphor is consistent all the way down, and Spanish keeps it in the plainest verb of the set.

Grammar Lens: the shape of an explanation

Explicar is regular — it takes the plain *-ar* endings of *hablar*, with no stem change at all: **explico, explicas, explica, explicamos, explican**. (*Contar*, which you met earlier, breaks its *o* to *ue*; this one does not, and there is nothing to remember.)

Here is a whole explanation, with every piece something this book has taught:

— ¿Por qué no corres? — **Creo que** llueve. No corro **porque** llueve, **así que** leo. **Debo** estudiar.

>

— *Why aren't you running?* — *I think it's raining. I'm not running because it's raining, so I read. I ought to study.*

Four moves, four words: an **opinion** (*creo que*), a **cause** (*porque*), a **consequence** (*así que*), an **obligation** (*debo*). That is what an explanation is made of, and you can now build one in either direction — cause first or claim first — because *porque* and *así que* let you choose.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “explico, explicas, explica, explicamos, explican”
- “Explico bien.” — I explain well.

- the four moves — “Creo que llueve, porque hace frío, así que debo leer.”
- “explicar” then English “explicit, complicated, simple, display”

Before you move on

What does *explicāre* literally say? (**To fold out** — *ex-* + *plicāre*.) What is *simple*, folded? (**Once** — *sim-plex*; *complicated* is folded together, again and again.) Name the four moves of an explanation and the word for each. (Opinion **creo que**, cause **porque**, consequence **así que**, obligation **debo**.)

Pronunciation — a reference, not a chapter

Not to be read before the lessons — every lesson tells you the one or two sounds its own word needs, right where you need them. This page sits at the back so the whole system is *somewhere* you can find it: look things up as curiosity strikes.

The five pure vowels

Spanish has exactly five vowel sounds, one per letter, every time — unlike English, which reuses each vowel letter for several sounds.

- **a** — as in *father*. Always.
- **e** — as in *bed*. Always.
- **i** — as the *ee* in *see* (not English *i*). The most common vowel slip for English speakers.
- **o** — as in *note*, short and clean, no *w*-glide.
- **u** — as the *oo* in *food*. Always.

Consonants that differ from English

- **h** — always silent. *hola* is *OH-la*.
- **qu** — a hard *k*, with a **silent u**: *quiero* is *KYEH-ro*.
- **ll** — like English *y*: *llamo* is *YA-mo*.
- **ñ** — the *ny* of *canyon*: *español*.

- **rr** — a rolled *r*; single *r* between vowels is a light tap (*pero* vs. *perro*).
- **j** — a throat-*h*, like Scottish *loch*: *jueves*.
- **c** before *e/i* — soft (*s* in Latin America, *th* in much of Spain): *gracias*.
- **d** between vowels — softens toward *th* in *this*.
- **v** and **b** — essentially identical, a soft *b*.

Stress and written accents

- Ends in a vowel, *n*, or *s* → stress the second-to-last syllable (*ca-SA*).
- Ends in another consonant → stress the last syllable (*ha-BLAR*).
- A written accent (´) overrides both and marks the stress exactly (*ha-BLÓ*, *DÍ-as*); it also separates look-alike words (*qué/que*, *tú/tu*).
- Questions and exclamations open with an inverted mark (¿, ¡) so the intonation is signalled up front.

Glossary

This glossary collects every word and phrase taught in the book. Pronunciation appears when it differs from the written form; chapter numbers show where each entry is introduced.

abrir

to open — a regular -ir verb with one irregular part, the participle abierto
Introduced in Chapter 131.

adiós

goodbye
Introduced in Chapter 12.

amarillo

yellow — from “a little bitter,” not from any Latin word for yellow at all
Introduced in Chapter 116.

así que

thus, in that way — and with que after it, “so”; built on the same *sīc* that gave you *sí*
Introduced in Chapter 140.

ayudar

to help — literally the same word as English “aid”, arriving by a different road
Introduced in Chapter 126.

azul

blue — an Arabic loan that became the plain everyday word, where French’s cousin stayed poetic
Introduced in Chapter 105.

beber

to drink (another -er verb — cementing the pattern)
Introduced in Chapter 27.

bien

well / good / fine
Introduced in Chapter 1.

buenas noches

good evening / good night
Introduced in Chapter 2.

buenas tardes

good afternoon

Introduced in Chapter 2.

buenos días

good morning (literally “good days”)

Introduced in Chapter 1.

café

coffee / a café — one useful noun before the polite request that follows

Introduced in Chapter 14.

caminar

to walk — built on a Celtic word for a path, beside andar, whose own past is unsettled

Introduced in Chapter 130.

cerrar

to close — from the bar dropped across a door, not from the Latin verb English inherited

Introduced in Chapter 131.

comer

to eat — your first -er verb, and the family whose yo-form you already own

Introduced in Chapter 25.

comí

the regular singular -er preterite — comí, comiste, comió

Introduced in Chapter 82.

cómo

how — a whole Latin phrase, quo modo, worn smooth into one word

Introduced in Chapter 6.

comprar

to buy — from Latin’s “get ready, procure”, and not from the verb behind English compare

Introduced in Chapter 139.

conocer

to meet, to be acquainted with — a verb built out of the moment knowing begins

Introduced in Chapter 136.

conseguir

to get, to obtain — getting as following a thing until you have it

Introduced in Chapter 134.

contar

to tell a story — and also to count, because in Spanish, as once in English, a story is something you reckon up

Introduced in Chapter 132.

contestar

to answer — a Roman courtroom word that English turned into a fight and Spanish turned into a reply

Introduced in Chapter 139.

correr

to run — a plain -er verb sitting on one of the largest roots English ever borrowed
Introduced in Chapter 130.

creer

to believe, to think — putting your heart somewhere, where pensar weighs it up
Introduced in Chapter 140.

cuando

“when” — the word that puts a scene and an event in one sentence, so the two
pasts can be seen doing different jobs
Introduced in Chapter 90.

de nada

you’re welcome (literally “of nothing”)
Introduced in Chapter 7.

deber

should, ought to — and to owe, because the word is literally “to have something
from someone”
Introduced in Chapter 140.

decir

to say or tell — with the singular present forms digo, dices, and dice
Introduced in Chapter 46.

día

day (el día — masculine)
Introduced in Chapter 1.

dieciséis — diecinueve

16-19 — not words to memorise but a formula, diez y X, with the seam still visible
Introduced in Chapter 114.

dónde

where?
Introduced in Chapter 27.

dormir

to sleep — and the other half of the boot, where a stressed o breaks to ue
Introduced in Chapter 130.

e → ie and o → ue

comparing the two vowel changes inside the learned singular forms
Introduced in Chapter 45.

el / la

the (masculine / feminine)
Introduced in Chapter 1.

el agua

water — a word that barely changed from Latin, and takes el without ever
stopping being feminine
Introduced in Chapter 109.

el hermano, la hermana

brother and sister — NOT from *frater/soror*, but from an adjective meaning “of the same seed”

Introduced in Chapter 106.

el libro

book — named after the part of a tree people wrote on before paper

Introduced in Chapter 54.

el padre, la madre

father and mother — among the oldest reconstructible words in the whole family

Introduced in Chapter 106.

el pan

bread — and the *compañero* who shares it with you

Introduced in Chapter 109.

el tiempo

the one noun that covers both “time” and “weather” — because Latin *tempus* already did

Introduced in Chapter 113.

el vino

wine — one Latin root that reached English by three separate roads, plus one English built at home

Introduced in Chapter 109.

entender

to understand — literally “to stretch toward”; the second *e*→*ie* stem-changer

Introduced in Chapter 119.

escribir

to write — from a Latin verb meaning “to scratch”, and the reason Spanish puts an *e-* in front

Introduced in Chapter 121.

español

“Spanish” — the language, the people, and the Roman name for the peninsula underneath it

Introduced in Chapter 22.

esperar

to wait — and to hope, and to expect, all in one verb

Introduced in Chapter 139.

está en...

is in or at... — locate someone with *estar* and the already-known *en*

Introduced in Chapter 39.

estar

to be — but the *standing* kind, straight from Latin *stāre*

Introduced in Chapter 8.

estás / está

what *estar* is for — a current state or location — and the only two forms you need this chapter
Introduced in Chapter 8.

estudiar

to study (a third -ar verb — the pattern is automatic now)
Introduced in Chapter 21.

explicar

to explain — literally to unfold, and the verb that names what this whole chapter has been building
Introduced in Chapter 140.

fui

the shared singular preterite of *ser* and *ir* — *fui*, *fuiste*, *fue*
Introduced in Chapter 81.

gato

cat — a word that travelled out of Africa with the animal, pushing Latin's own *fēlēs* aside
Introduced in Chapter 115.

gracias

thank you
Introduced in Chapter 7.

gustar

to please — the verb English calls “to like”, built the other way round
Introduced in Chapter 128.

hablar

to speak / to talk — at root, “to tell stories”
Introduced in Chapter 16.

Hablo español

your first sentence built from parts — and the rule that languages take no article
Introduced in Chapter 22.

hace calor, hace frío, hace sol

the three weather words Spanish reports with *hacer* — “it makes heat,” “it makes cold,” “it makes sun”
Introduced in Chapter 113.

hacer

to do or make — with the singular present forms *hago*, *haces*, and *hace*
Introduced in Chapter 46.

hasta

until / up to
Introduced in Chapter 12.

hasta luego

see you later (literally “until later”)
Introduced in Chapter 13.

hasta mañana

see you tomorrow (literally “until tomorrow”)

Introduced in Chapter 13.

hasta pronto

see you soon (literally “until soon”)

Introduced in Chapter 13.

hola

hello / hi

Introduced in Chapter 1.

ir

to go — with the three singular present forms voy, vas, and va

Introduced in Chapter 40.

jugar

to play — from Latin’s word for joking, and the only verb in the language that breaks u to ue

Introduced in Chapter 135.

la

“it” for something feminine — the one word in this pair that never had to change

Introduced in Chapter 62.

la cabeza

the head — Spanish KEPT Latin’s real word, unlike French, which replaced it with slang for “pot”

Introduced in Chapter 107.

la casa

house, home — and a word French wore down so far it stopped looking like a noun

Introduced in Chapter 53.

la comida

food, a meal — a noun you can build yourself out of a verb you already own

Introduced in Chapter 55.

la hora

hour / o’clock — telling the time, and a word Spanish inherited almost unchanged from Latin

Introduced in Chapter 112.

la mano

the hand — feminine despite ending in -o, Spanish’s most famous gender exception

Introduced in Chapter 107.

la noche

night / evening (la noche — feminine)

Introduced in Chapter 2.

la primavera, el verano, el otoño, el invierno

the four seasons — three straightforward, and one whose MEANING quietly shifted from “spring” to “summer”

Introduced in Chapter 108.

la tarde

afternoon (la tarde — feminine; also: late)

Introduced in Chapter 2.

le

“to him, to her, to you” — a Latin case Spanish kept and English threw away

Introduced in Chapter 71.

leer

to read — from a Latin verb meaning “to gather, to pick out”

Introduced in Chapter 120.

levantarse

to get up, to stand up — “to raise oneself”, built from a participle exactly as *sentarse* was

Introduced in Chapter 131.

llamo

I call (from *llamar*, to call)

Introduced in Chapter 4.

llovía / llovió

the same rain in two tenses — how a story uses the imperfect for the scene and the preterite for the events

Introduced in Chapter 132.

llueve

rain refuses the *hacer* pattern and brings its own verb — and its *ll-* is the sound change you already met in *llamar*

Introduced in Chapter 113.

lo

“it” — a word you have been saying since your fourth chapter, in a job you have not met yet

Introduced in Chapter 61.

lo siento

I’m sorry — literally “I feel it,” a naming of the feeling rather than a claim about yourself

Introduced in Chapter 103.

los meses

the months — Roman gods and emperors, marching almost unchanged from Latin

Introduced in Chapter 110.

luego

then, next — a word you already own from *hasta luego*, now doing a second job: joining two events in order

Introduced in Chapter 132.

lunes, martes, miércoles, jueves, viernes

the weekdays (Monday–Friday) — worn-down planet-god names

Introduced in Chapter 104.

más despacio

“more slowly” — the request that makes the last sentence solvable
Introduced in Chapter 15.

me

me / myself
Introduced in Chapter 4.

me llamo

my name is (literally “I call myself”)
Introduced in Chapter 4.

mediodía, medianoche

noon and midnight — both halves still fully alive as ordinary Spanish words,
unlike French’s worn-down *midi/minuit*
Introduced in Chapter 111.

mi, tu, su

my, your informal, and your formal or his or her — before a singular noun
Introduced in Chapter 40.

mucho

much / a lot
Introduced in Chapter 6.

mucho gusto

pleased to meet you (literally “much pleasure”)
Introduced in Chapter 6.

negro, blanco

black and white — the two words, and the straight-line Latin history of the first
one
Introduced in Chapter 105.

no

no / not
Introduced in Chapter 7.

no entiendo

“I don’t understand” — the most useful sentence a beginner owns
Introduced in Chapter 15.

nos

“us” — and the word hiding inside the verb ending you have used since *hablamos*
Introduced in Chapter 66.

nuestro, nuestra

our — matching a known masculine or feminine singular noun
Introduced in Chapter 45.

oír

to hear — the half of listening you do not choose, and a verb that sprouts a *y*
Introduced in Chapter 130.

once — quince

11-15 — five single opaque words, each one a Latin compound worn down until the seam disappeared

Introduced in Chapter 114.

os

“you all” as the object — the shortest word in the set, and the one that stops at a border

Introduced in Chapter 68.

pensar

to think — at root “to weigh”, and a stem-changer that breaks e→ie

Introduced in Chapter 118.

perdón

the other sorry — “give completely” — for fault and for getting past people, where lo siento is for regret

Introduced in Chapter 103.

perro

dog — a genuinely unsolved etymology, and the Latin word it pushed out

Introduced in Chapter 115.

poder

to be able or can — with the singular present forms puedo, puedes, and puede

Introduced in Chapter 45.

poner

to put or place — with the singular present forms pongo, pones, and pone

Introduced in Chapter 47.

por favor

please (literally “for [a] favour”)

Introduced in Chapter 14.

porque

because — two tiny words fused into one, and the reason a sequence becomes a story

Introduced in Chapter 132.

preguntar

to ask (a question) — and the reason English’s one “ask” becomes two Spanish verbs

Introduced in Chapter 125.

qué

what? (a new question word for verbs you already know)

Introduced in Chapter 27.

querer

to want — with the singular present forms quiero, quieres, and quiere

Introduced in Chapter 45.

regular

so-so / not great (also “más o menos”)

Introduced in Chapter 9.

rojo

red — a cousin of French rouge and English red, but by a different branch of the same very old family

Introduced in Chapter 105.

sábado, domingo

the weekend (Saturday, Sunday) — where religion overwrote astronomy

Introduced in Chapter 104.

salir

to leave or go out — with the singular present forms salgo, sales, and sale

Introduced in Chapter 48.

se llama

he/she calls himself; you (formal) call yourself

Introduced in Chapter 6.

seis, siete, ocho, nueve, diez

the numbers 6–10 and the old counting hidden in month names

Introduced in Chapter 38.

sentarse

to sit down — literally “to seat oneself”, the reflexive that lands the action back on you

Introduced in Chapter 131.

ser

to be — the verb used here to identify someone or say what someone is

Introduced in Chapter 39.

ser vs estar

identify with ser; describe a current state or location with estar

Introduced in Chapter 39.

sí

yes

Introduced in Chapter 7.

soy de...

I am from... — use ser with de to state origin

Introduced in Chapter 39.

te quiero

“you” as the object — and the sentence it makes, which is the one people actually need

Introduced in Chapter 63.

tener

to have — a common verb with two visible changes

Introduced in Chapter 38.

tengo · hago · digo

comparing the three learned yo forms that end in -go

Introduced in Chapter 46.

tomar

to take (and, across Latin America, to drink) — an everyday word with no settled origin

Introduced in Chapter 124.

trabajar

to work (a second -ar verb — same pattern)

Introduced in Chapter 20.

traer

to bring — Latin's word for dragging, and a verb with a direction built into it

Introduced in Chapter 133.

tú / usted

two of the three words Spanish uses to one person — and the one English quietly retired

Introduced in Chapter 5.

tú o usted

the choice English lost — and the surprise that usted takes he/she verb forms

Introduced in Chapter 5.

uno, dos, tres, cuatro, cinco

the numbers 1–5

Introduced in Chapter 38.

veinte

twenty — the ceiling of the teens, and a word that was worn but never fused

Introduced in Chapter 114.

venir

to come — with the singular present forms vengo, vienes, and viene

Introduced in Chapter 49.

ver

to see — veo, ves, ve

Introduced in Chapter 86.

verde

green — from a verb meaning “to flourish,” and a cousin of verdant but not of English green

Introduced in Chapter 116.

viví

the regular singular -ir preterite — viví, viviste, vivió

Introduced in Chapter 82.

vivir

to live — your first -ir verb, and a family that asks you to learn nothing new

Introduced in Chapter 26.

vos

“you” across a large part of the Spanish-speaking world — to recognise, not to say

Introduced in Chapter 5.

voy a + infinitive

I am going to... — the near future with *ir*, *a*, and a known infinitive
Introduced in Chapter 40.

y / ¿y tú?

and / and you? — a tiny connector that hands the conversation back
Introduced in Chapter 9.

¿cómo está usted?

how are you? — assemble the formal question from *cómo*, *estar*, and *usted*
Introduced in Chapter 8.

¿cómo se llama usted?

what's your name? (formal)
Introduced in Chapter 6.

¿Cuántos años tienes?

how old are you? — literally, how many years do you have?
Introduced in Chapter 38.

Review Questions

Try these without looking ahead. Every prompt comes from the same canonical lesson data as its chapter. Answers begin in the next section.

Chapter 1

1.1 *Grammatical gender — the two noun classes behind el and la*
How many grammatical noun classes does Spanish keep?

Chapter 2

2.1 *buenos or buenas — the rule you have been using all along*
Why does bueno become buenos in buenos dias?

2.2 *buenos or buenas — the rule you have been using all along*
And why buenas in buenas tardes?

Chapter 3

3.1 *un — “a,” and the number hiding in it*
Say a day in Spanish.

3.2 *un — “a,” and the number hiding in it*
Which one points at a day we both already know about: el dia or un dia?

3.3 *un — “a,” and the number hiding in it*
What number is hiding inside un, and inside English a?

3.4 *una — the feminine one*
Say an afternoon.

3.5 *una — the feminine one*
Un or una before dia?

3.6 *una — the feminine one*

Which of the two lost a syllable on the way from Latin?

3.7 *Review — the four little words*

The day.

3.8 *Review — the four little words*

An afternoon.

3.9 *Review — the four little words*

Where does an article get its gender from?

Chapter 11

11.1 *Where does ¿ begin? — bracket the spoken span*

In 'Roberto, ¿cómo estás?', is Roberto inside the question?

Chapter 16

16.1 *hablo — “I speak”*

Turn hablar into I speak.

16.2 *hablo — “I speak”*

Which single letter is doing the work of the word I?

16.3 *hablo — one word, one whole sentence*

How many words does Spanish need to say I speak?

16.4 *hablo — one word, one whole sentence*

Why must English say the word I, when Spanish need not?

Chapter 17

17.1 *hablas — “you speak,” to someone you know*

Turn hablar into you speak, to a friend.

17.2 *hablas — “you speak,” to someone you know*

Which one means I speak: hablo or hablas?

Chapter 18

18.1 *habla* — “he speaks,” and the polite “you speak”

Turn hablar into he speaks.

18.2 *habla* — “he speaks,” and the polite “you speak”

Which form goes with usted: hablas or habla?

Chapter 19

19.1 *Review* — the three forms, side by side

I speak.

19.2 *Review* — the three forms, side by side

She speaks.

19.3 *Review* — the three forms, side by side

You speak, to a friend.

Chapter 23

23.1 *Synthesis* — the same conversation, twice

You are talking to someone your own age. Which form: hablas or habla?

23.2 *Synthesis* — the same conversation, twice

You are speaking to someone you want to show respect to. Which form?

23.3 *Synthesis* — the same conversation, twice

In BOTH conversations, how do you say I speak?

Chapter 25

25.1 *comer* — “to eat,” and the second verb family

Which ending makes comer a different family from hablar?

25.2 *como* — “I eat,” and you already knew how

Turn comer into I eat.

25.3 *como* — “I eat,” and you already knew how

Which ending is identical in the -ar and -er families?

25.4 *comes* — “you eat,” and the first real difference

Turn comer into you eat, to a friend.

25.5 *comes* — “you eat,” and the first real difference

What does a final -s on a Spanish verb always tell you?

25.6 *come* — “he eats,” and the polite “you eat”

Turn *comer* into he eats.

25.7 *come* — “he eats,” and the polite “you eat”

Which form goes with *usted*: *comes* or *come*?

25.8 *Review* — the -er family, all three

I eat.

25.9 *Review* — the -er family, all three

You eat, to a friend.

25.10 *Review* — the -er family, all three

Which of the three slots is identical between the -ar and -er families?

Chapter 26

26.1 *vivir* — “to live,” and the third family (that’s barely new)

Give the three singular forms of *vivir* in order: I, tú, usted.

Chapter 27

27.1 *beber* — “to drink,” and the pattern is yours

Say ‘I drink coffee’ in Spanish.

27.2 *qué* — “what”, a new question word

Ask one friend ‘What do you drink?’ in Spanish.

27.3 *dónde* — “where?”

Say ‘I live in Madrid’ in Spanish.

27.4 *Practice* — asking real questions

Give the you forms of *comer*, *vivir*, and *beber*, in that order.

27.5 *Practice* — asking real questions

Ask one friend ‘What do you drink?’ in Spanish.

27.6 *Practice* — asking real questions

Answer ‘Where do you live?’ with Madrid.

Chapter 28

28.1 *Synthesis — asking, and answering*

Ask a friend what they eat.

28.2 *Synthesis — asking, and answering*

Ask a friend where they live.

28.3 *Synthesis — asking, and answering*

How many verb families do you now hold in the singular?

Chapter 29

29.1 *hablamos — “we speak”*

Turn hablar into we speak.

29.2 *hablamos — “we speak”*

What was the Latin ending that became -mos?

Chapter 30

30.1 *hablan — “they speak,” and “you all speak”*

Turn hablar into they speak.

30.2 *hablan — “they speak,” and “you all speak”*

Which form goes with ustedes?

30.3 *hablan — “they speak,” and “you all speak”*

What phrase is ustedes worn down from?

Chapter 31

31.1 *habláis — the form Spain keeps*

Which form goes with vosotros?

31.2 *habláis — the form Spain keeps*

You are addressing a group of friends in Argentina. Vosotros or ustedes?

31.3 *habláis — the form Spain keeps*

What two words is vosotros built from?

Chapter 32

32.1 Review — *the whole thing, at last*

We speak.

32.2 Review — *the whole thing, at last*

They speak.

32.3 Review — *the whole thing, at last*

How many forms does the present tense of a regular -ar verb have?

Chapter 33

33.1 Synthesis — *the same sentence, two continents*

In Madrid, to a group of friends: which verb form?

33.2 Synthesis — *the same sentence, two continents*

The same friends, in Bogota: which form?

33.3 Synthesis — *the same sentence, two continents*

Which of the two is the correct one?

Chapter 34

34.1 *comemos* — “*we eat*”

Turn *comer* into *we eat*.

34.2 *comemos* — “*we eat*”

Which part of the ending is the same in *hablamos* and *comemos*?

34.3 *vivimos* — *where the two families part*

Turn *vivir* into *we live*.

34.4 *vivimos* — *where the two families part*

What is the only difference between *comemos* and *vivimos*?

Chapter 35

35.1 *coméis and vivís* — *the second difference, and the last*

Vosotros, from *comer*.

35.2 *coméis and vivís* — *the second difference, and the last*

Vosotros, from *vivir*.

35.3 *coméis and vivís* — *the second difference, and the last*

In how many of the six slots do -er and -ir actually differ?

Chapter 36

36.1 *comen and viven — agreeing again*

They eat.

36.2 *comen and viven — agreeing again*

They live.

36.3 *comen and viven — agreeing again*

In which two slots do -er and -ir differ?

Chapter 37

37.1 *Review — the present tense, whole*

Which row is identical across all three families?

37.2 *Review — the present tense, whole*

In which two rows do -er and -ir differ?

37.3 *Review — the present tense, whole*

We live.

Chapter 38

38.1 *uno, dos, tres, cuatro, cinco — counting to five*

Write the Spanish numbers 1 through 5 in order.

38.2 *uno, dos, tres, cuatro, cinco — counting to five*

Say 'one coffee' in Spanish.

38.3 *seis, siete, ocho, nueve, diez — and the calendar's old count*

Write the Spanish numbers 6 through 10 in order.

38.4 *seis, siete, ocho, nueve, diez — and the calendar's old count*

Were July and August inserted into the Roman calendar or were older months renamed?

38.5 *tener — “to have,” with two visible changes*

Give the yo, tú, and él/ella forms of tener, in that order.

38.6 *¿Cuántos años tienes? — asking age*

Ask one friend 'How old are you?' in Spanish.

38.7 *¿Cuántos años tienes? — asking age*

Answer 'I am eight years old' using the Spanish age frame.

38.8 *Practice — counting, having, and age*

Write the Spanish numbers 1 through 10 in order.

38.9 Practice — counting, having, and age

Give the three learned singular forms of tener: yo, tú, then él/ella.

38.10 Practice — counting, having, and age

Answer ¿Cuántos años tienes? with nine years.

Chapter 39

39.1 ser — another way to say “to be”

Give the three learned singular forms of ser: yo, tú, then él/ella/usted.

39.2 ser — another way to say “to be”

Complete the identification for formal you: Usted ____ Ana.

39.3 ser vs estar — identity or current state?

Choose es or está: ¿____ usted Ana?

39.4 ser vs estar — identity or current state?

Choose es or está: ¿____ usted bien?

39.5 soy de... — saying where you are from

Ask one friend ‘Where are you from?’ in Spanish.

39.6 soy de... — saying where you are from

Answer ‘I am from Madrid’ in Spanish.

39.7 está en... — saying where someone is

Ask formal you ‘Where are you?’ in Spanish.

39.8 está en... — saying where someone is

Say ‘Ana is in Madrid’ in Spanish.

39.9 Practice — identity, origin, state, and location

Complete with es or está: ¿____ usted Ana?

39.10 Practice — identity, origin, state, and location

Say ‘I am from Madrid’ in Spanish.

39.11 Practice — identity, origin, state, and location

Say ‘Ana is in Madrid’ in Spanish.

39.12 Practice — identity, origin, state, and location

Complete with es or está: ¿____ usted bien?

Chapter 40

40.1 ir — “to go,” from more than one historical stem

Give the three learned singular present forms of ir: yo, tú, then él/ella/usted.

40.2 *ir* — “to go,” from more than one historical stem

Complete the formal question: ¿Dónde _____ usted?

40.3 *voy a + infinitive* — moving toward the near future

Say ‘I am going to speak’ in Spanish.

40.4 *voy a + infinitive* — moving toward the near future

Say ‘You are going to eat’ to one friend in Spanish.

40.5 *mi, tu, su* — whose café?

Say ‘my coffee’ in Spanish.

40.6 *mi, tu, su* — whose café?

Addressing usted, say ‘your coffee’ in Spanish.

40.7 *Practice* — going, approaching events, and ownership

Give the learned singular forms of *ir*: yo, tú, then usted.

40.8 *Practice* — going, approaching events, and ownership

Ask formal you ‘Where are you going?’ in Spanish.

40.9 *Practice* — going, approaching events, and ownership

Say ‘I am going to speak’ in Spanish.

40.10 *Practice* — going, approaching events, and ownership

Addressing usted, say ‘your coffee’ in Spanish.

Chapter 41

41.1 *somos* — “we are”

Say we are.

41.2 *somos* — “we are”

Why do *ser*’s forms look so unlike each other?

41.3 *son* — “they are”

Say they are.

41.4 *son* — “they are”

What Latin form is *son* worn down from?

41.5 *sois* — the last of the six

Vosotros, from *ser*.

41.6 *sois* — the last of the six

The same thing in Peru: which form?

41.7 *Review* — all of *ser*

We are.

41.8 *Review* — all of *ser*

They are.

41.9 *Review* — all of *ser*

Which of the six does not begin with *s*, and why?

Chapter 42

42.1 *estamos* — *the other “we are”*

Say we are, using *estar*.

42.2 *estamos* — *the other “we are”*

Why is *estar* regular here when *ser* is not?

42.3 *están* — *“they are”*

Say they are, using *estar*.

42.4 *están* — *“they are”*

Why does *están* carry an accent when *hablan* does not?

42.5 *estáis* — *and nothing surprises you*

Vosotros, from *estar*.

42.6 *estáis* — *and nothing surprises you*

The same thing in Chile: which form?

42.7 *Review* — *both verbs for “to be”*

We are, with *estar*.

42.8 *Review* — *both verbs for “to be”*

They are, with *estar*.

42.9 *Review* — *both verbs for “to be”*

Which of the two has a regular plural, and why?

Chapter 43

43.1 *tenemos* — *and the stem change disappears*

Say we have.

43.2 *tenemos* — *and the stem change disappears*

Why does *tienen* break its stem but *tenemos* does not?

43.3 *tienen* — *the break comes back*

Say they have.

43.4 *tienen* — *the break comes back*

In any stem-changing verb, which two forms never break?

43.5 *tienen* — *the break comes back*

What actually decides whether the stem breaks?

Chapter 44

44.1 *vamos* — from a verb that is not *ir*

Say we go.

44.2 *vamos* — from a verb that is not *ir*

Why does the present of *ir* begin with *v* when the infinitive has none?

44.3 *vamos* — from a verb that is not *ir*

Name the English pair that works the same way.

44.4 *van* — and the four are done

Say they go.

44.5 *van* — and the four are done

They are (permanently), and they are (right now): which two forms?

44.6 *van* — and the four are done

What usually explains a Spanish verb that looks chaotic?

Chapter 45

45.1 *querer* — wanting with one familiar vowel change

Give the learned singular present forms of *querer*: *yo*, *tú*, then *él/ella/usted*.

45.2 *querer* — wanting with one familiar vowel change

Say 'I want to speak' in Spanish.

45.3 *poder* — ability with the *o* → *ue* change

Give the learned singular present forms of *poder*: *yo*, *tú*, then *él/ella/usted*.

45.4 *poder* — ability with the *o* → *ue* change

Say 'You can eat' to one friend in Spanish.

45.5 *e* → *ie* and *o* → *ue* — compare the singular forms

Give the learned *yo* forms of *querer* and *poder*, in that order.

45.6 *e* → *ie* and *o* → *ue* — compare the singular forms

Give the learned *tú* forms of *tener*, *querer*, and *poder*, in that order.

45.7 *nuestro, nuestra* — “our” with singular gender agreement

Say 'our day' in Spanish.

45.8 *nuestro, nuestra* — “our” with singular gender agreement

Say 'our night' in Spanish.

45.9 *Practice* — wanting, ability, and our known nouns

Give the learned singular forms of *querer*: *yo*, *tú*, then *usted*.

45.10 *Practice* — wanting, ability, and our known nouns

Give the learned singular forms of *poder*: *yo*, *tú*, then *usted*.

45.11 Practice — *wanting, ability, and our known nouns*

Say 'I want to speak' in Spanish.

45.12 Practice — *wanting, ability, and our known nouns*

Say 'You can eat' to one friend in Spanish.

45.13 Practice — *wanting, ability, and our known nouns*

Say 'our night' in Spanish.

Chapter 46

46.1 hacer — *doing or making with three singular forms*

Give the learned singular present forms of hacer: yo, tú, then él/ella/usted.

46.2 hacer — *doing or making with three singular forms*

Say 'I make coffee' in Spanish.

46.3 decir — *saying with the same small person frame*

Give the learned singular present forms of decir: yo, tú, then él/ella/usted.

46.4 decir — *saying with the same small person frame*

Say 'I say hello' in Spanish.

46.5 decir — *saying with the same small person frame*

Ask one friend 'How do you say hello?' in Spanish.

46.6 tengo · hago · digo — *compare only what you know*

Give the learned yo forms of tener, hacer, and decir, in that order.

46.7 tengo · hago · digo — *compare only what you know*

Which learned yo form means 'I do' or 'I make'?

46.8 Practice — *doing, making, and saying in the singular*

Give the learned singular forms of hacer: yo, tú, then usted.

46.9 Practice — *doing, making, and saying in the singular*

Give the learned singular forms of decir: yo, tú, then usted.

46.10 Practice — *doing, making, and saying in the singular*

Give the learned yo forms of tener, hacer, and decir, in that order.

46.11 Practice — *doing, making, and saying in the singular*

Say 'I make coffee' in Spanish.

46.12 Practice — *doing, making, and saying in the singular*

Ask one friend 'How do you say hello?' in Spanish.

Chapter 47

47.1 *poner* — putting or placing with three singular forms

Give the learned singular present forms of poner: yo, tú, then él/ella/usted.

47.2 *poner* — putting or placing with three singular forms

What two English verbs does poner cover?

Chapter 48

48.1 *salir* — leaving with three singular forms

Give the learned singular present forms of salir: yo, tú, then él/ella/usted.

48.2 *salir* — leaving with three singular forms

Say 'I leave Madrid' in Spanish.

Chapter 49

49.1 *venir* — coming with three singular forms

Give the learned singular present forms of venir: yo, tú, then él/ella/usted.

49.2 *venir* — coming with three singular forms

Say 'I come from Madrid' in Spanish.

49.3 *venir* — coming with three singular forms

Give the tú forms of venir and tener, in that order.

Chapter 50

50.1 *Review* — six verbs, one ending

How many verbs are in the -go set?

50.2 *Review* — six verbs, one ending

Which slot does the -go appear in?

50.3 *Review* — six verbs, one ending

Are these six related to each other?

50.4 *Practice* — putting, leaving, and coming in the singular

Give the learned singular forms of poner: yo, tú, then usted.

50.5 *Practice* — putting, leaving, and coming in the singular

Give the learned singular forms of salir: yo, tú, then usted.

50.6 Practice — *putting, leaving, and coming in the singular*

Give the learned singular forms of venir: yo, tú, then usted.

50.7 Practice — *putting, leaving, and coming in the singular*

Say 'I leave Madrid; I come from Madrid' in Spanish.

50.8 Practice — *putting, leaving, and coming in the singular*

Give the learned yo forms of tener, hacer, decir, poner, salir, and venir, in that order.

50.9 Practice — *putting, leaving, and coming in the singular*

Match each Spanish verb to one English cousin: poner, salir, venir.

Chapter 51

51.1 Synthesis — *you, and somebody else*

Say I am leaving, in one word.

51.2 Synthesis — *you, and somebody else*

Now say she is leaving. Is it irregular?

51.3 Synthesis — *you, and somebody else*

In these six verbs, which slot is the only irregular one?

Chapter 52

52.1 *queremos, quieren* — *work them out first*

We want.

52.2 *queremos, quieren* — *work them out first*

They can.

52.3 *queremos, quieren* — *work them out first*

Poder changes o to ue. What is we can?

52.4 *hacemos, hacen* — *and the club has no plural at all*

We do or make.

52.5 *hacemos, hacen* — *and the club has no plural at all*

They leave.

52.6 *hacemos, hacen* — *and the club has no plural at all*

Decir stem-changes. What are we say and they say?

52.7 Synthesis — *a verb you have never met*

Salir is a -go verb. What is we leave?

52.8 Synthesis — *a verb you have never met*

And they leave?

52.9 *Synthesis — a verb you have never met*
How many rules generate the whole present tense?

Chapter 53

53.1 *la casa — “house,” and “home”*
Say the house in Spanish.

53.2 *la casa — “house,” and “home”*
Say I have a house.

53.3 *la casa — “house,” and “home”*
Which French word is casa worn all the way down?

Chapter 54

54.1 *el libro — “book”*
Say the book in Spanish.

54.2 *el libro — “book”*
Say I have a book.

54.3 *el libro — “book”*
What did Latin liber originally mean?

Chapter 55

55.1 *la comida — “food,” built from a verb you have*
Build the noun for food from the verb comer.

55.2 *la comida — “food,” built from a verb you have*
Say I make the meal.

55.3 *la comida — “food,” built from a verb you have*
What gender is any noun built with -ida?

Chapter 56

56.1 *las casas — “the houses”*
Say the houses.

56.2 *las casas* — “the houses”

Say the meals.

56.3 *las casas* — “the houses”

How many new rules did this lesson add?

Chapter 57

57.1 *los libros* — “the books”

Say the books.

57.2 *los libros* — “the books”

Why is it *los* and not *els*?

57.3 *los libros* — “the books”

Give all four forms of the Spanish word for the.

Chapter 58

58.1 *-es* — *the plural your first chapter owed you*

Make *español* plural.

58.2 *-es* — *the plural your first chapter owed you*

Which word have you been using this rule on since long before this chapter?

58.3 *-es* — *the plural your first chapter owed you*

Why *-es* rather than plain *-s* after a consonant?

Chapter 59

59.1 *Review* — *all four words for “the”*

Give the four Spanish words for the, in the order masculine singular, feminine singular, masculine plural, feminine plural.

59.2 *Review* — *all four words for “the”*

Say the books and then the houses.

59.3 *Review* — *all four words for “the”*

State the plural rule in one sentence, including what happens after a consonant.

Chapter 60

60.1 *Synthesis — more than one*

Say I have books.

60.2 *Synthesis — more than one*

Now say I have the books.

60.3 *Synthesis — more than one*

Say I make meals, meaning meals in general.

60.4 *Synthesis — more than one*

What is the difference in meaning between *casas* and *las casas*?

Chapter 61

61.1 *lo — “it”*

Say I have it, replacing *el libro*.

61.2 *lo — “it”*

Does the pronoun go before or after the conjugated verb?

61.3 *lo — “it”*

Which everyday Spanish word comes from the same Latin word as *lo*?

Chapter 62

62.1 *la — “it,” for a feminine noun*

Say I make it, about *la comida*.

62.2 *la — “it,” for a feminine noun*

What decides whether you say *lo* or *la*?

62.3 *la — “it,” for a feminine noun*

Why does the feminine article match its pronoun exactly, when the masculine pair does not?

Chapter 63

63.1 *me quieres — “you love me”*

Say you love me.

63.2 *me quieres — “you love me”*

In *me llamo* the *me* points back at the speaker. What is it doing in *me quieres*?

63.3 *me quieres* — “*you love me*”

How many new word forms did this lesson ask you to learn?

63.4 *te quiero* — “*I love you*”

Say I love you.

63.5 *te quiero* — “*I love you*”

Quiero un libro means I want a book. Why does *te quiero* not mean I want you?

63.6 *te quiero* — “*I love you*”

Which old English pair is the same inherited pair as *tu* and *te*?

Chapter 64

64.1 *Review* — *four pronouns, one slot*

Name the four object pronouns you now hold.

64.2 *Review* — *four pronouns, one slot*

What single question chooses between all four?

64.3 *Review* — *four pronouns, one slot*

Which two of the four depend on knowing a noun’s gender?

Chapter 65

65.1 *Synthesis* — *saying it once*

Answer yes to *Tienes el libro*, without repeating the noun.

65.2 *Synthesis* — *saying it once*

Answer yes to *Haces la comida*, without repeating the noun.

65.3 *Synthesis* — *saying it once*

Somebody says *Te quiero*. Say the answering half.

65.4 *Synthesis* — *saying it once*

Version one of the dialogue was grammatically correct. What was wrong with it?

Chapter 66

66.1 *nos* — “*us*”

Say they love us.

66.2 *nos* — “*us*”

Which verb ending is the same ancient word as *nos*?

66.3 *nos* — “us”

What are the two pieces inside nosotros, and what do they mean together?

Chapter 67

67.1 *los and las* — “them”

Say I have them, about los libros.

67.2 *los and las* — “them”

Say I make them, about las comidas.

67.3 *los and las* — “them”

The article *el* had to change shape for its plural. Why did the pronoun *lo* not?

Chapter 68

68.1 *os* — “you all,” in Spain

Say I love you all, as a speaker in Spain would.

68.2 *os* — “you all,” in Spain

Say the same thing the way most of the Spanish-speaking world would.

68.3 *os* — “you all,” in Spain

Which older word is *os* worn down from, and where is it still said whole?

Chapter 69

69.1 *Review* — *all eight*

Give all eight direct object pronouns.

69.2 *Review* — *all eight*

Which four of the eight need you to know a noun’s gender?

69.3 *Review* — *all eight*

Which two of the eight did you never have to be taught?

Chapter 70

70.1 *Synthesis* — *the conversation without them*

Answer yes to *Tienes los libros*, without the noun.

70.2 *Synthesis — the conversation without them*

Answer the question about las comidas, saying you make them.

70.3 *Synthesis — the conversation without them*

Say they love us.

70.4 *Synthesis — the conversation without them*

You have been talking about meals and you say los tengo. What goes wrong for your listener?

Chapter 71

71.1 *le — “to him,” “to her,” “to you”*

Say I tell him.

71.2 *le — “to him,” “to her,” “to you”*

How many genders does le have?

71.3 *le — “to him,” “to her,” “to you”*

Lo comes from Latin illum. Which Latin form does le come from, and what was it for?

Chapter 72

72.1 *les — “to them,” and what this system really costs*

Say I tell them.

72.2 *les — “to them,” and what this system really costs*

How many genuinely new words does the indirect set add?

72.3 *les — “to them,” and what this system really costs*

Which four pronouns are identical in both sets?

Chapter 73

73.1 *Which one is the verb asking for?*

State the one-question test in your own words.

73.2 *Which one is the verb asking for?*

Say I speak to her.

73.3 *Which one is the verb asking for?*

Say I have it, about the book, and say which set that is.

73.4 *Which one is the verb asking for?*

Somebody in Madrid says le veo for I see him. Has a rule been broken?

Chapter 74

74.1 Review — *two systems, two new words*

Give the six indirect object pronouns.

74.2 Review — *two systems, two new words*

Which row is the only one where the two sets differ in shape, and how?

74.3 Review — *two systems, two new words*

Across both tables, how many distinct word shapes are there in total?

Chapter 75

75.1 Synthesis — *the thing and the person, in one sentence*

Answer yes to *Tienes el libro*, without the noun.

75.2 Synthesis — *the thing and the person, in one sentence*

Say I tell her today.

75.3 Synthesis — *the thing and the person, in one sentence*

Say I speak to them.

75.4 Synthesis — *the thing and the person, in one sentence*

Two pronouns in the same slot, both two letters, both from one Latin word. What is the only thing that tells them apart?

Chapter 76

76.1 *me lo* — *both at once*

Say I tell it to you.

76.2 *me lo* — *both at once*

Which comes first, the person or the thing?

76.3 *me lo* — *both at once*

Say you make it for me, about la comida.

Chapter 77

77.1 *se lo* — *the pair that does not exist*

Say I tell it to him.

77.2 *se lo* — *the pair that does not exist*

In front of which four words do *le* and *les* become *se*?

77.3 *se lo — the pair that does not exist*

How many different people can *se lo digo* be about?

Chapter 78

78.1 *Why se? — and why it is not the se you know*

What did Old Spanish say instead of *se lo*?

78.2 *Why se? — and why it is not the se you know*

Is the *se* of *se lo digo* the same word as the *se* of *se llama*?

78.3 *Why se? — and why it is not the se you know*

Which two Latin pronouns were squeezed together to make *gelo*?

Chapter 79

79.1 *Review — the pairs*

State the two facts that generate the whole table.

79.2 *Review — the pairs*

Give the pair meaning it to us.

79.3 *Review — the pairs*

How many new pronoun forms did this arc introduce?

Chapter 80

80.1 *Synthesis — two at a time*

Say shall I tell it to you.

80.2 *Synthesis — two at a time*

Say I make it for her, about la comida.

80.3 *Synthesis — two at a time*

In *se la hago*, how many of the three words name anything?

80.4 *Synthesis — two at a time*

You lose track of which thing *se la* points at. Does the sentence become wrong?

Chapter 81

81.1 *fui* — one past set shared by *ser* and *ir*

Give the shared singular preterite forms of *ser* and *ir*: yo, tú, then él/ella/usted.

81.2 *fui* — one past set shared by *ser* and *ir*

Say 'I went to Madrid' in Spanish.

81.3 *fui* — one past set shared by *ser* and *ir*

In 'Fue Roberto', which verb does *fue* express?

81.4 *hablé* — a regular singular past from a known verb

Give the singular completed-past forms of *hablar*: yo, tú, then él/ella/usted.

81.5 *hablé* — a regular singular past from a known verb

Say 'I spoke Spanish' in Spanish.

81.6 *hablé* — a regular singular past from a known verb

Which form means 'I spoke' as a completed event: *hablo* or *hablé*?

81.7 Practice — two singular ways to talk about a completed past

Give the three learned forms shared by *ser* and *ir*.

81.8 Practice — two singular ways to talk about a completed past

Give the three learned completed-past forms of *hablar*.

81.9 Practice — two singular ways to talk about a completed past

Which sentence uses the shared form as *ir*, 'to go': *Fui a Madrid* or *Fue Roberto*?

81.10 Practice — two singular ways to talk about a completed past

Give 'I speak Spanish' and then 'I spoke Spanish.'

81.11 Practice — two singular ways to talk about a completed past

Which two of *hablé*, *hablaste*, *habló* carry written accents?

Chapter 82

82.1 *comí* — one regular -er singular past

Give the singular completed-past forms of *comer*: yo, tú, then él/ella/usted.

82.2 *comí* — one regular -er singular past

Which form means 'I ate' as a completed event: *como* or *comí*?

82.3 *comí* — one regular -er singular past

Did Spanish -í, -iste, -ió arise by simple letter-dropping alone, or by sound change plus analogy?

82.4 *viví* — reuse one past pattern with an -ir verb

Give the singular completed-past forms of *vivir*: yo, tú, then él/ella/usted.

82.5 *viví* — reuse one past pattern with an -ir verb

Say 'I lived in Madrid' in Spanish.

82.6 *viví* — reuse one past pattern with an -ir verb

Which three singular past endings do comer and vivir share?

Chapter 83

83.1 *tuve* — let the strong stem carry the stress

Give the singular completed-past forms of tener: yo, tú, then él/ella/usted.

83.2 *tuve* — let the strong stem carry the stress

Say 'I had coffee' in Spanish.

83.3 *tuve* — let the strong stem carry the stress

Which phrase best describes *tuve*: a letter-for-letter copy of *tenuī*, or a historically reshaped strong form?

83.4 *hice* — the strong pattern with one third-person swerve

Give the singular completed-past forms of hacer: yo, tú, then él/ella/usted.

83.5 *hice* — the strong pattern with one third-person swerve

Say 'I made coffee' in Spanish.

83.6 *hice* — the strong pattern with one third-person swerve

Which Latin strong-perfect form lies behind the historical development of *hice*?

83.7 *estuve* — a third known verb joins the strong pattern

Give the singular completed-past forms of estar: yo, tú, then él/ella/usted.

83.8 *estuve* — a third known verb joins the strong pattern

Say 'I was well' as a completed past statement in Spanish.

83.9 *estuve* — a third known verb joins the strong pattern

Which known strong form helped shape the family resemblance in *estuve*: *tuve* or *hice*?

Chapter 84

84.1 *Practice* — six singular patterns, no hidden vocabulary

Give the learned yo past forms of hablar, comer, and vivir, in that order.

84.2 *Practice* — six singular patterns, no hidden vocabulary

Give the learned yo past forms of tener, hacer, and estar, in that order.

84.3 *Practice* — six singular patterns, no hidden vocabulary

Say 'I made coffee' in Spanish.

84.4 *Practice* — six singular patterns, no hidden vocabulary

Say 'I lived in Madrid' in Spanish.

84.5 Practice — *six singular patterns, no hidden vocabulary*

Say 'I was well' as a completed event in Spanish.

84.6 Practice — *six singular patterns, no hidden vocabulary*

Which pair carries written accents: comí/comió or tuve/tuvo?

84.7 Practice — *six singular patterns, no hidden vocabulary*

Which learned form is especially described as analogically remodeled beside tuve: comí, hice, or estuve?

84.8 Synthesis — *you can hear which past it is*

A preterite with no written accent. Where is the stress, and which kind is it?

84.9 Synthesis — *you can hear which past it is*

Why does comi carry an accent when tuve does not?

84.10 Synthesis — *you can hear which past it is*

In the regular preterite, do -er and -ir take the same endings?

Chapter 85

85.1 hablaba — *let a past action stay open*

Give the learned singular imperfect forms of hablar: yo, tú, then él/ella/usted.

85.2 hablaba — *let a past action stay open*

Which form leaves 'I spoke' open or habitual: hablé or hablaba?

85.3 hablaba — *let a past action stay open*

Which consonant links Latin -ābam with Spanish -aba?

85.4 comía — *hear both vowels*

Give the learned singular imperfect forms of comer: yo, tú, then él/ella/usted.

85.5 comía — *hear both vowels*

Which form means 'I was eating': comí or comía?

85.6 comía — *hear both vowels*

Write comía with syllable breaks.

85.7 vivía — *reuse the complete -er row*

Give the learned singular imperfect forms of vivir: yo, tú, then él/ella/usted.

85.8 vivía — *reuse the complete -er row*

Which two infinitive classes share the learned imperfect endings -ía, -ías, -ía?

85.9 vivía — *reuse the complete -er row*

Say 'I was living in Madrid' in Spanish.

Chapter 86

86.1 *ver* — learn the verb before its past

What does Spanish *ver* mean?

86.2 *ver* — learn the verb before its past

Give the learned present forms of *ver*: yo, tú, then él/ella/usted.

86.3 *ver* — learn the verb before its past

Which Latin verb stands behind Spanish *ver*: *vidēre* or *īre*?

Chapter 87

87.1 *era* — an old root in an open past

Give the learned singular imperfect forms of *ser*: yo, tú, then él/ella/usted.

87.2 *era* — an old root in an open past

Which *ser* form presents a background past: *era* or *fue*?

87.3 *era* — an old root in an open past

Which Latin form stands directly behind Spanish *era*: *eram* or *ībam*?

87.4 *iba* — *ir* returns to its inherited past

Give the learned singular imperfect forms of *ir*: yo, tú, then él/ella/usted.

87.5 *iba* — *ir* returns to its inherited past

Say 'I was going to Madrid' in Spanish.

87.6 *iba* — *ir* returns to its inherited past

Which inherited Latin verb stands behind *iba*: *īre* or *vidēre*?

87.7 *veía* — keep the extra *e* you already met

Give the learned singular imperfect forms of *ver*: yo, tú, then él/ella/usted.

87.8 *veía* — keep the extra *e* you already met

Which sentence means 'I was seeing coffee': *Veo café* or *Veía café*?

87.9 *veía* — keep the extra *e* you already met

Which earlier Spanish form makes the extra *e* of *veía* easier to see: *veer* or *ir*?

Chapter 88

88.1 *Practice* — keep the past open or close it

Give the imperfect yo forms of *hablar*, *comer*, and *vivir*, in that order.

88.2 *Practice* — keep the past open or close it

Give the imperfect yo forms of *ser*, *ir*, and *ver*, in that order.

88.3 Practice — *keep the past open or close it*

Say 'I was speaking Spanish' in Spanish.

88.4 Practice — *keep the past open or close it*

Say 'I was living in Madrid' in Spanish.

88.5 Practice — *keep the past open or close it*

Say 'I was going to Madrid' in Spanish.

88.6 Practice — *keep the past open or close it*

Choose the open past: comí or comía.

88.7 Practice — *keep the past open or close it*

Match the three forms to their historical bridges: era, iba, veía — eram, ibam, veer.

88.8 Synthesis — *three exceptions, and no others*

How many irregular verbs does the imperfect have in the whole language?

88.9 Synthesis — *three exceptions, and no others*

Name them.

88.10 Synthesis — *three exceptions, and no others*

Why are those three the irregular ones?

Chapter 89

89.1 hablaba and habló — *two ways of looking*

Do the two past tenses differ in when something happened?

89.2 hablaba and habló — *two ways of looking*

Which form looks at the event from outside, finished?

89.3 hablaba and habló — *two ways of looking*

Say I was studying, putting the listener inside it.

Chapter 90

90.1 cuando — *putting both pasts in one sentence*

Say I was studying when Ana spoke.

90.2 cuando — *putting both pasts in one sentence*

Which tense sets the room, and which one walks into it?

90.3 cuando — *putting both pasts in one sentence*

Which other Spanish question words share the front of cuando?

Chapter 91

91.1 *tenía and tuve — when the tense changes the meaning*

Say I had a house, meaning it was simply so.

91.2 *tenía and tuve — when the tense changes the meaning*

What does tuve una casa actually mean?

91.3 *tenía and tuve — when the tense changes the meaning*

You meet a new verb that names a state. What will its preterite mean?

Chapter 92

92.1 *Review — one question, three answers*

State the one question that chooses the tense.

92.2 *Review — one question, three answers*

In estudiaba cuando hablo Ana, which verb is the scene?

92.3 *Review — one question, three answers*

Which two rows of the table are NOT the same event seen twice?

Chapter 93

93.1 *Synthesis — a small story*

In the story, which two verbs are the background?

93.2 *Synthesis — a small story*

Why is tuve un libro in the foreground when tenía un libro was not?

93.3 *Synthesis — a small story*

Say I was studying when I spoke with Ana.

93.4 *Synthesis — a small story*

Why did this take three chapters when neither tense was new?

Chapter 94

94.1 *hablaré — keep the infinitive, add the future*

Give the learned singular future forms of hablar: yo, tú, then él/ella/usted.

94.2 *hablaré — keep the infinitive, add the future*

Say 'I will speak Spanish' in Spanish.

94.3 *hablaré — keep the infinitive, add the future*

Which Latin verb meaning 'to have' contributed material to the Romance future endings?

94.4 *comeré — the same endings keep -er*

Give the learned singular future forms of *comer*: yo, tú, then él/ella/usted.

94.5 *comeré — the same endings keep -er*

Use the learned -er future pattern to say 'I will drink coffee' in Spanish.

94.6 *comeré — the same endings keep -er*

Which endings do *hablaré* and *comeré* share across the learned singular row?

94.7 *viviré — one future row for three verb families*

Give the learned singular future forms of *vivir*: yo, tú, then él/ella/usted.

94.8 *viviré — one future row for three verb families*

Say 'I will live in Madrid' in Spanish.

94.9 *viviré — one future row for three verb families*

Give the future yo forms of *hablar*, *comer*, and *vivir*, in that order.

Chapter 95

95.1 *hablaría — the whole infinitive meets -ía*

Give the learned singular conditional forms of *hablar*: yo, tú, then él/ella/usted.

95.2 *hablaría — the whole infinitive meets -ía*

Say 'I would speak Spanish' in Spanish.

95.3 *hablaría — the whole infinitive meets -ía*

Write *hablaría* with the final three syllables separated.

95.4 *comería — keep -er before "would"*

Give the learned singular conditional forms of *comer*: yo, tú, then él/ella/usted.

95.5 *comería — keep -er before "would"*

Give the yo pair 'I will eat; I would eat' in Spanish.

95.6 *comería — keep -er before "would"*

Which endings do *hablaría* and *comería* share across the learned singular row?

95.7 *viviría — the regular conditional closes its small frame*

Give the learned singular conditional forms of *vivir*: yo, tú, then él/ella/usted.

95.8 *viviría — the regular conditional closes its small frame*

Say 'I would live in Madrid' in Spanish.

95.9 *viviría — the regular conditional closes its small frame*

Give the conditional yo forms of *hablar*, *comer*, and *vivir*, in that order.

Chapter 96

96.1 *haré · tendré · podré — three stems, two ending sets*

Give the pair 'I will make coffee; I would make coffee' in Spanish.

96.2 *haré · tendré · podré — three stems, two ending sets*

Give the future and conditional yo forms of tener, in that order.

96.3 *haré · tendré · podré — three stems, two ending sets*

Give the pair 'I will be able to speak Spanish; I could speak Spanish' in Spanish.

96.4 *Practice — one infinitive frame, two futures of thought*

Give the future yo forms of hablar, comer, and vivir, in that order.

96.5 *Practice — one infinitive frame, two futures of thought*

Give the conditional yo forms of hablar, comer, and vivir, in that order.

96.6 *Practice — one infinitive frame, two futures of thought*

Say 'I will speak Spanish' in Spanish.

96.7 *Practice — one infinitive frame, two futures of thought*

Say 'I would live in Madrid' in Spanish.

96.8 *Practice — one infinitive frame, two futures of thought*

Give the pair 'I will make coffee; I would make coffee' in Spanish.

96.9 *Practice — one infinitive frame, two futures of thought*

Give the learned stems for hacer, tener, and poder, in that order.

96.10 *Practice — one infinitive frame, two futures of thought*

Which Latin 'have' verb contributed material to both Romance constructions?

Chapter 97

97.1 *Synthesis — promising, and supposing*

You are committing to it. I will speak: which form?

97.2 *Synthesis — promising, and supposing*

Now you are only supposing. I would speak: which form?

97.3 *Synthesis — promising, and supposing*

What single word is glued onto the infinitive in BOTH tenses?

Chapter 98

98.1 *Hablas español · Quiero que hables español — fact or wanted event?*

Which form asserts that one friend speaks: hablas or hables?

98.2 *Hablas español · Quiero que hables español — fact or wanted event?*

Say 'I want to speak Spanish' in Spanish.

98.3 *Hablas español · Quiero que hables español — fact or wanted event?*

Say 'I want you to speak Spanish' to one friend.

Chapter 99

99.1 *hable · hables · hable — the singular -ar row*

Give the learned singular present-subjunctive forms of hablar: yo, tú, then él/ella/usted.

99.2 *hable · hables · hable — the singular -ar row*

Which present form gives the stem for regular hable: hablo or habla?

99.3 *hable · hables · hable — the singular -ar row*

What joining idea sits inside the Latin source of subjuntivo?

99.4 *coma · comas · coma — let -er cross to a*

Give the learned singular subjunctive forms of comer: yo, tú, then él/ella/usted.

99.5 *coma · comas · coma — let -er cross to a*

Which form belongs after quiero que for one friend: comes or comas?

99.6 *coma · comas · coma — let -er cross to a*

Say 'I want you to eat' to one friend.

99.7 *viva · vivas · viva — -ir joins -er*

Give the learned singular subjunctive forms of vivir: yo, tú, then él/ella/usted.

99.8 *viva · vivas · viva — -ir joins -er*

Which two regular verb families share -a, -as, -a here?

99.9 *viva · vivas · viva — -ir joins -er*

Say 'I want you to live in Madrid' to one friend.

Chapter 100

100.1 *quiera · quieras · quiera — keep the change you know*

Give the learned singular subjunctive forms of querer: yo, tú, then él/ella/usted.

100.2 *quiera · quieras · quiera — keep the change you know*

Which known present yo form gives the stem quier-?

100.3 *quiera · quieras · quiera — keep the change you know*

Complete 'Quiero que ____ hablar español' for one friend.

100.4 *pueda · puedas · pueda — one more known stem change*

Give the learned singular subjunctive forms of poder: yo, tú, then él/ella/usted.

100.5 *pueda · puedas · pueda — one more known stem change*

Which known present yo form gives the stem pued-?

100.6 *pueda · puedas · pueda — one more known stem change*

Say 'I want you to be able to speak Spanish' to one friend.

100.7 *haga · hagas · haga — hago lends its stem*

Give the learned singular subjunctive forms of *hacer*: yo, tú, then él/ella/usted.

100.8 *haga · hagas · haga — hago lends its stem*

Which known present yo form gives the stem hag-?

100.9 *haga · hagas · haga — hago lends its stem*

Say 'I want you to make coffee' to one friend.

Chapter 101

101.1 *ojalá + subjunctive — a wish borrowed through Arabic*

Say 'I hope you speak Spanish' to one friend using *ojalá*.

101.2 *ojalá + subjunctive — a wish borrowed through Arabic*

Does the learned *ojalá* frame require *que* before *hables*? Answer yes or no.

101.3 *ojalá + subjunctive — a wish borrowed through Arabic*

Through which historical language variety did Spanish receive *ojalá*?

101.4 *Practice — assert the event or want it*

Choose the wanted-event form: *hablas* or *hables*.

101.5 *Practice — assert the event or want it*

Give the pair 'I want to speak Spanish; I want you to speak Spanish.'

101.6 *Practice — assert the event or want it*

Give the tú subjunctive forms of *hablar*, *comer*, and *vivir*, in that order.

101.7 *Practice — assert the event or want it*

Which present-person form supplies the stem in this chapter's recipe?

101.8 *Practice — assert the event or want it*

Give the learned singular subjunctive row of *querer*.

101.9 *Practice — assert the event or want it*

Say 'I want you to be able to speak Spanish' to one friend.

101.10 *Practice — assert the event or want it*

Say 'I want you to make coffee' to one friend.

101.11 *Practice — assert the event or want it*

Say 'I hope you live in Madrid' to one friend using *ojalá*.

101.12 *Practice — assert the event or want it*

What does the Latin source *subiūnctīvus* help you picture?

101.13 Practice — *assert the event or want it*

Name the historical language variety through which ojalá entered Spanish.

Chapter 102**102.1 Synthesis** — *claiming, and not claiming*

You are stating a fact about a friend: you speak Spanish. Hablas or hables?

102.2 Synthesis — *claiming, and not claiming*

Now you only wish it were so. Which form follows ojalá?

102.3 Synthesis — *claiming, and not claiming*

What did ojalá originally mean, and in which language?

Chapter 117**117.1 Synthesis** — *saying something about your own life*

Say I have a black dog.

117.2 Synthesis — *saying something about your own life*

You are mentioning your cat for the first time. Un gato or el gato?

117.3 Synthesis — *saying something about your own life*

Say it is cold.

Chapter 122**122.1 Review** — *four verbs of the mind*

Which of the four verbs originally meant to weigh?

122.2 Review — *four verbs of the mind*

Which one meant to gather or pick out?

122.3 Review — *four verbs of the mind*

And which one meant to scratch?

Chapter 123**123.1 Synthesis** — *what you understand, and what you don't*

What does no entiendo literally say, given intender?

123.2 Synthesis — *what you understand, and what you don't*

How do you say I understand now, once it slows down?

Chapter 127

127.1 Review — *three verbs that behave*

Which of the three is the same word as English aid?

127.2 Review — *three verbs that behave*

Which of the three has no agreed etymology at all?

127.3 Review — *three verbs that behave*

In all three verbs, who is the sentence about — the one doing it, or the thing done?

Chapter 129

129.1 Synthesis — *what you like, and who is doing the liking*

In *me gusta el café*, what is the subject?

129.2 Synthesis — *what you like, and who is doing the liking*

What did *gustar* originally mean?

129.3 Synthesis — *what you like, and who is doing the liking*

Which phrase you learned long ago is built from this same word?

Chapter 137

137.1 Review — *the four stem changes, all of them*

How many stem-change patterns does Spanish have in total?

137.2 Review — *the four stem changes, all of them*

Which pattern belongs to exactly one verb, and which verb?

137.3 Review — *the four stem changes, all of them*

Which change does *conseguir* make?

Chapter 138

138.1 Synthesis — *the choices English never makes you make*

You want to say you know a person. *Conocer* or *saber*?

138.2 Synthesis — *the choices English never makes you make*

Someone asks you to move something toward where they are. *Traer* or *llevar*?

138.3 Synthesis — *the choices English never makes you make*

You want to ask for a coffee, not ask a question. *Preguntar* or *pedir*?

Answer Key

The first response is the canonical display answer. When a question accepts other authored forms, they appear underneath.

Chapter 1

1.1 *Grammatical gender — the two noun classes behind el and la*

Answer: two

Also accepted: 2

Chapter 2

2.1 *buenos or buenas — the rule you have been using all along*

Answer: it agrees with masculine plural dias

Also accepted: agreement with masculine plural dias; dias is masculine plural; because dias is masculine and plural

2.2 *buenos or buenas — the rule you have been using all along*

Answer: tardes is feminine plural

Also accepted: because tardes is feminine; feminine plural; tardes is feminine and plural

Chapter 3

3.1 *un — “a,” and the number hiding in it*

Answer: un día

Also accepted: un día

3.2 *un — “a,” and the number hiding in it*

Answer: el día

Also accepted: el día; the first

3.3 *un — “a,” and the number hiding in it*

Answer: one

Also accepted: 1; uno; the number one

3.4 *una — the feminine one***Answer:** una tarde**Also accepted:** una tarde.**3.5** *una — the feminine one***Answer:** un**Also accepted:** un dia; un, dia is masculine**3.6** *una — the feminine one***Answer:** un**Also accepted:** un, from unus; the masculine one**3.7** *Review — the four little words***Answer:** el dia**Also accepted:** el día**3.8** *Review — the four little words***Answer:** una tarde**Also accepted:** una tarde.**3.9** *Review — the four little words***Answer:** from the noun beside it**Also accepted:** the noun; from the noun; it copies the noun

Chapter 11

11.1 *Where does ¿ begin? — bracket the spoken span***Answer:** no**Also accepted:** no it is not; it is not

Chapter 16

16.1 *hablo — “I speak”***Answer:** hablo**Also accepted:** yo hablo**16.2** *hablo — “I speak”***Answer:** o**Also accepted:** -o; the o**16.3** *hablo — one word, one whole sentence***Answer:** one**Also accepted:** 1; just one; uno**16.4** *hablo — one word, one whole sentence***Answer:** English endings wore down so they no longer show who is speaking**Also accepted:** english endings wore down; english lost its endings; english endings dont show the person; because speak never changes

Chapter 17

17.1 *hablas* — “you speak,” to someone you know

Answer: hablas

Also accepted: tu hablas

17.2 *hablas* — “you speak,” to someone you know

Answer: hablo

Also accepted: the first; hablo means i speak

Chapter 18

18.1 *habla* — “he speaks,” and the polite “you speak”

Answer: habla

Also accepted: el habla

18.2 *habla* — “he speaks,” and the polite “you speak”

Answer: habla

Also accepted: usted habla

Chapter 19

19.1 *Review* — the three forms, side by side

Answer: hablo

Also accepted: yo hablo

19.2 *Review* — the three forms, side by side

Answer: habla

Also accepted: ella habla

19.3 *Review* — the three forms, side by side

Answer: hablas

Also accepted: tu hablas

Chapter 23

23.1 *Synthesis* — the same conversation, twice

Answer: hablas

Also accepted: tu hablas

23.2 *Synthesis* — the same conversation, twice

Answer: habla

Also accepted: habla usted

23.3 *Synthesis* — the same conversation, twice

Answer: hablo

Also accepted: the same, hablo; hablo both times

Chapter 25

25.1 *comer* — “to eat,” and the second verb family

Answer: -er

Also accepted: er; the -er ending

25.2 *como* — “I eat,” and you already knew how

Answer: como

Also accepted: yo como

25.3 *como* — “I eat,” and you already knew how

Answer: the yo ending -o

Also accepted: -o; o; the yo ending

25.4 *comes* — “you eat,” and the first real difference

Answer: comes

Also accepted: tu comes

25.5 *comes* — “you eat,” and the first real difference

Answer: it is talking to tu

Also accepted: you, informal; it means tu; the subject is tu

25.6 *come* — “he eats,” and the polite “you eat”

Answer: come

Also accepted: el come

25.7 *come* — “he eats,” and the polite “you eat”

Answer: come

Also accepted: usted come

25.8 *Review* — the -er family, all three

Answer: como

Also accepted: yo como

25.9 *Review* — the -er family, all three

Answer: comes

Also accepted: tu comes

25.10 *Review* — the -er family, all three

Answer: the yo slot

Also accepted: yo; the I form; -o

Chapter 26

26.1 *vivir* — “to live,” and the third family (that’s barely new)

Answer: vivo, vives, vive

Also accepted: vivo vives vive; vivo / vives / vive

Chapter 27

27.1 *beber* — “to drink,” and the pattern is yours

Answer: Bebo café.

Also accepted: Bebo café; bebo cafe; bebo café.

27.2 *qué* — “what”, a new question word

Answer: ¿Qué bebes?

Also accepted: Qué bebes?; ¿Qué bebes; Qué bebes

27.3 *dónde* — “where?”

Answer: Vivo en Madrid.

Also accepted: Vivo en Madrid; Yo vivo en Madrid.; Yo vivo en Madrid

27.4 *Practice* — asking real questions

Answer: como, vivo, bebo

Also accepted: como vivo bebo; como / vivo / bebo

27.5 *Practice* — asking real questions

Answer: ¿Qué bebes?

Also accepted: Qué bebes?; ¿Qué bebes; Qué bebes

27.6 *Practice* — asking real questions

Answer: Vivo en Madrid.

Also accepted: Vivo en Madrid; Yo vivo en Madrid.; Yo vivo en Madrid

Chapter 28

28.1 *Synthesis* — asking, and answering

Answer: que comes

Also accepted: ¿que comes?; qué comes; que comes tu

28.2 *Synthesis* — asking, and answering

Answer: donde vives

Also accepted: ¿donde vives?; dónde vives

28.3 *Synthesis* — asking, and answering

Answer: three

Also accepted: 3; all three

Chapter 29

29.1 *hablamos* — “we speak”

Answer: hablamos

Also accepted: nosotros hablamos

29.2 *hablamos* — “we speak”

Answer: -mus

Also accepted: mus; amamus

Chapter 30

30.1 *hablan* — “they speak,” and “you all speak”

Answer: hablan

Also accepted: ellos hablan

30.2 *hablan* — “they speak,” and “you all speak”

Answer: hablan

Also accepted: ustedes hablan

30.3 *hablan* — “they speak,” and “you all speak”

Answer: vuestras mercedes

Also accepted: your graces; vuestra merced plural

Chapter 31

31.1 *habláis* — the form Spain keeps

Answer: hablais

Also accepted: habláis; vosotros hablais

31.2 *habláis* — the form Spain keeps

Answer: ustedes

Also accepted: ustedes hablan

31.3 *habláis* — the form Spain keeps

Answer: vos and otros

Also accepted: vos otros; you others

Chapter 32

32.1 *Review* — the whole thing, at last

Answer: hablamos

Also accepted: nosotros hablamos

32.2 *Review* — the whole thing, at last

Answer: hablan

Also accepted: ellos hablan

32.3 *Review* — the whole thing, at last

Answer: six

Also accepted: 6

Chapter 33

33.1 *Synthesis* — the same sentence, two continents

Answer: hablais

Also accepted: habláis; vosotros hablais

33.2 *Synthesis — the same sentence, two continents*

Answer: hablan

Also accepted: ustedes hablan

33.3 *Synthesis — the same sentence, two continents*

Answer: neither, they are regional

Also accepted: neither; both are correct; it depends where you are

Chapter 34

34.1 *comemos — “we eat”*

Answer: comemos

Also accepted: nosotros comemos

34.2 *comemos — “we eat”*

Answer: -mos

Also accepted: mos; the mos

34.3 *vivimos — where the two families part*

Answer: vivimos

Also accepted: nosotros vivimos

34.4 *vivimos — where the two families part*

Answer: one vowel

Also accepted: the vowel; e versus i; one letter

Chapter 35

35.1 *coméis and vivís — the second difference, and the last*

Answer: comeis

Also accepted: coméis; vosotros comeis

35.2 *coméis and vivís — the second difference, and the last*

Answer: vivis

Also accepted: vivís; vosotros vivis

35.3 *coméis and vivís — the second difference, and the last*

Answer: two

Also accepted: 2; nosotros and vosotros

Chapter 36

36.1 *comen and viven — agreeing again*

Answer: comen

Also accepted: ellos comen; ustedes comen

36.2 *comen and viven — agreeing again***Answer:** viven**Also accepted:** ellos viven; ustedes viven**36.3** *comen and viven — agreeing again***Answer:** nosotros and vosotros**Also accepted:** nosotros, vosotros; we and you all

Chapter 37

37.1 *Review — the present tense, whole***Answer:** yo**Also accepted:** the yo row; the I form; -o**37.2** *Review — the present tense, whole***Answer:** nosotros and vosotros**Also accepted:** nosotros, vosotros; we and you all**37.3** *Review — the present tense, whole***Answer:** vivimos**Also accepted:** nosotros vivimos

Chapter 38

38.1 *uno, dos, tres, cuatro, cinco — counting to five***Answer:** uno, dos, tres, cuatro, cinco**Also accepted:** uno dos tres cuatro cinco**38.2** *uno, dos, tres, cuatro, cinco — counting to five***Answer:** un café**Also accepted:** un cafe**38.3** *seis, siete, ocho, nueve, diez — and the calendar's old count***Answer:** seis, siete, ocho, nueve, diez**Also accepted:** seis siete ocho nueve diez**38.4** *seis, siete, ocho, nueve, diez — and the calendar's old count***Answer:** older months were renamed**Also accepted:** renamed; they were renamed; the older months were renamed**38.5** *tener — “to have,” with two visible changes***Answer:** tengo, tienes, tiene**Also accepted:** tengo tienes tiene; tengo / tienes / tiene**38.6** *¿Cuántos años tienes? — asking age***Answer:** ¿Cuántos años tienes?**Also accepted:** Cuántos años tienes?; ¿Cuántos años tienes; Cuantos anos tienes?

38.7 *¿Cuántos años tienes? — asking age***Answer:** Tengo ocho años.**Also accepted:** Tengo ocho años; tengo ocho anos; tengo ocho anos.**38.8 Practice** — *counting, having, and age***Answer:** uno, dos, tres, cuatro, cinco, seis, siete, ocho, nueve, diez**Also accepted:** uno dos tres cuatro cinco seis siete ocho nueve diez**38.9 Practice** — *counting, having, and age***Answer:** tengo, tienes, tiene**Also accepted:** tengo tienes tiene; tengo / tienes / tiene**38.10 Practice** — *counting, having, and age***Answer:** Tengo nueve años.**Also accepted:** Tengo nueve años; tengo nueve anos; tengo nueve anos.

Chapter 39

39.1 *ser — another way to say “to be”***Answer:** soy, eres, es**Also accepted:** soy eres es; soy / eres / es**39.2** *ser — another way to say “to be”***Answer:** es**Also accepted:** Usted es Ana.; usted es ana**39.3** *ser vs estar — identity or current state?***Answer:** es**Also accepted:** ¿Es usted Ana?; Es usted Ana?**39.4** *ser vs estar — identity or current state?***Answer:** está**Also accepted:** ¿Está usted bien?; Esta usted bien?; esta**39.5** *soy de... — saying where you are from***Answer:** ¿De dónde eres?**Also accepted:** De dónde eres?; ¿De dónde eres; De donde eres?**39.6** *soy de... — saying where you are from***Answer:** Soy de Madrid.**Also accepted:** Soy de Madrid**39.7** *está en... — saying where someone is***Answer:** ¿Dónde está usted?**Also accepted:** Dónde está usted?; ¿Dónde está usted; Donde esta usted?**39.8** *está en... — saying where someone is***Answer:** Ana está en Madrid.**Also accepted:** Ana está en Madrid; ana esta en madrid; ana esta en madrid.**39.9 Practice** — *identity, origin, state, and location***Answer:** es**Also accepted:** ¿Es usted Ana?; Es usted Ana?

39.10 Practice — *identity, origin, state, and location***Answer:** Soy de Madrid.**Also accepted:** Soy de Madrid**39.11 Practice** — *identity, origin, state, and location***Answer:** Ana está en Madrid.**Also accepted:** Ana está en Madrid; ana esta en madrid; ana esta en madrid.**39.12 Practice** — *identity, origin, state, and location***Answer:** está**Also accepted:** ¿Está usted bien?; Esta usted bien?; esta

Chapter 40

40.1 ir — *“to go,” from more than one historical stem***Answer:** voy, vas, va**Also accepted:** voy vas va; voy / vas / va**40.2 ir** — *“to go,” from more than one historical stem***Answer:** va**Also accepted:** ¿Dónde va usted?; Donde va usted?**40.3 voy a + infinitive** — *moving toward the near future***Answer:** Voy a hablar.**Also accepted:** Voy a hablar**40.4 voy a + infinitive** — *moving toward the near future***Answer:** Vas a comer.**Also accepted:** Vas a comer**40.5 mi, tu, su** — *whose café?***Answer:** mi café**Also accepted:** mi cafe**40.6 mi, tu, su** — *whose café?***Answer:** su café**Also accepted:** su cafe**40.7 Practice** — *going, approaching events, and ownership***Answer:** voy, vas, va**Also accepted:** voy vas va; voy / vas / va**40.8 Practice** — *going, approaching events, and ownership***Answer:** ¿Dónde va usted?**Also accepted:** Dónde va usted?; Donde va usted?; ¿Donde va usted?**40.9 Practice** — *going, approaching events, and ownership***Answer:** Voy a hablar.**Also accepted:** Voy a hablar**40.10 Practice** — *going, approaching events, and ownership***Answer:** su café**Also accepted:** su cafe

Chapter 41

41.1 *somos* — “we are”

Answer: *somos*

Also accepted: *nosotros somos*

41.2 *somos* — “we are”

Answer: it is two Latin verbs fused

Also accepted: two verbs; *esse* and *sedere*; it comes from two verbs

41.3 *son* — “they are”

Answer: *son*

Also accepted: *ellos son*; *ustedes son*

41.4 *son* — “they are”

Answer: *sunt*

Also accepted: *sunt*, minus the *t*

41.5 *sois* — the last of the six

Answer: *sois*

Also accepted: *vosotros sois*

41.6 *sois* — the last of the six

Answer: *son*

Also accepted: *ustedes son*

41.7 Review — all of *ser*

Answer: *somos*

Also accepted: *nosotros somos*

41.8 Review — all of *ser*

Answer: *son*

Also accepted: *ellos son*

41.9 Review — all of *ser*

Answer: *eres*, it came from a different Latin form

Also accepted: *eres*; *eres* - different origin; *eres*, from *eris*

Chapter 42

42.1 *estamos* — the other “we are”

Answer: *estamos*

Also accepted: *nosotros estamos*

42.2 *estamos* — the other “we are”

Answer: *estar* is one Latin verb, *ser* is two fused

Also accepted: *estar* is one verb; *ser* is two verbs, *estar* is one; because *estar* has one ancestor

42.3 *están* — “they are”

Answer: *están*

Also accepted: *están*; *ellos están*; *ustedes están*

42.4 *están* — “they are”**Answer:** the stress is on the ending**Also accepted:** because *estar* stresses the ending; stress on the last syllable**42.5** *estáis* — *and nothing surprises you***Answer:** *estais***Also accepted:** *estáis*; *vosotros estais***42.6** *estáis* — *and nothing surprises you***Answer:** *estan***Also accepted:** *están*; *ustedes estan***42.7** *Review* — *both verbs for “to be”***Answer:** *estamos***Also accepted:** *nosotros estamos***42.8** *Review* — *both verbs for “to be”***Answer:** *estan***Also accepted:** *están*; *ellos estan***42.9** *Review* — *both verbs for “to be”***Answer:** *estar*, because it is one Latin verb**Also accepted:** *estar*; *estar* - one verb; *estar*, it has one ancestor

Chapter 43

43.1 *tenemos* — *and the stem change disappears***Answer:** *tenemos***Also accepted:** *nosotros tenemos***43.2** *tenemos* — *and the stem change disappears***Answer:** the stress is on the stem in *tienes* and on the ending in *tenemos***Also accepted:** stress; because of where the stress falls; *tenemos* stresses the ending**43.3** *tienen* — *the break comes back***Answer:** *tienen***Also accepted:** *ellos tienen*; *ustedes tienen***43.4** *tienen* — *the break comes back***Answer:** *nosotros* and *vosotros***Also accepted:** *nosotros*, *vosotros*; *we* and *you* all**43.5** *tienen* — *the break comes back***Answer:** whether the stem is stressed**Also accepted:** stress; where the stress falls

Chapter 44

44.1 *vamos* — *from a verb that is not ir***Answer:** *vamos***Also accepted:** *nosotros vamos*

44.2 *vamos* — *from a verb that is not ir*

Answer: the present comes from a different verb, *vadere*

Also accepted: it is a different verb; from *vadere*; *ir* is two verbs

44.3 *vamos* — *from a verb that is not ir*

Answer: go and went

Also accepted: go, went; went is from *wend*

44.4 *van* — *and the four are done*

Answer: van

Also accepted: ellos van; ustedes van

44.5 *van* — *and the four are done*

Answer: son and estan

Also accepted: son, están; son y estan

44.6 *van* — *and the four are done*

Answer: it is more than one verb

Also accepted: two verbs fused; it is several words; suppletion

Chapter 45

45.1 *querer* — *wanting with one familiar vowel change*

Answer: quiero, quieres, quiere

Also accepted: quiero quieres quiere; quiero / quieres / quiere

45.2 *querer* — *wanting with one familiar vowel change*

Answer: Quiero hablar.

Also accepted: Quiero hablar

45.3 *poder* — *ability with the o → ue change*

Answer: puedo, puedes, puede

Also accepted: puedo puedes puede; puedo / puedes / puede

45.4 *poder* — *ability with the o → ue change*

Answer: Puedes comer.

Also accepted: Puedes comer

45.5 *e → ie and o → ue* — *compare the singular forms*

Answer: quiero, puedo

Also accepted: quiero puedo; quiero / puedo

45.6 *e → ie and o → ue* — *compare the singular forms*

Answer: tienes, quieres, puedes

Also accepted: tienes quieres puedes; tienes / quieres / puedes

45.7 *nuestro, nuestra* — *“our” with singular gender agreement*

Answer: nuestro día

Also accepted: nuestro dia

45.8 *nuestro, nuestra* — *“our” with singular gender agreement*

Answer: nuestra noche

Also accepted: nuestra noche.

45.9 *Practice — wanting, ability, and our known nouns***Answer:** quiero, quieres, quiere**Also accepted:** quiero quieres quiere; quiero / quieres / quiere**45.10** *Practice — wanting, ability, and our known nouns***Answer:** puedo, puedes, puede**Also accepted:** puedo puedes puede; puedo / puedes / puede**45.11** *Practice — wanting, ability, and our known nouns***Answer:** Quiero hablar.**Also accepted:** Quiero hablar**45.12** *Practice — wanting, ability, and our known nouns***Answer:** Puedes comer.**Also accepted:** Puedes comer**45.13** *Practice — wanting, ability, and our known nouns***Answer:** nuestra noche**Also accepted:** nuestra noche.

Chapter 46

46.1 *hacer — doing or making with three singular forms***Answer:** hago, haces, hace**Also accepted:** hago haces hace; hago / haces / hace**46.2** *hacer — doing or making with three singular forms***Answer:** Hago café.**Also accepted:** Hago café; Hago cafe; Hago cafe.**46.3** *decir — saying with the same small person frame***Answer:** digo, dices, dice**Also accepted:** digo dices dice; digo / dices / dice**46.4** *decir — saying with the same small person frame***Answer:** Digo hola.**Also accepted:** Digo hola**46.5** *decir — saying with the same small person frame***Answer:** ¿Cómo dices ‘hola’?**Also accepted:** ¿Cómo dices hola?; Cómo dices hola?; Como dices hola?; ¿Como dices hola?**46.6** *tengo · hago · digo — compare only what you know***Answer:** tengo, hago, digo**Also accepted:** tengo hago digo; tengo / hago / digo**46.7** *tengo · hago · digo — compare only what you know***Answer:** hago**Also accepted:** yo hago

46.8 Practice — *doing, making, and saying in the singular***Answer:** hago, haces, hace**Also accepted:** hago haces hace; hago / haces / hace**46.9 Practice** — *doing, making, and saying in the singular***Answer:** digo, dices, dice**Also accepted:** digo dices dice; digo / dices / dice**46.10 Practice** — *doing, making, and saying in the singular***Answer:** tengo, hago, digo**Also accepted:** tengo hago digo; tengo / hago / digo**46.11 Practice** — *doing, making, and saying in the singular***Answer:** Hago café.**Also accepted:** Hago café; Hago cafe; Hago cafe.**46.12 Practice** — *doing, making, and saying in the singular***Answer:** ¿Cómo dices ‘hola’?**Also accepted:** ¿Cómo dices hola?; Cómo dices hola?; Como dices hola?; ¿Como dices hola?

Chapter 47

47.1 poner — *putting or placing with three singular forms***Answer:** pongo, pones, pone**Also accepted:** pongo pones pone; pongo / pones / pone**47.2 poner** — *putting or placing with three singular forms***Answer:** to put or to place**Also accepted:** put or place; to put and to place; put and place

Chapter 48

48.1 salir — *leaving with three singular forms***Answer:** salgo, sales, sale**Also accepted:** salgo sales sale; salgo / sales / sale**48.2 salir** — *leaving with three singular forms***Answer:** Salgo de Madrid.**Also accepted:** Salgo de Madrid

Chapter 49

49.1 venir — *coming with three singular forms***Answer:** vengo, vienes, viene**Also accepted:** vengo vienes viene; vengo / vienes / viene

49.2 *venir — coming with three singular forms***Answer:** Vengo de Madrid.**Also accepted:** Vengo de Madrid**49.3** *venir — coming with three singular forms***Answer:** vienes, tienes**Also accepted:** vienes tienes; vienes / tienes

Chapter 50

50.1 *Review — six verbs, one ending***Answer:** six**Also accepted:** 6; seis**50.2** *Review — six verbs, one ending***Answer:** the yo slot**Also accepted:** yo; the I form; first person**50.3** *Review — six verbs, one ending***Answer:** no, they converged by accident**Also accepted:** no; they are not a family; they arrived by different routes**50.4** *Practice — putting, leaving, and coming in the singular***Answer:** pongo, pones, pone**Also accepted:** pongo pones pone; pongo / pones / pone**50.5** *Practice — putting, leaving, and coming in the singular***Answer:** salgo, sales, sale**Also accepted:** salgo sales sale; salgo / sales / sale**50.6** *Practice — putting, leaving, and coming in the singular***Answer:** vengo, vienes, viene**Also accepted:** vengo vienes viene; vengo / vienes / viene**50.7** *Practice — putting, leaving, and coming in the singular***Answer:** Salgo de Madrid; vengo de Madrid.**Also accepted:** Salgo de Madrid. Vengo de Madrid.; Salgo de Madrid, vengo de Madrid; Salgo de Madrid y vengo de Madrid**50.8** *Practice — putting, leaving, and coming in the singular***Answer:** tengo, hago, digo, pongo, salgo, vengo**Also accepted:** tengo hago digo pongo salgo vengo; tengo / hago / digo / pongo / salgo / vengo**50.9** *Practice — putting, leaving, and coming in the singular***Answer:** poner—position; salir—salient; venir—convene**Also accepted:** poner position salir salient venir convene; poner: position; salir: salient; venir: convene; position salient convene

Chapter 51

51.1 *Synthesis — you, and somebody else*

Answer: salgo

Also accepted: yo salgo

51.2 *Synthesis — you, and somebody else*

Answer: sale, and no

Also accepted: sale; sale - regular; no, sale

51.3 *Synthesis — you, and somebody else*

Answer: the yo slot

Also accepted: yo; the I form; first person

Chapter 52

52.1 *queremos, quieren — work them out first*

Answer: queremos

Also accepted: nosotros queremos

52.2 *queremos, quieren — work them out first*

Answer: pueden

Also accepted: ellos pueden; ustedes pueden

52.3 *queremos, quieren — work them out first*

Answer: podemos

Also accepted: nosotros podemos

52.4 *hacemos, hacen — and the club has no plural at all*

Answer: hacemos

Also accepted: nosotros hacemos

52.5 *hacemos, hacen — and the club has no plural at all*

Answer: salen

Also accepted: ellos salen; ustedes salen

52.6 *hacemos, hacen — and the club has no plural at all*

Answer: decimos and dicen

Also accepted: decimos, dicen

52.7 *Synthesis — a verb you have never met*

Answer: salimos

Also accepted: nosotros salimos

52.8 *Synthesis — a verb you have never met*

Answer: salen

Also accepted: ellos salen

52.9 *Synthesis — a verb you have never met*

Answer: three

Also accepted: 3; tres

Chapter 53

53.1 *la casa* — “house,” and “home”

Answer: la casa

Also accepted: casa

53.2 *la casa* — “house,” and “home”

Answer: tengo una casa

Also accepted: yo tengo una casa

53.3 *la casa* — “house,” and “home”

Answer: chez

Also accepted: chez, as in chez moi

Chapter 54

54.1 *el libro* — “book”

Answer: el libro

Also accepted: libro

54.2 *el libro* — “book”

Answer: tengo un libro

Also accepted: yo tengo un libro

54.3 *el libro* — “book”

Answer: the inner bark of a tree

Also accepted: tree bark; bark

Chapter 55

55.1 *la comida* — “food,” built from a verb you have

Answer: comida

Also accepted: la comida

55.2 *la comida* — “food,” built from a verb you have

Answer: hago la comida

Also accepted: yo hago la comida

55.3 *la comida* — “food,” built from a verb you have

Answer: feminine

Also accepted: always feminine

Chapter 56

56.1 *las casas* — “the houses”

Answer: las casas

Also accepted: las casa s

56.2 *las casas* — “the houses”

Answer: las comidas

Also accepted: comidas

56.3 *las casas* — “the houses”

Answer: none

Also accepted: zero; 0

Chapter 57

57.1 *los libros* — “the books”

Answer: los libros

Also accepted: libros

57.2 *los libros* — “the books”

Answer: the plural kept the vowel the singular lost

Also accepted: el is a worn-down elo; they wore down differently

57.3 *los libros* — “the books”

Answer: el, la, los, las

Also accepted: el la los las; el / la / los / las

Chapter 58

58.1 *-es* — the plural your first chapter owed you

Answer: espanoles

Also accepted: los espanoles

58.2 *-es* — the plural your first chapter owed you

Answer: ustedes

Also accepted: usted becomes ustedes; usted

58.3 *-es* — the plural your first chapter owed you

Answer: the bare s would be unsayable

Also accepted: you cannot pronounce it; spanish needs a vowel to get the s out

Chapter 59

59.1 *Review* — all four words for “the”

Answer: el, la, los, las

Also accepted: el la los las; el / la / los / las

59.2 *Review* — all four words for “the”

Answer: los libros, las casas

Also accepted: los libros las casas

59.3 *Review — all four words for “the”*

Answer: add -s, or -es when the bare s would be unsayable

Also accepted: -s after a vowel and -es after a consonant

Chapter 60

60.1 *Synthesis — more than one*

Answer: tengo libros

Also accepted: yo tengo libros

60.2 *Synthesis — more than one*

Answer: tengo los libros

Also accepted: yo tengo los libros

60.3 *Synthesis — more than one*

Answer: hago comidas

Also accepted: yo hago comidas

60.4 *Synthesis — more than one*

Answer: houses in general versus particular known ones

Also accepted: one is indefinite and one is definite; las casas means the houses

Chapter 61

61.1 *lo — “it”*

Answer: lo tengo

Also accepted: yo lo tengo

61.2 *lo — “it”*

Answer: before

Also accepted: in front of it; before the verb

61.3 *lo — “it”*

Answer: el

Also accepted: the article el; el, the article

Chapter 62

62.1 *la — “it,” for a feminine noun*

Answer: la hago

Also accepted: yo la hago

62.2 *la — “it,” for a feminine noun*

Answer: the gender of the noun it replaces

Also accepted: the noun’s gender; whether the noun is masculine or feminine

62.3 *la* — “it,” for a feminine noun

Answer: the masculine lost a vowel and the feminine had none to lose

Also accepted: only the masculine wore down; the sound change only hit the masculine

Chapter 63

63.1 *me quieres* — “you love me”

Answer: me quieres

Also accepted: tu me quieres

63.2 *me quieres* — “you love me”

Answer: it is the person the verb lands on

Also accepted: it is the object; it is who is being loved

63.3 *me quieres* — “you love me”

Answer: none

Also accepted: zero; 0

63.4 *te quiero* — “I love you”

Answer: te quiero

Also accepted: yo te quiero

63.5 *te quiero* — “I love you”

Answer: querer aimed at a person means to love

Also accepted: because the object is a person; with people it means love

63.6 *te quiero* — “I love you”

Answer: thou and thee

Also accepted: thou thee; thee and thou

Chapter 64

64.1 *Review* — four pronouns, one slot

Answer: me, te, lo, la

Also accepted: me te lo la; me / te / lo / la

64.2 *Review* — four pronouns, one slot

Answer: who or what the verb lands on

Also accepted: who is receiving the action; what the object is

64.3 *Review* — four pronouns, one slot

Answer: lo and la

Also accepted: lo, la; la and lo

Chapter 65

65.1 *Synthesis — saying it once*

Answer: si, lo tengo

Also accepted: lo tengo; si lo tengo

65.2 *Synthesis — saying it once*

Answer: si, la hago

Also accepted: la hago; si la hago

65.3 *Synthesis — saying it once*

Answer: me quieres

Also accepted: y yo te quiero; te quiero

65.4 *Synthesis — saying it once*

Answer: it named the same thing twice

Also accepted: it repeated the noun; nobody talks like that

Chapter 66

66.1 *nos — “us”*

Answer: nos quieren

Also accepted: ellos nos quieren

66.2 *nos — “us”*

Answer: -mos

Also accepted: the -mos ending; mos

66.3 *nos — “us”*

Answer: nos and otros, we others

Also accepted: nos + otros; we others

Chapter 67

67.1 *los and las — “them”*

Answer: los tengo

Also accepted: yo los tengo

67.2 *los and las — “them”*

Answer: las hago

Also accepted: yo las hago

67.3 *los and las — “them”*

Answer: lo never lost the vowel el lost

Also accepted: it kept its vowel; there was nothing to repair

Chapter 68

68.1 *os* — “you all,” in Spain

Answer: os quiero

Also accepted: yo os quiero

68.2 *os* — “you all,” in Spain

Answer: los quiero

Also accepted: las quiero; los quiero a ustedes

68.3 *os* — “you all,” in Spain

Answer: vos, in Argentina

Also accepted: vos; vos, in the river plate region

Chapter 69

69.1 *Review* — all eight

Answer: me, te, lo, la, nos, os, los, las

Also accepted: me te lo la nos os los las

69.2 *Review* — all eight

Answer: lo, la, los, las

Also accepted: lo la los las; the bottom two rows

69.3 *Review* — all eight

Answer: los and las

Also accepted: los, las

Chapter 70

70.1 *Synthesis* — the conversation without them

Answer: si, los tengo

Also accepted: los tengo; si los tengo

70.2 *Synthesis* — the conversation without them

Answer: las hago

Also accepted: si, las hago; las hago hoy

70.3 *Synthesis* — the conversation without them

Answer: nos quieren

Also accepted: ellos nos quieren

70.4 *Synthesis* — the conversation without them

Answer: they look for a masculine thing and there is not one

Also accepted: the pronoun points at nothing; the gender does not match what was said

Chapter 71

71.1 *le* — “to him,” “to her,” “to you”

Answer: le digo

Also accepted: yo le digo

71.2 *le* — “to him,” “to her,” “to you”

Answer: none

Also accepted: one form for all; it does not mark gender

71.3 *le* — “to him,” “to her,” “to you”

Answer: illi, for the one the action is aimed at

Also accepted: illi, the dative; illi

Chapter 72

72.1 *les* — “to them,” and what this system really costs

Answer: les digo

Also accepted: yo les digo

72.2 *les* — “to them,” and what this system really costs

Answer: two

Also accepted: 2; le and les

72.3 *les* — “to them,” and what this system really costs

Answer: me, te, nos, os

Also accepted: me te nos os

Chapter 73

73.1 *Which one is the verb asking for?*

Answer: does the verb act on it or aim at it

Also accepted: can you put to in front of it in english; to whom versus what

73.2 *Which one is the verb asking for?*

Answer: le hablo

Also accepted: yo le hablo

73.3 *Which one is the verb asking for?*

Answer: lo tengo, direct

Also accepted: lo tengo

73.4 *Which one is the verb asking for?*

Answer: no, it is leismo and it is accepted

Also accepted: no; no, that is normal in spain

Chapter 74

74.1 *Review — two systems, two new words*

Answer: me, te, le, nos, os, les

Also accepted: me te le nos os les

74.2 *Review — two systems, two new words*

Answer: the him/her row: lo and la versus le

Also accepted: the third row; lo la versus le

74.3 *Review — two systems, two new words*

Answer: nine

Also accepted: 9; me te lo la le nos os los las les

Chapter 75

75.1 *Synthesis — the thing and the person, in one sentence*

Answer: si, lo tengo

Also accepted: lo tengo

75.2 *Synthesis — the thing and the person, in one sentence*

Answer: le digo hoy

Also accepted: le digo

75.3 *Synthesis — the thing and the person, in one sentence*

Answer: les hablo

Also accepted: yo les hablo

75.4 *Synthesis — the thing and the person, in one sentence*

Answer: what you mean

Also accepted: the meaning; whether the verb acts on it or aims at it

Chapter 76

76.1 *me lo — both at once*

Answer: te lo digo

Also accepted: yo te lo digo

76.2 *me lo — both at once*

Answer: the person

Also accepted: indirect first; the indirect one

76.3 *me lo — both at once*

Answer: me la haces

Also accepted: tu me la haces

Chapter 77

77.1 *se lo — the pair that does not exist*

Answer: se lo digo

Also accepted: yo se lo digo

77.2 *se lo — the pair that does not exist*

Answer: lo, la, los, las

Also accepted: lo la los las; the direct object pronouns for things

77.3 *se lo — the pair that does not exist*

Answer: five: him, her, you, them, you all

Also accepted: five; him her you them or you all

Chapter 78

78.1 *Why se? — and why it is not the se you know*

Answer: gelo

Also accepted: ge lo

78.2 *Why se? — and why it is not the se you know*

Answer: no

Also accepted: no, they are unrelated; no, they only sound alike

78.3 *Why se? — and why it is not the se you know*

Answer: illi and illum

Also accepted: illi, illum; the dative and the accusative

Chapter 79

79.1 *Review — the pairs*

Answer: person first, and le becomes se before the thing

Also accepted: indirect first; le and les become se

79.2 *Review — the pairs*

Answer: nos lo

Also accepted: nos la; nos lo or nos la

79.3 *Review — the pairs*

Answer: none

Also accepted: zero; 0

Chapter 80

80.1 *Synthesis — two at a time*

Answer: te lo digo

Also accepted: ¿te lo digo?; te lo digo?

80.2 *Synthesis — two at a time***Answer:** se la hago**Also accepted:** yo se la hago**80.3** *Synthesis — two at a time***Answer:** none**Also accepted:** zero; 0**80.4** *Synthesis — two at a time***Answer:** no, it becomes about something else**Also accepted:** no; it stays grammatical but means something else

Chapter 81

81.1 *fui — one past set shared by ser and ir***Answer:** fui, fuiste, fue**Also accepted:** fui fuiste fue; fui / fuiste / fue**81.2** *fui — one past set shared by ser and ir***Answer:** Fui a Madrid.**Also accepted:** Fui a Madrid**81.3** *fui — one past set shared by ser and ir***Answer:** ser**81.4** *hablé — a regular singular past from a known verb***Answer:** hablé, hablaste, habló**Also accepted:** hablé hablaste habló; hablé / hablaste / habló**81.5** *hablé — a regular singular past from a known verb***Answer:** Hablé español.**Also accepted:** Hablé español**81.6** *hablé — a regular singular past from a known verb***Answer:** hablé**81.7** *Practice — two singular ways to talk about a completed past***Answer:** fui, fuiste, fue**Also accepted:** fui fuiste fue; fui / fuiste / fue**81.8** *Practice — two singular ways to talk about a completed past***Answer:** hablé, hablaste, habló**Also accepted:** hablé hablaste habló; hablé / hablaste / habló**81.9** *Practice — two singular ways to talk about a completed past***Answer:** Fui a Madrid.**Also accepted:** Fui a Madrid**81.10** *Practice — two singular ways to talk about a completed past***Answer:** Hablo español. Hablé español.**Also accepted:** Hablo español; hablé español; Hablo español. Hablé español; hablo español hablé español

81.11 Practice — *two singular ways to talk about a completed past***Answer:** hablé and habló**Also accepted:** hablé habló; hablé y habló; hablé / habló

Chapter 82

82.1 comí — *one regular -er singular past***Answer:** comí, comiste, comió**Also accepted:** comí comiste comió; comí / comiste / comió**82.2 comí** — *one regular -er singular past***Answer:** comí**82.3 comí** — *one regular -er singular past***Answer:** sound change plus analogy**Also accepted:** sound change and analogy; sound change, plus analogy**82.4 viví** — *reuse one past pattern with an -ir verb***Answer:** viví, viviste, vivió**Also accepted:** viví viviste vivió; viví / viviste / vivió**82.5 viví** — *reuse one past pattern with an -ir verb***Answer:** Viví en Madrid.**Also accepted:** Viví en Madrid**82.6 viví** — *reuse one past pattern with an -ir verb***Answer:** -í, -iste, -ió**Also accepted:** í iste ió; -í -iste -ió; -í / -iste / -ió

Chapter 83

83.1 tuve — *let the strong stem carry the stress***Answer:** tuve, tuviste, tuvo**Also accepted:** tuve tuviste tuvo; tuve / tuviste / tuvo**83.2 tuve** — *let the strong stem carry the stress***Answer:** Tuve café.**Also accepted:** Tuve café**83.3 tuve** — *let the strong stem carry the stress***Answer:** a historically reshaped strong form**Also accepted:** historically reshaped strong form; a reshaped strong form**83.4 hice** — *the strong pattern with one third-person swerve***Answer:** hice, hiciste, hizo**Also accepted:** hice hiciste hizo; hice / hiciste / hizo**83.5 hice** — *the strong pattern with one third-person swerve***Answer:** Hice café.**Also accepted:** Hice café

83.6 *hice* — the strong pattern with one third-person *swerve*

Answer: *fēcī*

Also accepted: *feci*

83.7 *estuve* — a third known verb joins the strong pattern

Answer: *estuve, estuviste, estuvo*

Also accepted: *estuve estuviste estuvo; esteve / estuviste / estuvo*

83.8 *estuve* — a third known verb joins the strong pattern

Answer: *Estuve bien.*

Also accepted: *Estuve bien*

83.9 *estuve* — a third known verb joins the strong pattern

Answer: *tuve*

Chapter 84

84.1 *Practice* — six singular patterns, no hidden vocabulary

Answer: *hablé, comí, viví*

Also accepted: *hablé comí viví; hablé / comí / viví*

84.2 *Practice* — six singular patterns, no hidden vocabulary

Answer: *tuve, hice, estuve*

Also accepted: *tuve hice estuve; tuve / hice / estuve*

84.3 *Practice* — six singular patterns, no hidden vocabulary

Answer: *Hice café.*

Also accepted: *Hice café*

84.4 *Practice* — six singular patterns, no hidden vocabulary

Answer: *Viví en Madrid.*

Also accepted: *Viví en Madrid*

84.5 *Practice* — six singular patterns, no hidden vocabulary

Answer: *Estuve bien.*

Also accepted: *Estuve bien*

84.6 *Practice* — six singular patterns, no hidden vocabulary

Answer: *comí and comió*

Also accepted: *comí comió; comí/comió; comí y comió*

84.7 *Practice* — six singular patterns, no hidden vocabulary

Answer: *estuve*

84.8 *Synthesis* — you can hear which past it is

Answer: on the stem, a strong preterite

Also accepted: stem, strong; on the stem; strong preterite

84.9 *Synthesis* — you can hear which past it is

Answer: the stress is on its final vowel

Also accepted: because the stress is on the ending; stressed final vowel; the ending is stressed

84.10 *Synthesis — you can hear which past it is*

Answer: yes

Also accepted: yes, the same; they agree; identical

Chapter 85

85.1 *hablaba — let a past action stay open*

Answer: hablaba, hablabas, hablaba

Also accepted: hablaba hablabas hablaba; hablaba / hablabas / hablaba

85.2 *hablaba — let a past action stay open*

Answer: hablaba

85.3 *hablaba — let a past action stay open*

Answer: b

Also accepted: the b; b sound

85.4 *comía — hear both vowels*

Answer: comía, comías, comía

Also accepted: comía comías comía; comía / comías / comía

85.5 *comía — hear both vowels*

Answer: comía

85.6 *comía — hear both vowels*

Answer: co-mí-a

85.7 *vivía — reuse the complete -er row*

Answer: vivía, vivías, vivía

Also accepted: vivía vivías vivía; vivía / vivías / vivía

85.8 *vivía — reuse the complete -er row*

Answer: -er and -ir

Also accepted: er and ir; -er / -ir; er ir

85.9 *vivía — reuse the complete -er row*

Answer: Vivía en Madrid.

Also accepted: Vivía en Madrid

Chapter 86

86.1 *ver — learn the verb before its past*

Answer: to see

Also accepted: see

86.2 *ver — learn the verb before its past*

Answer: veo, ves, ve

Also accepted: veo ves ve; veo / ves / ve

86.3 *ver* — learn the verb before its past

Answer: vidēre

Also accepted: videre

Chapter 87

87.1 *era* — an old root in an open past

Answer: era, eras, era

Also accepted: era eras era; era / eras / era

87.2 *era* — an old root in an open past

Answer: era

87.3 *era* — an old root in an open past

Answer: eram

87.4 *iba* — *ir* returns to its inherited past

Answer: iba, ibas, iba

Also accepted: iba ibas iba; iba / ibas / iba

87.5 *iba* — *ir* returns to its inherited past

Answer: Iba a Madrid.

Also accepted: Iba a Madrid

87.6 *iba* — *ir* returns to its inherited past

Answer: īre

Also accepted: ire

87.7 *veía* — keep the extra *e* you already met

Answer: veía, veías, veía

Also accepted: veía veías veía; veía / veías / veía

87.8 *veía* — keep the extra *e* you already met

Answer: Veía café.

87.9 *veía* — keep the extra *e* you already met

Answer: veer

Chapter 88

88.1 *Practice* — keep the past open or close it

Answer: hablaba, comía, vivía

Also accepted: hablaba comía vivía; hablaba / comía / vivía

88.2 *Practice* — keep the past open or close it

Answer: era, iba, veía

Also accepted: era iba veía; era / iba / veía

88.3 *Practice* — keep the past open or close it

Answer: Hablaba español.

Also accepted: Hablaba español

88.4 Practice — *keep the past open or close it*

Answer: Vivía en Madrid.

Also accepted: Vivía en Madrid

88.5 Practice — *keep the past open or close it*

Answer: Iba a Madrid.

Also accepted: Iba a Madrid

88.6 Practice — *keep the past open or close it*

Answer: comía

88.7 Practice — *keep the past open or close it*

Answer: era—eram; iba—ibam; veía—veer

Also accepted: era eram iba ibam veía veer; era-eram, iba-ibam, veía-veer

88.8 Synthesis — *three exceptions, and no others*

Answer: three

Also accepted: 3; tres; only three

88.9 Synthesis — *three exceptions, and no others*

Answer: ser, ir, ver

Also accepted: era, iba, veía; ser ir ver; to be, to go, to see

88.10 Synthesis — *three exceptions, and no others*

Answer: they are the most used verbs, so they were never regularised

Also accepted: because they are used constantly; most common verbs; they were never tidied up

Chapter 89

89.1 hablaba and habló — *two ways of looking*

Answer: no, in how you look at it

Also accepted: no; they differ in viewpoint

89.2 hablaba and habló — *two ways of looking*

Answer: hable

Also accepted: hablé; the preterite

89.3 hablaba and habló — *two ways of looking*

Answer: estudiaba

Also accepted: yo estudiaba

Chapter 90

90.1 cuando — *putting both pasts in one sentence*

Answer: estudiaba cuando hablo Ana

Also accepted: estudiaba cuando habló ana

90.2 cuando — *putting both pasts in one sentence*

Answer: the imperfect sets the room, the preterite walks in

Also accepted: imperfect is the scene, preterite is the event

90.3 *cuando — putting both pasts in one sentence*

Answer: que, quien, como

Also accepted: qué, quién, cómo; que and quien

Chapter 91

91.1 *tenía and tuve — when the tense changes the meaning*

Answer: tenía una casa

Also accepted: tenía una casa; yo tenía una casa

91.2 *tenía and tuve — when the tense changes the meaning*

Answer: i got a house

Also accepted: i received a house; the moment i came to have one

91.3 *tenía and tuve — when the tense changes the meaning*

Answer: the moment the state began

Also accepted: when it started; the start of the state

Chapter 92

92.1 *Review — one question, three answers*

Answer: am i saying what happened or what things were like

Also accepted: what happened versus what things were like; does it have edges

92.2 *Review — one question, three answers*

Answer: estudiaba

Also accepted: the imperfect one; estudiaba, the imperfect

92.3 *Review — one question, three answers*

Answer: the state rows, tenía and tuve

Also accepted: rows three and four; tenía and tuve

Chapter 93

93.1 *Synthesis — a small story*

Answer: estudiaba and tenía

Also accepted: estudiaba, tenía; the imperfects

93.2 *Synthesis — a small story*

Answer: tuve is the moment of getting it

Also accepted: because it is an event, not a state; getting has edges

93.3 *Synthesis — a small story*

Answer: estudiaba cuando hable con Ana

Also accepted: estudiaba cuando hablé con ana

93.4 *Synthesis — a small story***Answer:** because the choice is the difficulty, not the forms**Also accepted:** english lets you leave the question unanswered; the forms were never the hard part**Chapter 94****94.1** *hablaré — keep the infinitive, add the future***Answer:** hablaré, hablarás, hablará**Also accepted:** hablaré hablarás hablará; hablaré / hablarás / hablará**94.2** *hablaré — keep the infinitive, add the future***Answer:** Hablaré español.**Also accepted:** Hablaré español**94.3** *hablaré — keep the infinitive, add the future***Answer:** habēre**Also accepted:** habere; haber**94.4** *comeré — the same endings keep -er***Answer:** comeré, comerás, comerá**Also accepted:** comeré comerás comerá; comeré / comerás / comerá**94.5** *comeré — the same endings keep -er***Answer:** Beberé café.**Also accepted:** Beberé café; Bebere cafe; Bebere cafe.**94.6** *comeré — the same endings keep -er***Answer:** -é, -ás, -á**Also accepted:** é ás á; -é -ás -á**94.7** *viviré — one future row for three verb families***Answer:** viviré, vivirás, vivirá**Also accepted:** viviré vivirás vivirá; viviré / vivirás / vivirá**94.8** *viviré — one future row for three verb families***Answer:** Viviré en Madrid.**Also accepted:** Viviré en Madrid**94.9** *viviré — one future row for three verb families***Answer:** hablaré, comeré, viviré**Also accepted:** hablaré comeré viviré; hablaré / comeré / viviré**Chapter 95****95.1** *hablaría — the whole infinitive meets -ía***Answer:** hablaría, hablarías, hablaría**Also accepted:** hablaría hablarías hablaría; hablaría / hablarías / hablaría

95.2 *hablaría — the whole infinitive meets -ía*

Answer: Hablaría español.

Also accepted: Hablaría español

95.3 *hablaría — the whole infinitive meets -ía*

Answer: ha-bla-rí-a

Also accepted: habla-rí-a; rí-a

95.4 *comería — keep -er before “would”*

Answer: comería, comerías, comería

Also accepted: comería comerías comería; comería / comerías / comería

95.5 *comería — keep -er before “would”*

Answer: Comeré; comería.

Also accepted: Comeré comería; comeré / comería

95.6 *comería — keep -er before “would”*

Answer: -ía, -ías, -ía

Also accepted: ía ías ía; -ía -ías -ía

95.7 *viviría — the regular conditional closes its small frame*

Answer: viviría, vivirías, viviría

Also accepted: viviría vivirías viviría; viviría / vivirías / viviría

95.8 *viviría — the regular conditional closes its small frame*

Answer: Viviría en Madrid.

Also accepted: Viviría en Madrid

95.9 *viviría — the regular conditional closes its small frame*

Answer: hablaría, comería, viviría

Also accepted: hablaría comería viviría; hablaría / comería / viviría

Chapter 96

96.1 *haré · tendré · podré — three stems, two ending sets*

Answer: Haré café; haría café.

Also accepted: Haré café Haría café; haré café / haría café

96.2 *haré · tendré · podré — three stems, two ending sets*

Answer: tendré, tendría

Also accepted: tendré tendría; tendré / tendría

96.3 *haré · tendré · podré — three stems, two ending sets*

Answer: Podré hablar español; podría hablar español.

Also accepted: Podré hablar español Podría hablar español; podré hablar español / podría hablar español

96.4 *Practice — one infinitive frame, two futures of thought*

Answer: hablaré, comeré, viviré

Also accepted: hablaré comeré viviré; hablaré / comeré / viviré

96.5 Practice — *one infinitive frame, two futures of thought*

Answer: hablaría, comería, viviría

Also accepted: hablaría comería viviría; hablaría / comería / viviría

96.6 Practice — *one infinitive frame, two futures of thought*

Answer: Hablaré español.

Also accepted: Hablaré español

96.7 Practice — *one infinitive frame, two futures of thought*

Answer: Viviría en Madrid.

Also accepted: Viviría en Madrid

96.8 Practice — *one infinitive frame, two futures of thought*

Answer: Haré café; haría café.

Also accepted: Haré café Haría café; haré café / haría café

96.9 Practice — *one infinitive frame, two futures of thought*

Answer: har-, tendr-, podr-

Also accepted: har tendr podr; har- / tendr- / podr-

96.10 Practice — *one infinitive frame, two futures of thought*

Answer: habere

Also accepted: habere; haber

Chapter 97

97.1 Synthesis — *promising, and supposing*

Answer: hablare

Also accepted: hablaré; yo hablare

97.2 Synthesis — *promising, and supposing*

Answer: hablaria

Also accepted: hablaría; yo hablaria

97.3 Synthesis — *promising, and supposing*

Answer: haber

Also accepted: habere; the verb to have; have

Chapter 98

98.1 Hablas español · *Quiero que hables español — fact or wanted event?*

Answer: hablas

98.2 Hablas español · *Quiero que hables español — fact or wanted event?*

Answer: Quiero hablar español.

Also accepted: Quiero hablar español

98.3 Hablas español · *Quiero que hables español — fact or wanted event?*

Answer: Quiero que hables español.

Also accepted: Quiero que hables español

Chapter 99

99.1 *hable · hables · hable — the singular -ar row*

Answer: hable, hables, hable

Also accepted: hable hables hable; hable / hables / hable

99.2 *hable · hables · hable — the singular -ar row*

Answer: hablo

99.3 *hable · hables · hable — the singular -ar row*

Answer: subjoined or joined under

Also accepted: subjoined; joined under

99.4 *coma · comas · coma — let -er cross to a*

Answer: coma, comas, coma

Also accepted: coma comas coma; coma / comas / coma

99.5 *coma · comas · coma — let -er cross to a*

Answer: comas

99.6 *coma · comas · coma — let -er cross to a*

Answer: Quiero que comas.

Also accepted: Quiero que comas

99.7 *viva · vivas · viva — -ir joins -er*

Answer: viva, vivas, viva

Also accepted: viva vivas viva; viva / vivas / viva

99.8 *viva · vivas · viva — -ir joins -er*

Answer: -er and -ir

Also accepted: er and ir; -er / -ir

99.9 *viva · vivas · viva — -ir joins -er*

Answer: Quiero que vivas en Madrid.

Also accepted: Quiero que vivas en Madrid

Chapter 100

100.1 *quiera · quieras · quiera — keep the change you know*

Answer: quiera, quieras, quiera

Also accepted: quiera quieras quiera; quiera / quieras / quiera

100.2 *quiera · quieras · quiera — keep the change you know*

Answer: quiero

100.3 *quiera · quieras · quiera — keep the change you know*

Answer: quieras

100.4 *pueda · puedas · pueda — one more known stem change*

Answer: pueda, puedas, pueda

Also accepted: pueda puedas pueda; pueda / puedas / pueda

100.5 *pueda · puedas · pueda — one more known stem change*

Answer: puedo

100.6 *pueda · puedas · pueda — one more known stem change*

Answer: Quiero que puedas hablar español.

Also accepted: Quiero que puedas hablar español

100.7 *haga · hagas · haga — hago lends its stem*

Answer: haga, hagas, haga

Also accepted: haga hagas haga; haga / hagas / haga

100.8 *haga · hagas · haga — hago lends its stem*

Answer: hago

100.9 *haga · hagas · haga — hago lends its stem*

Answer: Quiero que hagas café.

Also accepted: Quiero que hagas café; Quiero que hagas cafe

Chapter 101

101.1 *ojalá + subjunctive — a wish borrowed through Arabic*

Answer: Ojalá hables español.

Also accepted: Ojalá hables español; Ojala hables espanol

101.2 *ojalá + subjunctive — a wish borrowed through Arabic*

Answer: no

101.3 *ojalá + subjunctive — a wish borrowed through Arabic*

Answer: Hispanic Arabic

Also accepted: Arabic; Andalusí Arabic; Hispano-Arabic

101.4 *Practice — assert the event or want it*

Answer: hables

101.5 *Practice — assert the event or want it*

Answer: Quiero hablar español; quiero que hables español.

Also accepted: Quiero hablar español Quiero que hables español; Quiero hablar español / quiero que hables español

101.6 *Practice — assert the event or want it*

Answer: hables, comas, vivas

Also accepted: hables comas vivas; hables / comas / vivas

101.7 *Practice — assert the event or want it*

Answer: the yo form

Also accepted: yo; present yo form

101.8 *Practice — assert the event or want it*

Answer: quiera, quieras, quiera

Also accepted: quiera quieras quiera; quiera / quieras / quiera

101.9 *Practice — assert the event or want it*

Answer: Quiero que puedas hablar español.

Also accepted: Quiero que puedas hablar español

101.10 Practice — *assert the event or want it*

Answer: Quiero que hagas café.

Also accepted: Quiero que hagas café; Quiero que hagas cafe

101.11 Practice — *assert the event or want it*

Answer: Ojalá vivas en Madrid.

Also accepted: Ojalá vivas en Madrid; Ojala vivas en Madrid

101.12 Practice — *assert the event or want it*

Answer: a clause subjoined or joined under another

Also accepted: subjoined; joined under

101.13 Practice — *assert the event or want it*

Answer: Hispanic Arabic

Also accepted: Arabic; Andalusí Arabic; Hispano-Arabic

Chapter 102

102.1 Synthesis — *claiming, and not claiming*

Answer: hablas

Also accepted: hablas - indicative

102.2 Synthesis — *claiming, and not claiming*

Answer: hables

Also accepted: hables - subjunctive; ojala hables

102.3 Synthesis — *claiming, and not claiming*

Answer: may God will it, in Arabic

Also accepted: arabic, may god will it; and may god will it; wa sha allah

Chapter 117

117.1 Synthesis — *saying something about your own life*

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Also accepted: yo tengo un perro negro

117.2 Synthesis — *saying something about your own life*

Answer: un gato

Also accepted: un; un gato blanco

117.3 Synthesis — *saying something about your own life*

Answer: hace frío

Also accepted: hace frío

Chapter 122

122.1 *Review — four verbs of the mind*

Answer: pensar

Also accepted: pensar (to think); think

122.2 *Review — four verbs of the mind*

Answer: leer

Also accepted: leer (to read); read

122.3 *Review — four verbs of the mind*

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Chapter 123

123.1 *Synthesis — what you understand, and what you don't*

Answer: I am not stretching that far

Also accepted: i am not reaching that far; not stretching toward it; i cannot stretch that far

123.2 *Synthesis — what you understand, and what you don't*

Answer: ahora entiendo

Also accepted: entiendo; entiendo ahora

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127.1 *Review — three verbs that behave*

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Also accepted: ayudar (to help); help

127.2 *Review — three verbs that behave*

Answer: tomar

Also accepted: tomar (to take); take

127.3 *Review — three verbs that behave*

Answer: the one doing it

Also accepted: the doer; the person doing it; the subject does it

Chapter 129

129.1 *Synthesis — what you like, and who is doing the liking*

Answer: el cafe

Also accepted: the coffee; cafe; el café

129.2 *Synthesis — what you like, and who is doing the liking*

Answer: to taste

Also accepted: taste; tasting

129.3 *Synthesis — what you like, and who is doing the liking*

Answer: mucho gusto

Also accepted: gusto; much pleasure

Chapter 137

137.1 *Review — the four stem changes, all of them*

Answer: four

Also accepted: 4; cuatro

137.2 *Review — the four stem changes, all of them*

Answer: u to ue, jugar

Also accepted: u-ue, jugar; jugar, u to ue; jugar

137.3 *Review — the four stem changes, all of them*

Answer: e to i

Also accepted: e-i; e becomes i; consigo

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138.1 *Synthesis — the choices English never makes you make*

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Also accepted: conocer (acquaintance); conozco

138.2 *Synthesis — the choices English never makes you make*

Answer: traer

Also accepted: traer (toward); bring

138.3 *Synthesis — the choices English never makes you make*

Answer: pedir

Also accepted: pedir (request); pedir un café

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chapter topic; Chapter 24, p. 127

Q**queremos, quieren — work them out first**

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 52, p. 233

quiera · quieras · quiera — keep the change you know

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 100, p. 361

R**rain refuses the hacer pattern and brings its own verb — and its****ll-** is the sound change you already met in *llamar llueve*

explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 113, p. 417

red — a cousin of French rouge and English red, but by a**different branch of the same very old family rojo**

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 105, p. 381

Review — All Eight

chapter topic; Chapter 69, p. 271

Review — All Four Stem Changes

chapter topic; Chapter 137, p. 513

Review — All Four Words for The

chapter topic; Chapter 59, p. 249

Review — Four Pronouns, One Slot

chapter topic; Chapter 64, p. 261

Review — Four Verbs of the Mind

chapter topic; Chapter 122, p. 453

Review — One Question, Three Answers

chapter topic; Chapter 92, p. 337

Review — Six Verbs, One Ending

chapter topic; Chapter 50, p. 227

Review — The Pairs

chapter topic; Chapter 79, p. 291

Review — the Present Tense, Whole

chapter topic; Chapter 37, p. 163

Review — The Three Forms Side by Side

chapter topic; Chapter 19, p. 113

Review — the Whole Present Tense

chapter topic; Chapter 32, p. 151

Review — Three Verbs That Behave

chapter topic; Chapter 127, p. 467

Review — Two Systems, Two New Words

chapter topic; Chapter 74, p. 281

S**Salir — Leaving**

chapter topic; Chapter 48, p. 223

Saying Why

chapter topic; Chapter 140, p. 525

Saying Your Name

chapter topic; Chapter 4, p. 25

Se Lo — The Pair That Does Not Exist

chapter topic; Chapter 77, p. 287

se lo — the pair that does not exist

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 77, p. 287

see you later (literally “until later”) *hasta luego*

explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 13, p. 89

see you soon (literally “until soon”) *hasta pronto*

explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 13, p. 89

see you tomorrow (literally “until tomorrow”) *hasta mañana*

explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 13, p. 89

Ser and Estar — Two Ways to Be

chapter topic; Chapter 39, p. 173

Ser in the Plural

chapter topic; Chapter 41, p. 187

should, ought to — and to owe, because the word is literally “to have something from someone” *deber*

explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 140, p. 525

so-so / not great (also “más o menos”) *regular*

explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 9, p. 65

sois — the last of the six

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 41, p. 187

somos — “we are”

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 41, p. 187

son — “they are”

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 41, p. 187

“Spanish” — the language, the people, and the Roman name for the peninsula underneath it *español*

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 22, p. 121

Synthesis — A Small Story

chapter topic; Chapter 93, p. 339

Synthesis — Asking, and Answering

chapter topic; Chapter 28, p. 143

Synthesis — Claiming, and Not Claiming

chapter topic; Chapter 102, p. 369

Synthesis — More Than One

chapter topic; Chapter 60, p. 251

Synthesis — Promising, and Supposing

chapter topic; Chapter 97, p. 353

Synthesis — Saying It Once

chapter topic; Chapter 65, p. 263

Synthesis — Saying Something About Your Own Life

chapter topic; Chapter 117, p. 435

Synthesis — The Choices English Never Makes You Make

chapter topic; Chapter 138, p. 515

Synthesis — The Conversation Without Them

chapter topic; Chapter 70, p. 273

Synthesis — The Same Conversation, Twice

chapter topic; Chapter 23, p. 125

Synthesis — the Same Sentence, Two Continents

chapter topic; Chapter 33, p. 153

Synthesis — The Thing and the Person

chapter topic; Chapter 75, p. 283

Synthesis — Three Exceptions, and No Others

chapter topic; Chapter 88, p. 325

Synthesis — Two at a Time

chapter topic; Chapter 80, p. 293

Synthesis — What You Like, and Who Does the Liking

chapter topic; Chapter 129, p. 473

Synthesis — What You Understand, and What You Don't

chapter topic; Chapter 123, p. 455

Synthesis — You, and Somebody Else

chapter topic; Chapter 51, p. 231

Synthesis — You Can Hear Which Past It Is

chapter topic; Chapter 84, p. 311

T**Talking to a Friend**

chapter topic; Chapter 17, p. 109

Telling Time

chapter topic; Chapter 112, p. 413

Telling What Happened

chapter topic; Chapter 132, p. 491

tenemos — and the stem change disappears

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 43, p. 199

Tener in the Plural, and the Stem-Change Rule

chapter topic; Chapter 43, p. 199

Tenia and Tuve — When the Tense Changes the Meaning

chapter topic; Chapter 91, p. 335

tenía and tuve — when the tense changes the meaning

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, usage and culture; Chapter 91, p. 335

thank you *gracias*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 7, p. 51

Thank You, Yes, and No

chapter topic; Chapter 7, p. 51

the choice English lost — and the surprise that usted takes**he/she verb forms *tú o usted***

explicit focus: grammar, usage and culture; Chapter 5, p. 31

The Conditional — Saying What Would Happen

chapter topic; Chapter 95, p. 345

the four seasons — three straightforward, and one whose**MEANING quietly shifted from “spring” to “summer” *la primavera, el verano, el otoño, el invierno***

explicit focus: etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 108, p. 397

The Future — Saying What Will Happen

chapter topic; Chapter 94, p. 341

the *h* in hermano — a letter that was never spoken

etymology topic; explicit focus: usage and culture; Chapter 106, p. 387

the hand — feminine despite ending in -o, Spanish’s most**famous gender exception *la mano***

explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 107, p. 393

the head — Spanish KEPT Latin’s real word, unlike French,**which replaced it with slang for “pot” *la cabeza***

explicit focus: etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 107, p. 393

The Imperfect — What Used to Happen

chapter topic; Chapter 85, p. 315

¿ i — the marks that open a question

script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, usage and culture; Chapter 11, p. 75

the (masculine / feminine) *el / la*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 1, p. 1

The Months

chapter topic; Chapter 110, p. 405

the months — Roman gods and emperors, marching almost**unchanged from Latin *los meses***

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 110, p. 405

the numbers 1–5 *uno, dos, tres, cuatro, cinco*

explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 38, p. 165

the numbers 6–10 and the old counting hidden in month

names *seis, siete, ocho, nueve, diez*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 38, p. 165

the one noun that covers both “time” and “weather” — because

Latin tempus already did *el tiempo*

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 113, p. 417

The Only Three Irregulars

chapter topic; Chapter 87, p. 321

the other sorry — “give completely” — for fault and for getting

past people, where lo siento is for regret *perdón*

explicit focus: etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 103, p. 371

The Preterite — Your First Past Tense

chapter topic; Chapter 81, p. 295

The *qu-* question family — one ancient pattern, many clues

etymology topic; explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 6, p. 39

The Regular Preterite

chapter topic; Chapter 82, p. 301

the regular singular -er preterite — comí, comiste, comió *comí*

explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 82, p. 301

the regular singular -ir preterite — viví, viviste, vivió *viví*

explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 82, p. 301

The Rest of the Greetings

chapter topic; Chapter 2, p. 13

the same rain in two tenses — how a story uses the imperfect for

the scene and the preterite for the events *llovía / llovió*

explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 132, p. 491

The Seasons

chapter topic; Chapter 108, p. 397

the shared singular preterite of ser and ir — fui, fuiste, fue *fui*

explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 81, p. 295

The Strong Preterites

chapter topic; Chapter 83, p. 305

The Subjunctive Built From the Yo Form

chapter topic; Chapter 100, p. 361

The Subjunctive, Regular

chapter topic; Chapter 99, p. 357

the three weather words Spanish reports with hacer — “it makes heat,” “it makes cold,” “it makes sun” *hace calor, hace frío, hace sol*

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 113, p. 417

The Three Words for You

chapter topic; Chapter 5, p. 31

The Weather

chapter topic; Chapter 113, p. 417

the weekdays (Monday–Friday) — worn-down planet-god**names** *lunes, martes, miércoles, jueves, viernes*

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 104, p. 375

the weekend (Saturday, Sunday) — where religion overwrote**astronomy** *sábado, domingo*

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 104, p. 375

The Written Accent

chapter topic; Chapter 10, p. 71

then, next — a word you already own from hasta luego, now**doing a second job: joining two events in order** *luego*

explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 132, p. 491

thus, in that way — and with que after it, “so”; built on the**same *sīc* that gave you *sí*** *así que*

explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 140, p. 525

tienen — the break comes back

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 43, p. 199

to answer — a Roman courtroom word that English turned into**a fight and Spanish turned into a reply** *contestar*

explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 139, p. 519

to ask (a question) — and the reason English’s one “ask”**becomes two Spanish verbs** *preguntar*

explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 125, p. 459

to be able or can — with the singular present forms puedo,**puedes, and puede** *poder*

explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 45, p. 207

to be — but the *standing* kind, straight from Latin *stāre* *estar*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 8, p. 65

to be — the verb used here to identify someone or say what**someone is** *ser*

explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 39, p. 173

to believe, to think — putting your heart somewhere, where**pensar weighs it up** *creer*

explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 140, p. 525

to bring — Latin’s word for dragging, and a verb with a**direction built into it** *traer*

explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 133, p. 499

to buy — from Latin’s “get ready, procure”, and not from the**verb behind English compare** *comprar*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 139, p. 519

to close — from the bar dropped across a door, not from the Latin verb English inherited *cerrar*

explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 131, p. 483

to come — with the singular present forms vengo, vienes, and viene *venir*

explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 49, p. 225

to do or make — with the singular present forms hago, haces, and hace *hacer*

explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 46, p. 215

to drink (another -er verb — cementing the pattern) *beber*

explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 27, p. 137

to eat — your first -er verb, and the family whose yo-form you already own *comer*

explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 25, p. 129

to explain — literally to unfold, and the verb that names what this whole chapter has been building *explicar*

explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 140, p. 525

to get, to obtain — getting as following a thing until you have it *conseguir*

explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 134, p. 503

to get up, to stand up — “to raise oneself”, built from a participle exactly as sentarse was *levantarse*

explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 131, p. 483

to go — with the three singular present forms voy, vas, and va *ir*

explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 40, p. 181

to have — a common verb with two visible changes *tener*

explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 38, p. 165

to hear — the half of listening you do not choose, and a verb that sprouts a y *oír*

explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 130, p. 475

to help — literally the same word as English “aid”, arriving by a different road *ayudar*

explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 126, p. 463

“to him, to her, to you” — a Latin case Spanish kept and English threw away *le*

explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 71, p. 275

to leave or go out — with the singular present forms salgo, sales, and sale *salir*

explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 48, p. 223

to live — your first -ir verb, and a family that asks you to learn nothing new *vivir*

explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 26, p. 135

to meet, to be acquainted with — a verb built out of the moment knowing begins *conocer*

explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 136, p. 509

to open — a regular -ir verb with one irregular part, the participle abierto *abrir*

explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 131, p. 483

to play — from Latin's word for joking, and the only verb in the language that breaks u to ue *jugar*

explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 135, p. 505

to please — the verb English calls “to like”, built the other way round *gustar*

explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 128, p. 469

to put or place — with the singular present forms pongo, pones, and pone *poner*

explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 47, p. 221

to read — from a Latin verb meaning “to gather, to pick out” *leer*

explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 120, p. 445

to run — a plain -er verb sitting on one of the largest roots English ever borrowed *correr*

explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 130, p. 475

to say or tell — with the singular present forms digo, dices, and dice *decir*

explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 46, p. 215

to see — veo, ves, ve *ver*

explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 86, p. 319

to sit down — literally “to seat oneself”, the reflexive that lands the action back on you *sentarse*

explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 131, p. 483

to sleep — and the other half of the boot, where a stressed o breaks to ue *dormir*

explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 130, p. 475

to speak / to talk — at root, “to tell stories” *hablar*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 16, p. 105

to study (a third -ar verb — the pattern is automatic now) *estudiar*

explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 21, p. 119

to take (and, across Latin America, to drink) — an everyday word with no settled origin *tomar*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 124, p. 457

to tell a story — and also to count, because in Spanish, as once in English, a story is something you reckon up *contar*

explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 132, p. 491

to think — at root “to weigh”, and a stem-changer that breaks

e→ie *pensar*

explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 118, p. 437

to understand — literally “to stretch toward”; the second e→ie

stem-changer *entender*

explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 119, p. 441

to wait — and to hope, and to expect, all in one verb *esperar*

explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 139, p. 519

to walk — built on a Celtic word for a path, beside andar, whose

own past is unsettled *caminar*

explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 130, p. 475

to want — with the singular present forms quiero, quieres, and

quiere *querer*

explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 45, p. 207

to work (a second -ar verb — same pattern) *trabajar*

explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 20, p. 115

to write — from a Latin verb meaning “to scratch”, and the

reason Spanish puts an e- in front *escribir*

explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 121, p. 449

Tomar — Taking, and a Word With No Past

chapter topic; Chapter 124, p. 457

Trabajar — Work, and the Torture Device Behind It

chapter topic; Chapter 20, p. 115

Traer — Bringing, and Latin for Dragging

chapter topic; Chapter 133, p. 499

tuve — let the strong stem carry the stress

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 83, p. 305

twenty — the ceiling of the teens, and a word that was worn but

never fused *veinte*

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 114, p. 421

two of the three words Spanish uses to one person — and the

one English quietly retired *tú / usted*

Chapter 5, p. 31

U

un — “a,” and the number hiding in it

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 3, p. 21

Un and Una — the Other Article

chapter topic; Chapter 3, p. 21

una — the feminine one

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 3, p. 21

until / up to *hasta*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 12, p. 83

Until When

chapter topic; Chapter 13, p. 89

“us” — and the word hiding inside the verb ending you have**used since *hablamos nos***

explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 66, p. 265

V**vamos — from a verb that is not *ir***

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 44, p. 203

van — and the four are done

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 44, p. 203

veía — keep the extra *e* you already met

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 87, p. 321

Venir — Coming

chapter topic; Chapter 49, p. 225

Ver — Seeing

chapter topic; Chapter 86, p. 319

Verbs That Break in the Middle — the Stem Changers

chapter topic; Chapter 45, p. 207

viva · vivas · viva — -ir joins -er

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 99, p. 357

vivía — reuse the complete -er row

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 85, p. 315

vivimos — where the two families part

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 34, p. 155

Vivir — the Family That Costs Nothing

chapter topic; Chapter 26, p. 135

viviré — one future row for three verb families

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 94, p. 341

viviría — the regular conditional closes its small frame

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 95, p. 345

***vuestra merced* → *usted* — respect compressed into one word**

etymology topic; explicit focus: etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 5, p. 31

W**Waiting, Answering, Buying**

chapter topic; Chapter 139, p. 519

Wanting, Not Asserting

chapter topic; Chapter 98, p. 355

water — a word that barely changed from Latin, and takes el
without ever stopping being feminine *el agua*

explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 109, p. 399

Water, Wine, and Bread

chapter topic; Chapter 109, p. 399

well / good / fine *bien*

explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 1, p. 1

what? (a new question word for verbs you already know) *qué*

explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 27, p. 137

**what estar is for — a current state or location — and the only
two forms you need this chapter** *estás / está*

explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 8, p. 65

what's your name? (formal) *¿cómo se llama usted?*

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 6, p. 39

“when” — the word that puts a scene and an event in one

sentence, so the two pasts can be seen doing different jobs *cuando*

explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 90, p. 331

When You Don't Understand

chapter topic; Chapter 15, p. 101

where? *dónde*

explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 27, p. 137

Where does ¿ begin? — bracket the spoken span

script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 11, p. 75

Where -er and -ir Part Company

chapter topic; Chapter 34, p. 155

Which One Is the Verb Asking For?

chapter topic; Chapter 73, p. 279

Which one is the verb asking for?

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, usage and culture; Chapter 73, p. 279

Why se? — and why it is not the se you know

etymology topic; explicit focus: etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 78, p. 289

Why Se? — Gelo, and a Collision

chapter topic; Chapter 78, p. 289

wine — one Latin root that reached English by three separate
roads, plus one English built at home *el vino*

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 109, p. 399

Y

yellow — from “a little bitter,” not from any Latin word for
yellow at all *amarillo*

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 116, p. 431

yes *sí*

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 7, p. 51

“you” across a large part of the Spanish-speaking world — to recognise, not to say *vos*

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 5, p. 31

“you all” as the object — the shortest word in the set, and the one that stops at a border *os*

explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 68, p. 269

“you” as the object — and the sentence it makes, which is the one people actually need *te quiero*

explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 63, p. 257

you’re welcome (literally “of nothing”) *de nada*

explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 7, p. 51

your first sentence built from parts — and the rule that languages take no article *Hablo español*

explicit focus: grammar, usage and culture; Chapter 22, p. 121

Your First Verb, and the Form That Means I

chapter topic; Chapter 16, p. 105